AN ARCHIVAL FAMILY HISTORY

Allen E. Sweigert, Sr.

World War II & A Family History

September 9, 1918 — March 29, 2012

Battery F, 213th Coast Artillery, Pennsylvania National Guard

90th Bomb Squadron, 3rd Bomb Group "The Grim Reapers," U.S. Army Air Forces

New Guinea & Australia

A complete oral history, wartime archive and unit record, told in his own words.

Compiled by his grandson, Jeremy Sweigert.

391 photographs and documents · 297 researched historical notes

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A Christmas gift to Allen, December 2011 — later displayed at his funeral.

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About This Document

This is an illustrated oral history. It grew out of two home-video tapes recorded in July 2006 — *Pap's Interview Pt 1.MPG*, about 87:04 long, and *Pap's Interview Pt 2.MPG*, about 14:04 — set alongside more than three hundred photographs and documents from Allen's own WW2-era collection and the wider family archive, and filled out with research into his unit's combat record.

What makes this collection unusual is how completely it survives together, in one family's hands: a first-person account recorded in his own voice; his personal service record book, filled in by his own hand at every posting; his own copy of his group's unit history; the physical artifacts he carried home from New Guinea and Australia — occupation currency, Japanese surrender leaflets, a field phrasebook inscribed with his name, an original issue of the Allied troop newspaper Guinea Gold — two of his actual flight suits, and hundreds of his own wartime photographs, most never printed or shown until now. Nobody keeps a count of how many WW2 veterans' collections hold all of that at once — an oral history, a documented service record, period artifacts, uniforms, and a photographic archive of this size — so there is no honest way to say how rare it is. What can be said is that each of those things is uncommon enough to survive on its own, let alone in one house together.

His Memorial Film

The film made for Allen's funeral in 2012, put together by his grandson out of the same photographs and interview tapes this history is built from. It plays here in full.

Allen E. Sweigert, Sr., 1918–2012 — the memorial film shown at his funeral.

youtu.be/r0Xc1GjV234

What Is In Here, and Who Made It

Of the **363 pictures** in this document, **241 are Allen's own photographs** — taken with the camera he carried overseas, or printed from a negative that was his. More than thirty of those show Allen himself, so somebody else pressed the shutter; they are counted here because the negative came home in his footlocker, and each one says in its caption that he is in it. Another **68** are documents and objects out of his effects: his service record book, his discharge papers, his medals, the occupation currency and surrender leaflets he brought home. **24** are family photographs from before or after the war, including frames from the 2006 interview itself and his grandson Jeremy wearing his coat in 1986.

Eight pictures are not from his hands at all, and every one of them says so where it appears: **6** are pages from the 3rd Bomb Group's own published unit history, **1** was taken by a squadron photographer, and **1** is a US Navy photograph from the National Archives. The maps and timelines were drawn for this history and say so on their own faces. **2** more are the front and back of one object that had been kept with the wartime papers but is twenty years younger than they are — a 1965 bubble-gum card — and it is labelled that way where it appears.

A further **20** came out of newspapers, and they are the newest part of this document. Sixteen are pages or clippings — two 1942 promotion notices, his own letter home printed in 1942, a wire story from New Guinea, his wedding notice, the chance meeting in Australia as it reached Cressona in 1943, a page of Cressona news from 1956, the sale of the house that paid for the next one, his promotion at the plant in 1958, his appointment to the cemetery committee in 1982, and a full-page Philco advertisement from 1947 with his name at the foot of it. Three are studio photographs that survive only as a newspaper's halftone of them, his wedding portrait among them; the originals are not in the collection. One is a photograph made by a newspaper's own staff photographer in 2005, and another by a second staff photographer in 2004; both are credited where they appear. Every one of the twenty is labelled on the page as coming from a newspaper, because none of them is his.

Those counts describe the document as it stood in September 2026. In October 2026 **thirteen** more pictures came in, all of them found through Fold3. Twelve are copies of government papers held by the National Archives, which Fold3 publishes, and one is an entry in Fold3's index of the American Battle Monuments Commission's records. **Seven** are about Allen: a draft card, a page of special orders, three pages from the

morning reports of his stateside squadron, the shipping list that sent him to Fort Dix and the roster that took him in there. One of those pages is the second page of a report and finishes a list that begins with his name on the first. The other **six** do not mention him. Five concern his squadron, and the index entry is for a man of another squadron in his group. Each carries a badge on the print saying where it came from, and each caption names the record series.

On the censor's stamp, and what it does not prove. In September 2026 the family photographed the backs of thirty of the prints, because Allen had written on them. Of those thirty, **twenty-three carry the US Army censor's circular handstamp** — PASSED BY / BASE / 2415 / U.S. ARMY / EXAMINER — thirteen struck cleanly and ten only partly inside the frame. **Seven carry no censor mark at all**, and **two of those seven are rubber-stamped, in block capitals, DO NOT MAIL.**

It would be easy to read those stamps as a record of which pictures were Allen's own. They are nothing of the kind. Base censorship examined outgoing mail: a passed stamp certifies that, on the day it was applied, an examiner judged that print could go home in an envelope. It says nothing about who pressed the shutter, whose negative the print came from, or whether it was ever actually posted. The War Department's own instruction sheet for soldiers, Pamphlet 21-1 of 29 July 1943, would not even lay down one rule for photographs; it told a man to go and find out what regulations were in force in his own theatre. The "2415" is most likely the examiner's own number rather than a base's, but nothing found so far says whose it was. DO NOT MAIL is noted here simply because it is there; who stamped it, and on whose authority, nobody knows, and it has not been allowed to decide whether a picture is his.

There is a simpler reason so many of these prints carry no stamp, and it comes from Allen himself. He told his grandson he hid them — in his footlocker, under his gear. They were never passed by a censor because they were never shown to one. Instead of going home a few at a time in envelopes, they stayed in the bottom of that locker through Port Moresby, Dobodura, Nadzab and Hollandia, and came back with him in September 1944.

That is worth more than any handstamp. What shows these are his pictures is not the mark on the few that were posted. It is the hundreds he kept out of the mail.

So the count above rests on three things, and not one of them is a handstamp: what the prints themselves are, what Allen wrote on their backs, and what he says on camera — which he put carefully, and is worth repeating in his own words. He carried his own camera the whole way. Of the pictures he kept: "a lot of them that you took, some you got from other people." The group ran a photo section with two trailer darkrooms, and by his account there was enough film, paper and chemistry in it that any man could print his own. Three kinds of print sit in one album, and the honest answer is that the great majority are his, with a minority coming from the men around him.

The tape is damaged. Pops and dropouts come and go right through it, over sound the 2006 digitization had already thinned: nothing above roughly 6 kHz survived that transfer, and what was lost there is not coming back. Before transcribing, the audio was de-clicked, adaptively denoised, and evened out for loudness.

Source formats, for the record: *Allen's two interview tapes survive as DVD-Video (MPEG-2, 720×480, MP2 audio at 48 kHz) — a 2006 digitization of the original analog home-video tape. Catherine's 2013 interview was shot on a digital camcorder as AVCHD (H.264, 1280×720, AC3 audio); a 2018 recording exists as raw HDV (H.264, 1920×1080) with a compressed web export. All transcription used faster-whisper large-v3 on 16 kHz mono audio extracted from these sources; originals and digitized copies remain in the family archive.*

The transcript was made by machine (faster-whisper, large-v3) and has not been proofread line by line against the tape. Where the model was unsure of what it heard — almost always where a burst of noise landed on his voice — the words are set in *italics*. That is a flag, not a correction.

In Part 1, 10 paragraphs out of 216 carry one of those italic stretches. In Part 2, 3 out of 10 do.

A few stutters of the machine's own making were taken out. Faster-whisper is known to repeat a phrase it has just produced and stamp the copy with a duration far too short for anyone to have said it. Telling those apart from a man genuinely saying something twice was left to arithmetic rather than taste: a repeat is kept only if its own duration allows at least 0.15 seconds per word. A handful failed that test and were dropped. Every other word stands.

A few stretches came back badly broken up, and the missing sentence breaks were put back by measuring each fragment's own pause — punctuation only, never a word changed.

Who is speaking is a guess, and it is worth saying so plainly. The tape is a single mixed track from a home camcorder, so nothing in the sound itself separates the two voices. The **ALLEN** lines and the indented italic **JEREMY** lines were sorted out by whether a line reads like a question or a prompt, and that fails in one predictable way: when Allen quotes dialogue inside his own story ("he says, what's going to happen?"), the question mark makes it look like Jeremy asking. The family caught 29 lines the text-only guess had back to front, plus the opening exchange, and all of them are corrected directly below rather than left for a reader to trip over; the same correction can still be made anywhere else it's needed.

A few plain mishearings have been put right in the text, on the family's word rather than a guess: the model heard "Allen" as "Alan," "Scott Field" as "Scottfield," Allen's nickname for Catherine ("Gram") as the name "Graham," and his hometown "Cressona" as "Crescent" — that last checked against his own obituary. No other wording has been changed.

Two more things the model invented were cleaned out, and in both cases the audio's own timing settled it rather than anybody's judgment. One was a stray character from another alphabet altogether — a Korean syllable Whisper glued onto the word "nets" — and a full scan confirmed it was the only such case. The other was a run of eighteen consecutive "and,"s packed into a 0.3-second segment, which no mouth could produce; it was collapsed to two, under the same rule used for genuine repeated speech elsewhere.

The shaded sidebars step away from the tape to fill in the history around it — the 3rd Bomb Group, the Battle of the Bismarck Sea, the Hollandia campaign, and the wartime artifacts Allen brought home — and each cites the public sources it draws on where it appears. **The book layout on the section-divider pages deliberately**

echoes Allen's own copy of 'The Reaper's Harvest,' the 3rd Bomb Group's unit history book, a scan of which appears later in this document.

Where the Newspaper Material Comes From

Every newspaper page, clipping and press photograph in this document carries its credit in its own caption. The papers are the *Pottsville Republican*; *The Call* of Schuylkill Haven, later *The Call and the Orwigsburg News*; the *Republican & Herald* of Pottsville; and *Guinea Gold*, the Australian Army's field newspaper in New Guinea, reproduced from his own copies.

Where a paper named its photographer, this document names him too — Nick Meyer for the veterans' breakfast of September 2004, Jacqueline Dormer for the cemetery in October 2005. Two cuttings he kept have no masthead and no date anywhere on them, and their captions say that rather than guess at one.

Newspaper text is quoted in short extracts, with the paper, the date and the page given every time, which is how this document handles any source. The digitised pages were read through Newspapers.com. Nothing here is offered as the newspapers' own publication of it, and no claim is made on anyone else's copyright.

Anyone holding rights in this material who would like a credit corrected, or an image taken down, is asked to open an issue on the GitHub repository this site is published from. It will be done.

Credits compiled September 2026.

The Army's Papers, and the Fire of 1973

Allen Sweigert's own Army personnel file has not been seen for this history. He was discharged at Fort Dix on 8 June 1945, and Army files for men discharged between 1912 and 1960 were the ones hit hardest by the fire at the National Personnel Records Center in St. Louis on 12 July 1973. The National Archives estimates that about 80 percent of them were destroyed. Whether his survived is not known until the file is requested.

What this history uses in its place are records that were never part of those files. A search of Fold3 in October 2026 found his enlistment record of 10 April 1941, a draft card stamped with the day he was separated, two entries in the index of the Army's hospital admission cards, and the 1945 morning reports, orders and shipping lists of the units he served in at home, from DeRidder to Fort Dix. Nothing on Fold3 names him before January 1945. The 90th Bomb Squadron's morning reports for his years in it are not online. Where these pages tell the squadron's losses and battles from other men's files, they say so, and each date drawn from a government paper says which paper it came from.

Some of what is still missing can be asked for. His personnel file, or whatever the Records Center rebuilt in its place, is requested from the National Personnel Records Center on Standard Form 180. The same Center holds the 90th Squadron's morning reports from 1941 to September 1944, which are asked for by unit and month. The 3rd Bomb Group's histories and daily operations records, V Bomber Command's records and the Army Air Forces accident reports are on microfilm at the Air Force Historical Research Agency, Maxwell Air Force Base, Alabama. The second page of his Pennsylvania compensation file, the one that names Catherine and the boys, is at the Pennsylvania State Archives in Harrisburg, Record Group 19, series 19.92. Fold3 carries only an index of the hospital admission cards; the cards are National Archives Record Group 112, the records of the Surgeon General. Aviation Archaeology, a private firm, copies single accident reports from its own microfilm for twenty to thirty-five dollars and can be asked to search what it has not indexed. Nothing has been bought. The second volume of *Harvest of the Grim Reapers*, the modern history of the group, has not yet been read for this document.

Sources: the National Archives, "The 1973 Fire, National Personnel Records Center"; the Fold3 records cited in each chapter, searched October 2026; Aviation Archaeology, order information, read October 2026.

About Allen E. Sweigert, Sr.

The First Rung, and Where He Earned It

Elsewhere his whole climb from enlistment to the top enlisted grade takes four words: rising to master sergeant. The 1942 notices supply the bottom rung of that ladder and fix it in place. One reads, “He was made corporal while at sea from San Francisco to Australia.” The other, “While enroute to Australia from San Francisco, he was made a corporal.”

Convoy 2030 cleared San Francisco on 31 January 1942 and the Ancon tied up at Brisbane on 25 February, so his corporal's stripes came somewhere inside those twenty-five days, at sea. That is as close as the promotion can be pinned. It is the earliest evidence of any grade he held that carries a date at all — earlier than the wire story that printed him as Tech. Sgt., and three years earlier than the Master Sergeant on his discharge paper. Two papers agree on the fact, the place and the voyage. Neither gives a day, and no day should be invented for them.

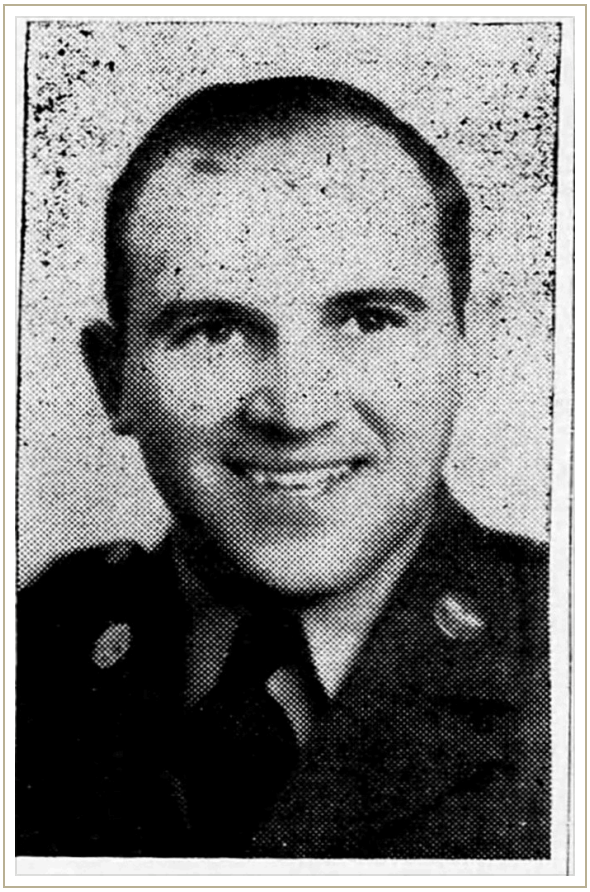
Sources: The Call, Schuylkill Haven, 29 May 1942, p. 1; Pottsville Republican, 28 May 1942, p. 18; 3rd Bombardment Group — Australia @ War.

The Only Portrait of Him in This Document

Of the pictures in this collection, not one is a formal portrait of Allen. He is in the field, in a group, at a distance, or turned away. This one came out of a newspaper: a coarse halftone, one column wide, printed above a notice his parents had given the paper.

It cannot be dated, but it can be hemmed in. The notice reports a cablegram from Australia, and no photograph came back on a cable. Whatever image the family handed over in 1942 was already in the house, which puts the sitting before he sailed on 31 January 1942 and leaves the Guard years open. He wears a service coat with a soft collar and tie and a disc on each lapel; the screen resolves no device on either one, so not even his branch can be read off it. No sleeve is in the frame. The picture cannot be cited as evidence of any rank, and the headline above it is the paper’s word, not the Army’s.

Sources: The Call, Schuylkill Haven, 29 May 1942, p. 1; national-guard.html, the camp photographs.

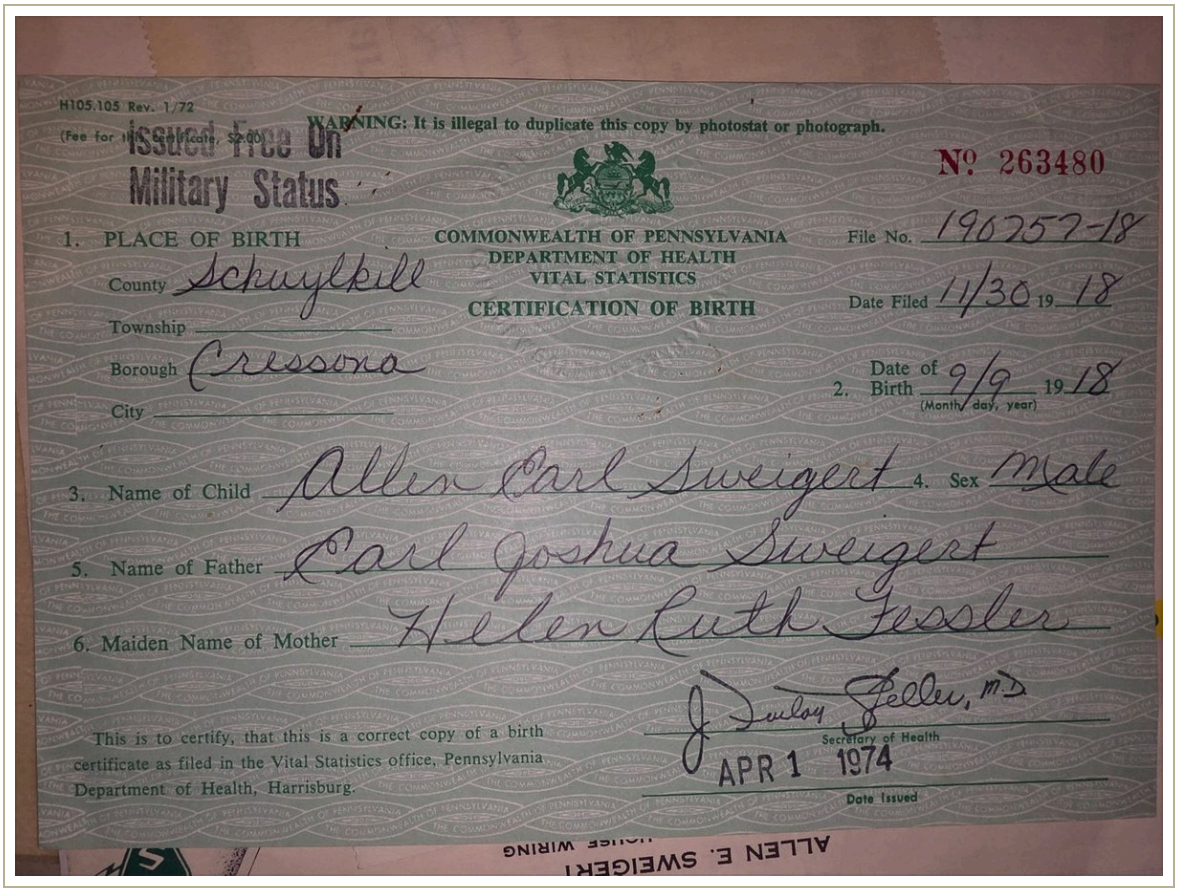


Allen E. Sweigert, Sr., in an undated studio portrait, printed on the front page of The Call of Schuylkill Haven on Friday 29 May 1942, above the notice of his promotion. No sleeve is in the frame, so the photograph carries no rank; it was taken at some point before he sailed on 31 January 1942, and may be from his National Guard years. Credit: The Call, Schuylkill Haven.

Born September 9, 1918, in Cressona, Pennsylvania, a son of Earl J. and Helen R. (Fessler) Sweigert. He graduated from Cressona High School in 1936, in the midst of the Depression, and enlisted that same year in the Pennsylvania National Guard — Battery F, 213th Coast Artillery (Anti-Aircraft), "The First Defenders," a Pottsville-based unit whose roots run back to the first companies that answered Lincoln's 1861 call for troops. He entered federal service at Pottsville, PA, on September 16, 1940, and was mobilized to Camp Pendleton and Camp Stewart, in Virginia and Georgia. He asked for his discharge from the Guard, took it, and enlisted in the Air Corps at Savannah, Georgia, on April 10, 1941. He was assigned to the 90th Bomb Squadron, 3rd Bomb Group — the "Grim Reapers" — and sent to radio school at Scott Field, Illinois, before returning to his squadron. He served with the 90th in New Guinea and Australia through September 1944, rising to master sergeant, in a unit that pioneered low-level B-25 strafing tactics. He came home stateside, and from November 1944 to May 1945 served with the 399th Fighter Squadron, 369th Fighter Group.

He married Catherine S. Kline on October 14, 1944, a week after coming home from the war. The couple settled in Cressona, where Allen went first to Coyne Electrical School in Chicago, graduating in January 1946, and then home to put his Army radio training to work running his own shop, "Allen E. Sweigert: Radios, Electrical Appliances," on Chestnut Street. He began an apprenticeship at the Alcoa works in Cressona in the autumn of

1947 and spent the rest of his working life there as an electrical foreman, retiring in 1977. He was a member and property committee chairman of St. Mark's United Church of Christ, Cressona; a charter member and past president of the Cressona Lions Club, recipient of its Melvin Jones Fellow Award; and a sixty-year member and past commander of American Legion Post 286, Cressona. He and Catherine raised two sons, Allen E. “Buddy” Jr. (1947–2020) and John S., and had two grandchildren, Jessica M. and Jeremy A. Sweigert. Allen Sr. passed away March 29, 2012, at 93, at Schuylkill Medical Center, and is buried with military honors in Cressona Cemetery.


H105.105 Rev. 1/72

(Fee for this Certificate, $2.00)

Issued Free On Military Status

WARNING: It is illegal to duplicate this copy by photostat or photograph.

No. 263480

COMMONWEALTH OF PENNSYLVANIA
DEPARTMENT OF HEALTH
VITAL STATISTICS
CERTIFICATION OF BIRTH

File No. 196252-18

Date Filed 11/30 19 18

1. PLACE OF BIRTH
County Schuylkill
Township
Borough Cressona
City

2. Date of Birth 9/9 19 18 (Month, day, year)

3. Name of Child Allen Earl Sweigert 4. Sex Male

5. Name of Father Earl Joshua Sweigert

6. Maiden Name of Mother Helen Ruth Fessler

This is to certify, that this is a correct copy of a birth certificate as filed in the Vital Statistics office, Pennsylvania Department of Health, Harrisburg.

J. Lewis Fellen, M.D.
Secretary of Health

APR 1 1974
Date Issued

ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

His Pennsylvania certification of birth, filed November 30, 1918 — recording his full name as Allen Earl Sweigert — named for his father, Earl Joshua Sweigert, whose own name is written in the same hand further down the same sheet. The E. he used all his life stood for Earl.

The E. Stands for Earl

This caption said for a while that the certificate recorded him as Allen *Carl* Sweigert, and set that against the Allen E. Sweigert of every other record as a discrepancy in the sources. It was a misreading of one cursive capital, and it is corrected here rather than quietly.

The test is on the certificate itself. Four lines below the child's name the same clerk wrote the father's: *Earl Joshua Sweigert*. The capital that opens the father's given name and the capital that opens the child's middle name are the same ornate double-looped letter, formed the same way in the same hand, on the same sheet, minutes apart. It is an E.

So there is nothing to reconcile. He was named for his father, the certificate and the Army agree, and the initial he signed for ninety-three years stood for Earl.

Source: his Pennsylvania certification of birth, No. 263480, file 190257-18, filed 30 November 1918.

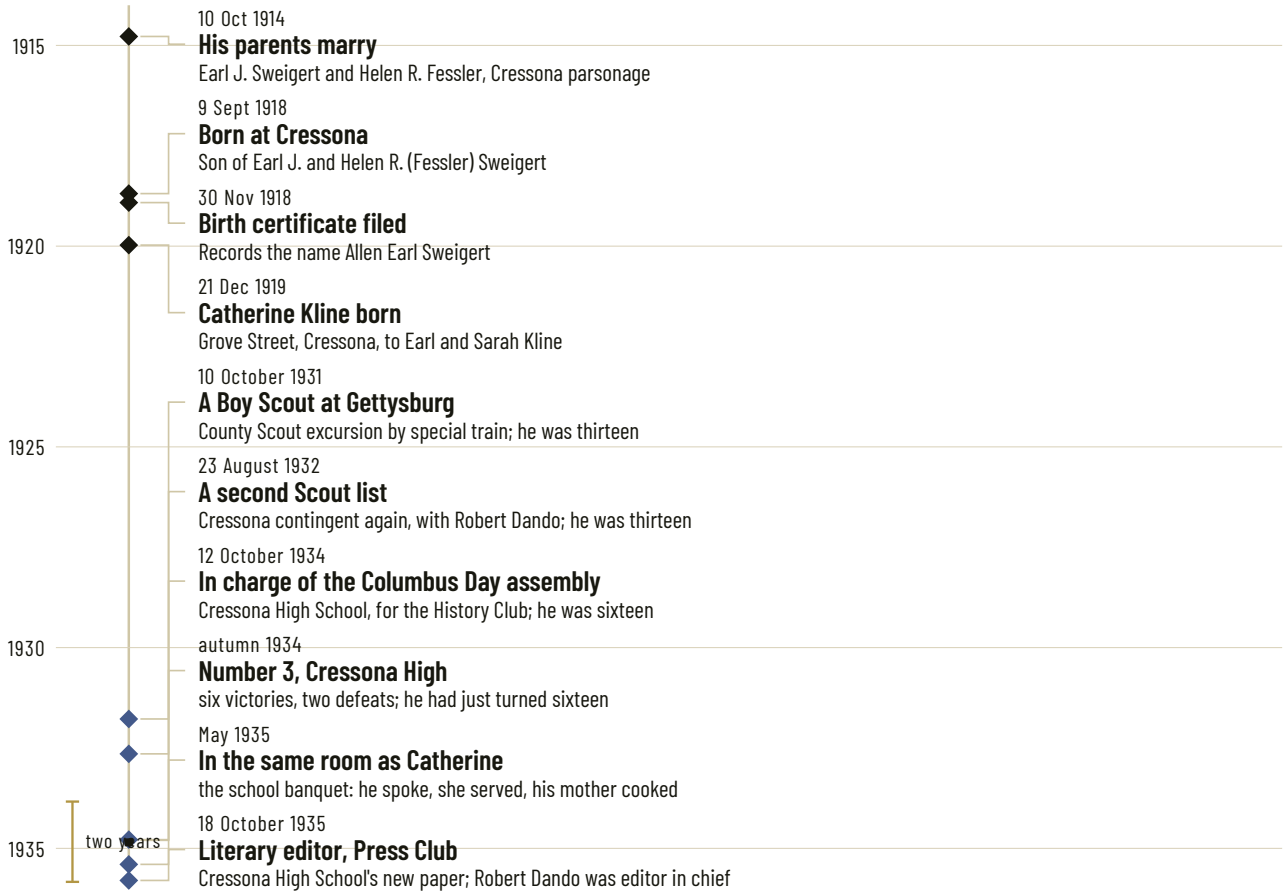
Allen's own unit shield: Battery F, 213th Coast Artillery (A.A.), Pennsylvania National Guard, "The First Defenders."

A Life in Brief

A LIFE IN BRIEF · 1 of 4

Before the uniform, 1914–1935

10 entries. The rail at the left runs to scale; the rows do not, and a bracket joins each to its own moment.



10 Oct 1914
His parents marry
Earl J. Sweigert and Helen R. Fessler, Cressona parsonage

9 Sept 1918
Born at Cressona
Son of Earl J. and Helen R. (Fessler) Sweigert

30 Nov 1918
Birth certificate filed
Records the name Allen Earl Sweigert

21 Dec 1919
Catherine Kline born
Grove Street, Cressona, to Earl and Sarah Kline

10 October 1931
A Boy Scout at Gettysburg
County Scout excursion by special train; he was thirteen

23 August 1932
A second Scout list
Cressona contingent again, with Robert Dando; he was thirteen

12 October 1934
In charge of the Columbus Day assembly
Cressona High School, for the History Club; he was sixteen

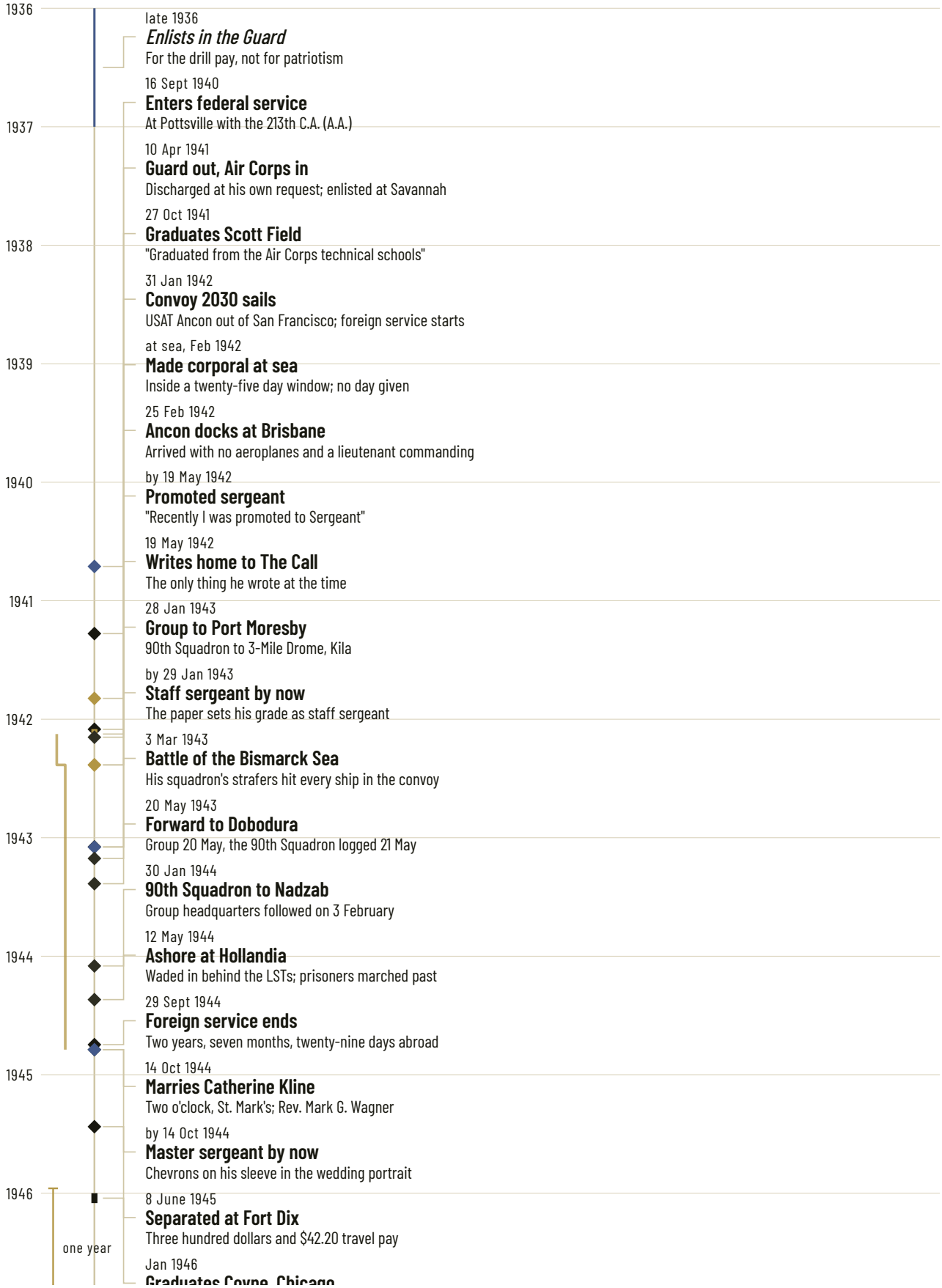
autumn 1934
Number 3, Cressona High
six victories, two defeats; he had just turned sixteen

May 1935
In the same room as Catherine
the school banquet: he spoke, she served, his mother cooked

18 October 1935
Literary editor, Press Club
Cressona High School's new paper; Robert Dando was editor in chief

The service years, 1936–1946

20 entries. The rail at the left runs to scale; the rows do not, and a bracket joins each to its own moment.



late 1936
Enlists in the Guard
For the drill pay, not for patriotism

16 Sept 1940
Enters federal service
At Pottsville with the 213th C.A. (A.A.)

10 Apr 1941
Guard out, Air Corps in
Discharged at his own request; enlisted at Savannah

27 Oct 1941
Graduates Scott Field
"Graduated from the Air Corps technical schools"

31 Jan 1942
Convoy 2030 sails
USAT Ancon out of San Francisco; foreign service starts

at sea, Feb 1942
Made corporal at sea
Inside a twenty-five day window; no day given

25 Feb 1942
Ancon docks at Brisbane
Arrived with no aeroplanes and a lieutenant commanding

by 19 May 1942
Promoted sergeant
"Recently I was promoted to Sergeant"

19 May 1942
Writes home to The Call
The only thing he wrote at the time

28 Jan 1943
Group to Port Moresby
90th Squadron to 3-Mile Drome, Kila

by 29 Jan 1943
Staff sergeant by now
The paper sets his grade as staff sergeant

3 Mar 1943
Battle of the Bismarck Sea
His squadron's strafers hit every ship in the convoy

20 May 1943
Forward to Dobodura
Group 20 May, the 90th Squadron logged 21 May

30 Jan 1944
90th Squadron to Nadzab
Group headquarters followed on 3 February

12 May 1944
Ashore at Hollandia
Waded in behind the LSTs; prisoners marched past

29 Sept 1944
Foreign service ends
Two years, seven months, twenty-nine days abroad

14 Oct 1944
Marries Catherine Kline
Two o'clock, St. Mark's; Rev. Mark G. Wagner

by 14 Oct 1944
Master sergeant by now
Chevrons on his sleeve in the wedding portrait

8 June 1945
Separated at Fort Dix
Three hundred dollars and $42.20 travel pay

Jan 1946
Graduates Coyne, Chicago

1947

Graduates Boyne, Chicago
91.3 in electricity, 94.5 in radio-electronics

Cressona, and the plant, 1947–1979

35 entries. The rail at the left runs to scale; the rows do not, and a bracket joins each to its own moment.

22 Jan 1947
Allen Jr. is born
Allen E. Sweigert, Jr. — Buddy

18 June 1947
Charter member, Cressona Lions
Charter night at the Necho Allen Hotel; he and Catherine both there

1947
Opens his own radio shop
Chestnut Street, Cressona, after Coyne and a Chicago distributor

1950

About October 1947
Apprenticed at Alcoa
Counted back from the certificate: 3½ years of training to 30 April 1951

12 November 1947
Philco dealer, first printing
Named under CRESSONA in Philco's own dealer list

3 Dec 1947
Philco's dealer for Cressona
The only name under the town in a full page

1948
His own shop's calendars
"Radios, Electrical Appliances, Chestnut Street, Cressona"

23 December 1948
30 N. Fourth conveyed to them
From Eva Mae Mosher, for $1

by 18 May 1949
Mother-Daughter banquet, St. Mark's
Catherine, his mother and her own mother in one printed roll; the paper dates its page, not the evening

1955

Apr 1950
Applies for state compensation
Commonwealth computes thirty-two months overseas

16 May 1950
Director, Cressona Lions
Elected to a two-year seat for the year beginning 1 July; installed 27 June

22 Aug 1950
Women's Guild at St. Mark's
Catherine and Helen both present; a clothing drive for children in Europe discussed

Early October 1950
Commander, Legion Post 286
Stanley Dengler Post, Cressona; installed by the 13th District commander

30 Apr 1951
Certified electrician, Alcoa
After a three-and-a-half-year apprenticeship

1960

June 1951
Incorporates the Memorial Park
One of nine; playgrounds as a memorial to war veterans

3 Feb 1955
John is born
John S. Sweigert, their second son

Thanksgiving 1955 or 1956
Roofing the new house
Up on the roof on Thanksgiving day

8 Sept 1955
Printed as Sweigert Sr.
The Cressona birthday column for 9 September carries the suffix seven months before the 1956 page

29 Sept 1955

Sells 30 N. Fourth
To build the Charles Street house

12 Apr 1956
Lions, father and son
Father and son on one page, nine years into the club

25 June 1957
His church changes name
Evangelical and Reformed becomes United Church of Christ

1957
Wiring his own house
Charles Street, built by "Father and Son"

1957
Kathy Keim is born
John's wife; Jeremy and Jessica's mother

31 Jan 1958
Named unit foreman
Electrical department, Cressona Alcoa plant

14 June 1959
His father retires from the railroad
Earl J. Sweigert, engineer for the Reading Railroad, after 43 years

10 October 1964
His parents' golden wedding
Fifty years; a family dinner at Reeser's in Reading

6 Mar 1966
Elder, pulpit committee chair
At the installation of the minister he had called

1 April 1969
Mill maintenance shift foreman
His second foreman's post at Cressona Works, eleven years after the first

10 Feb 1970
The family address in print
A newspaper report places the household on Charles Street

about 1972
Melvin Jones Fellow
Dated only by this document's own arithmetic; the obituary gives no year

January 1973
Twenty-five years at Alcoa
Into the 25 Year Club; the count puts his service date at about January 1948

30 Oct 1975
John and Kathy are engaged
Announced with her photograph; a June 1976 wedding planned

1977
The plant shuts down
Alcoa closes Cressona; he retires after thirty years

by 5 June 1978
His father's estate settled
Allen as executor; Earl J. Sweigert was dead by this date and no closer one is known

1978
Jeremy is born
who would set up the camera in 2006

The last thirty years, 1980–2012

19 entries. The rail at the left runs to scale; the rows do not, and a bracket joins each to its own moment.

1980

5 Feb 1982
Named to the cemetery committee
Three-year term, by borough council

1983
Jessica is born
Jessica M. Sweigert, Allen's granddaughter

1986
Jeremy in his coat
His grandson wearing the master sergeant's service coat

1985

by 2 Oct 1990
At the borough council meeting
Speaks as a resident about bicycle ramps behind St. Mark's

In his eighties
Walking a few miles a day
His own routine, to keep in shape; by October 2005 the paper photographs him with a walker

29 May 2004
Service to America certificate
Post 286, marking the WWII Memorial dedication

1990

about Jan 2004
Steps off the commission
After what he called twenty years on it

22 Sept 2004
Veterans' breakfast, River Inn
At eighty-six, with Warren and Jean Frei

From 2001
Still holding hands in restaurants
Fifty-seven years married, and out to dinner like that

1995

16 Oct 2005
Quoted on the cemetery
At eighty-seven, on a walker, at an 1855 grave

Memorial Day 2006
Legion service, Cressona
Photographed at Post 286's plaza observance

July 2006
The interview recorded
Two tapes, about 101 minutes, in his own words

2000

About 22 September 2011
The flags taken from his porch
An American flag and a Yankees flag; his last mention before the obituary

30 September 2011
His son writes to the paper
"Theft of flags is thoughtless act"; it confirms he built the house with his father

After the theft, 2011
A congressman sends a replacement flag
Family testimony; no newspaper found reports it, and the date is not known

2005

Dec 2011
The book given to him
A Christmas gift; the family gathered for the holidays

29 Mar 2012
Dies at ninety-three
Schuylkill Medical Center; buried with military honours

2010

30 Mar 2012
His obituary runs
Republican & Herald, Pottsville, over three days

two years

2012
The memorial film
Made by his grandson from these photographs and tapes

Ninety-three years, in four panels. The service years are thinned here to the turns only; the full register of them is in Chapter One.

▼ HOW TO READ THIS, AND WHAT THE MARKS MEAN

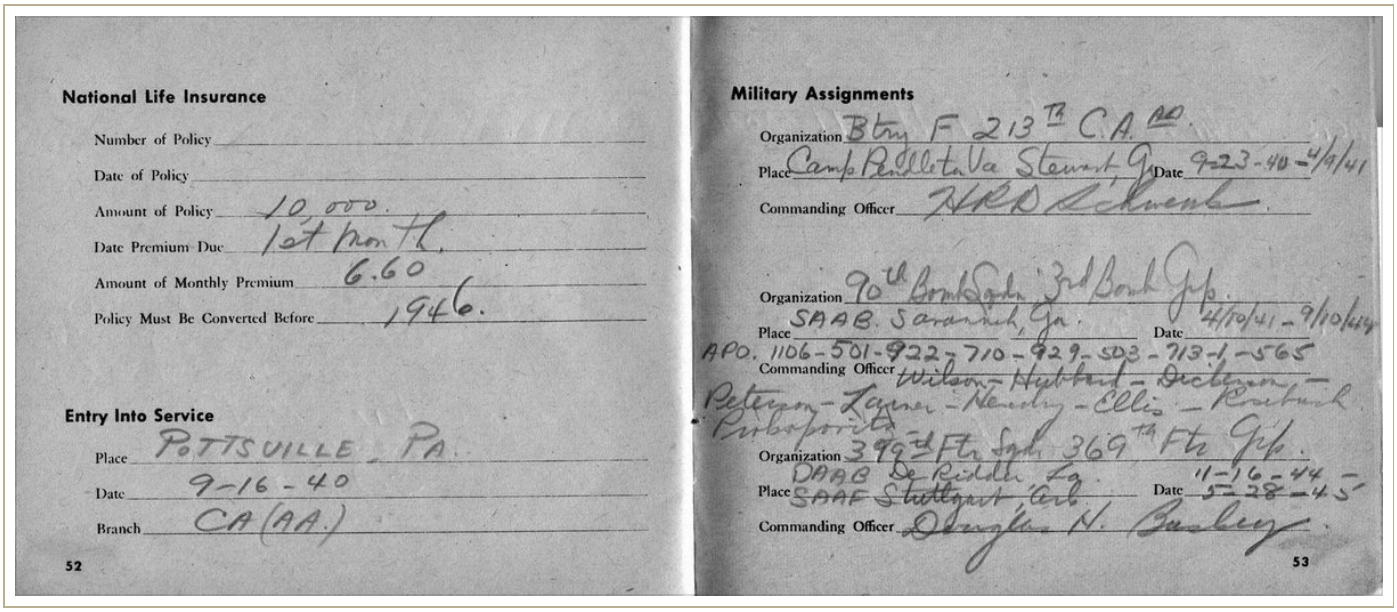
- A **filled diamond** is a date from a document — a service book, a discharge paper, a state form.
- A **blue diamond** is a date from a newspaper printed at the time.
- A **brass diamond** is a date from his own letter home, written in Australia in May 1942. There are only a handful, and they are the best dates in the document.
- A **hollow diamond, with the entry in italic**, is Allen himself, remembering in 2006. The italic is there so the distinction survives a photocopier.
- A **dashed outline** is family memory.
- A **diamond** is a day. A **bar** is a stretch of time — a month, a season, a year, or a run of years — drawn to the length the evidence actually covers, so "spring 1942" is not pretending to be the fifteenth of April.
- The rail at the left runs to scale and the rows do not. Where the brackets fan out, his life was crowded; where they run straight across, it was not.
- The brass bar with a label beside it is a scale stick: it shows how much time one length of rail is worth on that panel, which differs from panel to panel.
- Sixty-two entries across the whole life. The years from 1936 to 1946 carry more than eighty in the record; only the turning points are drawn here.

His Military Record, In His Own Handwriting

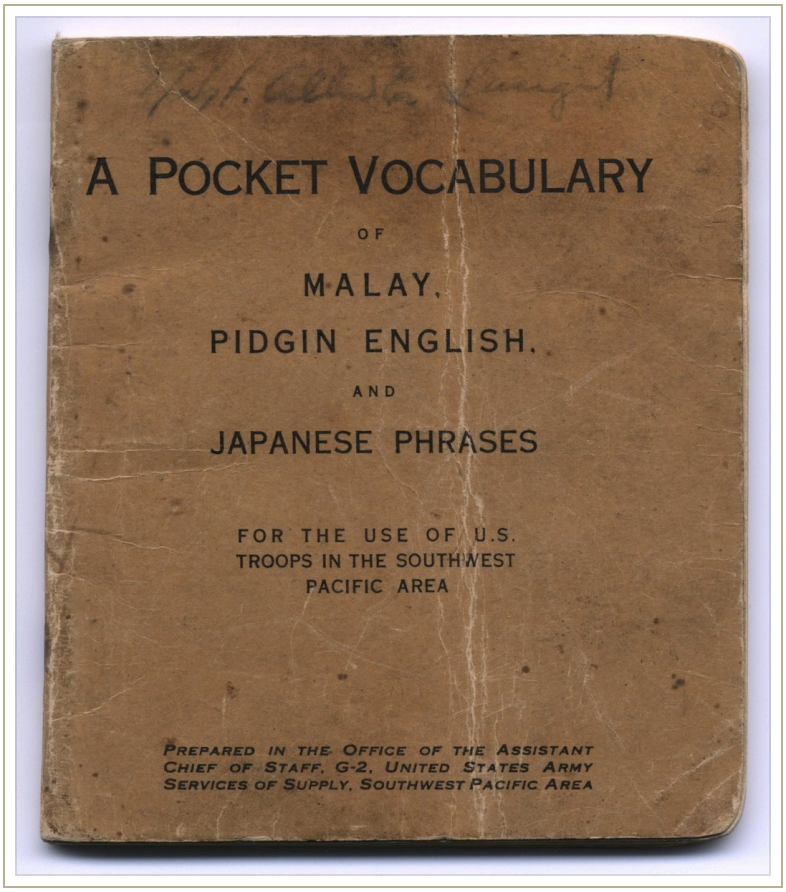
Transcribed from Allen's personal service record book, which he filled in himself during the war.

ORGANIZATION	PLACE	DATES	COMMANDING OFFICER(S)
Battery F, 213th Coast Artillery (A.A.)	Camp Pendleton, VA → Camp Stewart, GA	9-23-40 to 4-10-41	H.R.D. Schwenk
90th Bomb Squadron, 3rd Bomb Group	SAAB Savannah, GA → overseas (APOs 1106, 501, 922, 710, 929, 503, 713-1, 565)	4-10-41 to 9-10-44	Wilson – Hubbard – Dickerson – Peterson – Lasner – Hendry – Ellis – Kretzsch – Priboroski
399th Fighter Squadron, 369th Fighter Group	DAAB DeRidder, LA → SAAF Stuttgart, AR	11-16-44 to 5-28-45	Douglas N. Bagley

Full names for five of the commanding officers Allen listed by surname, found in the 3rd Bomb Group's own published unit history: Wilson is 1st Lt. Bennett G. Wilson; Hubbard is Lt. Col. Ronald D. Hubbard; Dickerson (Allen's own spelling) is Maj. Wesley E. Dickinson; Peterson is Maj. Raymond T. Peterson; Ellis is Lt. Col. Richard H. Ellis. Lasner, Hendry, Kretzsch, and Priboroski were not found in that source's decorations roster and remain surnames only.


National Life Insurance
Number of Policy
Date of Policy
Amount of Policy 10 000.
Date Premium Due 1st month.
Amount of Monthly Premium 6.60
Policy Must Be Converted Before 1946.
Entry Into Service
Place POTTSVILLE PA.
Date 9-16-40
Branch CA(AA.)
52
Military Assignments
Organization Btry F 213TH C.A. AA.
Place Camp Pendleton Va Stewart Ga Date 9-23-40 – 4/9/41
Commanding Officer H.R.D. Schwenk
Organization 90th Bomb Sqdn. 3rd Bomb Grp.
Place SAAB. Savannah, Ga. Date 4/10/41 – 9/10/44
APO. 1106-501-922-710-929-503-713-1-565
Commanding Officer Wilson – Hubbard – Dickerson – Peterson – Lasner – Hendry – Ellis – Kretzsch Priboroski
Organization 399th Ftr Sqn. 369th Ftr Grp.
Place DAAB DeRidder La. SAAF Stuttgart Ark. Date 11-16-44 – 5-28-45
Commanding Officer Douglas N. Bagley
53

Allen's own handwritten service record book — the source of the table above.



His field phrasebook, "Sgt. Allen E. Sweigert" written across the top in his own hand.

His Discharge Papers

Where the Original Is

The Pennsylvania Historical and Museum Commission credited under the image is the parent of the State Archives, and the file itself sits in Record Group 19, Records of the Department of Military and Veterans Affairs, as series 19.92, World War II Veterans' Compensation Applications — three thousand and eighty-two cartons, arranged alphabetically by surname.

The Archives' own description of the series lists very nearly the fields on this sheet, and adds three that are not on this side of the paper: wife, minor children, and living parents. So there is a second page to Allen's file, and it names Catherine and the boys. Access to the originals is restricted to veterans, their families and authorised veterans' agencies, which is to say that this family can ask for it.

Sources: Pennsylvania State Archives, RG-19, series 19.92.

Fifteen Months the Form Will Not Count

He entered active service on 16 September 1940, and the form pays for none of it. The act reaches only from 7 December 1941 to 2 September 1945, so his first fifteen months are not disallowed — they are simply never reached. That is why the first date in the service box is 7 December 1941, and a reader who misses the pre-printed window will take it for the day he joined.

The form asks separately when and where he entered the service, and where he was living when he did. Those two answers were not there to be paid for. The act defines a Pennsylvania veteran by the residence he gave on entering the forces, whatever state he enlisted in, so the two lines together established his standing to claim at all. The address he gave is Railroad Street, Cressona — the same street stamped on his dog tags, written down a second time by a different hand for a different purpose.

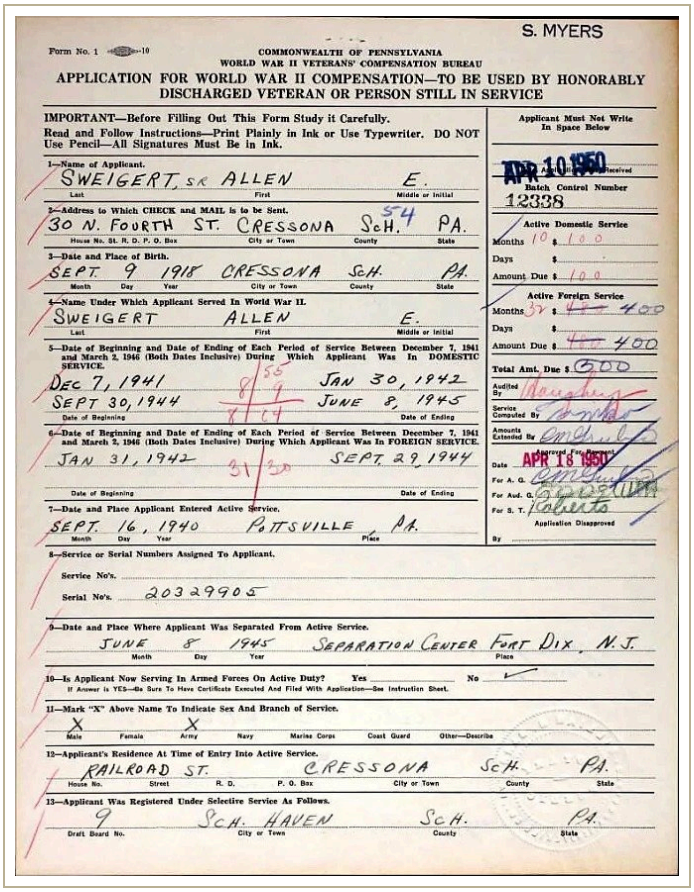
Sources: World War II Veterans' Compensation Act, sections 2, 3 and 4; his dog tags, in the family's keeping.

What the Commonwealth Paid Him

Pennsylvania put the question to its own voters before it paid anybody. The World War II Veterans' Compensation Act of 11 June 1947 set the terms, but its own section 16 held the money back until a constitutional amendment allowed the state to borrow for it. That came on 8 November 1949, authorising half a billion dollars of bonds. Allen's application went in five months later.

The rates were ten dollars for every month of service inside the United States, fifteen for every month outside it, and not a cent over five hundred in total. His ten domestic months came to a hundred dollars. His thirty-two foreign months came to four hundred and eighty. Together that is five hundred and eighty, which the act forbids, so a clerk struck out the foreign figure and wrote four hundred over it — not a rate at all, but five hundred less the hundred already allowed, so the page would foot. Every figure on it is consistent with the statute, and nothing has to be forced.

Sources: World War II Veterans' Compensation Act, Act of 11 June 1947, P.L. 565, No. 248, sections 2, 3, 15 and 16; Constitution of Pennsylvania (1874), Article IX § 22, added by amendment of 8 November 1949; Bonuses for Veterans of World War II, Report No. 2 (1951).



S. MYERS

Form No. 1 -10

COMMONWEALTH OF PENNSYLVANIA
WORLD WAR II VETERANS' COMPENSATION BUREAU

APPLICATION FOR WORLD WAR II COMPENSATION—TO BE USED BY HONORABLY DISCHARGED VETERAN OR PERSON STILL IN SERVICE

IMPORTANT—Before Filling Out This Form Study it Carefully.
Read and Follow Instructions—Print Plainly in Ink or Use Typewriter. DO NOT Use Pencil—All Signatures Must Be in Ink.

Applicant Must Not Write In Space Below

APR 10 1950 Received
Batch Control Number 12338

1—Name of Applicant.
SWEIGERT, SR ALLEN E.
Last First Middle or Initial

2—Address to Which CHECK and MAIL is to be Sent.
30 N. FOURTH ST. CRESSONA SCH. 54 PA.
House No. St. R. D. P. O. Box City or Town County State

3—Date and Place of Birth.
SEPT. 9 1918 CRESSONA SCH. PA.
Month Day Year City or Town County State

4—Name Under Which Applicant Served In World War II.
SWEIGERT ALLEN E.
Last First Middle or Initial

5—Date of Beginning and Date of Ending of Each Period of Service Between December 7, 1941 and March 2, 1946 (Both Dates Inclusive) During Which Applicant Was In DOMESTIC SERVICE.
DEC 7, 1941 8/55 JAN 30, 1942
SEPT 30, 1944 8/4 JUNE 8, 1945
Date of Beginning Date of Ending

6—Date of Beginning and Date of Ending of Each Period of Service Between December 7, 1941 and March 2, 1946 (Both Dates Inclusive) During Which Applicant Was In FOREIGN SERVICE.
JAN 31, 1942 31/30 SEPT. 29, 1944
Date of Beginning Date of Ending

7—Date and Place Applicant Entered Active Service.
SEPT. 16, 1940 POTTSVILLE PA.
Month Day Year Place

8—Service or Serial Numbers Assigned To Applicant.
Service No's.
Serial No's. 20329905

9—Date and Place Where Applicant Was Separated From Active Service.
JUNE 8 1945 SEPARATION CENTER FORT DIX, N.J.
Month Day Year Place

10—Is Applicant Now Serving In Armed Forces On Active Duty? Yes ____ No ✓
If Answer is YES—Be Sure To Have Certificate Executed And Filed With Application—See Instruction Sheet.

11—Mark "X" Above Name To Indicate Sex And Branch of Service.
X X
Male Female Army Navy Marine Corps Coast Guard Other—Describe

12—Applicant's Residence At Time of Entry Into Active Service.
RAILROAD ST. CRESSONA SCH. PA.
House No. Street R. D. P. O. Box City or Town County State

13—Applicant Was Registered Under Selective Service As Follows.
9 SCH. HAVEN SCH. PA.
Draft Board No. City or Town County State

Active Domestic Service
Months 10 $ 100
Days $
Amount Due $ 100

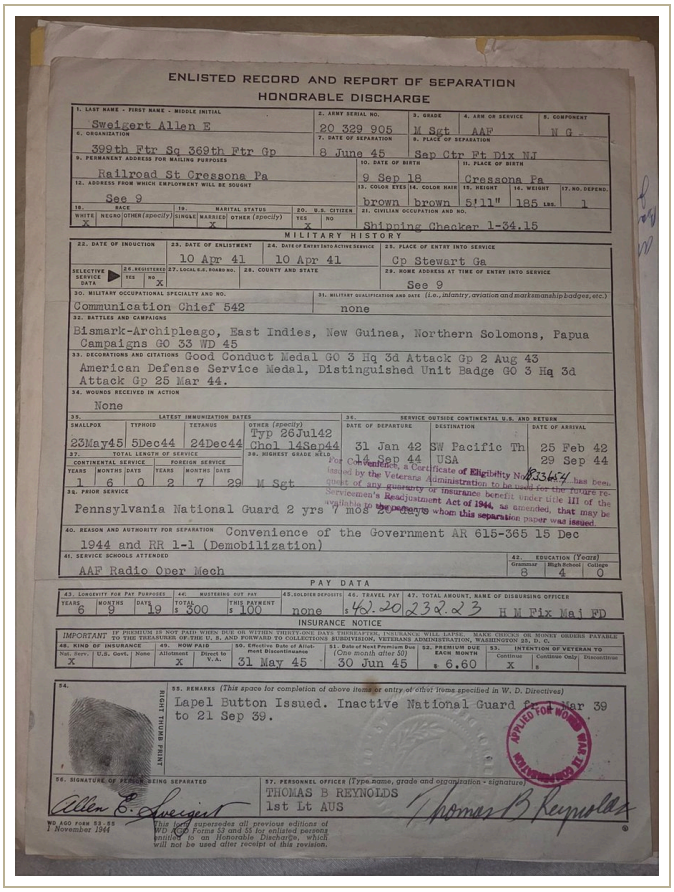
Active Foreign Service
Months 37 $ 400
Days $
Amount Due $ 400

Total Amt. Due $ 500

Audited By Naughton
Service Computed By
Amounts Extended By
Approved for Payment
Date APR 18 1950
For A. G.
For Aud. G.
For S. T. Roberts
Application Disapproved
By

Application for World War II Compensation, Commonwealth of Pennsylvania, received 10 April 1950 and approved for payment on the 18th. He signed it "SWEIGERT, SR" — Allen Jr. was three. Pennsylvania Historical and Museum Commission.

His official "Enlisted Record and Report of Separation," issued at the Separation Center, Fort Dix, New Jersey, June 8, 1945 — the government's own record, alongside his personal one above.



ENLISTED RECORD AND REPORT OF SEPARATION
HONORABLE DISCHARGE

1. LAST NAME - FIRST NAME - MIDDLE INITIAL: Sweigert Allen E
2. ARMY SERIAL NO.: 20 329 905
3. GRADE: M Sgt
4. ARM OR SERVICE: AAF
5. COMPONENT: N G
6. ORGANIZATION: 399th Ftr Sq 369th Ftr Gp
7. DATE OF SEPARATION: 8 June 45
8. PLACE OF SEPARATION: Sep Ctr Ft Dix NJ
9. PERMANENT ADDRESS FOR MAILING PURPOSES: Railroad St Cressona Pa
10. DATE OF BIRTH: 9 Sep 18
11. PLACE OF BIRTH: Cressona Pa
12. ADDRESS FROM WHICH EMPLOYMENT WILL BE SOUGHT: See 9
13. COLOR EYES: brown
14. COLOR HAIR: brown
15. HEIGHT: 5'11"
16. WEIGHT: 185 LBS.
17. NO. DEPEND.: 1
18. RACE: WHITE X; NEGRO; OTHER (specify)
19. MARITAL STATUS: SINGLE; MARRIED X; OTHER (specify)
20. U.S. CITIZEN: YES X; NO
21. CIVILIAN OCCUPATION AND NO.: Shipping Checker 1-34.15

MILITARY HISTORY

22. DATE OF INDUCTION:
23. DATE OF ENLISTMENT: 10 Apr 41
24. DATE OF ENTRY INTO ACTIVE SERVICE: 10 Apr 41
25. PLACE OF ENTRY INTO SERVICE: Cp Stewart Ga
SELECTIVE SERVICE DATA: 26. REGISTERED YES; NO X; 27. LOCAL B.D. BOARD NO.; 28. COUNTY AND STATE
29. HOME ADDRESS AT TIME OF ENTRY INTO SERVICE: See 9
30. MILITARY OCCUPATIONAL SPECIALTY AND NO.: Communication Chief 542
31. MILITARY QUALIFICATION AND DATE (i.e., infantry, aviation and marksmanship badges, etc.): none
32. BATTLES AND CAMPAIGNS: Bismark-Archipleago, East Indies, New Guinea, Northern Solomons, Papua Campaigns GO 33 WD 45
33. DECORATIONS AND CITATIONS: Good Conduct Medal GO 3 Hq 3d Attack Gp 2 Aug 43 American Defense Service Medal, Distinguished Unit Badge GO 3 Hq 3d Attack Gp 25 Mar 44.
34. WOUNDS RECEIVED IN ACTION: None
35. LATEST IMMUNIZATION DATES — SMALLPOX: 23May45; TYPHOID: 5Dec44; TETANUS: 24Dec44; OTHER (specify): Typ 26Jul42, Chol 14Sep44
36. SERVICE OUTSIDE CONTINENTAL U.S. AND RETURN — DATE OF DEPARTURE: 31 Jan 42; DESTINATION: SW Pacific Th; DATE OF ARRIVAL: 25 Feb 42; DATE OF DEPARTURE: 14 Sep 44; DESTINATION: USA; DATE OF ARRIVAL: 29 Sep 44
37. TOTAL LENGTH OF SERVICE — CONTINENTAL SERVICE: YEARS 1, MONTHS 6, DAYS 0; FOREIGN SERVICE: YEARS 2, MONTHS 7, DAYS 29
38. HIGHEST GRADE HELD: M Sgt
For convenience, a Certificate of Eligibility No. 833654 issued by the Veterans Administration to be used for the future receipt of any gratuity or insurance benefit under title III of the Servicemen's Readjustment Act of 1944, as amended, that may be available to the person to whom this separation paper was issued.
39. PRIOR SERVICE: Pennsylvania National Guard 2 yrs 7 mos 27 days
40. REASON AND AUTHORITY FOR SEPARATION: Convenience of the Government AR 615-365 15 Dec 1944 and RR 1-1 (Demobilization)
41. SERVICE SCHOOLS ATTENDED: AAF Radio Oper Mech
42. EDUCATION (Years) — Grammar: 8; High School: 4; College: 0

PAY DATA

43. LONGEVITY FOR PAY PURPOSES — YEARS: 6; MONTHS: 9; DAYS: 19
44. MUSTERING OUT PAY — TOTAL: $ 300; THIS PAYMENT: $ 100
45. SOLDIER DEPOSITS: none
46. TRAVEL PAY: $ 42.20
47. TOTAL AMOUNT, NAME OF DISBURSING OFFICER: 20232 23 H M Fix Maj FD

INSURANCE NOTICE

IMPORTANT — IF PREMIUM IS NOT PAID WHEN DUE OR WITHIN THIRTY-ONE DAYS THEREAFTER, INSURANCE WILL LAPSE. MAKE CHECKS OR MONEY ORDERS PAYABLE TO THE TREASURER OF THE U. S. AND FORWARD TO COLLECTIONS SUBDIVISION, VETERANS ADMINISTRATION, WASHINGTON 25, D. C.

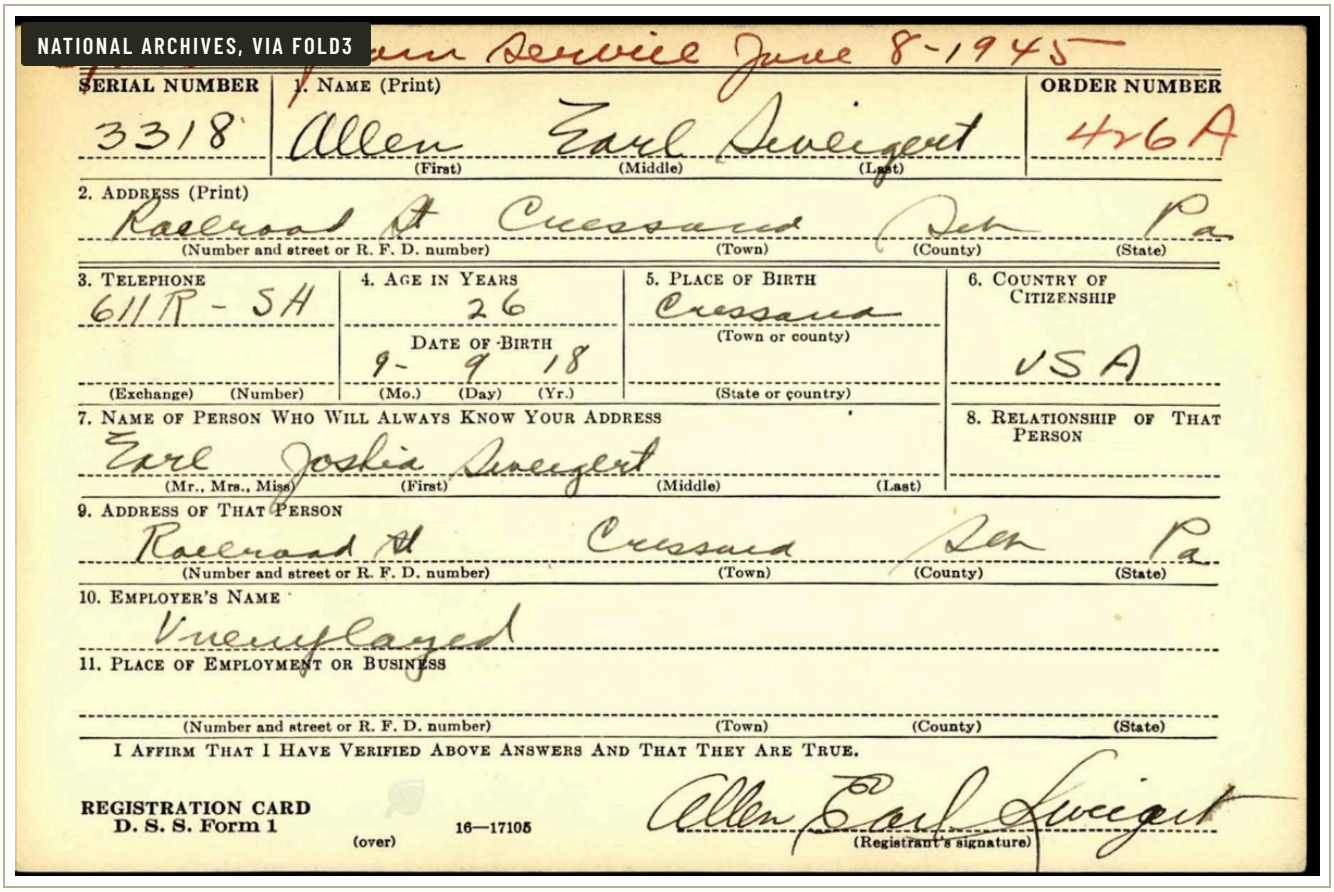
48. KIND OF INSURANCE — Nat. Serv.; U.S. Govt.; None X
49. HOW PAID — Allotment; Direct to V.A. X
50. Effective Date of Allotment Discontinuance: 31 May 45
51. Date of Next Premium Due (Give month after 50): 30 Jun 45
52. PREMIUM DUE EACH MONTH: $ 6.60
53. INTENTION OF VETERAN TO — Continue X; Convert; Discontinue

54. RIGHT THUMB PRINT
55. REMARKS (This space for completion of above items or entry of other items specified in W. D. Directives): Lapel Button Issued. Inactive National Guard [illegible] Mar 39 to 21 Sep 39.
APPLIED FOR WORLD WAR II SERVICE EMBLEM
56. SIGNATURE OF PERSON BEING SEPARATED: Allen E. Sweigert
57. PERSONNEL OFFICER (Type name, grade and organization - signature): THOMAS B REYNOLDS 1st Lt AUS Thomas B Reynolds

WD AGO FORM 53-55 1 November 1944
This form supersedes all previous editions of WD AGO Forms 53 and 55 for enlisted persons entitled to an Honorable Discharge, which will not be used after receipt of this revision.

Serial No. 20 329 905; Military Occupational Specialty, Communication Chief (542); campaigns credited: Bismarck Archipelago, East Indies, New Guinea, Northern Solomons, Papua (GO 33 WD 45); decorations: Good Conduct Medal (GO 3, Hq 3d Attack Gp, 2 Aug 43), American Defense Service Medal, and Distinguished Unit Badge (GO 3, Hq 3d Attack Gp, 25 Mar 44). Departed for the Southwest Pacific Theater January 31, 1942; arrived back in the USA September 29, 1944 — 2 years, 7 months, 29 days of foreign service. Separated for the "Convenience of the Government," mustered out with $300 plus $42.20 travel pay.

His own dog tags, the same serial number as his discharge papers: ALLEN E SWEIGERT / 20329905 T41 / EARL J SWEIGERT (his father and next of kin) / RAILROAD ST / CRESSONA PENN. The "A" is his blood type.



His draft registration card, D.S.S. Form 1, filed in the 1940 series. The age of twenty-six and the red stamp, "Separated from Service June 8-1945", place the writing of it after he came home. He signed it Allen Earl Sweigert. Credit: National Archives, World War II Draft Registration Cards (Record Group 147), via Fold3.

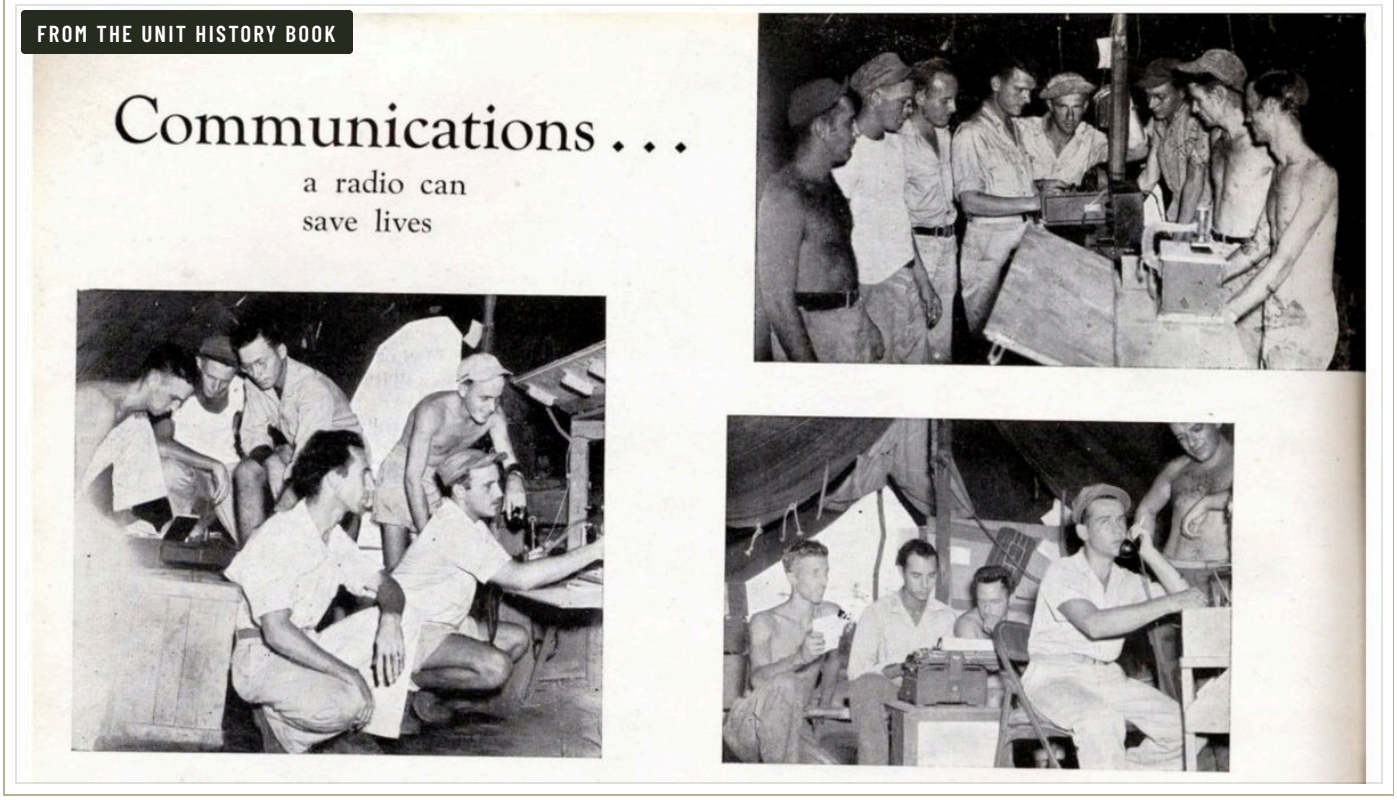
The Draft Card Stamped With His Discharge

His card in the 1940 draft registration series cannot have been written in 1940. It gives his age as twenty-six, which he was only between September 1944 and September 1945, and where it asks for an employer it says “Unemployed”. Across the top, in red, someone wrote “Separated from Service June 8-1945”, the day Fort Dix let him go. When the country registered on 16 October 1940 he had already been in federal service with the 213th for a month. The card was filled in, or finished, once he was home, and “Unemployed” fits the weeks after June 1945 better than the months before, when he was still in uniform.

The rest of it agrees with the papers above. Born 9-9-18 at Cressona; Railroad Street, the address on his dog tags; Earl Joshua Sweigert as the man who would always know where he was, his middle name spelled Joshia by whoever held the pen. The registrar described him as five feet ten and 190 pounds, with brown eyes, brown hair and a dark complexion. His board was Local Board No. 9, at Schuylkill Haven.

Source: US, WWII Draft Registration Cards, 1940, Sweigert, Allen Earl, two pages (National Archives, Record Group 147), via Fold3.

FROM THE UNIT HISTORY BOOK



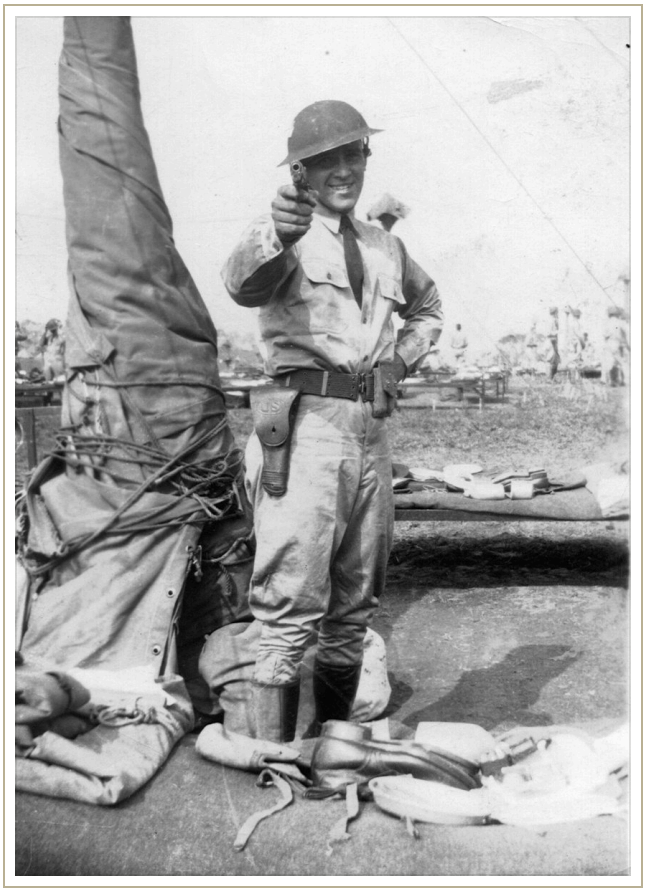
This print is a page from the 90th Squadron's own chapter of the 3rd Bomb Group's published unit history, The Reaper's Harvest, captioned in the book itself, "a radio can save lives." The airmen aren't individually named, but this is Allen's own squadron's Communications section — the same department he ran as Communication Chief.

CHAPTER ONE

ALLEN E. SWEIGERT, SR. · WWII & FAMILY HISTORY

The Reaper's Harvest

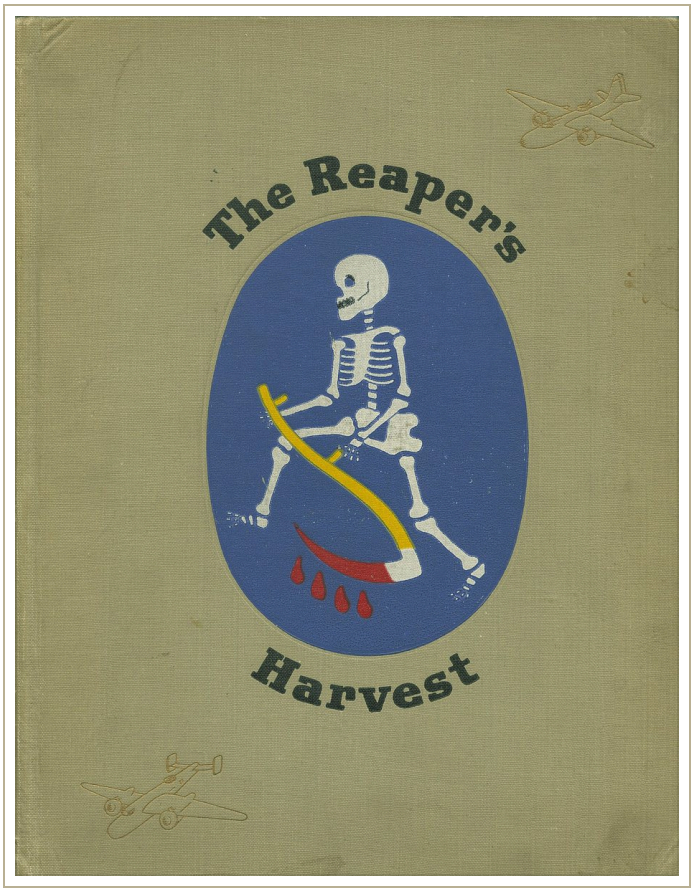
Allen's own copy of the 3rd Bomb Group unit history book



One of the family's own favourites: sidearm drawn, field kit laid out beside him. The same frame appears later in this document captioned as a Saturday inspection at Indiantown Gap, Pennsylvania, 1937 — and the pre-war dress makes the Pennsylvania reading the likelier of the two.

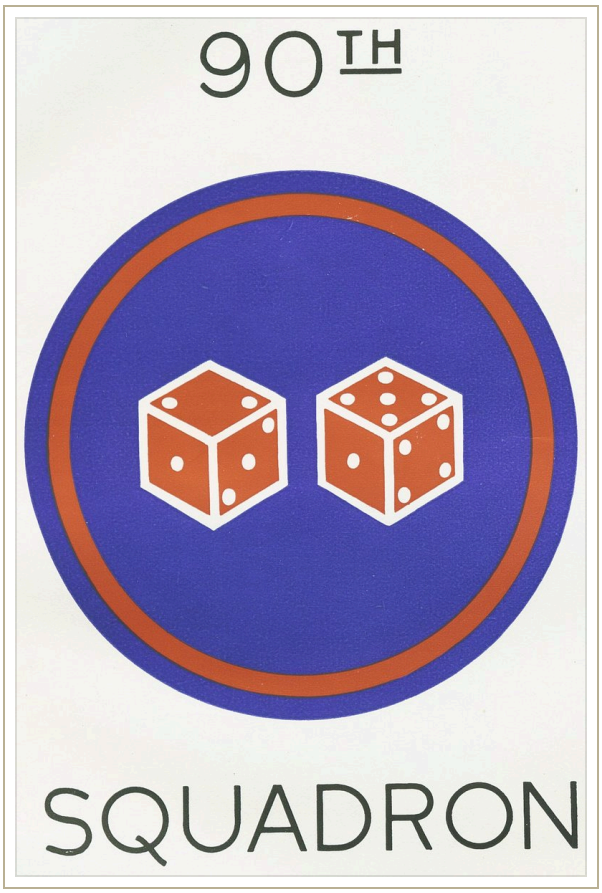
The Unit History Book

Allen kept his own copy of the 3rd Bomb Group's unit history book, *The Reaper's Harvest* — its cover carries the same blue oval emblem that runs through these pages, and gold-embossed B-25 silhouettes in the corners.

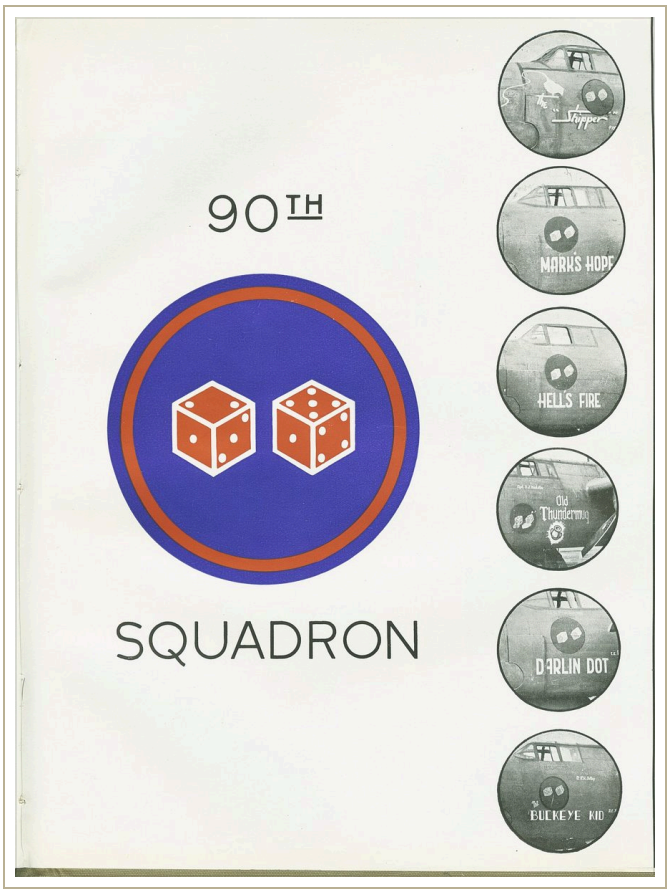


Allen's own copy of "The Reaper's Harvest," the 3rd Bomb Group's unit history.

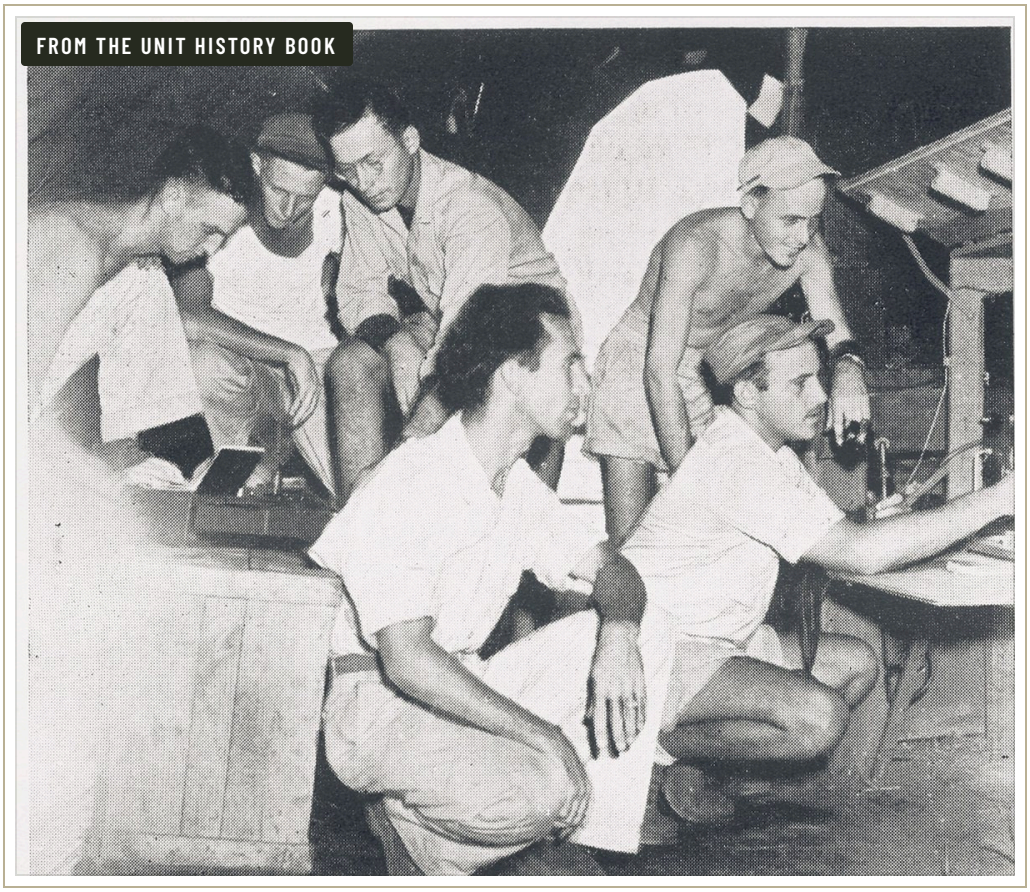
The 90th Squadron



The 90th Squadron insignia, as printed in the unit history.



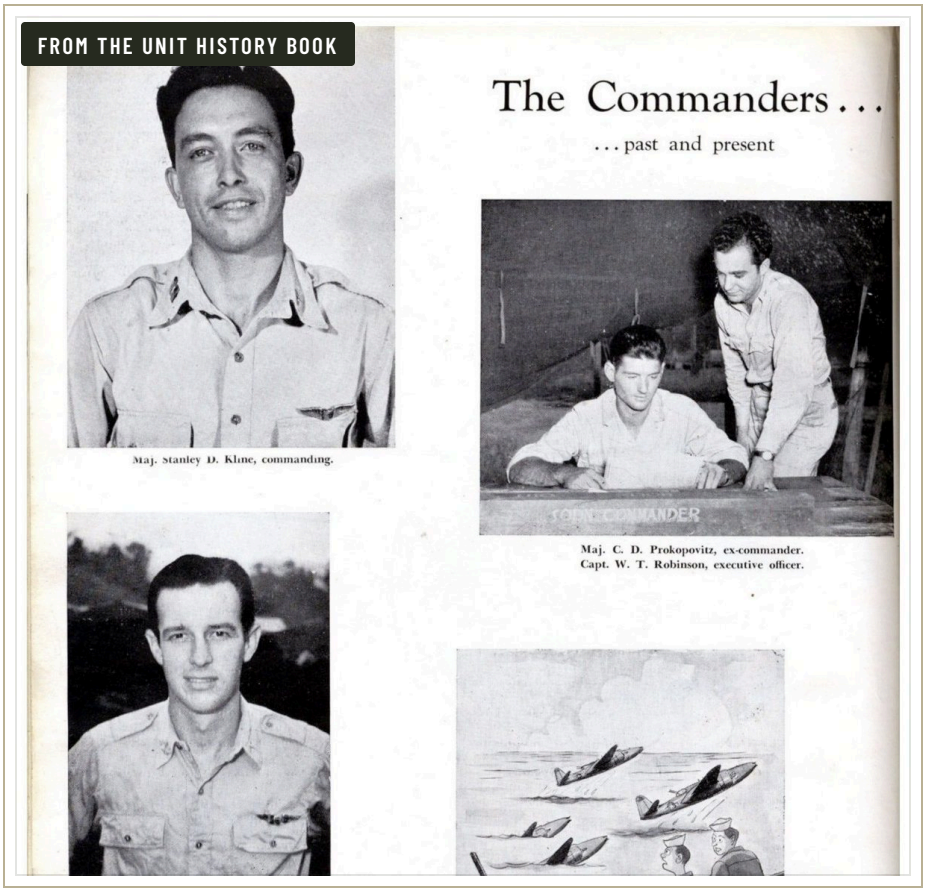
The squadron insignia alongside named B-25 noses: The Skipper, Mark's Hope, Hell's Fire, Old Thundermug, Darlin Dot, The Buckeye Kid.



Another page from the same unit history book — that's Allen himself, turning the dials on the squadron's radio equipment. His own trade: Communication Chief.

The 90th Squadron's Own "The Commanders" Page

Another page from the 90th Squadron's own chapter of *The Reaper's Harvest*, naming the squadron's commanding officers "past and present" as of the book's printing: Maj. Stanley D. Kline (commanding), Maj. C. D. Prokopovitz (ex-commander), Capt. W. T. Robinson (executive officer), and Maj. K. E. Rosebush (ex-commander). Not one of those four names appears among the nine commanding officers Allen wrote out by surname in his own service record book (Wilson, Hubbard, Dickerson, Peterson, Ellis, Lasner, Hendry, Kretzsch, Priboroski). The likeliest reason is a plain one: the book records who held squadron command near the end of the war, while Allen's list runs back through the men he served under earlier in his tour.



"The Commanders ... past and present," from the 90th Squadron's own pages in The Reaper's Harvest.

The 3rd Bomb Group — "The Grim Reapers"

The 3rd Bombardment Group deployed to Australia in early 1942 and flew under the newly formed Fifth Air Force out of Port Moresby by January 1943, with five squadrons: HQ, 8th, 13th, 89th, and 90th. In late 1942, engineering officer Maj. Paul "Pappy" Gunn modified the group's B-25s at Eagle Farm, Brisbane — stripping the glass bombardier nose and packing it with four fixed .50-cal guns, plus twin "package guns" on each side, cleared to attack at masthead height. The entire 90th Squadron was flying these "commerce destroyer" strafers by February 1943. At the Battle of the Bismarck Sea (2–3 March 1943) — the first sea-level B-25 strafing attack of the war — the 90th hit every ship in an 18-vessel Japanese convoy. The group struck Wewak's airfields on 17 August 1943, earning a Distinguished Unit Citation, then staged from Dobodura and Nadzab as the front moved forward through 1943–44.

Sources: Army Air Corps Museum; OzAtWar field-modification records.

The 5th Air Force — The Command Above His Own

The 3rd Bomb Group flew under the Fifth Air Force, activated in Australia on 3 September 1942 under Maj. Gen. George C. Kenney, headquartered in Brisbane. Kenney had landed in Brisbane just weeks earlier, on 29 July 1942, made a rapid tour of the Fifth's bases across northern Queensland, and fired its entire command air staff. At its founding the Fifth had five bomber groups on hand — the 3rd (Allen's own, flying B-25s, A-20s, and A-24s), the 19th, 22nd, 38th, and 43rd — under roughly 1,600 officers and 18,000 men servicewide. Brig. Gen. Kenneth Walker commanded the Fifth's Bomber Command from Townsville; the Fifth opened sustained operations against the Japanese in Papua New Guinea on 4 November 1942. In June 1944 it combined with the Thirteenth Air Force to form the Far East Air Forces, still under Kenney, with Lt. Gen. Ennis Whitehead taking direct command of the Fifth.

Source: OzAtWar (Peter Dunn, ozatwar.com).

The Group's Medal of Honor

The 3rd Bomb Group's own history book records one Medal of Honor, earned in the group's costliest raid: the low-level strike on Simpson Harbor, Rabaul, November 2, 1943, that sank 104,000 tons of Japanese shipping but flew the Mitchells directly into the harbor's ring of naval anti-aircraft fire. Major Raymond H. Wilkins, his own bomber already damaged, deliberately flew it into the heaviest fire from two Japanese heavy cruisers — drawing their guns onto himself and away from the rest of his squadron so they could get through. He did not survive the mission. The book's own words: “He sacrificed his life to save the aircraft of his squadron.” Nobody wrote down which of the group's squadrons Wilkins flew with, so this belongs here as the wider group's story rather than as Allen's own — there is nothing to say the 90th was on that particular raid.

Source: The Reaper's Harvest, 3rd Attack Group Association.

The tan linen cover of a unit history book, bearing a blue oval with a white skeleton striding behind a scythe whose red blade drips three drops of blood, lettered in an arch "The Reaper's" above and "Harvest" below; two twin-engine bombers are embossed faintly in the cloth at opposite corners.

Timeline, 1936–1946

Guard, and the road to the Air Corps

20 entries between 10 June 1936 and 24 Sept 1940.

1941

Camp Pendleton, Virginia
Regiment moves south for training

Radio school to the Golden Gate

21 entries between 19 Feb 1941 and 10 Mar 1942.

1941

19 Feb 1941
Savannah air base dedicated
The installation he would enlist into weeks later

22 Feb 1941
On to Camp Stewart
Georgia, the new antiaircraft training centre

10 Apr 1941
Guard out, Air Corps in
Discharged at his own request; enlisted at Savannah

10 Apr 1941
The Army's enlistment record
Air Corps, Regular Army; place given as Camp Stewart

26 May 1941
Catherine graduates from Kutztown
Kutztown State Teachers' College, in the new Schaeffer auditorium

late May 1941
Scott Field course begins
Twenty-two weeks, radio operator-mechanic

1941
Last leave at home
About half a day, his last before sailing

1941
Photographed at Pendleton
A print he labelled "Camp Endelton, VA, '41"

27 Oct 1941
Graduates Scott Field
"Graduated from the Air Corps technical schools"

16–28 Nov 1941
Carolina Maneuvers
His photograph back reads "Pope Field / Maneuvers / Nov. 1941"

7 Dec 1941
Last sight of Battery F
Visiting Camp Stewart when Pearl Harbor news came in

Dec 1941
Squadron moves inland
Savannah to Augusta, Georgia, foxholes already dug

one year

early Jan 1942
Cadre to Palm Beach
Anti-submarine group; sent back the next day

19 Jan 1942
Troop train leaves Savannah
Group's station at Savannah ends after fifteen months

24 Jan 1942
Oakland, and a warehouse
Seven days waiting, cots up, each squadron its area

31 Jan 1942
Convoy 2030 sails
USAT Ancon out of San Francisco; foreign service starts

at sea, Feb 1942
Made corporal at sea
Inside a twenty-five day window; no day given

1942

25 Feb 1942
Ancon docks at Brisbane
Arrived with no aeroplanes and a lieutenant commanding

25 Feb 1942
Under canvas at Ascot
"Some racetrack" — the Brisbane staging camp

8 Mar 1942
Entrains for Charters Towers

Eltrains for Charters Towers
89th and 90th Squadrons go inland

10 Mar 1942
Group at Charters Towers
A strip begun 16 February; days old, not years

Australia and New Guinea

21 entries between 1 Apr 1942 and Christmas Eve 1943.

1 Apr 1942
Collecting the Dutch B-25s
Archerfield; orange triangles and Dutch handbooks

21 Apr 1942
Bartle Frere crash
A 90th Squadron B-25 into the mountain, seven killed

early May 1942
Standing by for Coral Sea
Woken before dawn; three days beside a parked Mitchell

by 19 May 1942
Promoted sergeant
"Recently I was promoted to Sergeant"

19 May 1942
Writes home to The Call
The only thing he wrote at the time

28 May 1942
Promotion printed at Pottsville
Cabled from Australia, set from his parents' news

12 June 1942
His letter in print
"Shots from Camp," page one, Schuylkill Haven

southern spring 1942
Rockhampton, and his cousin
Nose wheel gone; Pvt. Donald Berger found by ambulance markings

Nov 1942
A photo back dated 11/42
Two comrades' prints: one marked "N. G." and 11/42, one written "outside hut in New Guinea. Nov. 1942"

1943

15 Dec 1942
41-13091 lost on the way home
Found on the Kirrama Range in July 1943; eleven dead

20 Dec 1942
41-29706 into the Coral Sea
North of Osprey Reef in bad weather; none recovered

28 Jan 1943
Group to Port Moresby
90th Squadron to 3-Mile Drome, Kila

by 29 Jan 1943
Staff sergeant by now
The paper sets his grade as staff sergeant

29 Jan 1943
The story reaches home
"It's A Small World!" — and it came out crooked

3 Mar 1943
Battle of the Bismarck Sea
His squadron's strafers hit every ship in the convoy

one year

12 Apr 1943
A hundred planes overhead
Only raid near that size while he was at Moresby

20 May 1943
Forward to Dobodura
Group 20 May, the 90th Squadron logged 21 May

1943
Roll of Honor dedicated
Cressona names its serving men and women

2 Aug 1943
Good Conduct Medal
General Order 3, Headquarters 3d Attack Group

17 Aug 1943

The Wewak strike
Earned the group a Distinguished Unit Citation

Christmas Eve 1943

The scorpion in the bag
A shot from the medics, then the pictures anyway

1944

Home, and out

32 entries between 30 Jan 1944 and Jan 1946.

1944

30 Jan 1944
90th Squadron to Nadzab
Group headquarters followed on 3 February

25 Mar 1944
Distinguished Unit Badge
General Order 3, Headquarters 3d Attack Group

16 Apr 1944
Black Sunday at Nadzab
Thirty-seven aircraft lost to weather, none to the enemy

12 May 1944
Ashore at Hollandia
Waded in behind the LSTs; prisoners marched past

summer 1944
The Bob Hope show
He drew the lucky half of the crew

9 Sept 1944
Word on his birthday
Back from the hill movie to shouting in camp

10 Sept 1944
Service book closes overseas
His own hand ends the 90th Squadron at 9-10-44

29 Sept 1944
Foreign service ends
Two years, seven months, twenty-nine days abroad

7 Oct 1944
Home to Cressona
Back porch, the light on, and the dog

14 Oct 1944
Marries Catherine Kline
Two o'clock, St. Mark's; Rev. Mark G. Wagner

by 14 Oct 1944
Master sergeant by now
Chevrons on his sleeve in the wedding portrait

Oct 1944
Twenty-one day delay
A week's honeymoon by car, then reassignment

20 Oct 1944
The wedding notice prints
Both portraits, and thirty-two months overseas

Nov 1944
Atlantic City redistribution
Refused two grades to stay; posted to DeRidder

16 Nov 1944
Joins the 399th
399th Fighter Squadron, DeRidder Army Air Base

1945

6 Jan 1945
Expert with the carbine
Score 171 in record firing, Special Orders No. 6

9 Jan 1945
Twenty-one days' furlough
Ordinary furlough from DeRidder; back to duty 31 January

31 Jan – 7 Feb 1945
Malaria, DeRidder station hospital
"Malaria, vivax (tertian)" on the admission card

8 Feb 1945
Misses the move by a day
Back to duty the 7th, the day the train left

16–25 Mar 1945
Station hospital, Stuttgart

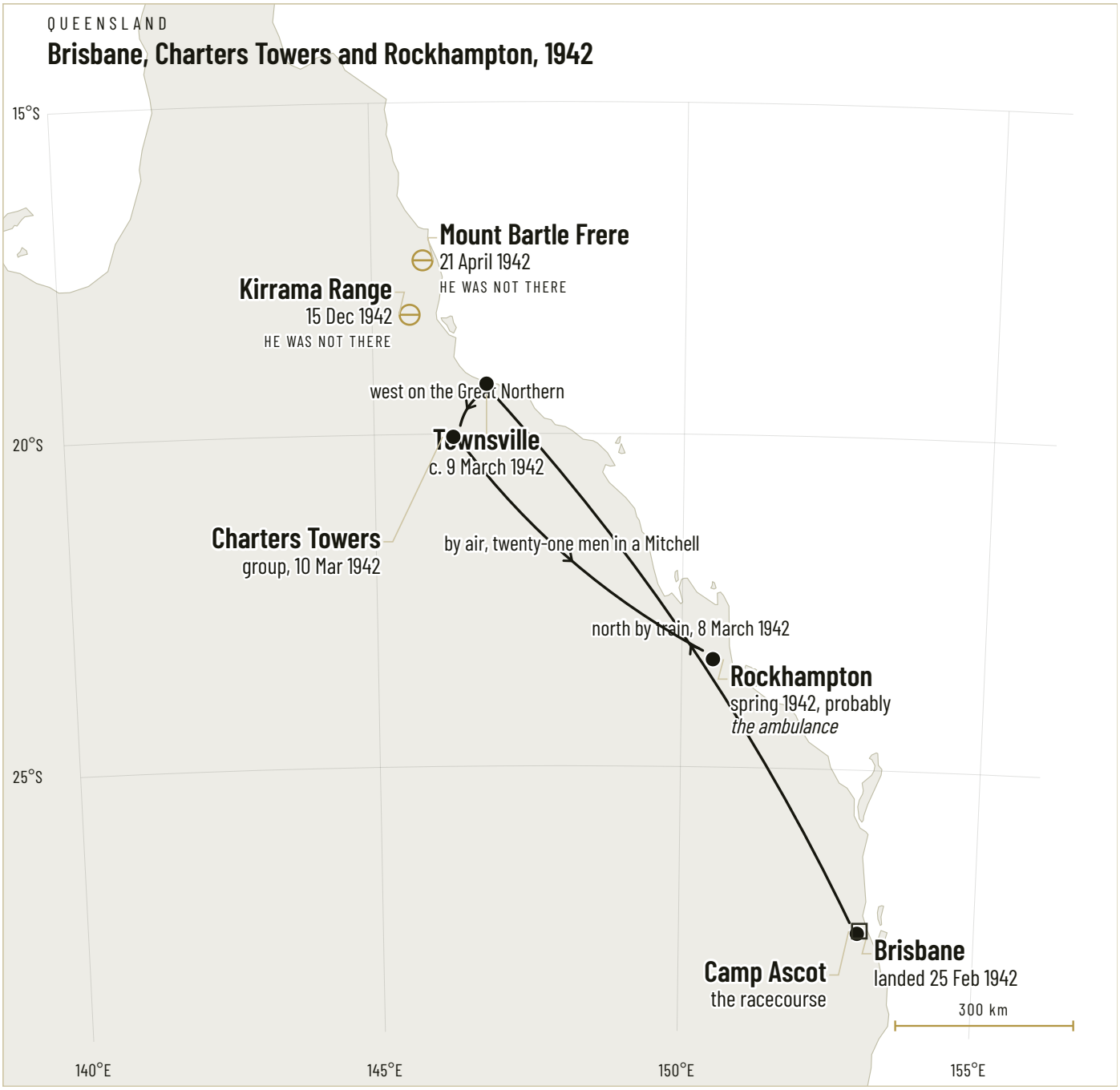
The service years in full: eighty entries between the mathematics prize at Cressona High in June 1936 and his graduation from Coyne in Chicago in January 1946.

▼ HOW TO READ THIS, AND WHAT THE MARKS MEAN

- A **filled diamond** is a date from a document — a service book, a discharge paper, a state form.
- A **blue diamond** is a date from a newspaper printed at the time.
- A **brass diamond** is a date from his own letter home, written in Australia in May 1942. There are only a handful, and they are the best dates in the document.
- A **hollow diamond, with the entry in italic**, is Allen himself, remembering in 2006. The italic is there so the distinction survives a photocopier.
- A **dashed outline** is family memory.
- A **diamond** is a day. A **bar** is a stretch of time — a month, a season, a year, or a run of years — drawn to the length the evidence actually covers, so "spring 1942" is not pretending to be the fifteenth of April.

- The rail at the left runs to scale and the rows do not. Where the brackets fan out, his life was crowded; where they run straight across, it was not.
- The brass bar with a label beside it is a scale stick: it shows how much time one length of rail is worth on that panel, which differs from panel to panel.
- Four panels, each to its own scale. The second covers fourteen months and the first covers five years, which is why the scale sticks differ.
- Where a rank is attested the brass line at the left steps across: private, corporal, sergeant, staff sergeant, master sergeant. It is drawn only where a grade is actually recorded, never between.

Where He Served



Queensland, 1942: Brisbane and Camp Ascot, north by train to Townsville and west to Charters Towers, and the flight to Rockhampton.

▼ THIS DRAWING, SET OUT IN WORDS

- Brisbane, where he landed on 25 February 1942, and Camp Ascot, the racecourse the group was quartered in.

- Townsville on the coast, about 9 March 1942, then west on the Great Northern.
- Charters Towers, the group's station from 10 March 1942.
- Rockhampton, reached by air in the southern spring of 1942 — probably — twenty-one men in a Mitchell, and the ambulance whose number matched the one Donald Berger drove.
- Mount Bartle Frere, where his squadron lost a crew on 21 April 1942. He was not aboard.
- The Kirrama Range, west of Cardwell, where a 90th Squadron B-25 flying home from Port Moresby came down on 15 December 1942; the wreck was not found until July 1943. He was not aboard.
- A filled disc marks a place he is documented to have been. An open square marks a place documented for his unit rather than for him. An open square with a diagonal tick marks his own squadron. A dashed circle marks a place that is inferred rather than recorded.
- A brass ring crossed by a bar marks a place he never stood on — a target, or somewhere his group went without him. Each carries the words HE WAS NOT THERE.
- A solid line is a journey whose means of travel is recorded. A dashed line is a move that is documented while the means is not. A dotted line rests on his own account alone.
- No plate carries a computed distance. The document already holds his own “about 12,000 miles” against a measured 9,500 to 10,200, and a third quietly calculated figure would be the fault this rebuild exists to remove.

A harbour under attack, photographed from the shore beneath a palm frond: a white fireball and streaks of burning debris burst from a warship inside a floating drydock, heavy black smoke rolling across the water behind a pipeline trestle. Identified in the U.S. Navy record (National Archives 80-G-16871) as the destroyer USS Shaw in floating drydock YFD-2, Pearl Harbor, 7 December 1941.

The 90th Squadron in the Field

Named aircraft of the 90th Bomb Squadron, from Allen's own wartime photo collection.

"Hell's Fire," shark-mouth nose art and mission markings.

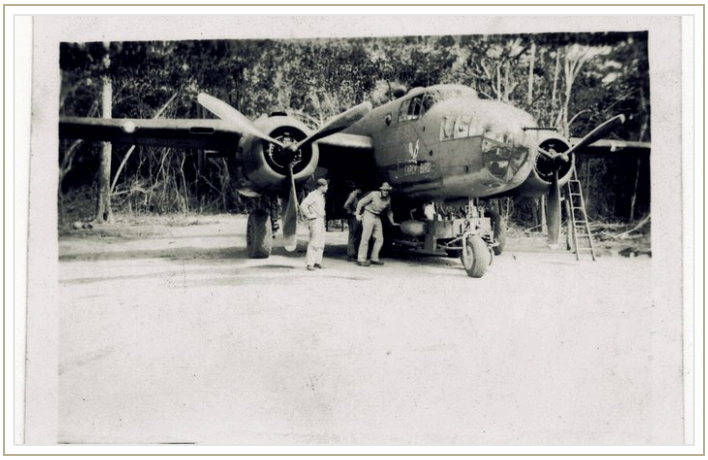
Three crewmen beneath "Chatter Box."

Four crewmen beneath "Shy-Baby."

"Fat Cat" — a cartoon cat smoking a cigar.

Three crewmen in front of "Fat Cat," shark-mouth and bow tie visible.

"Early Bird," rooster nose art, two crewmen in front.



Ground crew load bombs beneath "Early Bird."

"Sad Sack" nose art, a bomb-loading cart beneath the fuselage.

Four crewmen in front of "Merchant."

Two crewmen crouch in front of another shark-mouthed B-25 nose.

Pin-up nose art — a woman seated on a bomb, painted on the fuselage.

*A B-25 Mitchell low over open water, photographed from another aircraft. The fin carries **11290[2]** — the tail number for serial 41-1290[2], a B-25C from the same production block as Spook II, 41-12969. The national insignia is a plain white star in a disc with no side bars, which dates the frame before the end of June 1943, when the bars were added.*

Trucks drawn up in a freshly cleared patch of tall timber, the ground torn to mud and littered with cut branches and logs. Two shirtless men work in the bed of a tandem-axle cargo truck, one paying a rope over the side rail beside a row of sacks; to the right a dump body stands heaped with earth or broken rock. Nothing in the frame fixes the place.

The Planes He Photographed

One of Them Names Itself: 41-12962

The Mitchell photographed low over the water from another aircraft carries **112962** in white on the outer face of the near fin — the tail number for serial 41-12962. That is enough to look up, and it comes back.

Pacific Wrecks records 41-12962 as a B-25C of the Fifth Air Force, **3rd Bombardment Group, 13th Bombardment Squadron**, carrying the names *Calamity Jane* and *M & M*. So this is Allen's own group and not his own squadron: the 13th, not the 90th. It is the only aircraft in the collection identified from a serial rather than from a name painted on the nose.

The number is also close to home in another sense. Spook II was 41-12969. Seven airframes apart in the same contract block, the two of them were built and delivered within days of each other and ended up in the same group.

The frame dates itself as well. The star on the rear fuselage is a plain disc with no side bars, the marking carried until the end of June 1943, so the photograph was made before then.

Sources: the print; Pacific Wrecks — B-25C "Calamity Jane / M & M", serial 41-12962.

A P-40 with White Crosses, and Where It Was Taken LIKELY

The fighter with the crosses is a Curtiss P-40: a liquid-cooled inline engine under a long nose, a low wing and a tailwheel. It is not a P-39, which sits on a nose wheel.

Everything about the setting says the United States rather than the Pacific. Pine woods along the far edge of the field, a long open-sided shed, a boom truck, grass rather than pierced steel plank. The back of the print is rubber-stamped “DO NOT MAIL” and carries no censor mark, which is a stateside handling stamp and not a theatre one.

Large white crosses on the fuselage and upper wing, with the fin and rudder in broad stripes, are exercise markings — put on so that umpires and the other side can tell friend from enemy in a war game. Allen was at the Carolina Manoeuvres of 16–28 November 1941; he wrote them on the back of one of his own photographs. Pine woods, a grass field and aircraft painted up for an exercise fit that, and this document goes no further than saying so. Nothing in the frame carries a date, a unit or a place.

Sources: the print and its reverse; Allen’s own annotation on a Carolina Manoeuvres photograph.

The Frame That Was Not "Fat Cat II"

One caption in this chapter has been calling an aeroplane Fat Cat II. Looked at closely, the print does not say so. What is actually on the fuselage is a Roman **II** in white serif capitals, with a bar above it and a bar below, and shark-mouth teeth in the corner of the frame. The word in front of the numeral is not in the picture at all: the top edge of the print cuts it off.

Two things argue against Fat Cat and for Spook II. The photograph of Spook II reproduced in the group's own printed history shows the II drawn with a bar above and below — the same numeral, drawn the same way. And the frames in this collection that do carry Fat Cat's name carry a cat with it, in a bow tie, in a deck chair or an armchair, with a cigar or a cigarette; none of them carries a numeral. No Fat Cat II turns up anywhere else here, or in the group history.

And then the two prints settle it between them. Set side by side they are one aeroplane: the same shark mouth at the nose, the same cluster of package gun barrels aft, the same mainwheel with its white hubcap, the same scrub behind the tail, and the same II with its bars in the same place on the fuselage. In the other frame the word SPOOK stands above that numeral in large white capitals. In this one the top edge of the paper cuts it off. Three men stand in front of her in each, and they are not the same three.

So this is another frame of Spook II. Allen's own frames of her come to four, three of them separate photographs.

Sources: the print; The Reaper's Harvest, 3rd Bomb Group.

Every Aeroplane in the Collection, With a Name

Asked whether the aeroplanes had all been found, the honest first answer was that nobody had counted. So all two hundred and fifty-three photographs in the wartime chapters were opened and looked at, one at a time, with two questions: is there an aeroplane in this, and is there anything painted on it. Fifty-five have an aeroplane somewhere in the frame. Thirty-seven carry a name, a number, a stencil or a piece of nose art.

Eleven aircraft are named on prints Allen made himself: **Hell's Fire**, with a Japanese flag painted on her nose and about twenty-five mission symbols under the cockpit; **Chatter Box**; **Shy-Baby**; **Spook II**; **Fat Cat**; **Early Bird**, under her white rooster; **Merchant**; **Algernon IV**, with a mission tally of her own; **Sad Sack**; and the one whose sun-bleached name reads **CHIC…A-HIYA**. Five more are named on the one page he kept out of the group's printed history: **The Skipper**, **Mark's Hope**, **Old Thundermug**, **Darlin Dot** and **The Buckeye Kid**, each nose carrying the 90th's two-dice-in-a-disc.

Then there are the ones that got away. A shark-mouthed nose whose name ends in a long-tailed **K**, the rest above the top edge of the print. A fuselage with a pin-up of a woman seated on a bomb and no lettering anywhere near her. A propeller blade whose stencil gives a drawing number, an Air Corps number and the line INSTALLED-7-10-42. And a Mitchell low over the water with **41-1290**[**2**] on her fin, four aircraft away in the serial block from Spook II.

Counting a squadron's aircraft from one man's snapshots is not the same as counting the squadron's aircraft, and this list does not pretend to be an inventory of the 90th. It is what he pointed a camera at.

Method: all 253 wartime photographs read at full size, September 2026.

Fat Cat, and Why She Photographs Light

Every other aeroplane in this collection photographs dark. Fat Cat is pale, and there is a reason for it that the group wrote down at the time. She had flown seventy-three missions and two hundred and forty-five combat hours when she cracked up on landing on 22 June. Rather than scrap her the group stripped two thousand two hundred pounds of equipment out of her, refinished her in bright silver, and put her on the milk run down to the Australian mainland to bring back fresh food and drink for the men.

So the light finish in this frame is not bare factory metal and not a trick of exposure. It is a combat aeroplane that had been retired into the job of fetching the squadrons their supper. The nose art here — the cat in its deck chair, the cigarette, the parasol beneath, the name staggered inside quotation marks — matches detail for detail the photographs of Fat Cat made at Dobodura in about September 1943 by Jack Heyn, who had crossed the Pacific on the same ship as Allen. Allen was at Dobodura from 21 May 1943 and sailed for home on 29 September 1944, which brackets this picture.

Two things are deliberately not said. This was the group's aeroplane by then, rebuilt by men of four squadrons, so she is not written here as the 90th's. And no serial is printed in the caption: Pacific Wrecks records Fat Cat as B-25C 41-12449, but no contemporary source seen here carries a serial at all, and the wartime article that names her gives none. There was also more than one. Elsewhere in this same collection is a quite different machine — olive drab, shark-mouthed, package guns, and a cat that is a head in a bow tie between the two words of her name rather than a cat in a chair. Two aeroplanes, two paintings, one name. A third print, which used to be filed here as "Fat Cat II" on the strength of a Roman numeral, has turned out to be Spook II with her name cut off by the edge of the paper, and has been moved out of Fat Cat's file.

Sources: the 3rd Bomb Group's own wartime paper, as quoted by Australia @ War; photographs of Fat Cat at Dobodura credited to Jack Heyn and Howard E. Poit; 3rd Attack Group Association; Pacific Wrecks (for the serial, reported and not confirmed).

Serial numbers and fates for the named B-25s in Allen's own collection, checked against the 3rd Bomb Group's surviving loss records and against its own official unit history, *The Reaper's Harvest* — the same book Allen kept, digitized in full by the 3rd Attack Group Association.

Spook II, 41-12969, was Larner's own aircraft. Leading his squadron into the attack at the Battle of the Bismarck Sea, March 3, 1943, he radioed his wingmen off his tail — "Get off my wing, you guys, get your own damn ships! This one's mine!" — and bore down alone on the largest ship in the convoy, a Teratsuki-class

destroyer. The 3rd Bomb Group's strafers helped sink or damage every vessel in an 18-ship convoy that day, the action that proved low-level strafing tactics could work. Spook II — also logged as Onkle Rafe — stayed Larner's aircraft until she crashed on April 30, 1943.

Fat Cat, 41-12449, was flown by 1st Lt. William R. "Red" Johnson. **Feather Merchant** (also called Irene), 41-12442 — likely the "Merchant" in Allen's own photo — survived the war and was later put on display at Aitape High School. **Chatter Box** is harder to pin down: one detailed account gives 41-13088, piloted by Capt. Bob Chatt at the Bismarck Sea; the 3rd Bomb Group's own loss roster instead lists a "El Diablo III / Chatter Box," 41-30088, pilot Howe, force-landed April 16, 1943 — possibly the same aircraft renamed, possibly two planes that shared a name, as squadrons sometimes did once one was lost. Hell's Fire, Early Bird, Shy-Baby, Algernon IV and Sad Sack have so far given up no serial numbers at all, neither in the unit's own history book nor in the outside aviation archives; a data plate or a nose number in a sharper print would settle them.

Sources: Pacific Wrecks, 3rd Bombardment Group aircraft roster; worldwarphotos.info; Warbird Information Exchange forum; The Reaper's Harvest (3rd Attack Group Association).

Chatter Box, In the Flesh

This print comes from the unit history book rather than from Allen's camera, and it puts a face to the aircraft named on the previous page: the 90th Squadron's own *Chatter Box*, shark's teeth painted across her nose, with the men of the squadron posed in front of her. The book's own caption reads simply, "90th Squadron men who participated in Bismarck Sea Battle." Allen is not picked out anywhere in the crowd, and nothing in the frame says which of the two logged serial numbers this particular airframe wore. What it does give is the name, the nose art, and the squadron's own judgement that this was a photograph worth printing.

FROM THE UNIT HISTORY BOOK

"90th Squadron men who participated in Bismarck Sea Battle," from The Reaper's Harvest.

The Dutch B-25s

Allen's memory here is exact, and the paperwork backs him. On 30 June 1941 the Netherlands Purchasing Commission contracted for 162 B-25C Mitchells, and the first eighteen began reaching Archerfield aerodrome outside Brisbane from 2 March 1942 — by which date the Netherlands East Indies they had been bought to defend was a week from surrender, Java capitulating on 8 March. The first dozen wore Netherlands Indies serials in the N5- series, N5-120 to N5-131, and the orange triangle national marking, and with no Dutch crews available to fly them a delivery agreement passed the bulk of the shipment to American units: of fifty-four aircraft, eighteen were to go to the Netherlands East Indies and thirty-six, plus six already landed, to the USAAF.

On 1 April 1942 a party from the 3rd Bomb Group flew down to Archerfield to collect them, and some went on flying for a time still carrying their Dutch serials. The Queensland Heritage Register entry for Charters Towers airfield states the same thing plainly: the group's A-24 dive bombers were followed by B-25s intended for the Dutch in the East Indies and taken over by the Americans. The story is often told as a theft — Pappy Gunn helping himself to idle Dutch bombers — but a Dutch curator and the delivery agreement both point to a formal handover, and Allen's own word, consigned, is closer to the documents than the legend is. The Dutch-language instruction pamphlets are his own contribution to the record: no published account we have found so much as mentions them, though they are exactly what a factory-consigned aeroplane would have arrived with.

Sources: IPMS Nederland — ML-KNIL B-25 Mitchell (English); Queensland Heritage Register 602739 — Charters Towers Airfield Bore Sight Range and Compass Swinging Platform; Australia @ War — How the 3rd Bomb Group obtained their B-25 Mitchells from the Dutch; Australia @ War — 3rd Bombardment Group.

Turning a bomber into a strafer

What Allen is describing from the inside is one of the most consequential field modifications of the Pacific war. The Mitchell came out of the factory as a medium bomber that attacked from altitude; the 3rd Bomb Group took it apart and rebuilt it to attack from treetop height. The bombsight and the bombardier went, because at fifty feet the pilot simply aims the aeroplane and lets the bombs go himself.

The retractable belly turret went too — useless at that height, and an expensive drag and weight penalty. In their place went four fixed .50 calibre Browning guns in the nose, fired through the old bomb-aiming panel, and four more in pairs in blister packages on the fuselage sides below the cockpit: eight forward-firing guns, all of them under the pilot's thumb. The work began at Eagle Farm aerodrome in Brisbane about November and December 1942, with a dozen aircraft finished by February 1943, after which the programme moved to the air depot at Townsville, which had turned out roughly 175 converted B-25C and D strafers by September 1943. One small correction to offer gently: Allen remembers the extra guns as being out on the wings, while every technical account puts them in those fuselage-side packages — outboard of the crew, but not on the wing.

Sources: Australia @ War — B-25 Strafer Field Modifications; Aircraft Information — B-25C/D Strafers; Queensland Heritage Register 602739 — Charters Towers Airfield Bore Sight Range; Pacific Wrecks — 3rd Bombardment Group, North American B-25 Mitchells.

Pappy Gunn and the man from North American

The rebuild Allen lived through was the work of two men, one of whom was standing on his own airfield. Jack Fox was North American Aviation's field service representative based at Charters Towers, and he worked up drawings showing .50 calibre guns built into the bombardier's station and sent them back to North American's California plant — drawings developed with Major Paul Irvin Gunn of the 3rd Bomb Group, universally known as Pappy. Gunn was an unlikely officer: born 18 October 1899, an enlisted Navy pilot who retired as a chief petty officer in December 1939 after twenty-one years, an instructor at Pensacola, and a founder's partner in Philippine Air Lines.

When the Philippines fell his wife and four children were interned at Santo Tomas, which is generally held to explain a good deal about how hard he fought the rest of the war. Already a captain by the Java campaign, he had been commissioned straight into the Army Air Forces, and General Kenney later took him onto his personal staff as his special-projects man; North American eventually built versions of his armament ideas into production Mitchells. Gunn was killed when his aircraft went down in a storm over the Philippines on 11 October 1957.

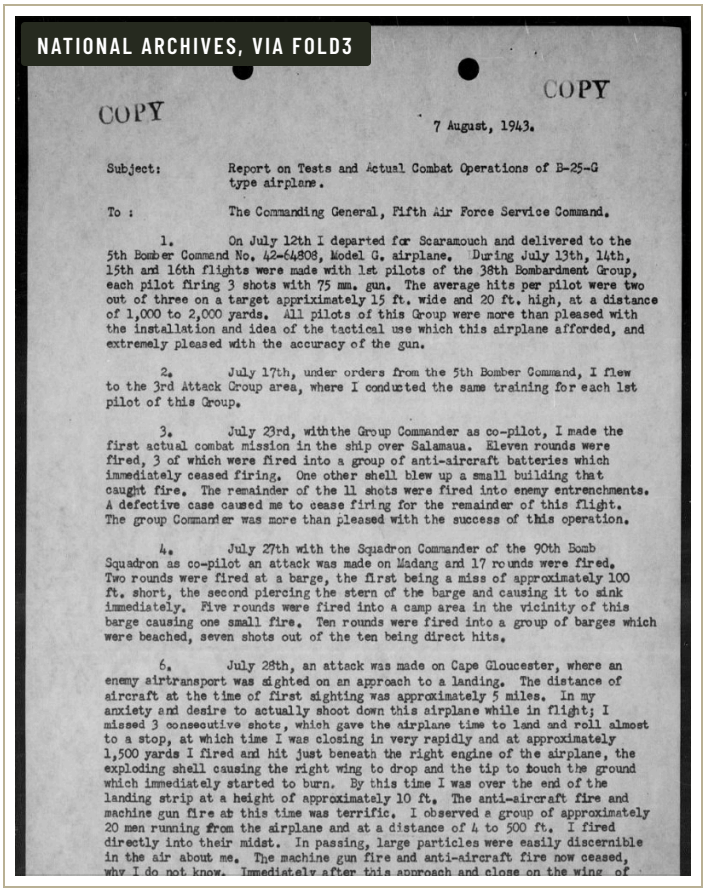
Sources: Australia @ War — Paul Irvin "Pappy" Gunn in Australia during WW2; Wikipedia — Pappy Gunn; Australia @ War — B-25 Strafer Field Modifications; Aircraft Information — B-25C/D Strafers (Jack Fox and Major Paul I. Gunn, 3rd Bombardment Group).

Gunn's Own Report on the Cannon B-25, July 1943

Gunn's next machine was the B-25G, with a 75-millimetre cannon in the nose, and his own report on it survives in a Navy file. It is dated 7 August 1943 and addressed to the commanding general of the Fifth Air Force Service Command, and it reached the Chief of Naval Operations that autumn, forwarded on 30 October by the Seventh Fleet's air commander. On 17 July, Gunn writes, he flew to the 3rd Attack Group under orders from V Bomber Command and trained each of its first pilots on the gun.

Then he took it into combat with the group's own officers in the right-hand seat. On 23 July the group commander sat beside him over Salamaua. On 27 July it was "the Squadron Commander of the 90th Bomb Squadron", in an attack on Madang that fired seventeen rounds and sank a barge. Over Cape Gloucester on the 28th he went in on the wing of a Colonel Hall, who was leading. The report does not name the 90th's commander, and Allen is not in it.

Source: Lt. Col. P. I. Gunn, "Report on Tests and Actual Combat Operations of B-25-G type airplane", 7 August 1943, enclosure A to Commander Aircraft Seventh Fleet, "Report of operations by U.S. aircraft against Japanese small craft in the southwest Pacific", 30 October 1943 (National Archives, World War II War Diaries), via Fold3.



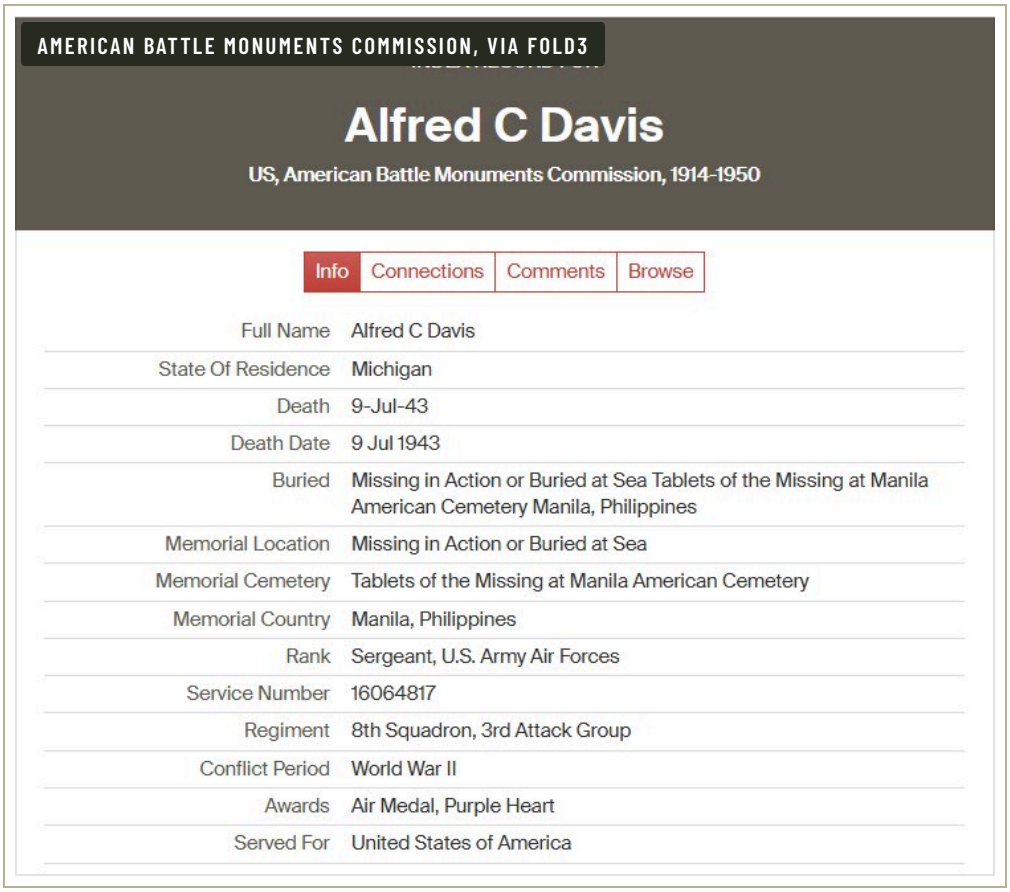
The first page of Pappy Gunn's report on the B-25G, 7 August 1943. Paragraph 4: "July 27th with the Squadron Commander of the 90th Bomb Squadron as co-pilot an attack was made on Madang and 17 rounds were fired." Allen is not named. Credit: National Archives, World War II War Diaries, Commander Aircraft Seventh Fleet file of 30 October 1943, via Fold3.

Three Men of the Group on the Tablets at Manila

Fold3 carries an index of the American Battle Monuments Commission's records for 1914 to 1950. Three of its entries from July 1943 give the unit as the 3rd Attack Group, the name Allen's group went by. Captain Ralph C. Payne of Ohio, 8th Squadron, died on 4 July. Sergeant Alfred C. Davis of Michigan, also of the 8th, died on the 9th, and the index credits him with the Air Medal and the Purple Heart. Flight Officer Robert L. Sturm of West Virginia, 13th Squadron, died on the 23rd and is credited with the Purple Heart.

Each is entered as "Missing in Action or Buried at Sea", and each is named on the Tablets of the Missing at the Manila American Cemetery. The index says nothing about how or where they were lost. None of the three was in the 90th, and Allen is not named. A search of Fold3 in October 2026 found no memorial page for any of them beyond the index entry, and no Missing Air Crew Report for their losses has been looked for.

Source: US, American Battle Monuments Commission, 1914–1950, index records for Ralph C. Payne (Fold3 record 529974010), Alfred C. Davis (529947978) and Robert L. Sturm (529988563), via Fold3.



American Battle Monuments Commission index record for Sergeant Alfred C. Davis of Michigan, 8th Squadron, 3rd Attack Group, who died on 9 July 1943: Air Medal and Purple Heart, "Missing in Action or Buried at Sea", named on the Tablets of the Missing at the Manila American Cemetery. Allen is not named. Fold3 record 529947978. Credit: American Battle Monuments Commission records, 1914 to 1950, via Fold3.

The seat that was deleted

This is the quietest sentence in the interview and one of the most personal. A B-25 came to the 90th Squadron with a crew of six — two pilots, a bombardier, two gunners and a radio man. The strafer flew with three, and the trade Allen had taught himself by mail order from Cressona, and then studied at Scott Field from about June to October 1941 by his own reckoning, no longer had a seat in the aeroplane. Published crew tables for Fifth Air Force strafers do not agree with one another — some units kept a radio-gunner, and the factory-built B-25G and H still carried a radio operator — so what Allen is describing is what his own squadron actually flew, not a rule laid down for the whole air force.

What did not disappear was the work. Elsewhere in the same interview he lays out exactly what the section did instead: service the radio sets in the aircraft, run a ground radio station, and lay and maintain the telephone lines between every operations building and the tents of the men in charge — patching calls by hand on an antique switchboard whose little flaps dropped down when a call came in. He went home a Master Sergeant and a communications chief. The seat was deleted; the trade was not.

Sources: Aircraft Information — B-25C/D Strafers; Australia @ War — B-25 Strafer Field Modifications; Allen E. Sweigert interview transcript, part 1 (family recording); Allen E. Sweigert handwritten service record book, transcribed in the interview PDF (90th Bomb Squadron, 4-10-41 to 9-10-44).

The bomb on a parachute LIKELY

Low-level attack only works if the bomb you drop does not catch you, and the answer was a small fragmentation bomb hung beneath a parachute. The canopy killed the bomb's forward speed and an instantaneous fuze burst it in the open, so the aircraft that had dropped it was already clear of the blast. General Kenney is the man usually credited with pushing the parafrag into the South West Pacific, out of prewar Army experiments, and with finding a stock of them in war reserve before he left for Australia — though we have not yet found a published source we would stand behind for the year he began that work, the number shipped, or the fragment count so often quoted.

The use of them is beyond argument: on 12 October 1943 the 3rd Bomb Group went into Rapopo airfield with 20lb parafrags and .50 calibre fire, and from then on that pairing, delivered at treetop height, was the Grim Reapers' signature. The group is also widely said to have flown the first parafrag mission of the war, over Buna airfield in Papua in September 1942, and one of the bombs is said to be displayed in the Second World War gallery of the National Museum of the United States Air Force; both are worth chasing down to a document, and the group's own history, The Reaper's Harvest, is the place to start. Even the nominal weight is unsettled: the sources give it as both 20 and 23 pounds.

Sources: National Museum of the United States Air Force — WWII Weapons (23-pound parafrag bomb on display); Wikipedia — 3rd Operations Group (lineage and WWII tactical innovations); History of War — 3rd Bombardment Group (parafrag use, Rapopo, October 1943); Wikipedia — George Kenney (no mention of parafrag development; instantaneous fuzes and the Pruth demonstration).

Four squadrons, and an older name

The transcript loses the last of the four numbers Allen is reciting, and it happens to be his own: the 8th, the 13th, the 89th and the 90th Bombardment Squadrons. The group they belonged to had one of the longest pedigrees in American military aviation. It was organised on 1 July 1919 as the Army Surveillance Group, became the 1st Surveillance Group that August, the 3rd Group (Attack) on 15 September 1921 and the 3rd Attack Group on 25 January 1923; it was redesignated 3rd Bombardment Group (Light) on 15 September 1939, briefly (Dive) from 28 September 1942, and (Light) again from 25 May 1943.

Officially a bombardment group for the whole of Allen's service, it went on calling itself the 3rd Attack Group anyway — there is a hand-painted "3rd Attack Gp" sign in his own photographs — which, given what it was actually doing over New Guinea, was the more honest description. Its wartime station list reads like a fair copy of Allen's own itinerary: Brisbane from 25 February 1942, Charters Towers from 10 March 1942, Port Moresby from 28 January 1943, Dobodura from 20 May 1943, Nadzab from 3 February 1944 and Hollandia from 12 May 1944. It came out of the war with a Distinguished Unit Citation for Papua and another for the Wewak strike of 17 August 1943 — the five citations often quoted for the group include its three Korean War awards — and a name nobody had to be told twice: the Grim Reapers.

Sources: Army Air Corps Museum — 3rd Bombardment Group (lineage, stations with dates, campaign credits); Wikipedia — 3rd Operations Group (full designation history); Pacific Wrecks — 3rd Bombardment Group "The Grim Reapers"; History of War — 3rd Bombardment Group (Wewak DUC, 17 August 1943; squadron list).

Aiming an aeroplane

Eight guns bolted rigidly to an airframe are aimed by aiming the aeroplane, which means that before a strafer is any use to anybody, somebody has to line its guns up on a measured target on the ground. At Charters Towers the concrete for doing exactly that is still there.

In mid-February 1943 the US Army put a requisition to the Queensland Department of Public Works for a bore sight range: a firing platform with an adjustable steel plate to take the nose wheel of tricycle-undercarriage aircraft such as the B-25, sighting some 1,180 feet down to a target area, together with a compass swinging platform. It is the only known example of its type in Queensland and was entered on the Queensland Heritage Register on 14 May 2010. One thing to be honest about: it went up after Allen's group had gone north to New Guinea, and it served the fighter and bomber replacement training centre that took over the field. But it was built for his aeroplane, to solve the problem his squadron's conversion had created.

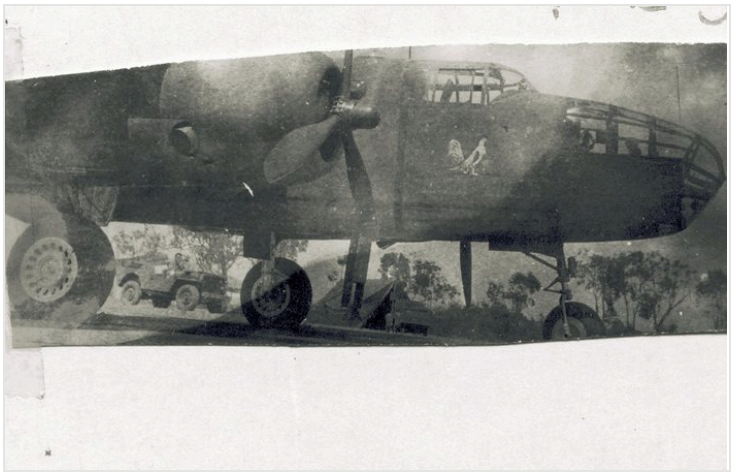
Sources: Queensland Heritage Register 602739 — Charters Towers Airfield Bore Sight Range and Compass Swinging Platform; Wikipedia — Bore Sight Range and Compass Swinging Platform at Charters Towers Airfield; Queensland WWII Historic Places — Charters Towers Airfield.

A serviceman in oil-stained coveralls stands between the propeller and the nose of a combat aircraft, with a white rooster painted on the nose above lettering now too faded to read. A tent and a truck stand at the edge of the strip behind him.

Three men stand under the nose of a bomber lettered in outlined capitals, the first letters reading CHIC and the last, past a worn stretch, HIYA; the man nearest the camera is stripped to the waist and wearing dog tags. Two pairs of machine-gun barrels project from the gun pack on the fuselage side, with the main wheel and a tarpaulin behind them.

A low oblique aerial photograph of two small coastal vessels lying close alongside one another in sheltered water, with smoke or steam rising between their hulls, a boat made fast on the outboard side, and a narrow straight track of white water running across the surface toward them. A mangrove shoreline fills the top of the frame.

A serviceman in coveralls and a soft cap stands with one hand raised against the nose of a bomber lettered "SAD SACK" in quotation marks, with the cursive word "The" above it and a reclining pin-up painted below. A spare tyre stands upright on the ground at the left, and crates and equipment are stacked along the hardstand behind him.



A twin-engined bomber standing on a dispersal, photographed from beneath the wing, with a white cockerel painted on the nose ahead of the cockpit glazing; a jeep with a driver at the wheel is parked under the fuselage, and scrub and gum trees stand beyond.

*Spook II. A serviceman in light fatigues and a soft cap leans into her open cockpit, an access hatch swung down beside him, the first letters of her name — **SPO** — painted across the nose and hatch. Here they are outlined capitals with a drop shadow, where the frames that show the back of the name have it in solid white. An aerial wire runs from the canopy back along the fuselage, a small dorsal dome shows above it, and jungle trees rise behind.*

*The same photograph again, re-shot so the back could be read. The nose carries the outlined, drop-shadowed capitals **SPO**, with the rest of the word behind the man's leg and the edge of the print. The back reads "Maj. Edward[?] L…": the rank Major is clear and the given name reads Edward, with Edmund possible, but the surname runs off the right edge of the photograph of the back rather than off the paper, so it could be recovered by re-photographing.*

Three crewmen, one shirtless, beneath "Spook II."

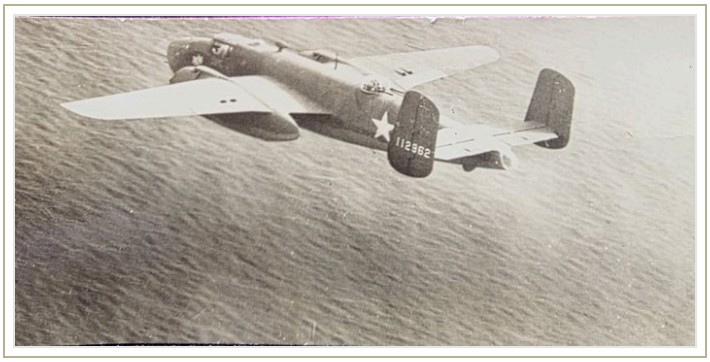
*Crewmen standing at attention in front of a field-modified B-25 strafer. All that survives of her name is a Roman **II** in white serif capitals with a bar above and below; the word in front of it is cut off by the top edge of the print, and shark-mouth teeth show in the top left corner. She is Spook II. Another print in this collection shows the same nose from a little lower, with the word SPOOK standing above that same II; here the top edge of the paper has cut it off. This caption used to call her "Fat Cat II."*

Crewmen load a belt of ammunition into the top turret of a B-25. The letters "OOK" show on the fuselage beside them — the back end of SPOOK, with the rest of the name out of frame.

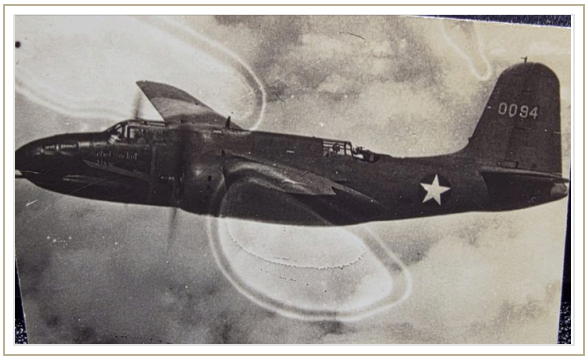
*The same photograph as the turret-loading frame in the ground crew section, re-shot from the print. Four men handle long belts of machine-gun ammunition at the fuselage of a B-25, two belts hanging in loops over the top from a man kneeling up there with a steel helmet beside him. The letters **OOK** stand on the skin in solid white capitals — the back end of SPOOK, the rest of the name forward of the frame.*

A loose formation of A-20 Havocs, photographed from another aircraft at height against an empty sky. At least five machines are in the frame, strung out in line abreast and stepped down, each carrying a single white letter on the fin — K on the nearest, P on the one in the centre. The print is a small contact print, faded and torn along the top edge.

A twin-engine bomber banks away at the top left of the frame while the camera aircraft runs low over a coastline. Dark smoke stands in two or three columns along the shore in the middle distance, with a ridge behind it flattened by haze. The exposure is heavily burnt out in the sky and the print does not say where this is.



A B-25 Mitchell photographed from above and behind, flying low over open water; the wind ripple on the sea fills the whole background. The twin fins, the gull-wing break outboard of the nacelles and the retracted ventral turret under the rear fuselage are all clear, and the serial 112962 is painted in white on the outer face of the near fin. A white star without bars is carried on the rear fuselage ahead of the tailplane.



A twin-engined bomber photographed in flight from another aircraft, banking away so that the far wing rises above the fuselage line. The fin carries the number 0094, and a line of script nose art runs below the cockpit which the print is too coarse to read with confidence. The national insignia on the rear fuselage is a plain white star on a dark disc with no side bars, which places the frame before late June 1943.

A four-engined bomber standing on a cleared dispersal, photographed from off the port bow. A white kangaroo is painted on the nose with the aircraft's name in two lines of small white capitals beside it; the print is too coarse to read the name with certainty. A maintenance stand stands against the nose, and the wing, engine nacelle and undercarriage leg of a second aircraft fill the right of the frame.

Two wrecked aircraft lying in long grass at the edge of scrub, seen from the side. Both have been stripped: cowlings removed and the engine cylinders left bare, glazing gone from the canopies with the frames still standing, and panels missing from the fuselage sides. The letters F-1 are painted on the fin of the right-hand machine.

Major Edward L. Larner in the cockpit of Spook II. This one is not Allen's photograph: it is a page from the 3rd Bomb Group's published unit history, The Reaper's Harvest, and it shows the same aircraft Allen photographed himself on the previous page.

Spook II, Four Photographs

Four of Allen's photographs show the same aeroplane, and until his grandson said so none of them was recognised for what it was. Said out loud it is plain enough — SP is the front of her name and OK is the back of it, and a man walking round one aircraft on one afternoon catches it from both ends. She is **Spook II**, and a fifth frame gives the whole name at once: SPOOK in solid white capitals with a Roman II below it, drawn with a bar above and below.

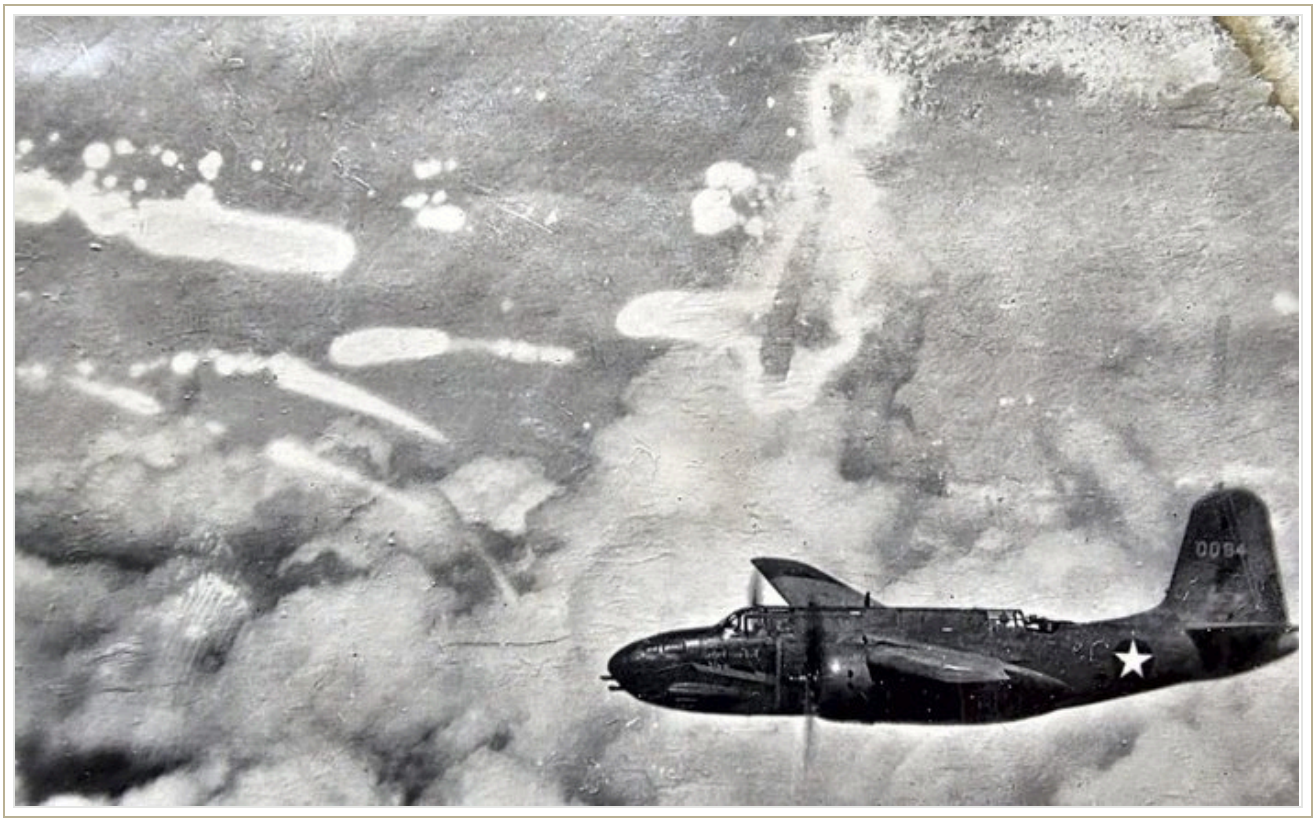
One detail is worth recording and not over-reading. In the frame that shows the front of the name, the letters are outlined with a drop shadow; in the frames that show the back of it, they are solid white. That could be the nose lettered differently from the fuselage side, or one side of the aircraft differently from the other, or a repaint between one photograph and the next. This document briefly built a second aeroplane on that difference, reading the airframe in the SP frame as an A-20 Havoc rather than a Mitchell. Enlarged, that frame shows a long fuselage and a small dorsal dome and no tail at all, so there was nothing in it to support the reading, and it has been withdrawn.

Larner really did have two aircraft and really did carry the name from one to the next — an A-20A Havoc, serial 40-109, and then the B-25C, 41-12969 — and that is set out on its own elsewhere in this chapter. What is not claimed any more is that Allen photographed the first one.

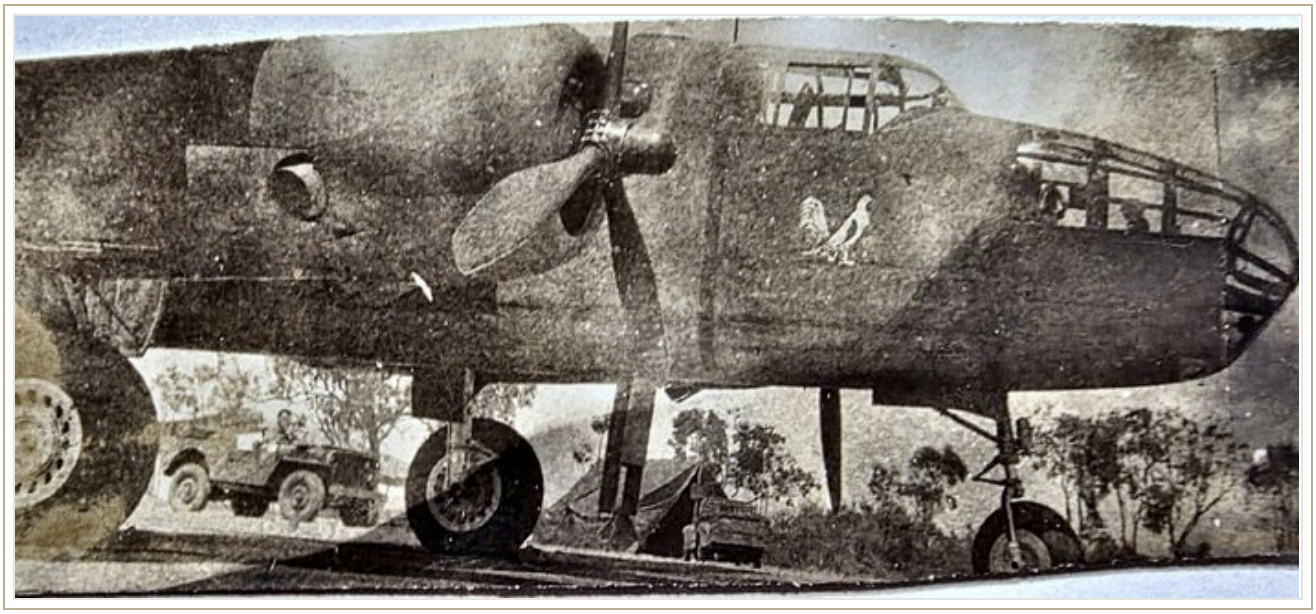
The count is smaller than it looks. The SP frame appears twice in this document, once as a scan of the print and once as a phone photograph of the same print made to capture its back; so does the turret-loading frame. Six figures, four photographs, one aeroplane.

And the date holds. Spook II went into the ground at Dobodura on 30 April 1943 with all eight aboard, so every frame of her here was made before that, which makes them the earliest firmly dated aircraft pictures in the collection. The pencil on the back of one of them reads "Maj. Edward L…" — on a print of Larner's own aeroplane, which is as close as this collection comes to naming the man in the cockpit.

Identification: Jeremy Sweigert, September 2026. Pacific Wrecks — B-25C Spook II / Onkle Rafe, serial 41-12969.

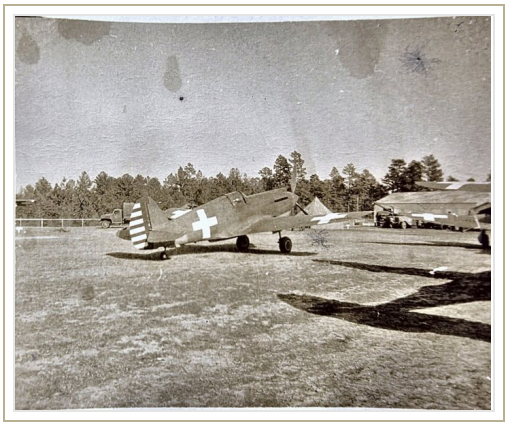


*A Douglas A-20 Havoc seen in profile from slightly above, crossing the frame nose-left: a solid, unglazed nose — a field strafer conversion — a single tall fin carrying the number **0094**, and a plain white star-in-circle with no bars on the rear fuselage. The air ahead of and above it is streaked with pale puffs and trails of smoke.*



A B-25 Mitchell with its bombardier nose unmodified, parked at a dispersal, a white strutting cockerel painted on the starboard nose below the cockpit. A jeep with two men aboard, a tarpaulin shelter and a stake-bed truck stand in the sunlit background. Two other prints here show the same cockerel with EARLY BIRD lettered beneath it, so this is probably that aircraft; no name is painted below the bird in this frame, and no serial or unit marking is in view.

"Fat Cat," a B-25 Mitchell of the 3rd Bomb Group, on the line in New Guinea. The black cat in its deck chair with the cigarette, the parasol beneath it and the name staggered in quotation marks match, detail for detail, published photographs of Fat Cat taken at Dobodura in about September 1943.

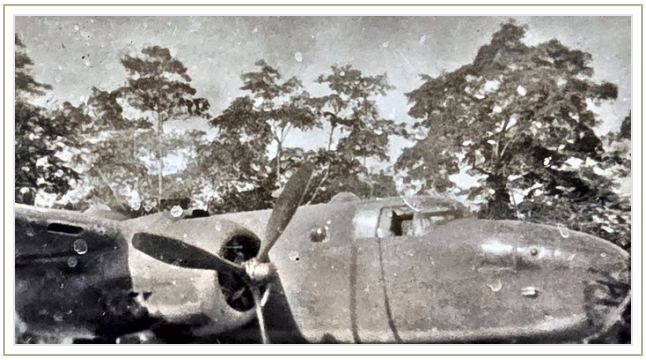


A Curtiss P-40 — a single-engine low-wing fighter with an inline liquid-cooled engine and a tailwheel — standing on a grass field, its fuselage and upper wing painted with large white crosses and its fin and rudder in broad stripes. A cargo truck is parked at the left behind the tail; at the right, in front of a long open-sided shed, stand a truck fitted with a boom and further aircraft carrying the same white markings, one of them cut by the edge of the print, with pine woods along the far edge. Its back is rubber-stamped "DO NOT MAIL" in block capitals and carries no censor stamp.

A man in shirtsleeves, trousers and a garrison cap stands beneath the nose of a B-25 Mitchell, a three-bladed propeller above his head and the white rooster of EARLY BIRD on the starboard nose. The name itself is not legible in this frame; the aircraft is identified from the bird. Vehicles, tentage and stacked gear stand on the open field behind him.

Two bare-chested men crouch on the strip beside a main wheel and its oleo strut under an aircraft wing, one in a pith helmet and one in a fatigue cap. Above and to the right, a row of painted white teeth runs along the fuselage, part of a shark-mouth marking.

A narrow strip of a photograph showing a parked bomber from the side — a wing running out to the left with its tip toward the camera, the framed cockpit glazing and a rounded engine cowling below it, and a large plain white star national insignia, with no bar, further aft on the fuselage. One man in light clothing stands at the wing root beside the engine, and a low treeline runs behind the aircraft. No name is written on the back; the reverse carries only the censor stamp "PASSED BY / BASE / 2415 / U.S. ARMY / EXAMINER".



The nose, cockpit glazing and one three-bladed propeller of a bomber standing in a clearing at the edge of tall timber, with no one in the frame. The back of this print is rubber-stamped "DO NOT MAIL" in block capitals, with ink writing added over the stamp afterwards and no censor stamp.

Margaret: the airplane in the photograph

The aircraft was B-25C Mitchell serial 41-12946, constructor's number 82–5581, built by North American Aviation at Inglewood, California, and ferried overseas by way of Hickam Field and across the Pacific to Australia. Peter Dunn's Australia @ War records it as the first strafer-modified B-25, arriving at Charters Towers on 8 December 1942 and assigned there to the 90th Bombardment Squadron, 3rd Bombardment Group — Allen's own squadron, on Allen's own field, three months after he turned twenty-four.

The conversion fitted eight forward-firing Browning .50 caliber machine guns: four grouped in the nose, set through the original bomb-aiming panel, and four more in blister packages hung two to a side on the forward fuselage. The Army Air Forces official history independently supports the timing, noting that the experimental model had passed its tests in December 1942 and that by April some thirty B-25Cs had been modified the same way. Allen described the same surgery from the inside of it, in his own words, without ever naming the airplane that proved it.

Sources: B-25 Strafer Field Modifications — Australia @ War (Peter Dunn); Pacific Wrecks — B-25C "Margaret" Serial Number 41-12946; The Army Air Forces in World War II, Vol. IV, ch. 5 (Craven & Cate, HyperWar); 3rd Bombardment Group — Australia @ War (Peter Dunn).

Who cut the guns in, and where the record goes soft LIKELY

The idea belonged to Major Paul I. “Pappy” Gunn of the 3rd Bombardment Group — the old naval aviator Kenney had put in charge of special projects — working with Jack Fox, North American Aviation’s field service representative in Australia, who was based at Charters Towers alongside Allen’s squadron; Kenney gave the program his authorization after seeing what Gunn had already done to the A-20. Where the work on Margaret was actually done is less settled than the conversion itself.

The only published caption anyone has found for the aircraft places her in a hangar at Garbutt airfield at Townsville, in Base Depot Number 4; yet the same page’s account of the program says the modifications began at Eagle Farm in Brisbane about November or December 1942, and the big Townsville depot job it describes in detail is a later one — more than sixty Mitchells of the 345th Group, at Depot Number 2 at Mount Louisa, in August 1943. Which shed and whose hands finished Margaret is simply not on the record. Allen remembered the guns as being out on the wings, which is the one detail the written record does not support — the side packages hung in blisters on the fuselage under the cockpit, not on the wing. That is a sixty-year-old memory of a shape glimpsed from the radio compartment, not an error worth correcting so much as a reminder of how he saw the airplane.

Sources: B-25 Strafer Field Modifications — Australia @ War (Peter Dunn); Paul Irvin “Pappy” Gunn in Australia during WW2 — Australia @ War; B-25C/D Strafers — aircraftinformation.info; The Genesis of the B-25 Mitchell Strafer-Bomber — Tails Through Time.

“First conversion” and “first combat” are two different claims LIKELY

Two aircraft carry a claim to being the first B-25 strafer, and both deserve their hearing here. Australia @ War names 41-12946 Margaret as the first strafer-modified B-25; a separate and equally common account names B-25C 41-12437, the airframe chosen for the initial tests and remembered ever since as “Pappy’s Folly.” That second aircraft has a particular resonance here, because Pacific Wrecks records it as one of the Mitchells built against the Netherlands East Indies order — delivered in February 1942 as N5-132, ferried to Australia, flown by the Dutch-manned No. 18 Squadron out of RAAF Fairbairn before the Army Air Forces took it over on 1 September 1942, and posted during 1943 to the 90th itself.

It was one of the Dutch-consigned machines Allen remembered arriving with Dutch markings and Dutch manuals. The combat claim is also narrower than it sounds: the Army Air Forces official history records that the 90th’s crews practiced for weeks on an old wreck lying off Port Moresby, and that the planes “went out twice during February against real targets, but each time failed to locate the reported vessels.” The Bismarck Sea was therefore the first time the strafers proved themselves in action, not the first time they went out looking for a fight — and nothing anyone wrote down will carry the claim further than that.

Sources: Pacific Wrecks — B-25C 41-12437 (“General Custer” / “Pappy’s Folly”); B-25C/D Strafers — aircraftinformation.info; B-25 Strafer Field Modifications — Australia @ War (Peter Dunn); The Army Air Forces in World War II, Vol. IV, ch. 5 (Craven & Cate, HyperWar).

Bismarck Sea, 3 March 1943: thirty-seven bombs, seventeen hits

The Army Air Forces official history records that twelve of the 90th Squadron's B-25C-1s flew in the coordinated morning attack of 3 March 1943 — "probably the most successful attack of all" — and that out of the thirty-seven bombs dropped, seventeen were claimed as direct hits. The official history does not name the man who led them; for that the source is Kenney himself, quoted in Air & Space Forces Magazine: "Ed Larner with twelve of my new B-25 commerce destroyers skip-bombed," and "Ed Larner's squadron dropped thirty-seven 500-pound bombs, scoring seventeen direct hits." Pacific Wrecks credits eight 90th Squadron aircraft with sinking a destroyer and two transports that day.

Across the battle of 2 to 4 March, Allied air power sank all eight Japanese transports and four of the eight escorting destroyers, and the low-level gunship Mitchell was never questioned again. Larner did not long outlive the vindication: he was killed over his own field in the spring of 1943, a loss the group set down in its own published history and nowhere online. Whether Margaret herself was one of the twelve in the air that morning, nobody wrote down — and it would be wrong to put her among them.

Sources: The Army Air Forces in World War II, Vol. IV, ch. 5 (Craven & Cate, HyperWar); Pacific Wrecks — Battle of the Bismarck Sea; Pacific Wrecks — 90th Bombardment Squadron (90th BS); Victory in the Bismarck Sea — Air & Space Forces Magazine.

What became of her, and the other photograph

Margaret did not die in combat. On 7 August 1943 she took off from Port Moresby under 1st Lt Joseph H. Castelli on a mission to practice formation flying, flew too low, and struck the sea about two miles due east of Buna airfield in Papua; Herschel Piper's diary describes the left engine catching the water, the propeller breaking away, the right wing digging in, and the airplane going over on its back and sinking in a matter of seconds. All four men aboard were killed: 1st Lt Castelli, 2nd Lt Hugh A. Phelps, Sgt Daniel W. Atkins and Pfc Harry J. Spies.

Only Atkins was recovered, and he was buried afterward at Woodlawn Cemetery in Spray, North Carolina; the other three are named on the tablets of the missing at Manila American Cemetery. The aircraft was condemned two days later, and no Missing Air Crew Report was raised. The only published photograph of her located anywhere is a single Australia @ War image, captioned as showing her in a hangar at Garbutt airfield, Base Depot Number 4; Allen's photograph, taken out on the line with four of his squadron standing beneath the nose and a shark mouth painted under her name, appears to be a second and previously unpublished view of the same aircraft. The shark mouth is consistent with 90th Squadron practice, which gave the same marking to the Mitchells Mortimer (41-12443) and Runts Roost (41-29727).

Sources: Pacific Wrecks — B-25C "Margaret" Serial Number 41-12946; B-25 Strafer Field Modifications — Australia @ War (Peter Dunn); B-25C Mitchell 90th BS "Mortimer" nose art — World War Photos; B-25D 41-29727 "Runts Roost" with shark mouth — World War Photos.

Unit Signs

A camp sign reading "FRISCO" with a short list of names beneath it.

Four servicemen pose beside the same "FRISCO" sign. Allen is standing at the left.

A "90th SQ Radio" sign beside the squadron's news bulletin board.

Nineteen men in front of an "Armament" tent sign with painted dice.

The "3rd Attack Gp" sign, with all four squadron insignia: 8th, 13th, 89th, 90th.

Ground Crew at Work

Maintenance, munitions, and the daily work of keeping the squadron flying.

Ground crew work on an exposed aircraft engine.

Bombs laid out on the ground beside wooden crates.

*Engine maintenance on a bomber lettered **ALGERNON IV** in block capitals with the Roman numeral. A faint outline cartoon figure is sketched on the skin above and left of the name, and a row of mission symbols runs under the cockpit.*

Seven servicemen at a maintenance area stocked with fuel drums.

Mechanics working on an exposed twin-row radial engine, the propeller, nacelle and one mainwheel filling the frame. The blade carries its data stencil, legible when the print is turned upright: "DWG. NO. 6353A-18 / A.C. NO. 41-0107[4] / LOW PITCH 22 / HIGH PITCH [80] / INSTALLED-7-10-42." That last line is a date: this blade went on in July 1942.

Two servicemen clean a rifle barrel on an oil-drum table.

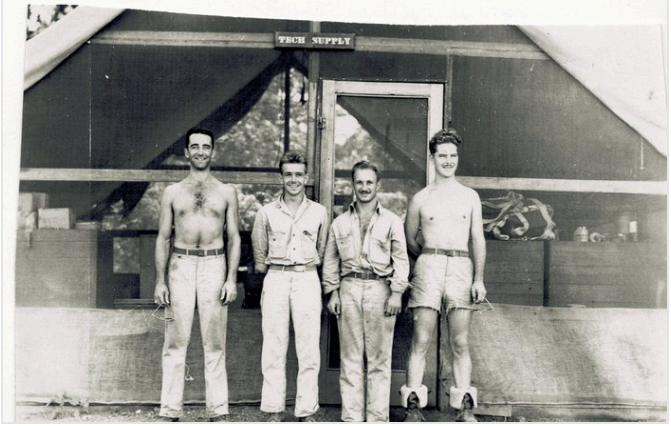
Bombs loaded onto a wheeled trailer beneath a B-25's open bomb bay.

A truck convoy loaded with servicemen — that's Allen taking a big swig from a large water jug.

A twin-barrel anti-aircraft gun position, gunner at the ready — airfield defense at one of the squadron's bases.

Five men crouch in a row beneath the nose of an aircraft while a sixth stands behind them, the nose painted with a shark's mouth of white teeth and four machine-gun muzzles projecting past it. A small dog sits at the feet of the two men in the centre.

Seven servicemen grouped under the wing of a parked aircraft, the white national star insignia on the underside directly above their heads. Five stand in khaki shirts, bush hats and one sun helmet, while two crouch in front, one of them stripped to the waist; a squad tent and folding cots stand behind them at the edge of tall timber.



Four servicemen stand in a row in front of a screened tent-front hut, beneath a small painted board over the doorway reading "TECH SUPPLY". Two are bare-chested, one of them in cut-down shorts with boots and rolled-down socks, and a parachute harness, cartons and cans sit on the shelving behind them.

Sixteen men gathered in front of a tarpaulin-roofed hut with a wooden gable and screened window, jungle trees behind and a second tent pitched at the right, with another man cut off at the left edge of the frame. Four crouch in front, several wear sun helmets or soft caps, one has a pipe in his mouth, and one man's steel helmet carries a name painted across the front that is now only partly legible.

Four men crouch beneath an aircraft's undercarriage leg, the oleo strut and its linkage hanging from the flat underside of the airframe directly above their heads. Three wear light khaki shirts with rolled or cut-off trousers — the man at left with a winged badge at the breast — the fourth a darker work shirt and a knitted cap; two of them have moustaches.

Two men work over an upturned oil drum standing in for a bench, with a vise clamped to a board across the top of it beside an oil can and a small bottle; a metal tool box sits on the ground and a length of rod rests across the drum.

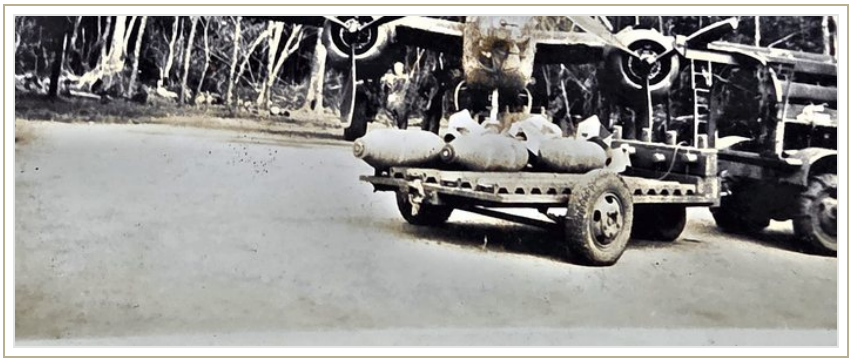
Eleven men pose outside a corrugated-iron hut with an open upper wall, five kneeling in front and six standing behind, in fatigue shirts, caps and bush hats, two of them stripped to the waist. A large urn stands on a bench at the left.

Two servicemen in khaki stand beside a snub-nosed military lorry with a wire-mesh grille guard, a canvas cab top and heavy off-road tyres, on a stony clearing at the edge of dry scrub; the man on the left wears a broad-brimmed field hat, the man on the right holds something small in both hands.

Nine men in khaki shirts and trousers along the front of a long camp building, its raised floor skirted with corrugated iron and its upper wall left as open framing, with tall grass growing up in front of them. One man, in a soft fatigue cap, sits perched on the sill with his legs crossed and his hands in his lap; several of the others wear spectacles.

Five men in worn, oil-stained coveralls and fatigues stand in a line in front of a bomber's nose lettered "EARLY BIRD", the last letter clipped by the top edge of the print; three wear soft fatigue caps, one a broad-brimmed bush hat and one is bare-headed, and a mainwheel and strut show at the right.

Four men line up beneath an aircraft wing, the man at left in coveralls and a sun helmet with his hands on his hips and the three beside him bare-chested in work trousers and belts. A maintenance ladder is propped against the wing and a main wheel stands behind them; the frame is cropped so that two of the heads are cut off at the top.



A low four-wheeled bomb trailer, its slotted bed loaded with finned bombs, stands on a bare strip, coupled to a second trailer of the same pattern at right with a vehicle's wheels beyond. Behind it are the mainwheels and undercarriage of a large aircraft, one figure on foot at the treeline.

Two men stand beside an aircraft: one bare-chested in cut-down shorts, socks and laced boots with a soft cap, his arm stretched out and his hand resting on the other man's shoulder, the other in a long-sleeved work shirt and trousers. A main wheel is at right and stacked equipment lies in the shade behind them.

Life in Camp

Daily life at the squadron's forward strips in New Guinea.

Jungle camp buildings, one signed "90th S.O. Intelligence."

A muddy tent camp among the trees — everyday field conditions.

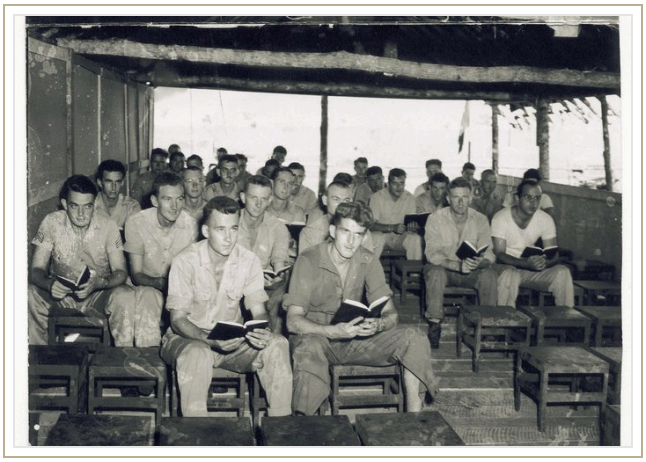
Three servicemen relax inside a tent, one smoking a pipe.

Allen relaxes in a folding camp chair, laundry on the line behind him.

Servicemen gather around a large cooking pot at the outdoor kitchen.

Servicemen sit at a wooden table writing letters home.

A hand-lettered camp canteen sign advertises beer and cigarettes.



About twenty-five servicemen at a chapel service under a thatched roof.

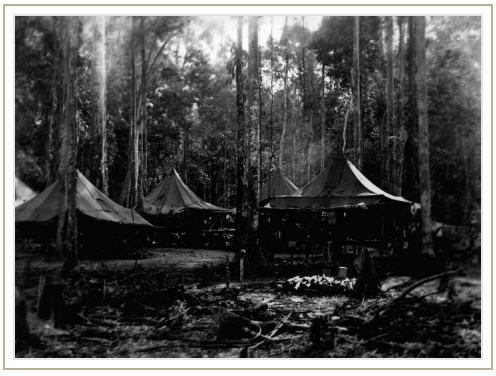
The same chapel service, closer in — Allen, in the white shirt, hymnal open beside another man still shirtless from the heat.

The camp's open-air shower — a makeshift stand rigged for the men on the slope, with servicemen gathered round it.

The squadron, more than a dozen men, lined up in two ranks before a camp building.

A group of servicemen, freshly washed up, one wrapped in a towel.

The squadron's makeshift club tent, decorated with hand-painted pin-up art typical of the era.



Tents pitched among tall jungle trees, campfire coals smoldering in the foreground.

A row of large pyramidal tents pitched on raised timber floors among tall rainforest trees, with a laundry line strung between the trunks, oil drums standing at the right, and cut branches and split logs scattered across the churned ground.

Allen sitting on the ground in a white undershirt with a pipe in his mouth and a towel round his neck, wearing boots with white socks turned down over the tops, in a camp of thatched and canvas shelters. A laundry line of shirts and towels is strung at the right, and behind him two tall stripped poles carry thin wires, one with a small box fixed part way up.

A serviceman stands stripped to the waist in a pith helmet with a pipe in his teeth, wearing cut-off shorts, a wristwatch and boots, with identity tags on a chain around his neck. Behind him are a tent, mosquito netting and a canvas deck chair, and two pale tins stand on the bare ground at his feet.

Four men arm in arm on a dirt track in open scrub country, Allen third from the left: three in shirtsleeves and soft caps, the second from left in a peaked service cap and necktie. The man at the left wears a senior sergeant's chevrons on his sleeve.

A serviceman in a belted one-piece work suit with a canvas bag slung across his shoulder, standing in front of a dark building opening, his hair, face and eyebrows caked with a pale dust or powder.

Three men pose for the camera in a scrubby clearing: the man in the centre stands grinning with both hands raised, while the two flanking him level rifles at him, one in shirt and cap with a second rifle slung on his shoulder, the other stripped to the waist.

Three men at work inside an open-sided building with a thatched roof on rough timber posts: two at a table on the left, one of them seated in a canvas chair, a typewriter on a bench in the middle of the room, and a third standing at a bench on the right. The glare through the open walls swallows the far end, so there is no telling whether anyone else is in the room.

Four men stand in front of a squad tent pitched against a wooded hillside: one in a steel helmet with sergeant's chevrons on his sleeve, one in coveralls, one in shirt and trousers, and one bare-chested in shorts. A furled flag on a staff stands between the first two men, and a thin pole leans upright between the last two.

Three men at a bathing place on a wide, slow river: two out in the water with only their heads and shoulders showing, and a third sitting bare-chested on a fallen tree that leans out over the surface from the scrub of the far bank.

Two men stripped to the waist stand chest-deep in a jungle river, hands resting on a long felled trunk that lies out across the water from the bank beyond them, where tall grass and scrub give way to rainforest.

Allen at the right of three servicemen in khaki shirts and trousers, two of them in field caps, standing shoulder to shoulder in front of a timber building raised on posts with part of its roof thatched; a log rail and steps run up to the building on the left.

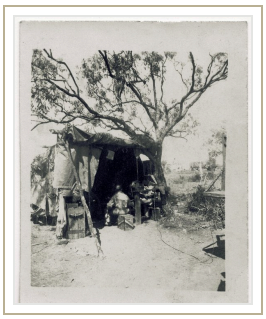
Allen, bareheaded, in a light shirt and trousers in a camp of pyramidal and tarpaulin tents, with a ridge of cloud-covered high ground behind him. Guy ropes run down at right, where a pale bag and a flat woven mat lie on the ground under the tent fly.

Allen in a garrison cap, light shirt and trousers, crouching on bare ground in front of a large tarpaulin shelter rigged on poles, with further tents and eucalyptus-like trees beyond.

Allen in a peaked fatigue cap and work shirt, sitting on a rough timber rail with one boot up, dense vines and jungle foliage behind him and a low table or crate at right.

Allen in shirt and trousers on a folding chair beneath a shelter built of poles and split logs lashed against a large tree, papers spread on the bench beside him and a white enamel pan on the ground at his feet.

Half a dozen men at a swimming hole shaded by overhanging gum trees, one standing waist-deep in the water in a dark singlet while the others gather on the rocks and fallen limbs of the far bank. Clothing hangs drying from the branches above them.



A man sits on a wooden crate at a bench inside the open end of a tent pitched under a spreading gum tree, its canvas fly stretched out over the entrance and propped on cut saplings. Packing cases stand at the doorway and a cable runs across the bare ground into the tent.

A tabby kitten rears up against a wooden step or sill, reaching toward a man's open hand; only his white sleeve and dark trouser leg are in the frame.

How These Prints Are Known to Be His

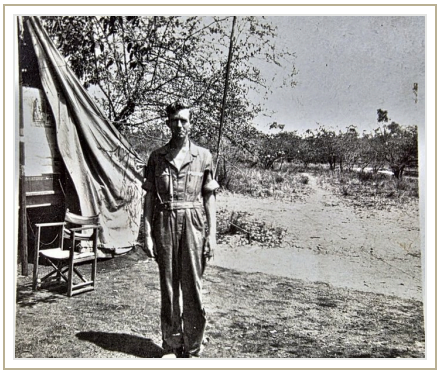
Two things run through the whole collection and neither is a stamp. The first is the pencil. The writing on the backs — the names, the places, the months, "outside hut in New Guinea. Nov. 1942", "Driving… in Australia" — is Allen's own hand, on print after print. A man does not caption another man's photographs in his own pencil and then keep them for sixty-six years.

The second is that he is in a good many of them, and his grandson is still going through and saying which. That does not make them less his. It means that on those afternoons somebody else pressed the button — a friend borrowing the camera, most likely his — and the negative came home in his footlocker all the same. This document does not keep a running tally of which frames he stands in; where he is identified, the caption says so and says who identified him.

Identifications: Jeremy Sweigert, September 2026.

A hand-made squadron signboard of corrugated iron, its raised letters reading "90TH ATTACK SQ" below a painted panel of a palm-fringed bay with aircraft flying over it, and a scythe-bearing figure on a shield at the right end. Pyramidal tents stand in the grass behind the board, and the edge of a second print of the same sign shows along the bottom of the frame.

Allen in a work shirt and shorts, leaning against the closed steel cab of a military truck with one boot up on the running board and a cigarette in his mouth, a pale bundle lashed to the front fender and a line of further trucks stretching away down the dirt road behind. The back carries a caption rather than a name: only the first word "Driving" and the closing line "in Australia." can be made out, the pencilled words between them past reading.

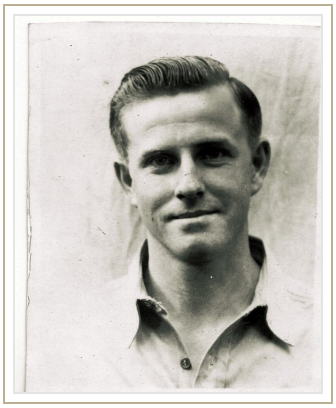


A serviceman in a one-piece work suit with the sleeves turned back stands bareheaded on bare ground beside a tent, its canvas wall drawn up and a folding wood-and-canvas camp chair set at the entrance, with open scrub and thin trees behind him. Named on the back as R. L. Thomas of Arlington, Massachusetts; the print also carries a US Army censor stamp.

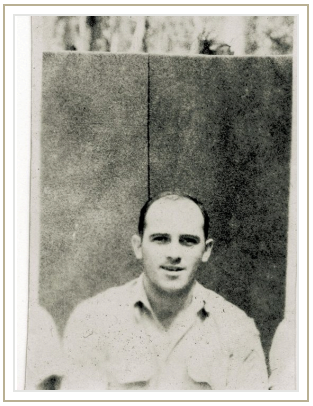
One man stands alone in a cleared patch of open ground, hands on his hips in light trousers and shirt and a soft cap, with scrub and trees close behind him. The back gives the surname Miller with "N. G." for New Guinea and the date "11/42"; the given name is written in a hand that reads as "Hank" to one eye and "Herb" to another.

The Crew

Allen, wearing glasses, seated under the trees.



A close head-and-shoulders portrait.



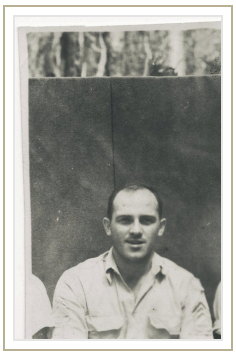
Allen, smiling, in a formal seated portrait.

Two servicemen, one wearing a winged insignia pin.

A seated serviceman with wavy dark hair.

A smiling seated serviceman.

A seated, balding serviceman.



Allen, sergeant's chevrons visible on his sleeve, in a formal portrait.

Three men in khaki shirts and trousers, two of them in caps, stand arm in arm in front of a raised hut with a thatched eave and a log railing; the back of the print carries three pencil signatures, all of them too faint to read with any confidence, so the three of them go unnamed.

Four men pose in front of an aircraft, two standing — one in coveralls, one in a work shirt and trousers — and two crouching in front; the man at lower left wears a broad-brimmed slouch hat with a hat badge and three chevrons on his sleeve. Drums sit on a timber rack at right and a bench stands in the shade beneath the fuselage behind.

Three men in shirtsleeves on a dirt track at the edge of scrub bush: one kneels in the foreground in a dark shirt and cap, another crouches barehanded over something on the ground, and a third stands behind in a light shirt. The back gives three surnames with home states and the caption "Cracking Coconuts" — "Sweigert Pa." is Allen naming himself, alongside "Davidson Ky." and a first surname read uncertainly as Funell, Furrell or Fennell.

Passed Down

The Reaper's Harvest never left the family. Jeremy Sweigert, who recorded the interview these pages are built from, still has Allen's own copy — along with two of his actual flight suits and a wider collection of his wartime artifacts and photographs, only some of which are shown here.

Jeremy, 2017, in one of Allen's own flight suits — the 90th Squadron reaper on the chest, the same emblem that runs through these pages — holding Allen's own copy of "The Reaper's Harvest."

Allen and Jeremy Sweigert, Memorial Day 2006 — the same visit this interview was recorded on.

A boy in glasses stands in a panelled room wearing an oversized Army olive-drab service coat, its master sergeant chevrons on both sleeves, "U.S." and squadron-style insignia discs on the lapels, a ribbon bar and a shoulder patch on the left arm; the back identifies him as Allen's grandson Jeremy, in 1986, wearing Allen's own coat while going through the war collection.

The Radio Section

His own trade, photographed from the inside.

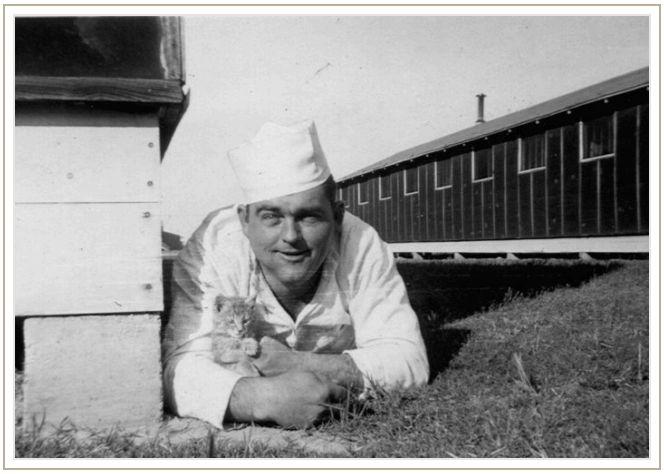
Nine men, five standing and four crouching, in front of a tent with its side flap propped open on a pole and a large pale chart pinned up inside. A dark equipment case fitted with dials and small panels stands on the ground at the left, and a slender antenna mast with its wire rises at the right of the group; two of the men wear sun helmets and one of those crouching is in a T-shirt.

Three men in a tent fitted out as a radio shop: two work standing at a bench of receivers and test gear, while a third sits back in a folding canvas chair and looks at the camera. A small plate on one set is lettered "WO7", and a chalked board hangs on the tent wall behind the bench.

A grinning man in a white T-shirt, hand on hip, stands beside a framed hand-painted sign reading "90TH SQ." with a pair of dice and, below, "RADIO"; a board at the right is lettered "LATE WORLD N…". The back carries a big flourish of a pencil signature, read as "John B. H——" by one eye and given up as illegible by another, along with part of a censor stamp; the grinning man stays unnamed.

The Mess, and What Was In It

He remembered corned beef, powdered lemonade and two bottles of beer a man. These are the kitchens it came out of.



A man in a cook's white jacket and white cap lies on the grass beside a wooden building, holding a tabby kitten against his chest. A long dark barracks with a row of windows and a stovepipe on the roof runs away behind him.

Two dozen or more men line the front of a long, open-sided building with corrugated-iron walls, many of them holding mess kits and cups, in a stand of tall slender trees. The ground in front is churned mud with a fallen log lying across it.

A field kitchen under a timber-truss roof open along both sides, with cooks in white aprons and men in fatigues working over field ranges; large aluminium stock pots, open cans and stacked pan lids crowd the benches in the foreground.

A serviceman in light one-piece coveralls kneels at the end of a tent beside a field wash line, one hand steadying a board across a galvanised can while a canvas tub hangs above it from a rope bridle; oil drums and a shallow pan stand on the bare ground behind.

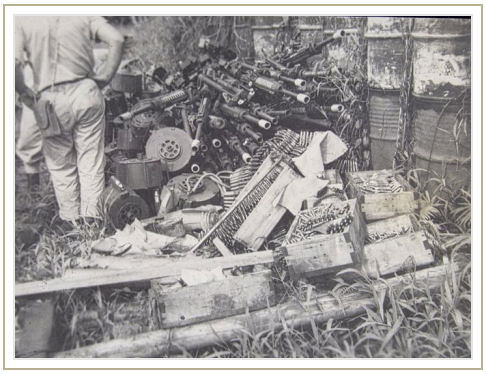
Ashore at Hollandia

"We came in with the LSTs and waded in there, and then everybody was standing around the beach."

Seen from above, a double column of trucks, trailers and jeeps stands nose to tail along the edge of the palms at a landing beach, with men moving across the open sand and small craft drawn up at the waterline in the distance. A large pale circular object — a spare wheel or a coil — rides on top of the load of the nearest truck.

Three servicemen on a large wreck of heavy timber and riveted steel plate, snapped through near its centre and lying on a flat of dried mud and sand. One stands on top stripped to the waist in shorts, one sits on the broken edge in fatigues, and one stands below it wearing a cap; a line of palms runs along the horizon.

A group of captured Japanese soldiers, eight or nine visible, stands on a shoreline track with their belongings tied up in cloth bundles and a canteen in one man's hand; some are in uniform shirts and field caps, others stripped to undershirts or bare to the waist. A further man in a light shirt and soft cloth cap walks along the track behind them, with water and a far shore beyond.



A serviceman in light khaki, his back to the camera and a flap pouch on his belt, stands over a heaped dump of captured Japanese weapons: machine guns with ribbed and perforated barrel jackets, bipods folded beneath them, flared muzzle cones and top-mounted feed housings, piled shoulder-high at the back. Around the foot of the pile lie large flat drum magazines pierced with a ring of holes, faceted metal ammunition canisters, loops of belted ammunition and light wooden crates — some packed with loose cartridges, one stencilled with a single character that appears to be Japanese. Empty fuel drums stand in the grass behind.

The Country, and the People In It

"We made several trips up to the native village to see how it was."

A man high on the trunk of a coconut palm, arms wrapped around the bole just below the crown, photographed from the ground looking up through a stand of palms.

Allen, in shirtsleeves in the low jungle undergrowth, holding up a snake long enough to loop down to the ground beside him — the pale corner of a tent showing through the trees behind. Identified by the family.

Five servicemen — four in sun helmets, one stripped to the waist — stand for a group photograph on a jungle slope with a New Guinean woman and a girl, who are in the front rank facing the camera: the woman in a dark wrap with a pale cloth apron and her hands held together in front of her, the girl beside her bare above the waist in a skirt of hanging fibre. A further head shows at the back of the group, too indistinct to count either way, and a lone figure is silhouetted on the rise behind.

A New Guinean village house raised on a forest of rough posts, its roof deep in sago thatch, a notched log ladder leaning up to the doorway and more houses of the same build running away behind it under a stand of coconut palms. Across the sand in the foreground, in thin white letters, "Greetings — New Guinea", and below and to the right of it, set like a signature, "Joe".

A shore photographed from out on the water: a dense wall of coconut palms and heavier trees, a narrow strip of pale sand, and drawn up along it a line of outrigger canoes, their booms showing as thin struts against the beach. Two low shelters stand back at the tree line.

Palm trees silhouetted against a hazy New Guinea shoreline.

Three servicemen sit in a row along a heavy log rail in front of a New Guinean house raised on a forest of thin posts, with a sago-thatch roof and plank and woven walls; two of them are bare-chested and two wear wide sun helmets. At the right end of the rail a New Guinean child stands beside them, bare-chested and barefoot in a pale cloth wrap, turned away from the camera. A second house of the same build stands in the left background, fogged by a light leak. The back names the men in pencil — "Dutchman / Gillmer / Haskin" — and then places and dates the picture: "outside hut in New Guinea. Nov. 1942."

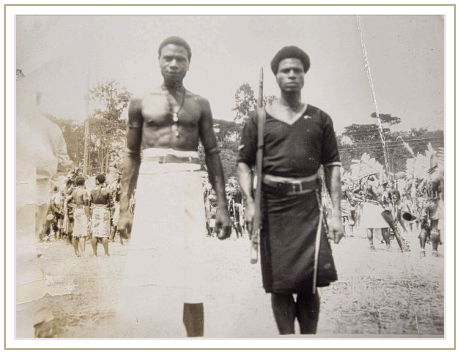
One wide print, not two. A dispersal road runs across the upper half with a Dodge four-wheel-drive pickup at the left, a GMC cargo truck with slatted sides at the right and a man walking between them; in the foreground three American servicemen stand with a group of New Guinean people, four of the women in fibre skirts, while a propeller blade and a large cylindrical store fill the right of the frame and another man reaches up to the aircraft behind them.

About thirty New Guinean villagers gathered for the camera on cleared, burnt-over ground, with four servicemen standing behind them. The children make up the front two rows; several of the adults behind hold upright staffs. A woman stands a little apart at the right in a dark upper garment and a paler skirt.

Three young women stand close together facing the camera, low scrub behind them. The two at centre and right wear long garlands of pale flowers over the shoulders and skirts of hanging fibre and are bare above the waist, the centre one with a band of flowers set across her hair; the woman at left wears a dark patterned shirt with her garland over it. All three are smiling. The print is a small one, worn at the edges and scratched across the emulsion.

A gathering on cleared, trampled ground with tall thin trees behind: twenty or more people in long cloaks and skirts of hanging fibre, several of them carrying bundles taller than themselves — broad, curved and tapering to a point, possibly rolled matting or sheets of bark — up on the shoulder. A child of about ten stands square to the camera in the foreground in a fibre cape and skirt, holding a tall thin staff, with others holding staffs behind. Two men in light shirts and trousers stand watching at the left, and the crowd runs away up the rise to the tree line. The print does not say where this is or what the occasion was.

Two children stand on pale sand, each with both arms raised to steady a large rounded load at the head and shoulder; the copy print is too coarse to say what the loads are. A fan of palm frond and a scuffed hollow in the sand lie between them. Neither child is clothed.



Two men stand facing the camera at the edge of a crowd. The one on the left is bare-chested in a white wrapped cloth and belt, with shell bands on both upper arms and a long pendant on a cord; the one on the right wears a dark long-sleeved jersey over a dark wrap, a broad belt and shell bands at both wrists, and holds an upright wooden shaft in one hand and a thin cane in the other. Behind them stand dozens of people in tall feather headdresses, several carrying hourglass drums.

"Greetings — New Guinea", and a Man Called Joe

The village house on the sand carries a message across its foreground in thin white cursive: "Greetings — New Guinea", and then, below and to the right where a signature goes, "Joe".

How it was made is worth a sentence. Letters drawn in sand with a finger come out broad and ragged, and the groove takes a shadow, so it prints dark on one side. These are thin, even and confident, they print bright white, and the sand grain runs on underneath them undisturbed. That is what a needle in the emulsion of a negative looks like: scratch the film and the print comes back with a clean white line. Somebody made this print to send, and signed the sending.

Who Joe was, this document cannot say. It is not Allen. He may be one of the men whose names are pencilled on the backs of the prints in the same batch, or the greeting may be addressed to a Joe at home rather than signed by one. It is the only photograph in the collection that has been written on rather than written behind.

Source: the print itself.

Where These Were Taken, and What They Are Of

Two different questions get confused here, so this note separates them before it counts anything.

Where they were taken. Most of this collection was made in New Guinea. From the squadron's move up to Port Moresby at the end of January 1943 until he sailed for home on 29 September 1944 — twenty months — the island is the ground under nearly every frame in this chapter. The camps, the strips, the revetments, the mess queue, the aeroplanes, the men: that is New Guinea in the picture, whatever the picture is of.

What they are of. Here the count has moved, twice, and in opposite directions. A sweep of the two hundred and fourteen photographs then in this document found exactly two that contain New Guinean people. Then, on 25 September 2026, seventeen more prints arrived that had never been handed over — and six of them are New Guinea and the people who lived there. A group of thirty or more gathered on burnt-over ground; three young women in flower garlands and fibre skirts; a gathering in long fibre cloaks; two children carrying loads on their heads; two men at the edge of a crowd, one of them dressed as a village constable; and a mixed group of servicemen and New Guineans beside the trucks.

So the figure is eight, not two, and the earlier version of this note said he "brought back almost nothing of it." That was wrong, and it was wrong because of what had been given to the people writing this document rather than because of what he photographed. The lesson is about the archive and not about him.

What still holds is the proportion. Eight frames of the island's people, and four more with the country itself as the subject, out of well over two hundred. He was a radio man on an airstrip and what he photographed was mostly what he lived among. He told his grandson "we made several trips up to the native village to see how it was" — the sentence at the head of this section — and now there are pictures of those trips.

The sweep also took something away, and that stands. The group photograph on the slope had been captioned here as showing four Papuans. Enlarged, two of the four are American servicemen in the hard brim shadow of their sun helmets, one with a clear tan line at the collar. A man at the right of a Japanese prisoner column was flagged and refused: his hair is smooth and swept back with a highlight across the crown, which tightly curled hair does not do.

Method: every frame read at full size; all flags adversarially reviewed, September 2026.

Three Names, and a Date Two Months Early

This caption used to say that only one word on the back could be read. Enlarged and sharpened, the pencil gives up the lot: three surnames one under another — *Dutchman, Gillmer, Haskin* — and beneath them "outside hut in New Guinea. Nov. 1942." Three names for three men on a rail, and the photograph placed and dated by the man who wrote on it.

Two of the three were already in this chapter, on other prints in the same batch. A signature read as Haskin is on the back of a photograph marked "N. G." for New Guinea, and James W. Gillmer of Miami, Florida, is named on a portrait. The third name is new. Dutchman appears nowhere else here — unless it is the clipped line on the back of another portrait in this batch, the one that gives a home town of Westphalia, Kansas. That is a suggestion and not an identification. The print is undamaged; it is the photograph of the print that cuts the name off, so another exposure of that back would settle it.

The date is the part that matters. The squadron's own record has it arriving at Port Moresby on 28 January 1943. This back says New Guinea in November 1942, spelled out, two months earlier — and it is the second print in the collection to say so, after the one marked "N. G." and 11/42. A single abbreviation could be misread. Two backs in two different hands, one of them writing the place out in full, are harder to argue with. Whatever the paper movement of the squadron was, men of it were on the island, and photographing each other outside a hut, by November 1942.

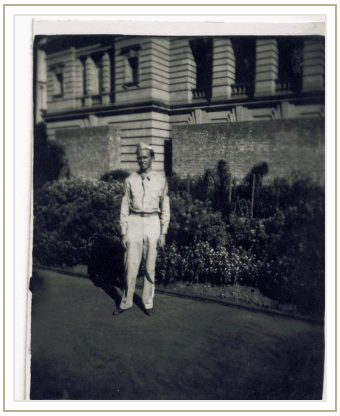
One question belongs to the family rather than to the record. "Dutchman" heads a list of three names on a picture of three men, in a collection kept by a Pennsylvania Dutchman from Schuylkill County. Whether it was what they called Allen, or what they called somebody else, nothing here can say.

Sources: the reverse of the print, enlarged; the reverse of the "N. G." print dated 11/42; 3rd Bomb Group unit record.

The Men in the Frame

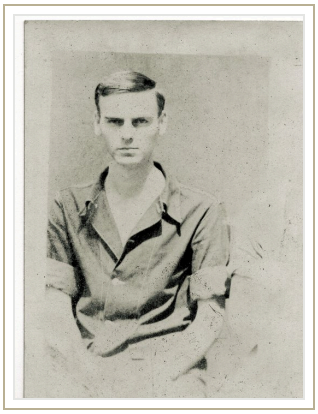
A run of single portraits from his collection, most of them made against a hung blanket or a tent wall. Some of these prints were written on the back and some were not; where a back gives a name the caption gives it, and the rest go unnamed unless the family knew the face.

Two young servicemen sit side by side in front of a dark doorway, both in light open-collar summer shirts with the sleeves rolled. A small winged badge is pinned above the left man's breast pocket; the print is too coarse to tell which qualification wings they are.



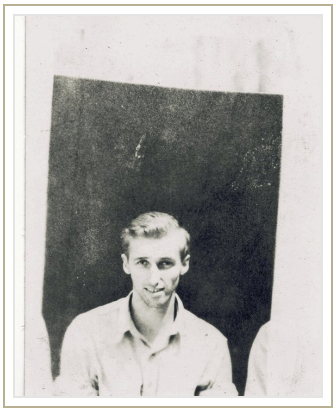
A serviceman in light summer khakis and a garrison cap stands on a paved garden path, a low brick wall and dense flowering shrubs behind him. Above the wall rises the rusticated masonry facade of a large building, its tall windows fronted by small stone balustrades, the top of it cut off by the frame.

Allen, in spectacles and a soft fatigue cap, sitting on the ground against a wall of jungle growth, sleeves pushed above the elbow and his wristwatch on his left wrist. Identified by the family.

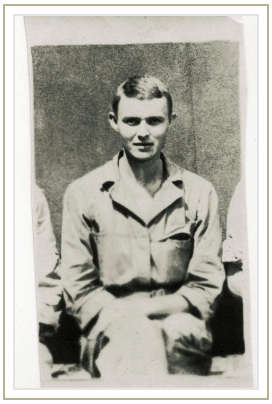


A waist-up portrait of a young serviceman, his hair combed back, seated in an open-collar shirt with the sleeves rolled to the elbow, his forearms crossed and hands clasped in his lap.

A young serviceman sits with his arms crossed over his knee in a light open-collar shirt with the sleeves turned up; a second man's arm and shoulder are cut off at the left edge of the frame.



A young serviceman in a light open-collar shirt sits smiling against a dark panel or wall; the shoulder of another man is just visible at the right edge.



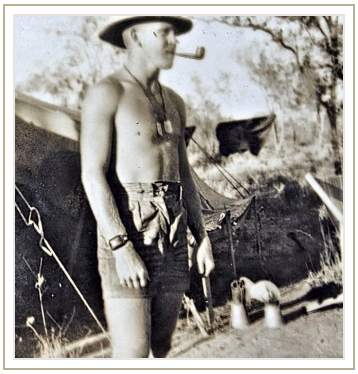
A young serviceman in a light shirt and trousers, seated with his hands on his knees against a plain stucco wall. The shoulders of the men on either side of him show that this small print was trimmed out of a larger group photograph.

Close portrait of a fair-haired serviceman in an open-collar shirt, seated in front of a dark wall; a neighbour's shoulder at the lower left corner shows the print was cut from a group photograph.

A serviceman with his hair combed to one side sits with his hands in his lap against a mottled concrete wall, in the same light shirt and trousers worn by the other men in this set of trimmed cut-outs.

A slightly built serviceman sits in a short-sleeved shirt with the cuffs turned back and his hands in his lap, against a mottled wall; the arm and leg of the man beside him remain at the right edge of the trimmed print.

A serviceman in a two-pocket shirt with the sleeves pushed up sits with his hands in his lap in front of a grainy wall; the arm and knee of the man next to him are still visible at the left edge where the print was cut down.



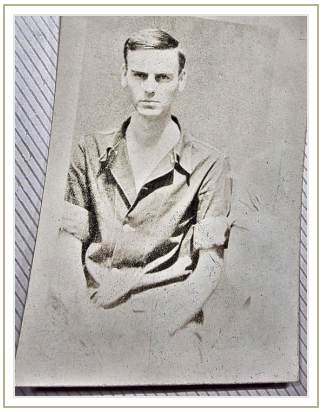
A bare-chested serviceman in a broad-brimmed campaign hat stands among pitched tents with a pipe clenched in his teeth, dog tags on a chain, a wristwatch on his right wrist and a slender tool handle gripped in his left hand. Named on the back as William Gatzman, with the home town written "Bugaloosa Ala." — kept just as it stands, though the Bogalusa on the map is in Louisiana.

A young man with his hair combed back sits facing the camera in a light shirt with flap breast pockets, his hands in his lap and the shoulder of another man just visible at the left edge. The back reads "Glenn W. Snoo...", the surname running off the right edge of the frame — Snow, Snook and Snodgrass are all possible — with "Liberty, Kans" beneath it.

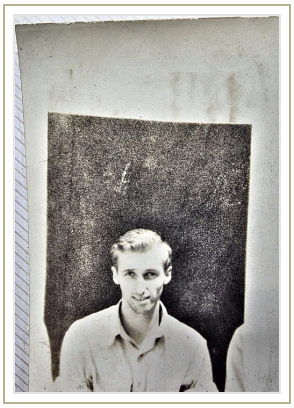
A wavy-haired man sits in a light open-collar shirt with two flapped breast pockets, half-smiling at the camera, the shoulder of the next man showing at the right edge. Named on the back as John B. Nunn of Springerville, Arizona.

Leonard Cyr of Norway, Maine. A much-faded seated portrait of a young man in a light open-collar shirt with the sleeves turned back, hands in his lap, against a dark mottled backdrop; the back reads "Leonard Cyr." with "Norway, Maine" beneath it and carries a US Army censor stamp.

A young man in a light short-sleeved open-collar shirt sits cross-legged on the ground, hands resting in his lap, with the shoulder and knee of a second man just inside the left edge of the print. The back names him as Wilton M. Bunn of Troy, North Carolina — the given name clear, the surname doubtful — and carries a US Army censor stamp.



Waist-up portrait of a young man in a light open-collar shirt with the sleeves turned back, arms folded across his chest, looking straight at the camera. Named on the back as Kenneth E. Radlein of 994 North Ave., Des Plaines, Illinois; the print carries a US Army censor stamp.



A young man in a light open-collar shirt, photographed head-and-shoulders against a dark wall, with another man's shoulder at the right edge of the frame. Named on the back as "Rod. Leonard" of Berkeley, California; the print carries a US Army censor stamp.

A serviceman stands in rough grass with scrub and trees behind him, wearing a bulky sleeveless vest over his shirt and trousers, hands at his waist. The back reads "Me in life vest and parachute" over a fast signature read, tentatively, as "Alex Garcia". A man who writes "Me" is very probably the man standing in the picture. There is a US Army censor stamp on the back as well.

A serviceman in one-piece coveralls and a pith-style sun helmet stands hands-on-hips on cleared ground, a web belt at his waist with a dark holster at his left hip, felled timber and dense bush behind him. The back carries a single signature read as "Haskin[?]" — Haskins or Hoskin are also possible — with "N. G." for New Guinea, and the censor stamp "PASSED BY / BASE / 2415 / U.S. ARMY / EXAMINER."

A bare-chested man in belted shorts stands squarely facing the camera on open, dry scrubland with thin trees behind him, the small print shown as it was photographed on a desk. The back reads "George E. Thom...", the surname running off the edge of the print after "Thom".

A serviceman in a dark one-piece work suit, belted at the waist, stands with his hands on his hips in open grassland, a fallen dead tree lying behind him and low scrub along the horizon. Named on the back as S. L. Taylor — the middle initial could equally be an R — with no home town given, and the reverse carries a US Army censor stamp struck twice.

A young man sits with his hands loosely in his lap, wearing an open-collared light shirt with two flap breast pockets and the sleeves rolled above the elbow, photographed against a mottled backdrop. The name line on the back is clipped by the edge of the frame and cannot be read; below it the back gives "Westphalia, Kan", and part of a US Army censor stamp survives.

A young man sits smiling for the camera in a light open-necked shirt with breast pockets and turned-back sleeves, a belt at his waist and his hands folded in his lap, with the white sleeve of a second man at the right edge of the print. The back gives the surname as "Hoskins[?]" with the given name clipped by the frame, and beneath it "Galveston, Texas"; the censor stamp reads "PASSED BY / BASE / 2415 / U.S. ARMY / EXAMINER".

A young man sits for the camera in a light short-sleeved open-collar shirt, hands folded in his lap, with the sleeve and shoulder of the man beside him cropped away at the right edge of the print. Named on the back as Henry "Hank" Mille — of Pittsfield, Massachusetts, the surname running off the edge of the print. Miller is the obvious guess, but the paper does not say so.

A thin-faced man sits in a light open-collar shirt with two buttoned breast pockets and a web belt at his waist, hands resting in his lap; another man's sleeve is just visible at the right edge. Named on the back as Henry Gosztyla of Hamtramck, Michigan.

A young man sits square to the camera in a light open-collar work shirt with a flapped breast pocket, arms low in his lap and the arms of the men on either side cropped at the edges of the print. Named on the back as James Frenell[?] of Cairo, Illinois — the surname is drawn F-r-e-n-e-l-l and Fennell may be the intended spelling.

A fair-haired man in a light service shirt with a buttoned breast pocket turns his head to look off to one side of the camera. Named on the back as James W. Gillmer of Miami, Florida, though the surname could as easily read Gillner or Gilmer.

A man in a dark work shirt and trousers crouches on bare, dry ground among low scrub, a fallen bare-branched tree lying behind him, holding something small in his cupped right hand. The back of the print reads "L. L. Taylor" over "Los Angeles, Cal." — the surname is certain, while the second initial reads as an L to one eye and a J to another.

Under Attack

The few frames in his collection taken while something was happening.

A low oblique aerial photograph looking down on a jungle shoreline, with columns of pale smoke rising from among the trees just inland of the beach and a track running along behind the sand. A number is inked on the print at lower left, partly cropped, reading "-83".

A near-vertical aerial view of open scrub laced with vehicle tracks: a twin-engine aircraft flies low across the lower part of the frame while small white parachute canopies descend over the ground and a column of smoke rolls up at the upper left.

A low-level aerial photograph taken along a cleared airstrip, its matted surface and a long strip of runway matting running away from the camera. A tall column of black smoke and several lighter bursts rise from the far end of the strip and from the treeline beyond it.

A low oblique aerial photograph of a small warship under way, with broad pale plumes standing in the water around it and a wake trailing astern. The dark curved marks at the left edge are damage to the print.

A twin-engine, twin-tailed bomber seen from above, dark against ground almost wholly veiled by smoke and blown dust, with scattered dark debris and a curving line of specks trailing off to its right.

A low oblique taken from an aircraft over a coconut plantation running along a shore. Four or five columns of smoke are rising among the palms, with more smoke drifting along the ridge behind. Buildings with slatted or thatched walls stand under the trees along the bottom of the frame, and the whole image is smeared sideways by the aircraft's speed.

A burnt-out aircraft lying in open, scorched grass. The wreck has broken up and been largely consumed by fire: a dark slab of structure, probably a fin or a section of wing standing on edge, rises at the centre, with a flat ribbed skin panel to the right and what may be an engine mounting ring among the debris at the left. Vehicles or tents are visible on the far edge of the clearing.

An anti-aircraft gun emplaced in shoulder-high kunai grass, the barrel at high elevation and the mounting sunk behind a low earth or sandbag parapet. Eight or so men stand about the pit, several of them looking at the camera; the man at the right of the breech wears an overseas cap and has chevrons on his sleeve. Ammunition boxes sit on the platform beside the gun.

The Bismarck Sea, and the Man in the Cockpit

On 3 March 1943 the 90th Squadron took its rebuilt Mitchells against a Japanese convoy, and settled the argument about whether the strafer worked.

The man in the cockpit was Allen's own squadron commander

The photograph reproduced here from the group history book is not a picture of a stranger. Edward Lawrence Larner was born in San Francisco on 1 July 1917 and reported to the 3rd Bomb Group's 89th Squadron on 28 October 1942, a transfer in from the 46th Bomb Group with more than eight hundred flying hours behind him; General Kenney noticed him within a fortnight and set the verdict down himself — "That lad was good. He had fire, leadership and guts." By the turn of the year he was checking pilots out on the newly converted strafer B-25s, and he did that work in Queensland, not New Guinea: the 90th Bombardment Squadron was still at Charters Towers and did not move up to 3 Mile Drome at Port Moresby until 28 January 1943.

He was a major by the time he led that squadron into its first great action. The family's own record places Allen in the 90th, and that is why this man belongs in Allen's story: the officer in the cockpit was his squadron commander. Which photograph sits on the page he holds up is something the sources cannot settle for us.

Sources: Pilot Spotlight: Edward L. Larner Makes History — International Historical Research Associates; Edward Larner — Hall of Valor; Edward Lawrence Larner (1917–1943) — Find a Grave Memorial; Pacific Wrecks — Major Edward Larner in the cockpit of B-25C Spook II / Onkle Rafe 41-12969.

The convoy, and the morning of 3 March 1943

Eight Japanese transports and eight escorting destroyers sailed from Simpson Harbour at Rabaul on 28 February 1943 carrying roughly 6,900 troops for Lae, with about a hundred fighters assigned to cover them. On the morning of 3 March the Fifth Air Force and the RAAF struck the convoy in one stacked sequence: B-17s from about seven thousand feet to scatter it, B-25s releasing between three and six thousand, then thirteen Australian Beaufighters in at deck height to beat down the anti-aircraft guns, then Major Larner with twelve of the modified B-25s coming in at mast height, a squadron of A-20s behind them and P-38s overhead. By daybreak on 4 March all eight transports and four of the eight destroyers had been sunk.

The count of men is where the accounts part: the Australian War Memorial gives about 2,890 Japanese dead and only 850 ashore at Lae, while other histories carry at least three thousand dead and some twelve hundred landed. On one figure they agree — about twenty-seven hundred were pulled from the water and taken back to Rabaul. The 90th Squadron had itself reached Moresby only five weeks earlier, on 28 January 1943.

Sources: Battle of the Bismarck Sea, 2-4 March 1943 — Australian War Memorial; Victory in the Bismarck Sea — Air & Space Forces Magazine; March 2-4, 1943: Battle of the Bismarck Sea — Fold3 HQ; Battle of the Bismarck Sea — Wikipedia.

Why the battle is called the proof of the strafer

The whole of the 90th Squadron was in operation with strafer B-25s by the beginning of February 1943, each aircraft carrying eight forward-firing fifty-calibre guns — four in the nose, four in side packages — with two more in the top turret that could be swivelled forward, and the Bismarck Sea was the first time the converted aeroplanes were thrown at a convoy. Kenney's own account credits Larner's squadron with dropping thirty-seven five-hundred-pound bombs and claiming seventeen direct hits that morning, a claim and not a count, as the Australian War Memorial is careful to record it; unit records catalogued by Pacific Wrecks credit eight B-25s of the 90th with a destroyer and two transports.

The tactic worked because it was sequenced: the high-level bombing scattered the convoy and the Beaufighters silenced the guns, and only then did the mast-height aircraft go in. Every account reaches the same verdict: the idea had been proved, and decisively. What Allen describes in his own words is exactly that conversion, from a bombing outfit with a bombardier and a radio man to a low-level strafing outfit that no longer needed either.

Sources: B-25 Strafer Field Modifications — Australia @ War (Peter Dunn); Victory in the Bismarck Sea — Air & Space Forces Magazine; Pacific Wrecks — 90th Bombardment Squadron; Battle of the Bismarck Sea, 2-4 March 1943 — Australian War Memorial (records the 17 hits as a claim).

The claims were roughly double the result, and the record says so

A memorial should not repeat the wartime score sheet without saying what happened to it. The Fifth Air Force claim announced at the time ran to thirteen or fourteen merchant ships and seven destroyers sunk, and MacArthur's communique went further still, at twenty-two ships; the figure that postwar accounting settled on, and that the Australian War Memorial and the standard modern histories carry, is eight transports and four destroyers. The over-claim was honest rather than dishonest, the predictable arithmetic of many aircraft attacking the same burning ships in a few minutes of smoke and spray. It does not reduce the battle at all, because the convoy was in fact annihilated and the reinforcement of Lae by sea was finished. It is simply the difference between what the men were told that week and what the ledger closed at.

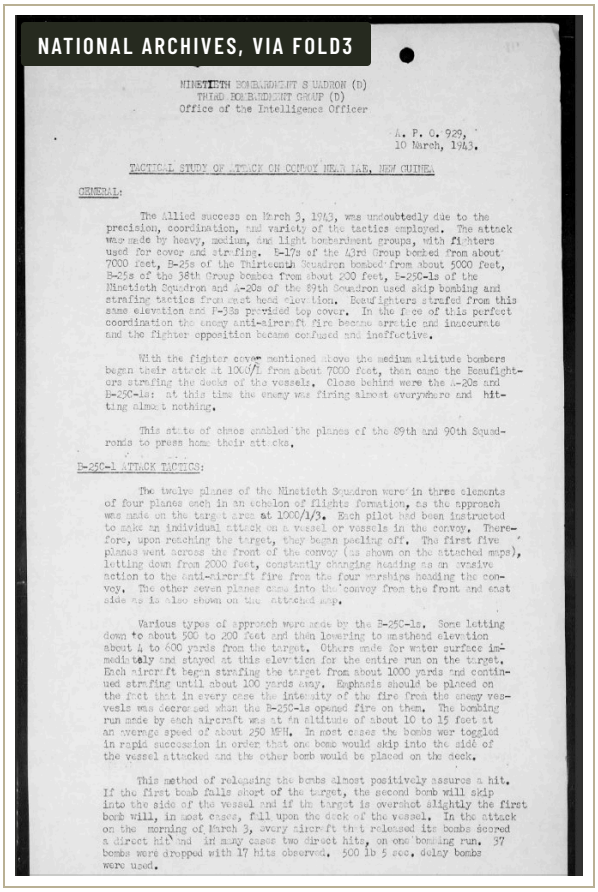
Sources: Victory in the Bismarck Sea — Air & Space Forces Magazine; Battle of the Bismarck Sea, 2-4 March 1943 — Australian War Memorial; Battle of the Bismarck Sea — Wikipedia.

The Squadron's Own Account of the Battle

The figures above come from Kenney, the official history and Pacific Wrecks. The 90th Squadron's own reports survive as well, in a file V Bomber Command's intelligence office put together in March 1943 and stamped as received on 19 April: a hundred and sixty-three pages of mission reports, sketches and charts from the American and Australian units that attacked the convoy. The squadron's intelligence officer, Second Lieutenant Ivan P. Head, wrote its summary on 10 March. Twelve B-25C-1s went in that morning in three elements of four, and "37 bombs were dropped with 17 hits observed", five-hundred-pound bombs with five-second delay fuses. In the afternoon the squadron went back and claimed ten direct hits with twenty-four bombs.

The pilots' own reports follow. Lieutenant Robert W. Reed's sets down the briefing: Major Larner's flight to go in head-on, Captain John P. Henebry's from the side and the third from the rear oblique, after a rendezvous off Cape Ward Hunt at nine. Henebry's report counts thirty-six bombs and seventeen hits, one bomb fewer than the squadron's figure. Each report names its crew, radio gunner included. Allen's name is on none of the pages.

Source: V Bomber Command, Office of A-2, "Tactical reports of attacks on Lae convoy in the Bismark Sea and off Lae, New Guinea, 3/2–4/43", 90th Bombardment Squadron section (National Archives, World War II War Diaries), via Fold3.



Tactical study of the attack on the convoy near Lae, written in the 90th Bombardment Squadron's intelligence office at APO 929 on 10 March 1943: "The twelve planes of the Ninetieth Squadron were in three elements of four planes each." Allen is not named. Credit: National Archives, World War II War Diaries, V Bomber Command A-2 file on the Bismarck Sea, via Fold3.

Spook and Spook II were two different aeroplanes

The name belonged to Larner and he carried it from one aircraft to the next. The first Spook was an A-20A Havoc, serial 40-109, on the 89th Squadron's books, and Pacific Wrecks records that Larner named it after his wife's nickname.

That aeroplane nosed over on takeoff from 3-Mile Drome at Port Moresby on 26 January 1943 under a different pilot, First Lieutenant Turner Williamson, who died in the wreckage; his gunner got out. The second was a B-25C, serial 41-12969, formerly on the 13th Squadron's books and converted to a strafer shortly before the Bismarck Sea, and it carried two names on the nose, Spook II and Onkle Rafe. If the print in Allen's collection shows a B-25 and not the slimmer A-20, then it is the second aircraft. What is still open is whether any of those frames is one that has been published. That is worth pinning down, because the copy catalogued by Pacific Wrecks is a cockpit portrait credited to the 3rd Bomb Group by way of Joseph Masiero, and it may not be the same photograph the family holds.

Sources: Pacific Wrecks — B-25C Spook II / Onkle Rafe Serial Number 41-12969; Pacific Wrecks — A-20A Spook Serial Number 40-109; Pacific Wrecks — Major Edward Larner in the cockpit of B-25C Spook II / Onkle Rafe 41-12969.

Larner's decorations: what can be proved and what cannot LIKELY

The award that can be documented is a posthumous Silver Star, recorded to Major Edward L. Larner, Air Corps, service number O-382601, 90th Bombardment Squadron, 3rd Bombardment Group (Light), Fifth Air Force, for gallantry as the pilot of a B-25 in the South West Pacific. The action dates on that record are given only as 1942 and 1943, so it cannot be tied to one mission. Some secondary accounts say that at the time of his death he had been recommended for the Distinguished Service Cross for the Bismarck Sea, but no source we can reach says so in its own words, and no roll of recipients has yet been searched properly for his name. The honest position, then: the Silver Star is documented, and the Distinguished Service Cross is a report we can neither confirm nor dismiss. A copy of his service record or a Fifth Air Force general order would settle it.

Sources: Edward Larner — Hall of Valor: Silver Star; Battle of the Bismarck Sea: A 15-Minute War in the South Pacific — Warfare History Network; Distinguished Service Cross Recipients, World War II, Army E-F — Home of Heroes.

How Larner died, and where the accounts disagree

He was killed at Dobodura on 30 April 1943, eight weeks after the Bismarck Sea, and nobody aboard Spook II survived. Eight men are named in the record: Larner, co-pilot Frederick H. Ensminger, navigator John J. Clarke, upper gunner Columbus G. Pelham, radio operator Vernon Moore, engineer Berj Manuelian, assistant engineer Robert L. Fecitt, and an Australian Army passenger, Captain Albert F. J. White.

The sources do not agree on how many were aboard — Pacific Wrecks says nine, and one published account says ten — so a ninth and perhaps a tenth man died unnamed here. The accident summary has the aircraft taking off from Dobodura, buzzing the fighter strip, pulling up to break away and falling off on one wing from about two hundred feet, with the left engine found to have cut and no height left to recover. A second account describes a heavily loaded aeroplane stalling at the top of the climbing turn he was known for, and has him landing rather than leaving. They agree on the date, the place, the aircraft and the fact that nobody walked away; they do not settle whether he was going out or coming in. He was twenty-five, and he is buried in San Francisco National Cemetery. Allen's own squadron moved up to Dobodura three weeks after the crash.

Sources: Pacific Wrecks — B-25C Spook II / Onkle Rafe Serial Number 41-12969; Pilot Spotlight: Edward L. Larner Makes History — International Historical Research Associates; Edward Lawrence Larner (1917–1943) — Find a Grave Memorial; Pacific Wrecks — 90th Bombardment Squadron.

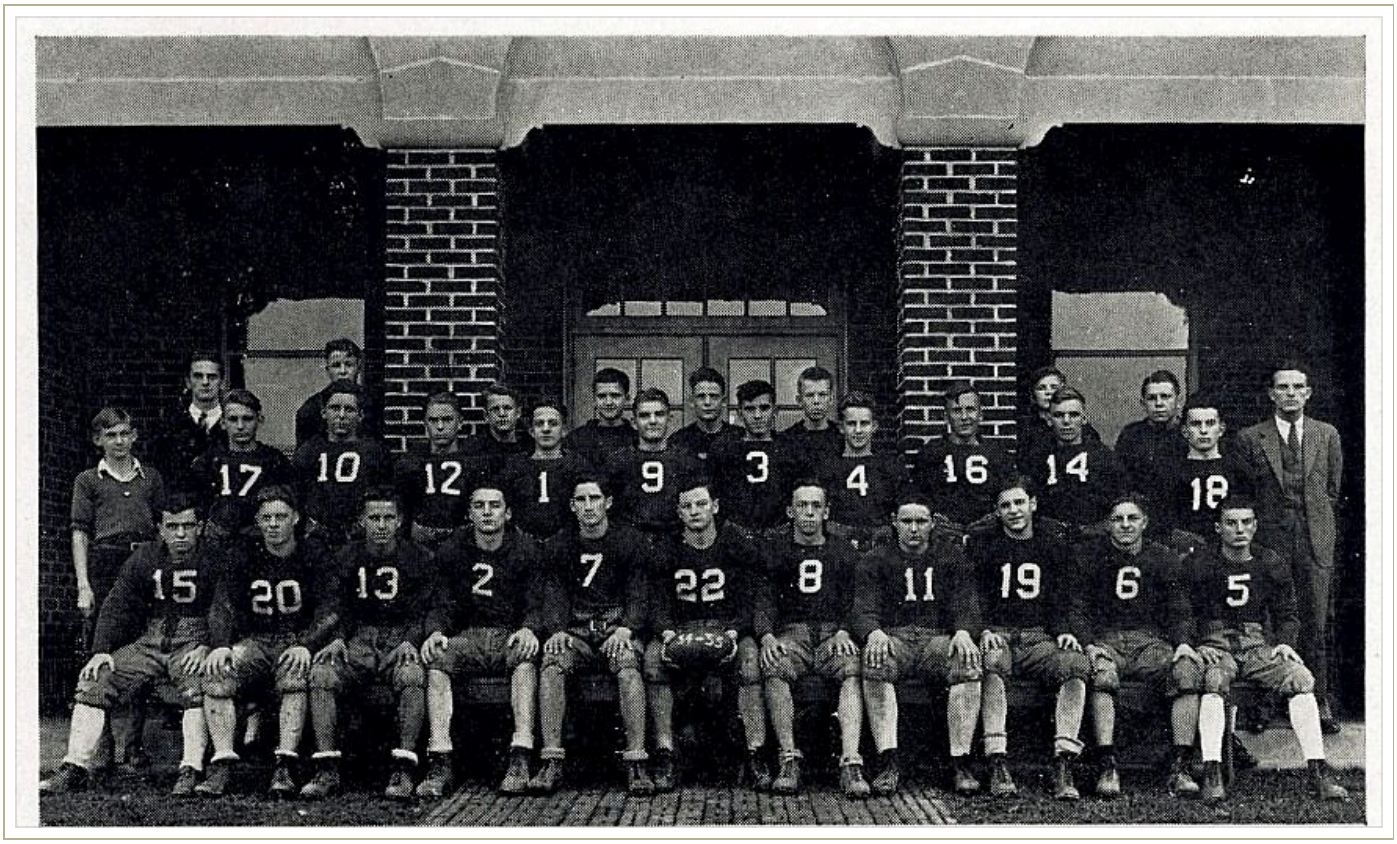
CHAPTER TWO

ALLEN E. SWEIGERT, SR. · WWII & FAMILY HISTORY

Pennsylvania National Guard

1936 – 1940, 213th Coast Artillery

Before the Air Force



The Cressona High School football team, from the 1935 Maroon and White. Allen is number 3, sixth from the left in the back row. Coach Stauffer stands at the right in a suit.

Number 3, enlarged. He was sixteen when this season was played.

Six Victories and Two Defeats

Before the armory and the drill nights there was a football field. The 1935 *Maroon and White*, the Cressona High School yearbook, gives the team a page and Allen a number: 3, back row, sixth from the left.

"The football season began with the same old slogan, 'A winning team this year.' It was an ideal but a hard one for Coach Stauffer and his boys to attempt. Thirty-two candidates reported for work and only five of them were varsity men. Everyone went to work with a will and the good old Cressona spirit. The results were most gratifying because we had a glorious beginning when we beat the Pottsville J. V's. 19-0 and finished the season with six victories and only two defeats."

The schedule bears it out, and so do the two that got away. Cressona 19, Pottsville J.V.s 0. Cressona 7, Schuylkill Haven 22. Cressona 12, Port Carbon 0. Cressona 20, Pine Grove 7, and 13 to 6 in the return away. Cressona 0, Cass Township 31. Cressona 7, St. Clair 0. Cressona 20, the Alumni 0. Ninety-eight points to sixty-six across the season, and both defeats heavy ones.

He turned sixteen a fortnight into that season. Two years later he would be in the National Guard for the drill pay, and three years after that a sergeant of Battery F.

Sources: Maroon and White, Cressona High School, 1935, p. 38.

The Mathematics Prize, June 1936

A school prize, four years before the uniform. The Call of Schuylkill Haven reported the Cressona High School commencement on its front page of Friday 12 June 1936: the thirty-fifth annual exercises, held in the school on the Wednesday evening, twenty-four young people taking their diplomas before a well-filled auditorium. The graduating speakers took as their subjects the different trades they expected to follow.

Then the prizes. "The Alumni Association gave the following awards to the members of the class: French and History prize to Miss Eleanore Kulp, **Mathematics prize to Allen Sweigert**, Science prize to Miss Evelyn Herring."

He was seventeen. Within five years the Army would put him through twenty-two weeks of radio theory at Scott Field and he would graduate from that with high honours too; within ten he would be wiring houses and selling Philcos, and after that he spent thirty years as an electrician and an electrical foreman. The whole working life is already visible in a line of small type about a school prize.

Source: The Call, Schuylkill Haven, 12 June 1936, p. 1.

The Mathematics Prize, and Who Gave It

A second paper carries the prize, and it adds the thing the first one left out. The Call of Friday 12 June 1936, on its front page under NINETY GRADUATE: "The Alumni Association gave the following awards to the members of the class: French and History prize to Miss Eleanore Kulp; Mathematics prize to Allen Sweigert; Science prize to Miss Evelyn Herring." The local Legion post gave the English prize, also to Miss Kulp, and Paul Strauch handed out the alumni prizes.

So the mathematics prize was the Alumni Association's. Three years later, in June 1939, the same association sat him at its annual banquet and had him introduce the president of the senior class. He had been one of their prize-winners; then he was on the programme.

The rest of the page fills in the room. Eleanore Kulp was valedictorian and took "Teaching as a Career" for her theme; Ezebel Yankauskie was salutatorian and spoke on business; Claire Specht spoke on nursing, Evelyn Herring on home economics, Margaret Yeick on music and art. Mrs. J. W. Bittle, president of the school board, handed out the diplomas, and an orchestra under Clarke Rauch played.

Sources: The Call, Schuylkill Haven, 12 June 1936, p. 1; Pottsville Republican, 10 June 1936.

An Allen Sweigert Who Is Not This One

Every name in this chapter had to be checked rather than assumed, and one of them failed. The Lancaster New Era of Monday 18 February 1935 lists the acts in a children's variety show — a ring master, a Midgets from Hollywood skit, an elocution turn, a Lion solo — and among the performers of a "surprise specialty from the World's Fair": Edna Mae Gibble, John Meeking, Nancy Biemesderfer, Suzanne Steele, Margaret Ziegler, Donald Biemesderfer and Allen Sweigert.

That is not him. Lancaster is more than fifty miles from Cressona, the surnames around him are Lancaster County surnames, and in February 1935 this Allen Sweigert was a sixteen-year-old at Cressona High School, where the same papers have him running a school assembly the previous October and speaking at a banquet the following May.

It is recorded here rather than quietly dropped because it is the shape of the problem. The name is not rare enough to stand alone. In the searches behind this chapter, a Pete Sweigert plays football at Cressona in 1937, a Bernice Sweigert goes to Girl Scout camp in 1939, a Marlin Sweigert rides the Gettysburg train in 1931, and an Allen Sweigert sings in Lancaster. Only the ones with Cressona and a date around them are treated as him.

Sources: Lancaster New Era, 18 February 1935, p. 8.

A Second Scout List, August 1932

The Gettysburg excursion of October 1931 is not the only time the Scouts put him in the paper as a boy. The Pottsville Republican of Tuesday 23 August 1932 prints another county-wide list, town by town, with a scoutmaster named at the head of one of the contingents: "From Cressona: Robert Dando, Ray Berger, Mrs. Robert Berger, Millard Wilson, Francis Moser, Henry E. Otto, Vincent Fegley, Edwin Zimmerman, **Allen E. Sweigert**, Richard Rubright, Dean Berger, Harry C. Jennings, Betty Berger, F. J. Jennings."

He was thirteen, and Robert Dando heads the Cressona list again, as he had on the train to Gettysburg ten months before. What the 1932 outing was, this document cannot say: the headline sits above the part of the page the reader could reach, and the column beside it is an advertisement for a motor excursion to Atlantic City on 27 August with two nights' lodging for $4.50, which is a neighbour on the page and not necessarily the same thing.

What it adds is continuity. Scouting has him at thirteen in 1931, at thirteen again in 1932, and running a troop of his own at twenty-one in 1939.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 23 August 1932, p. 5; Pottsville Republican, 10 October 1931, p. 2.

Headquarters Battery, July 1937 — and a Second Sweigert

This chapter has carried a note headed "Headquarters Battery in 1937, Battery F by 1942", worked out sideways from other evidence. Here it is said outright. The Pottsville Republican of Monday 12 July 1937 prints the roster of the men going to camp, and closes it: "Paul C. Hinkle and Floyd W. Witman have been assigned to National Guard Reserve and will proceed with the Headquarters Battery to camp on the active list." The Call reprinted the same list four days later.

The roster runs alphabetically to the end: "…John L. Russell, Nelson Shollenberger, Joseph L. Stees, Alfred T. Stank, **Allen E. Sweigert, Luther E. Sweigert**, Harry W. Wentzel, Francis E. Wil[liams], Harold H. Woodring, Steven Zulick."

Two Sweigerts, one after the other, in the same battery. Allen was eighteen and had been in the Guard about eight months on his own account. Who Luther was, this document does not say and will not guess: what it can say is that he was not a brother, because the notice of his parents' golden wedding in 1964 states flatly that Earl and Helen had one son.

So the earliest firm date for his Guard service is now the summer camp of 1937, with Headquarters Battery, at eighteen — and the gunner's examination in which he scored 98.5 falls two months before it, in May of the same year.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 12 July 1937, p. 7; The Call, Schuylkill Haven, 16 July 1937, p. 5; The Call, 7 May 1937, p. 4.

Sergeant by August 1940, Six Weeks Before the Front Page

The front-page roster of 17 September 1940 prints him under *Sergeants*, and this chapter has leaned on it. There is an earlier one. The Pottsville Republican of Saturday 3 August 1940 lists the battery by grade and reaches Cressona: "**Sgts. Kenneth E. Berger, Rayfield R. Berger, Allen E. Sweigert**; Corporals John H. Leininger, Russel W. Rauch, Wm. F. Hartman; Private First Class Edwin T. Heffner; Privates Aaron E. Shirey, Wm. M. Shirey, Earl D. Rauch, Emmett H. Rauch… Robt. R. Dando, Edwin H. Zimmerman, Leroy E. Koch, Cressona."

So the stripes are on him in print six weeks before federal service, not on the day after it. Two rosters, two papers, six weeks apart, both putting him among the sergeants — which is as much as a small county daily can be asked to give, and it is what the Republican meant when it wrote in April 1941 that "Sweigert has been a sergeant since 1939."

Robert Dando is in this list too, as a private. He had been editor in chief of the school paper Allen wrote for in 1935 and headed the Cressona contingent on the Scout train to Gettysburg in 1931. By August 1940 they were in the same battery, and on that list three grades apart. On 27 September The Call prints a Robert R. Dando, Jr. among the sergeants of the same battery. Whether that is a promotion in the weeks between the two papers or an error in one of them, this document cannot say: the Republican's own roster of 17 September has no Dando among the sergeants at all. The August list sets him as "Robt. R. Dando" without the "Jr.", but this paper had already printed a Robert Dando, Jr. in the Cressona Guard contingent of August 1939, beside Allen.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 3 August 1940, p. 2; Pottsville Republican, 17 September 1940, p. 1; Pottsville Republican, 12 April 1941, p. 4.

Gettysburg, October 1931: the First Time He Is in a Newspaper

The earliest appearance of him anywhere in print is not the mathematics prize and not the football team. It is a Boy Scout excursion. The Pottsville Republican of Saturday 10 October 1931 runs a story by John L. Conlin, headed for Gettysburg — hundreds of Boy Scouts from all over Schuylkill County leaving Pottsville on a special train, going through the Capitol at Harrisburg, and then out to the battlefield and the Lincoln monument.

Then it prints who went, town by town. "Cressona — Clayton Wenrich, Allen Sweigert, Francis Mosher, Henry E. Otto, Robert Dando, Jr., Lewis Heinbach, Harold Dieter, Marlin Sweigert, Fred Owens, Aaron Owens…" and on for another thirty names, with three or four adults among them.

He was thirteen years and one month old. Eight years later, in October 1939, the same newspaper would call him the scoutmaster of Troop 124 of Cressona and print the eighteen young people at his Hallowe'en party. He went to Gettysburg as a Scout and came back to run the troop.

Robert Dando, Jr. is on that train with him, aged about the same. Dando is editor in chief of the school paper in 1935, at the hot-dog roast on the Blue Mountain in June 1939, and away at Guard camp with him in August 1939. A Marlin Sweigert is in the Cressona list too; the relationship, if any, is not stated here and is not guessed at.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 10 October 1931, p. 2; Pottsville Republican, 26 October 1939, p. 2.

Columbus Day, 1934: Sixteen, and In Charge

He had been in a newspaper once before, on the Boy Scout train to Gettysburg in 1931. This is the first time one has him running something. The Pottsville Republican of Thursday 11 October 1934, in the Cressona column: "Special exercises will be held in the local schools on Friday, Columbus Day. The exercises in the high school, which will be held during assembly, will be in charge of the History Club and will be in charge of Allen Sweigert."

The sentence says it twice, clumsily, which is how you can tell the paper meant it. Then it prints the programme he had put together: "Song, 'America the Beautiful'; scripture reading, Marie Wagner; vocal solo, Clare Wagner; Early Life of Columbus, Evelyn Herring; Columbus Voyage, Robert Dando; song, 'Columbia The Gem of the Ocean'; Later Voyages of Columbus, Eleanore Kulp; Last Days of Columbus, Glen Mullins; song, 'Hail Columbia Happy Land'; reading, America, by William Cullen Bryant; song, America."

Eleven items, five speakers, four songs and a reading, in a school assembly on Friday 12 October 1934. He was sixteen years and one month old. A year later he was literary editor of the school paper; five years later he was scoutmaster of a troop; and by 1939 the Guard had made him a sergeant. This assembly is where that sequence starts, as far as anything printed can show.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 11 October 1934, p. 5.

A Coffin into the Cressona Cemetery, February 1937

Charles W. Hartman, a retired railroader of Cressona, was buried from his son's house on Schuylkill Street at two in the afternoon. The Pottsville Evening Republican of Wednesday 10 February 1937 reports the service and then the men who carried him: "The pall bearers were: Luther Geary, Elmer Miller, Frank Otto, Allen Sweigert, Martin McGuire and Earl Diehl." The Rev. John Ramsey of St. James' Episcopal, Schuylkill Haven, took the service and the grave; W. M. Armour of Orwigsburg was the undertaker.

Allen was eighteen years and five months old, and one of six men trusted with the weight of a coffin. It is a small item and it is worth keeping for one reason. The grave was in the Cressona Cemetery. Forty-five years later, in February 1982, the borough council appointed him to the commission that ran it, and he stayed on it for about twenty years. He carried a man into that ground at eighteen and helped look after it into his eighties.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 10 February 1937, p. 12; Pottsville Republican, 5 February 1982, p. 1.

Alumni Dine, June 1939

Three years out of school, he was given a speaking part at his own high school's alumni banquet. The Pottsville Republican of Saturday 10 June 1939, under the heading ALUMNI DINE: the Cressona High School Alumni Association held its annual banquet the previous evening in the high school, the social room hung with crepe paper streamers and the tables set with cut flowers, about ninety people present, William Boussum the toastmaster.

"Allen Sweigert introduced the president of the Senior Class, who in turn introduced all the graduates of the present year." The main speaker was Vincent Dalton of Schuylkill Haven, class of 1914. Miss Claire Wagner accompanied the singing — the same Claire Wagner who had sung the vocal solo at his Columbus Day assembly five years before, and who would be in the party on the Blue Mountain five days later.

That week of June 1939 is about as full a picture of his twenties as the papers give. On the Friday he stood up at the alumni banquet; on the Wednesday he was at a hot-dog roast up at the Scout camp with twelve others, one of them Catherine Kline.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 10 June 1939, p. 6.

Thanked at the Football Banquet, December 1937

He had left school a year and a half before, and he was still turning up for the team. The Pottsville Republican of Friday 10 December 1937 reports the football banquet: a ball from the season, painted red and white and lettered with the score and the players' names, put in the school case; a decision that the team would stop having one captain and name a new one from the seniors before each game.

Then: "Appreciation was expressed for the work done by Wm. Hartman and Allen Sweigert and to Managers Emmet Rauch and Allen Gordon." What the work was, the paper does not say — helping with the squad, the kit, the line, something that needed doing and that two young men out of school kept coming back to do.

Emmet Rauch is worth marking. Forty-five years later, when the borough council put Allen on the Cressona Cemetery commission, Emmett Rauch was on it with him. They were managing a high-school football team together in 1937 and running a graveyard together in the 1980s.

One caution about names. The seniors introduced that evening include a Pete Sweigert. He is not Allen and nothing here says who he was; Cressona had more than one Sweigert family in it.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 10 December 1937, p. 26; Pottsville Republican, 5 February 1982, p. 1.

Sixteen Men from Cressona Went to Camp, August 1939

The Pottsville Republican of Tuesday 8 August 1939, in the Cressona column, sets down a thing nobody else in this collection records: who he served with at home. “The following men from Cressona went to camp last week with the National Guard: Aaron Shirey, Wm. Shirey, Ed. Heffner, Robert Dando, Jr., Allen Sweigert, Wm. Hartman, Rayfield Berger, Arnold Reichert, Richard Schneck, Kenneth Berger, Russell Rauch, Merritt Kramer, Kenneth Beck, Leroy Koch, Paul Hepler, and Elmer Knittle.”

Sixteen men out of one small borough, away at the annual summer camp in the last week of July or the first of August 1939. It is the only dated evidence in the collection of him at a Guard camp before the regiment was federalised, and it sits in the right year: the Republican would write in April 1941 that “Sweigert has been a sergeant since 1939.”

The names are not strangers. Robert Dando, Jr. was editor in chief of the school paper Allen wrote for in 1935 and was at the hot-dog roast on the Blue Mountain two months before this; Kenneth Beck was at that roast too. William Hartman was thanked beside Allen at the football banquet of December 1937. The same two dozen young people are in every item in this chapter, in different rooms.

The item just above it, on the same page, is the Girl Scouts going to their own camp on the Blue Mountain, with a Bernice Sweigert among them. She is not identified here and no relationship to Allen is claimed.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 8 August 1939, p. 3; Pottsville Republican, 12 April 1941, p. 4.

Literary Editor, October 1935

In his last year at Cressona High the school started a Press Club, and the Pottsville Republican of Friday 18 October 1935 printed the whole slate. "Editor in Chief, Robert Dando; Literary Editor, Allen Sweigert; Art Editor, Leonard Matz; Business Manager, Robert Seitz; Circulation Manager, Lee Fidler; Alumni Editor, Millard Wilson; Sports Editor, Robert Seitz" — and then printers, distribution agents, typists, and a reporter for every year in the school.

He was the literary editor and not the editor in chief. The distinction is worth making because at a glance the item reads the other way: the two offices run across a line break, and a search highlight lands on "Chief, Allen" as though the words belonged together. Magnified, the sentence is unambiguous. Robert Dando had the chair; Allen had the writing.

The names around him are the names that keep coming back for the rest of the decade. Robert Dando, Leonard Matz, Robert Seitz and Lee Fidler are on this slate in 1935; Robert Seitz and Robert Dando are still with him at the hot-dog roast on the Blue Mountain in June 1939, in the party that also had Catherine Kline in it.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 18 October 1935, p. 2; Pottsville Republican, 15 June 1939, p. 17.

Scoutmaster of Troop 124, October 1939

Seven weeks after his twenty-first birthday he was running a Boy Scout troop. The Pottsville Republican of Thursday 26 October 1939 has it in the Cressona column, under the heading "Had Hallowe'en Party": "The Boy Scout Troop No. 124, of Cressona, Allen Sweigert, Scoutmaster, had a Hallowe'en party last evening in the basement of the Evangelical Church."

Eighteen names follow, seven of them girls' — Jeanne Merkle, Betty Herring, Alice Scott, Joan Mengle, Charlotte Miller, Gloria Schappel, Geraldine Becker — and then the boys, with his own name among them. The column lists the scoutmaster twice, once in charge and once in the room. A second Allen Sweigert of scouting age in a borough of under two thousand people is the harder thing to believe, and nothing turned up so far points to one.

It falls in the year the same paper would later date his stripes to. When three sergeants quit the 213th for the Air Corps in April 1941, the Republican wrote that "Sweigert has been a sergeant since 1939." He was twenty-one, with a rank in the Guard and a troop of his own in the town.

One detail is worth leaving unsmoothed. His troop met in the basement of the Evangelical Church, and the item immediately above it on the same page is a different troop altogether — the one at St. Mark's Reformed Church, whose scoutmaster was Glenn Ewing and who held their own Hallowe'en party at his house the same evening. St. Mark's was Allen's congregation for the whole of his life, the church he married in and was buried from. Cressona had two troops that autumn, and his was the one at the other church.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 26 October 1939, p. 2, "Had Hallowe'en Party" and "Boy Scout Party"; Pottsville Republican, 12 April 1941, p. 4.

Candy, Sandwiches and Sweaters at Pottsville

The Call of Schuylkill Haven ran its own roster ten days later, on Friday 27 September 1940, carried over from page one under the jump head "Sch. Haven Gives". What survives of the sentence the jump cuts into is a send-off: "…ettes, candy, sandwiches and sweaters were given them by the Red Cross at Pottsville." An earlier reading of this page gave the fourth item as "others". Enlarged, it is *sweaters*, broken across two lines — which is a different thing to hand a man in September. The first word is broken too, and what the page shows is "…ettes": cigarettes is the obvious reading and it is still a reading. Then: "The members of Battery F from Schuylkill Haven and Cressona are as follows:" Only the jump head and the page-four text have been read. The front-page headline and the paragraphs above the jump have not.

The two lists do not agree. On Allen they do: both papers put him among the sergeants. Below that they part. The Call gives seven sergeants from Schuylkill Haven and Cressona alone: "Sergeants — Geo. A. Fatkin, John H. Roeder, John E. Dewald, Schuylkill Haven; Rayfield R. Berger, Robert R. Dando, Jr., **Allen E. Sweigert** and Russell W. Rauch, Cressona." The Republican, ten days earlier, gave five for the whole battery, and its five include Edward J. Weiser of Schuylkill Haven, whom The Call does not put among its sergeants.

Dewald, Dando and Rauch are sergeants in one paper and not in the other; Weiser is a sergeant in the other and not in this one. Scope does not explain it. The Call keeps to the two towns — that is why it prints only Frank Knarr of the battery's three second lieutenants and leaves out Rehrig of Allentown and Zerbey of Pottsville — but Weiser is a Schuylkill Haven man and belongs inside that rule. Two of the seven stood lower in the Republican's list of 3 August: a Robt. R. Dando among the Cressona privates, a Russel W. Rauch among its corporals. Kenneth E. Berger, a Cressona sergeant on that same August list, is among the sergeants of neither September roster. Which paper had the armory's list right cannot be settled here.

Two things the item will not carry. The privates break off into damaged type partway through, so nothing can be said about who is missing from the lower grades, and nobody can be shown absent from a list that was not read to its end. And the paper does not date the send-off: the Red Cross met them at Pottsville, the regiment went south to Camp Pendleton on 24 September by the unit records, and this note does not join the two.

Sources: The Call, Schuylkill Haven, 27 September 1940, p. 1, continued p. 4 (jump head and p. 4 text only); Pottsville Republican, 17 September 1940, p. 1; Pottsville Republican, 3 August 1940, p. 2.

The Roster, on the Front Page

The Pottsville Republican put Battery F on its front page on Tuesday 17 September 1940 — the day after federal service began — and printed every man in it. The paper made a point of the towns: "so that the two units here are not really Pottsville's but may truly be called Schuylkill County's First Defenders."

Battery F, as the paper set it. Captain, H. R. D. Schwenk, Sch. Haven. First Lieutenant, Lewis R. Noecker, Sch. Haven. Second Lieutenants, Frank Knarr, Cressona; Lester Rehrig, Allentown; Joseph H. Zerbey, 3rd, Pottsville. First Sergeant, Donald L. Eiler, Sch. Haven. Staff Sergeant, Harold B. Ney, Sch. Haven. Sergeants: Rayfield R. Berger, Cressona; Geo. A. Fatkin, Sch. Haven; John H. Roeder, Sch. Haven; **Allen E. Sweigert, Cressona**; Edward J. Weiser, Sch. Haven.

One of five sergeants as the Republican set them, at twenty-two, on the front page of the county daily. The Call counted differently ten days later, and the note on that paper takes it up. The captain's name is the one already written in his own service record book. And it settles something this chapter had to leave open: a 1937 newspaper puts him in Headquarters Battery, while this puts him in Battery F three years later, so he moved between them at some point before the call-up rather than being a different man altogether.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 17 September 1940, p. 1.

A Used Car, February 1940

The smallest thing the search turned up, and worth keeping for that reason. On Friday 16 February 1940 the Pottsville Republican printed its weekly round-up of property and vehicle transfers across Schuylkill County. Under the heading "Used Car Sales were as follows", between George Sterner of Schuylkill Haven and John Hiler of Harrisburg, is "Allen E. Sweigert, Cressona."

He was twenty-one, four years into the Guard, eighteen months from Scott Field and two years from Australia, and he bought himself a second-hand car. The paper does not say what it was.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 16 February 1940, p. 2.

Three Sergeants Gave Up Their Stripes

The Pottsville Republican of Saturday 12 April 1941 ran it under a headline: **3 QUIT 213TH FOR AIR CORPS**, and beneath that, *Sgts. Sweigert, Frack, Fedorchak Now at Savanaah Air Base* — the paper's own misspelling. It is datelined Camp Stewart and bylined Harvey D. Haddad, who writes "our induction last September" and so was in the battery himself.

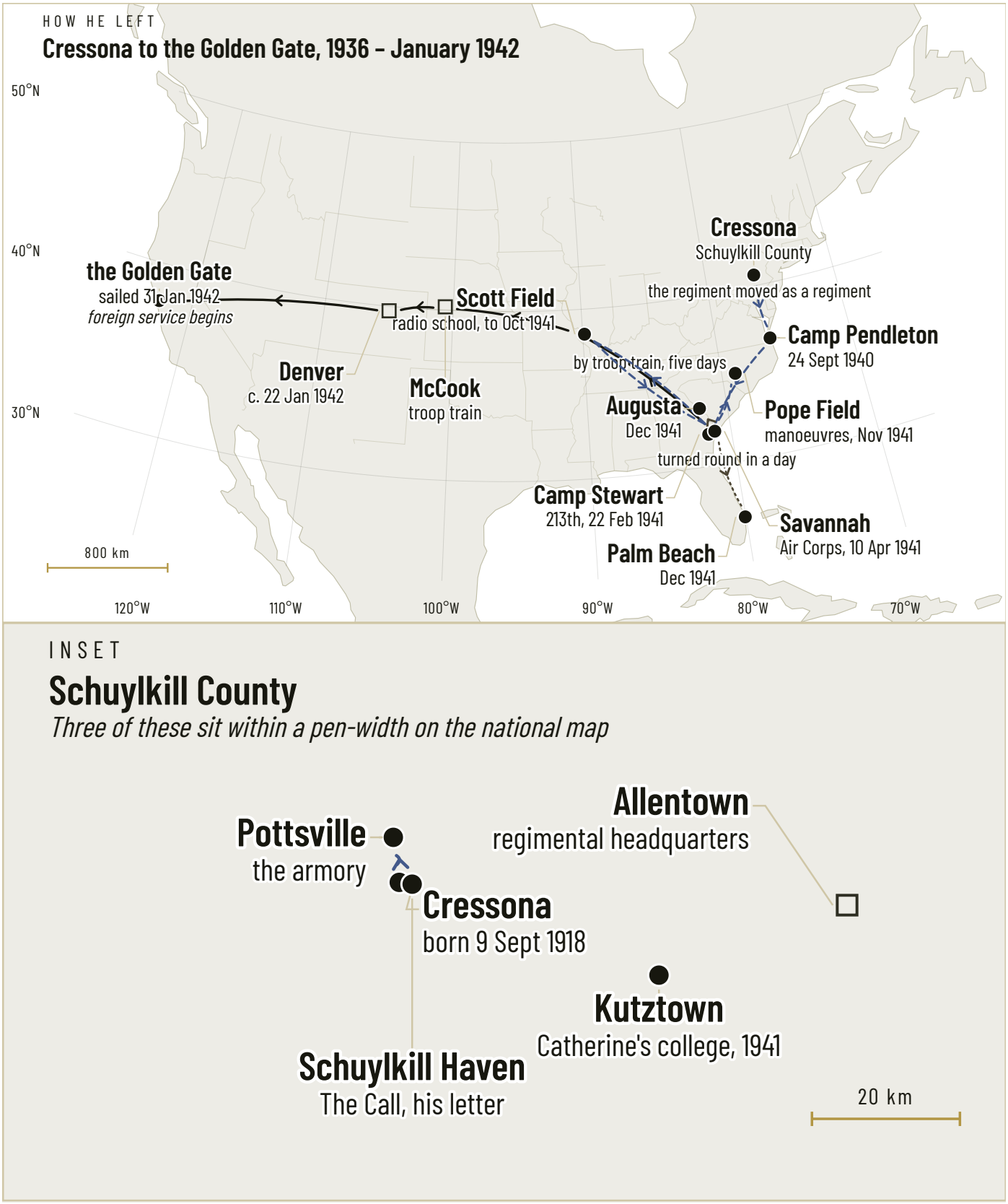
"Three of Battery F's sergeants received their discharge papers tonight, so they could enlist in the morning in the Army Air Corps and will be stationed at the air base in Savannah, Ga. The three men are Sergt. Allen E. Sweigert, Cressona; Sergt. Jesse D. Frack, Frackville, and Sergt. Andrew Fedorchak, Pottsville."

Two things in that are new. He did not go alone — two other men went with him, and they can be named. And he was *a sergeant already*. The paper says so twice: "Sweigert has been a sergeant since 1939." Enlisting in the Air Corps meant surrendering that, which is why he sailed for Australia in the ranks and why he could write home from Brisbane that he had had two promotions since leaving the States. He had been a sergeant, given it up, and had to earn it again.

The last line of the item says what he was after. "While Frack is mainly interested in the flying end of the Air Corps, the other two men are looking at the radio part of this branch." In April 1941, before Scott Field and before anybody assigned him anything, radio was the thing he went for.

One caution. The item says the three had "been members since 1939," where this chapter has him joining in late 1936 on his own account. Whether the writer meant Battery F specifically, or the 1939 date is simply wrong, the page does not say, and the two are left standing side by side.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 12 April 1941, p. 4.



Four miles lay between Cressona and the Pottsville armory — too little for the national map to keep them apart. Schuylkill Haven, whose weekly paper posted The Call to him in Australia and printed his letter back, is a mile the other way.

How he left: Cressona to the Golden Gate, 1936 – January 1942. Coastlines from Natural Earth (public domain), projected on an Albers conic equal-area and generalised for this document.

▼ THIS DRAWING, SET OUT IN WORDS

- Cressona, in Schuylkill County, where he was born on 9 September 1918. The county is drawn separately below, because Cressona, Pottsville and Schuylkill Haven fall within a pen-width at this scale.
- Camp Pendleton, Virginia, from 24 September 1940, with the regiment.
- Camp Stewart, Georgia, from 22 February 1941.
- Savannah, forty miles away, where he left the Guard at his own request and enlisted in the Air Corps on 10 April 1941.
- Scott Field, Illinois, the Air Corps radio school, which he left on 27 October 1941.
- Pope Field, North Carolina, for the Carolina manoeuvres of November 1941.
- Augusta, Georgia, in December 1941, and a one-day errand to Palm Beach.
- The troop train west, the one leg whose means is recorded: five days through St. Louis, McCook and Denver to Oakland, 19 to 24 January 1942.
- The Golden Gate, 31 January 1942 — the day his foreign service begins, by the Commonwealth's reckoning and the Army's.
- A filled disc marks a place he is documented to have been. An open square marks a place documented for his unit rather than for him. An open square with a diagonal tick marks his own squadron. A dashed circle marks a place that is inferred rather than recorded.
- A brass ring crossed by a bar marks a place he never stood on — a target, or somewhere his group went without him. Each carries the words HE WAS NOT THERE.
- A solid line is a journey whose means of travel is recorded. A dashed line is a move that is documented while the means is not. A dotted line rests on his own account alone.
- No plate here carries a distance worked out by arithmetic. His own “about 12,000 miles” already stands in these pages against a measured 9,500 to 10,200, and a third figure, quietly calculated, would be a number nobody ever measured.

Headquarters Battery in 1937, Battery F by 1942

The battery he joined in late 1936 has always been given as Battery F at Pottsville, and for the later years the evidence is good. His own letter of May 1942 sends "regards to the boys of Btry. 'F', 213th," and the Pottsville Republican says he "left Pottsville with the 213th Coast Artillery."

The first two years are less settled. The Call of 7 May 1937 prints Allen E. Sweigert among the results of a gunner's examination sat by "the men of Headquarters Battery" of the regiment. The roster of July 1937 puts him in Headquarters Battery by name, and the front page of 17 September 1940, printed above, puts him in Battery F, so he moved between them at some point between that examination and the call-up rather than being a different Allen E. Sweigert; when the move came is not recorded. The same paragraph carries a Luther M. Sweigert, same battery, same mark, with no word of how the two men were related, or whether they were at all. For 1936 and 1937, then, the safest thing to say is simply the regiment.

Sources: The Call, Schuylkill Haven, 7 May 1937, p. 4; Letter of Sgt. Allen E. Sweigert, 19 May 1942, in The Call, 12 June 1942; Pottsville Republican, 28 May 1942, p. 18.

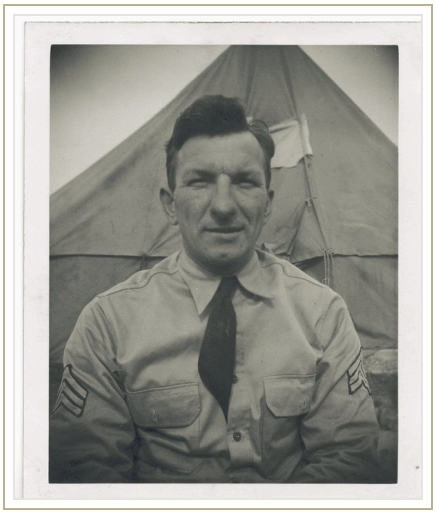
Before the Army Air Force there were four years in the Pennsylvania National Guard — weekend drills at the armory and summer encampments in the field, from 1936 to 1940. This was Allen's first soldiering.

"The First Defenders"

The nickname predates the 213th itself. When Lincoln called for troops on April 15, 1861, five Pennsylvania militia companies reached Washington, D.C. within two days — among the first armed Union units to arrive, earning the state's volunteers the name "First Defenders." Two of those companies were Pottsville's own: the Washington Artillerists and the National Light Infantry. In 1922 those two units were consolidated into a new Pennsylvania National Guard regiment, the 213th Coast Artillery (Anti-Aircraft), carrying the First Defenders name and lineage forward — the regiment, and Battery F, that Allen joined in 1936. After Allen left the regiment in April 1941 — discharged at his own request, and enlisted in the Air Corps at Savannah — the 213th itself deployed overseas as part of Operation Torch, fighting in North Africa and Italy, before being broken up in an April 1944 reorganization of anti-aircraft units.

Sources: Pennsylvania First Defenders; Schuylkill County Historical Society; 213th Coast Artillery Regiment archives.

Allen, in a garrison cap, close portrait.

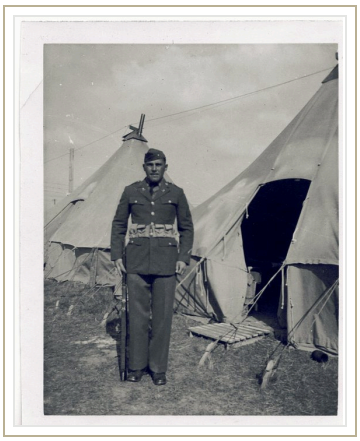


A sergeant, chevrons visible, stands before a tent.

A hand-lettered camp sign reads "SGT. R. BUBECK" and "SGT. A. SWEIGERT" — Allen's own name, in camp.

A company street of tents, one marked with the letter "F" for Battery F.

Four soldiers operate a mobile anti-aircraft gun mount in the field.



Allen stands at attention in full dress uniform, rifle at his side.

Four soldiers, one crouching, smile for a group photo among the tents.

Soldiers clown around camp, one balancing on the backs of three others.

Soldiers joke around a hand cart on a barracks street.

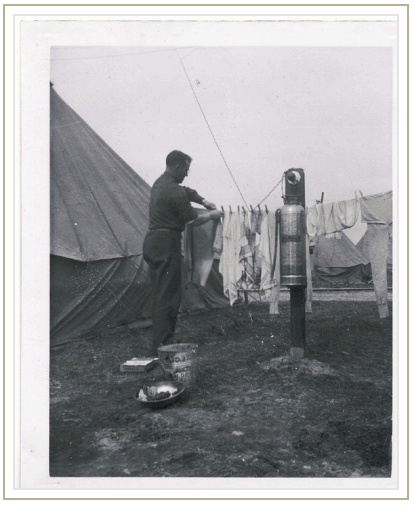
Six soldiers, several smoking pipes, relax on the steps of barracks 810.

Allen with an older woman — likely his mother, visiting camp.

Allen and two other soldiers relax on a beach, wood-frame cottages behind them.

Allen is one of four men outside a pyramidal tent with a stovepipe through its peak: two in one-piece work coveralls and soft hats, one in shirt and trousers with a pipe in his mouth, and one bare-headed in shirtsleeves standing on a wooden duckboard. Folding cots, hanging towels, a pan and a bucket stand about the tent, with more tents and a pole line beyond.

Allen is one of two servicemen in khaki shirts and ties with garrison caps standing either side of a woman in a dark fur-collared coat and hat at the entrance of a pyramidal tent, the stovepipe rising behind them and further tents on both sides.



Allen, in wool shirt and trousers, pegs washing to a line strung between tents, a soda-acid fire extinguisher hanging from a board on a post beside him. On the ground are a washbasin, a flat cardboard box, and a galvanized bucket stencilled "NO. 3" and hand-lettered below with "SGT" and a name ending "...ALD".

Six men in a dark room, several in undershirts and light fatigue caps, their hands gathered at the centre of the group and a metal basin on the table in front of them. Bare bulbs hang from the ceiling, a printed sheet is tacked to the wall at the left, and the only light comes through a slatted window at the right.

Allen at the left, with another man in fatigue coveralls, crouching on an unpaved camp road holding up a home-made crate of light wooden slats fitted with a carrying handle, something dark visible inside it; Allen wears chevrons on his sleeve and each of them holds a tool. Wooden camp buildings, tall pines, a parked 1930s sedan and a distant figure near the far building fill the background.

Five Frames That Were in the Wrong Chapter

Five photographs printed here were, until this revision, in the Pacific chapter, filed with the camps at Port Moresby and Dobodura. They belong with the Guard. Jeremy said so, and once said it is obvious: stovepipes through the peaks of the tents, wool shirts, garrison caps, and in one of them a woman visiting in a fur-collared winter coat. Nobody wore wool or lit a tent stove in New Guinea, and no wives came to visit.

The roll agrees. All five carry frame numbers from the same strip as eighteen other pictures that were already in this chapter — the company street with the letter F, the mobile gun mount, the hand-lettered sign reading “SGT. R. BUBECK” and “SGT. A. SWEIGERT.” The five that had drifted were separated from their own strip, not from their own place. The last two are the plainest of all: one is a room with bare bulbs and a slatted window, and the other has pine woods, wooden camp buildings and a parked American sedan of the middle thirties in it.

Allen is in three of the five, which means that for those he was not the one holding the camera. Somebody in the same camp took them and he kept the prints. The galvanised bucket by the washing line is stencilled for a different sergeant, a name ending in [1]ald[1], which is the sort of detail that says whose company street this was as clearly as any caption.

Identification: Jeremy Sweigert, 24 September 2026.

Extra Money in the Coal Country

Cressona sits in the southern anthracite field of Schuylkill County, where the Depression arrived early and never really left. Between 1926 and 1933 the coal operators cut production by a third and laid off nearly 67,000 of the region's 169,000 anthracite miners; by 1932 roughly 39,000 of Schuylkill County's 82,000 workers were out of a job, and by the mid-1930s illegal "bootleg" mining on company land accounted for about a tenth of all anthracite produced.

That is the town Allen graduated into in the spring of 1936, and it explains why a National Guard enlistment read as wages rather than patriotism. The National Defense Act set the rhythm: a Guard battery had to turn out for drill at least forty-eight times a year and spend at least fifteen days in the field, and a Guardsman drew pay for every one of those days at a day's rate of the Regular Army base pay for his grade. A private's base pay in the late 1930s was $21 a month, so a drill night was worth cents rather than dollars — but it was cash, it came on a schedule, and in Schuylkill County in 1937 very little else did.

Sources: Schuylkill County [Great Depression] Historical Marker — ExplorePAHistory (Pennsylvania Historical & Museum Commission); 32 U.S.C. 502: Required drills and field exercises; 1922–1940 Enlisted Military Base Pay Chart.

Battery F, Pottsville — The First Defenders

The regiment Allen joined was the 213th Coast Artillery (Antiaircraft), a Pennsylvania National Guard unit with its headquarters at Allentown and its batteries scattered through the armories of eastern Pennsylvania: the searchlight battery at Reading, three-inch antiaircraft gun batteries at Allentown, Bethlehem and Easton, and the machine-gun batteries at Lancaster, Pottsville, Reading and Lebanon. Battery F was the Pottsville battery, working .30-calibre water-cooled guns a few miles up the Schuylkill from Cressona — near enough that a boy from Cressona could belong to it.

The regiment's motto, "The First Defenders," was earned rather than chosen: of the five Pennsylvania militia companies that answered Lincoln's call in April 1861 and became the first volunteer troops to reach Washington, at six in the evening on 18 April, two — the Washington Artillerists and the National Light Infantry — were Pottsville companies, and the 213th descended from them by way of the 4th Pennsylvania Infantry. Both came down into the regiment as its Service and Headquarters batteries, so when Allen turned out for weekly drill in the Pottsville armory in 1937 he was standing in a line — his town's and his regiment's both — that ran back to the first Union volunteers to reach the capital. The squadron patches and unit names of the Pacific were still five years away; this was his first outfit, and it was a local one.

Sources: FIRST DEFENDERS — The 213th Coast Artillery Regiment (Anti Aircraft) — unit history site listing battery home stations and armament; 213th Air Defense Artillery Regiment (United States) — lineage of the 213th Coast Artillery (AA); Pennsylvania First Defenders; Historical Sketches: Coast Artillery Regiments 1917–1950 (National Guard) — Coast Defense Study Group.

“Something Brewing”: The New York Manoeuvres

Allen sets this camp “before we were mobilized,” which places it in the summer of 1940 rather than 1941 — by the summer of 1941 he had already left the Guard and was at radio school in Illinois. From 5 to 23 August 1940 the First Army held its manoeuvres in northern New York, putting provisional I, II and III Corps of Regular Army and National Guard troops into the field through St. Lawrence County, with the camps spread around Canton and Ogdensburg — by far the largest body of troops most of these men had ever stood in.

The county history of the 213th records the regiment at III Corps manoeuvres at Heuvelton, near Ogdensburg, and a citation from 28th Division headquarters during the First Army manoeuvres for its “high spirit and usual initiative” and the manner in which it gave antiaircraft protection. Three weeks in the field instead of the customary fifteen days, camped alongside the regular establishment, with France newly fallen and the newspapers full of it — the feeling that something was brewing was entirely sound. The men came out of the field on 23 August. The call-up order reached them three weeks later, on 15 September.

Sources: Schuylkill County Pennsylvania Military History: The 213th Coast Artillery, Schuylkill County Men During the Years of Peace, 1922–1941; First Army Maneuvers: Northern New York, August 5 to 23, 1940 (contemporary official publication); Biennial Reports of the Chief of Staff of the United States Army, July 1, 1939 to June 30, 1941 (HyperWar); 44th Infantry Division (United States) — First Army manoeuvres near Canton, New York, August 1940.

16 September 1940: A Camp in Virginia

Congress opened the door with Joint Resolution 96, approved 27 August 1940, which authorised the President to order the National Guard into federal service for twelve consecutive months — and forbade its use beyond the Western Hemisphere and America's own possessions. The first Guard units went in on 16 September 1940, the same day the Selective Training and Service Act was signed into law; in all, the Guard handed the Army 20,006 officers, 216 warrant officers and 282,805 enlisted men.

The 213th was in that first wave, inducted at Allentown on 15 September and moved to Camp Pendleton, Virginia, on 24 September for training, then on to Camp Stewart, Georgia, on 22 February 1941 — Camp Stewart being the Army's brand-new antiaircraft training centre, carved out of nearly half of Liberty County and pieces of four more, raw pine and palmetto scrub where live antiaircraft firing did not begin until July 1941. He had the order of it exactly right — a camp in Virginia, then Camp Stewart — and only the length of time generous, since the regiment had been in Georgia barely seven weeks when he was discharged on 10 April 1941. The twelve-month promise did not hold either: on 12 August 1941 the House voted 203 to 202 to extend service by up to eighteen months more, and the buddies he went back to visit on 7 December — the regiment held Camp Stewart until the 12th — were still in uniform because of a single vote.

Sources: Historical Sketches: Coast Artillery Regiments 1917–1950 (National Guard) — Coast Defense Study Group; station dates for the 213th CA (AA); Biennial Reports of the Chief of Staff of the United States Army, 1939–1941 — Joint Resolution No. 96 and the 16 September 1940 induction; Fort Stewart — New Georgia Encyclopedia (Camp Stewart as antiaircraft training centre, 1940–41); Tally sheet for the House vote on H.J. Res. 222, August 12, 1941 — U.S. Capitol Visitor Center.

Getting Out of a Federalised Regiment LIKELY

A man could be let out of a federalised Guard regiment before his twelve months ran; which paragraph of the rules let Allen out, nobody now knows. The governing regulation was AR 615-360, Enlisted Personnel — Discharge, and its Section X covered discharge for the convenience of the Government. Regular Army enlistment, meanwhile, stayed open through 1941 and was suspended for the duration on 13 December of that year — eight months after Allen walked through that door.

Other Guardsmen in federal service certainly did take Regular Army enlistments. A Comptroller General decision of 22 December 1941 turns on a man discharged from the 120th Engineers on 16 September 1941 who enlisted in the Regular Army the next day — but his term had simply run out, which is not what the notices describe for Allen. They describe a request granted in the middle of one. No War Department instruction allowing a man out for the express purpose of joining the Air Corps has ever turned up.

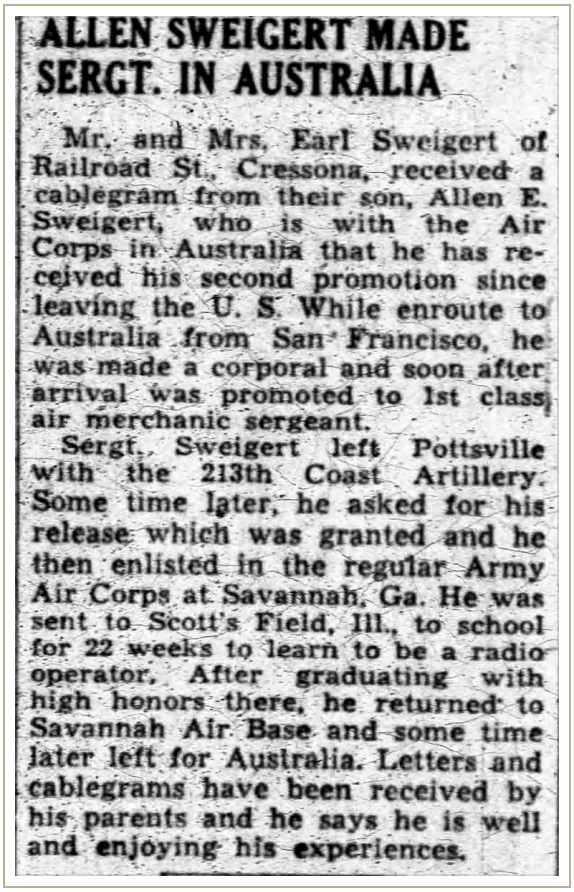
Sources: Comptroller General decision B-21629, 22 December 1941, 21 Comp. Gen. 603; AR 615-360, Enlisted Personnel — Discharge; Army of the United States — Wikipedia.

He Asked To Be Let Go

Until these two notices surfaced, the only account of how Allen left the 213th was his own, given on tape sixty-four years afterwards. Both papers, set from a family's information within months of the event, say the same thing and add one word that changes the shape of it. "He left Pottsville with the 213th Coast Artillery and later asked for a discharge, which was granted, and then he enlisted in the regular army with the Air Corps at Savannah, Georgia." The other: "Some time later, he asked for his release which was granted and he then enlisted in the regular Army Air Corps at Savannah, Ga."

Two compositors, working from separate copy, set the same two steps in the same order: a discharge he asked for, and then a fresh enlistment. So it was not a transfer at all. And the thing the papers add — the thing no other source in the collection says — is that the asking was his.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 28 May 1942, p. 18; The Call, Schuylkill Haven, 29 May 1942, p. 1; transcript-part1.html.

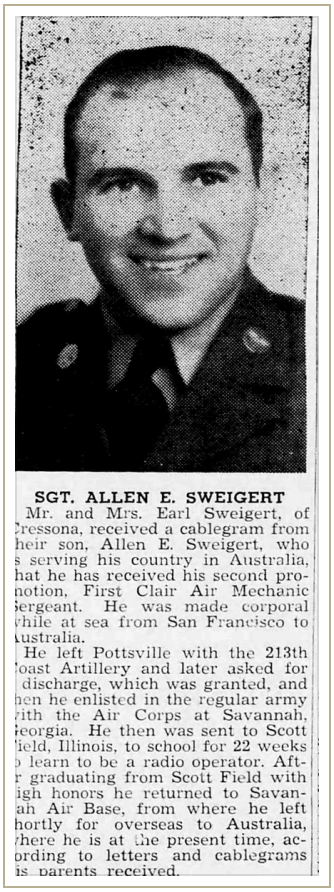


ALLEN SWEIGERT MADE SERGT. IN AUSTRALIA

Mr. and Mrs. Earl Sweigert of Railroad St., Cressona, received a cablegram from their son, Allen E. Sweigert, who is with the Air Corps in Australia that he has received his second promotion since leaving the U. S. While enroute to Australia from San Francisco, he was made a corporal and soon after arrival was promoted to 1st class air merchanic sergeant.

Sergt. Sweigert left Pottsville with the 213th Coast Artillery. Some time later, he asked for his release which was granted and he then enlisted in the regular Army Air Corps at Savannah, Ga. He was sent to Scott's Field, Ill., to school for 22 weeks to learn to be a radio operator. After graduating with high honors there, he returned to Savannah Air Base and some time later left for Australia. Letters and cablegrams have been received by his parents and he says he is well and enjoying his experiences.

The same news as the Pottsville Republican had set it the day before, on Thursday 28 May 1942. The wordings differ throughout, and on one point — how long he was back at Savannah before sailing — the two papers disagree outright. Credit: Pottsville Republican.



SGT. ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

Mr. and Mrs. Earl Sweigert, of Cressona, received a cablegram from their son, Allen E. Sweigert, who is serving his country in Australia, that he has received his second promotion, First Clair Air Mechanic Sergeant. He was made corporal while at sea from San Francisco to Australia.

He left Pottsville with the 213th Coast Artillery and later asked for discharge, which was granted, and then he enlisted in the regular army with the Air Corps at Savannah, Georgia. He then was sent to Scott Field, Illinois, to school for 22 weeks to learn to be a radio operator. After graduating from Scott Field with high honors he returned to Savannah Air Base, from where he left shortly for overseas to Australia, where he is at the present time, according to letters and cablegrams his parents received.

The Call of Schuylkill Haven, Friday 29 May 1942, front page — the news of his promotion, sent home by cablegram from Australia. The notice sets out his whole route into the Air Corps, and it is the source for the detail that the discharge from the Guard was granted at his own request. Credit: The Call, Schuylkill Haven.

What the “20” in His Serial Number Means

Army serial number 20 329 905 is not a random string; in the wartime system the leading digits told a clerk where a man had come from. A number beginning with 1 belonged to a Regular Army volunteer, 3 or 4 to a man who had been drafted, and 20 to a federally recognised National Guardsman.

Because every Guard number carried a zero in the second place, the geography was pushed to the third digit — and 3 was the Third Corps Area, headquartered at Baltimore and covering Pennsylvania, Maryland, Virginia and the District of Columbia. So the number on Allen’s papers states, on its face and without any family testimony at all, that he entered federal service as a Pennsylvania National Guardsman. It stayed with him through the discharge in Georgia, the enlistment at Savannah, three years of New Guinea and the discharge at Fort Dix: whatever the shoulder patch said afterwards, the first two digits always said Guard.

Sources: How to Decode a WWII US Army Serial Number — Amy Johnson Crow; Army Serial Numbers (ASN) history — WWII Dog Tags; Service number (United States Army) — Wikipedia (20-million series, National Guard); Corps area — Wikipedia (Third Corps Area: Pennsylvania, Maryland, District of Columbia and Virginia; headquartered at Baltimore).

The Radio School at Scott Field

Scott Field, outside Belleville, Illinois, had spent the 1920s and 1930s as the Army's lighter-than-air station, dominated by an airship hangar three blocks long and fifteen storeys high; the balloon and dirigible era ended abruptly in 1937, and on 1 June 1939 the field turned formally back to teaching as a branch of the Air Corps Technical Schools. Radio instruction had been concentrated at Chanute Field, but when Chanute's space was needed for aeroplane mechanics the radio work was moved to Scott, where the Radio School opened in September 1940.

Allen would have sat through the radio operator-mechanic course: twenty-two weeks long as it stood in 1940, meant to turn out a man who could work an aircraft radio station at sixteen words a minute and do first and second echelon maintenance on all of its equipment. His own dates, "maybe June up to about October," fit that course almost exactly — and he arrived with a head start, having already been working through a mail-order radio course at home in Cressona before the Army had any use for it. By the end of the war Scott Field had graduated 77,370 radio operator-mechanics and grown into some forty-six school buildings; Allen went through it in the school's first year.

Sources: The Army Air Forces in World War II, Volume VI: Men and Planes, Chapter 19 (HyperWar) — radio operator-mechanic course, 22 weeks, 16 words per minute; transfer of radio training from Chanute to Scott; Scott Air Force Base — Wikipedia (lighter-than-air era, Radio School, 77,370 graduates); Scott History: 1940s — Scott Air Force Base official history.

Savannah Air Base Was Very Nearly Its Name

The field at Savannah carried two names at once, and the notices used the Army's. The city bought the land in 1927 and dedicated the airport as Hunter Field in May 1940, after a Savannah-born flying ace of the first war. On 30 August 1940 the Air Corps received approval to build a base there, and the airfield was dedicated as Savannah Army Air Base on 19 February 1941 — a few weeks before Allen enlisted into it. It became Hunter Air Force Base in September 1950.

So "Savannah Air Base" is not loose home-town shorthand for an unnamed field. It is the installation's own designation, missing only the word Army. Within about two months of the 1940 decision the Air Corps had moved some three thousand men of the 3rd and 27th Bombardment Groups there, and Camp Stewart, where the 213th was then sitting, is forty miles away. The enlistment was a short journey, not a leap.

Sources: Hunter Army Airfield — unit and installation histories; New Georgia Encyclopedia, Camp Stewart.

The Army's Record of the Enlistment

The War Department kept a punch-card record of every enlistment, and it survives at the National Archives as a database. Allen's entry agrees with his papers on nearly everything: serial 20329905, enlisted 10 April 1941, Air Corps, Regular Army, four years of high school, single and without dependents, born in Pennsylvania in 1918 and living in Schuylkill County. It classes him as an "Enlisted Man, Regular Army, within 3 months of Discharge", which fits a Guardsman let go at his own request and sworn in again the same day.

It disagrees on the place. The card gives "Cp Stewart Hinesville Georgia", the camp where Battery F was sitting, while both 1942 notices say he enlisted at Savannah and his service book starts the 90th Squadron at SAAB Savannah from the same date. Nothing found settles which is right. The card also codes his civilian occupation as "Firemen, other than process firemen". The 1930 census lists his father as a fireman on a steam railroad; nothing in the collection explains the entry for Allen himself.

Sources: US, WWII Army Enlistment Records, 1938–1946, Allen E. Sweigert (National Archives, Record Group 64; source box 0341, film reel 3.63), via Fold3; US, Census, 1930, Cressona Borough, enumeration district 54-20, sheet 19B, via Fold3; Pottsville Republican, 28 May 1942, p. 18; The Call, Schuylkill Haven, 29 May 1942, p. 1.

Where the Two Papers Disagree

The notices were set from the same news and diverge all through, but on one point of substance they contradict each other. The first has him returning to Savannah Air Base "from where he left shortly for overseas to Australia." The second: he "returned to Savannah Air Base and some time later left for Australia."

The calendar settles it against the first. He graduated at Scott Field on 27 October 1941, by his own account; the 3rd Bombardment Group left Savannah on 19 January 1942 and sailed from San Francisco on the 31st. That is twelve weeks exactly, which is not "shortly." The looser wording is the accurate one, and the distinction earns its place because of what falls inside the interval: the Carolina Maneuvers of 16-28 November 1941, the episode this document has from the back of his own photograph. The first paper's compression would leave no room for it.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 28 May 1942, p. 18; The Call, Schuylkill Haven, 29 May 1942, p. 1; the-record.html, Convoy 2030.

Twenty-Two Weeks, Now From the Family's Own Hand

The length of his course had to be worked out the long way round, from the official history. His parents simply knew it. Both 1942 papers state the figure outright, in the family's own words: "to school for 22 weeks to learn to be a radio operator." That the number is reported rather than deduced matters, because the same official history records that soon after Pearl Harbor the radio operator-mechanic curriculum was cut to eighteen weeks. His was the long version, and that puts his class before December 1941.

It dates him, too, though not in the direction anyone expected. Working only from the twenty-two weeks, the arithmetic once put the start of the course in the first half of June 1941, which made his remembered "about October" look a few weeks early. Then his own letter of 19 May 1942 gave the date outright: he graduated at Scott Field on 27 October 1941. Twenty-two weeks back from that lands about 26 May, six weeks after he enlisted at Savannah. So the course began in late May. His memory was right and the arithmetic was wrong, and he was back with the squadron about three weeks before the manoeuvres opened on 16 November.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 28 May 1942, p. 18; The Call, Schuylkill Haven, 29 May 1942, p. 1; Craven & Cate, The Army Air Forces in World War II, Vol. VI, ch. 19.

Cressona in 1936

Cressona was settled in 1847 and incorporated as a borough ten years later, named for John Chapman Cresson, the Philadelphia engineer who managed the Schuylkill Navigation Company and presided over the Mine Hill and Schuylkill Haven Railroad; the borough grew up along that line, four miles south of Pottsville, and has never covered much more than a square mile. When Allen finished high school in 1936 it held fewer than two thousand people and was losing them — 1,946 at the 1930 census, 1,695 by 1940. Behind that drop was the collapse of the anthracite trade.

Between 1926 and 1933 the operators cut production by a third and let go nearly 67,000 of the region's 169,000 miners, and Schuylkill County took the worst of it: by 1932 roughly 39,000 of the county's 82,000 workers were out of work, 16,000 of them miners. Men dug coal illegally out of company ground to eat, and as late as 1941 bootleg mining still accounted for about one job in four in Schuylkill and Northumberland Counties. Against a background like that, a National Guard drill cheque was real money, and "I did get some part-time jobs" is the whole of the local economy in one clause.

Sources: Cressona, Pennsylvania — census figures, founding and namesake (Wikipedia); Cressona Borough, Munsell's History of Schuylkill County (USGenWeb Archives transcription); ExplorePAHistory — "Bootleg Coal Mining" historical marker essay (unemployment and production figures for Schuylkill County); Schuylkill County [Great Depression] Historical Marker — ExplorePAHistory (production, layoff and unemployment figures verified verbatim).

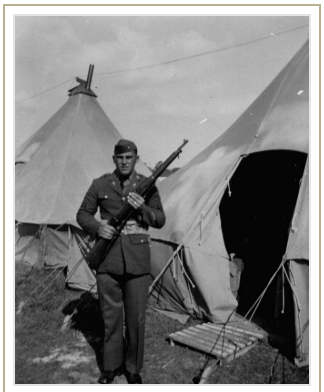
Battery F was a Pottsville outfit LIKELY

The battery Allen joined in late 1936 drilled four miles up the road: Battery F of the 213th Coast Artillery (Anti-Aircraft) was based at Pottsville, which is why a Cressona boy could belong to it and still sleep at home between weekly drills. The regiment carried the motto "The First Defenders," and the claim was literal.

When Lincoln called for troops on 15 April 1861, five Pennsylvania companies reached Washington before any others, arriving on the 18th — and two of them, the Washington Artillerists and the National Light Infantry, were Pottsville men. In the 1922 reorganisation those two became the Service Battery and the Headquarters Battery of the regiment that took the name 213th Coast Artillery two years later, so the anti-aircraft regiment recruiting in Schuylkill County in the 1930s held one of the oldest defence lineages in the United States. The mobilisation date reaches us a day apart, depending on who wrote it down: one regimental account gives 15 September 1940, the family record 16 September 1940.

Sources: FIRST DEFENDERS — The 213th Coast Artillery Regiment (Anti Aircraft): 1940 battery locations, Battery F at Pottsville; The 213th Coast Artillery: Schuylkill County Men During the Years of Peace, 1922–1941 (Schuylkill County Military History); Pennsylvania First Defenders (Wikipedia) — the five 1861 companies; 213th Air Defense Artillery Regiment (Wikipedia) — regimental lineage and motto.

Allen's mother, in a tweed overcoat, light brimmed hat and dark buckled shoes with a handbag held in both hands, standing beside him at the Guard camp — he is in wool service shirt, tie and garrison cap with a cap insignia, wearing wire-rimmed spectacles. Behind them are pyramidal tents, one with a stovepipe through the roof, and a wooden platform laid at the tent's edge.



Allen in a wool service coat with collar disks, shirt and tie and a garrison cap, holding a .30-calibre bolt-action rifle across his chest. He stands between pyramidal tents, one with its flap open and a wooden duckboard laid at the entrance.

A crowd of soldiers in wool service coats and garrison caps presses in around a Black civilian in a long overcoat, striped sweater and soft cap, who is laughing as he shakes hands with one of them. Wooden barracks with shingled roofs and metal roof ventilators stand behind; a first sergeant's chevrons show on the sleeve at the left of the frame.

Waist-up portrait of a sergeant in a wool service shirt and tie, three chevrons on his sleeve, seated in front of a pyramidal tent with a pale towel hung over its front.

A grinning serviceman in a wool shirt and tie, a small metal insignia pinned to the curtain of his garrison cap, photographed in front of a pyramidal tent; a second man stands at the right edge of the frame with chevrons on his sleeve.

Allen, broadly smiling, in a wool service shirt and tie with three-chevron sergeant's stripes on both sleeves, in front of a pyramidal tent.

A moustached serviceman in a wool shirt and tie, chevrons just visible at the cut edge of his sleeve, looks into the camera while behind him another man in a light shirt works at the open flap of a pyramidal tent.

Five men in cotton service shirts, ties and garrison caps at the corner of a wooden barracks building, Allen at the left — four standing and one seated on the ground in front of them. A second two-storey barracks stands beyond, with a group of roughly twenty more men gathered along the road behind.

Three men in cotton service shirts and ties in an open field, Allen at the left: two in garrison caps and the third in a visored service cap with a cap badge. A long line of men is massed across the background, and at the right a man in shorts and a light shirt runs past.

Six men pose among pyramidal tents pitched in a pine wood, four standing — one of them stooped forward with his head down — and two crouching in front. Five wear work fatigues and soft caps; the man at the right is bareheaded in a dark sweater with a light scarf at his neck. A rough timber rack and table stand at the left, a timber rail runs across the group, and wires are strung overhead. The back reads "Pope Field / Maneuvers / Nov. 1941".

The paper trail that matches his caption

For years the November 1941 maneuvers were the one episode in Allen's account that could not be matched to a printed page. The standard unit histories of the 3rd Bombardment Group record only that it sat at Savannah, Georgia, from 6 October 1940 to 19 January 1942, and say nothing at all about North Carolina. The order of battle for the exercise itself does. Listed under the Blue force's 1st Air Support Command, in both phases of the maneuver, is the 3d Bombardment Group — Allen's own group, lent out for the length of the war game to Colonel William E. Kepner's command and to Lieutenant General Hugh Drum's First Army.

Its parent unit went the other way. The 3rd Air Support Command, activated on 1 September 1941 at the Army Air Base at Savannah — Allen's own station — served the Red side under IV Corps. The Army's own history of Hunter Field adds that the 3rd and 27th Bomb Groups trained there through 1940 and 1941 while taking part in large-scale Army maneuvers in the Carolinas. No published source names the squadron or the airfield. For those two things the only witness is Allen's own handwriting.

Sources: 3rd Air Support Command (activation, assignment dates, attachment to IV Corps); History of Hunter Army Airfield, U.S. Army Garrison Fort Stewart; 3rd Bombardment Group, historyofwar.org (stations and dates); 3rd Bombardment Group, Peter Dunn's Australia @ War.

The largest war game the Army had ever run

The exercise Allen joined covered more ground than any war game the United States Army had ever fought on its own soil, though not more men — the Louisiana maneuvers of that same autumn had fielded some 400,000. Roughly 350,000 contended here, across a box about ninety by a hundred and fifty miles south and east of Charlotte, on the Charlotte-Columbia-Camden-Cheraw-Fort Bragg line. It ran in two phases: the first from 16 to 21 November 1941, remembered afterward as the Battle of the Pee Dee, and the second from 25 to 28 November, the Second Battle of Camden.

Lieutenant General Hugh Drum's Blue First Army of about 195,000 met a smaller Red force of roughly 100,000 under Major General Oscar Griswold, stiffened by the I Armored Corps and George Patton's tanks. Each side was given an air support command of its own, and on the opening day of the second phase Blue aviation — Allen's side of the game — bombed the Pee Dee bridges from Cheraw south. The whole thing was called off on 28 November. Pearl Harbor came nine days later.

Sources: "Relax — It's Only a Maneuver", HistoryNet (phase dates, force sizes, area, air action, end date); Carolina Maneuvers (order of battle, troop strength, Red and Blue air support commands); 1st Air Support Command (Kepner, attachment to First Army); The U.S. Army GHQ Maneuvers of 1941, CMH Pub 70-41 (Gabel), U.S. Army Center of Military History.

Canvas in the longleaf pines LIKELY

The picture delivers what the caption promises: tents pitched among tall pines, a group of men standing about in the sand. Canvas was the whole of the arrangement. An army on maneuvers bivouacked where it stopped, tens of miles from any barracks, and November in the sandhills is not mild — men who were on the Carolina Maneuvers remembered ice on the water buckets in the morning and a scramble for kerosene heaters, with early C-rations for chow.

The permanent post behind them was bursting all the same. Fort Bragg had held 5,406 officers and enlisted men on 1 June 1940 and carried more than 67,000 by 1941, and in a single nine-month stretch of those two years it went from 376 buildings of various types to 3,155 — the scale of the expansion that had put Allen in uniform in the first place. Out in the field, letters still found them — mail call was as welcome there as anywhere, handed round by the company clerk or a non-commissioned officer instead of collected at an orderly-room window back in garrison. It is a cold camp in that picture, whatever else it is.

Sources: "Relax — It's Only a Maneuver", HistoryNet (field conditions, ice on the water buckets, rations); Fort Bragg, North Carolina Postal History Society (garrison strength, 376 to 3,155 buildings, mail call in the field); Pope AFB (Pope Field), NC — History (Fort Bragg strength 1940-41, paved runways 1940).

Marston Mat was born in the same weeks, a few miles away

Within the same maneuver area, in the same month, the Army laid the first pierced-steel-plank airstrip ever built in the United States. The site was a low hill a mile east of US Route 1, two miles northeast of the hamlet of Marston, North Carolina, southwest of Fort Bragg and beside what would later be Camp Mackall's airfield. Engineers cleared and graded 350 feet by 3,800 feet, moved some fifty thousand cubic yards of earth and laid a strip 150 feet wide and 3,000 feet long, and the whole job took eleven days; each panel was ten feet by fifteen inches, weighed 66.2 pounds, and needed no tool but a sledge to hook it to its neighbor.

It came up as easily as it went down — when the maneuvers ended the strip was lifted, loaded into eighteen railroad gondola cars and hauled off to Langley Field, Virginia. Judged a success, the mat went to the Pacific carrying the name of that North Carolina hamlet, and Allen would meet it again on the New Guinea strips. Nothing in his account says he saw it laid, and there is no reason to suppose he did. But the steel he later took entirely for granted and the tent camp in his photograph belong to the same few weeks and very nearly the same stretch of Carolina pine.

Sources: Marston Mat (name origin, 3,000 by 150 foot strip, eleven days, panel dimensions and weight, Pacific use); "Marston Mat", Air & Space Forces Magazine (site description, construction figures, earthmoving).

The sister group that went the other way

Two light bombardment groups shared Hunter Field at Savannah in 1941, the 3rd and the 27th, carried on the rolls of the same air support command — the 27th with A-24 dive bombers, four of the 3rd's five squadrons with A-20s. In November they parted. The 27th sailed from San Francisco on 1 November 1941 and its ground echelon reached Manila on the 20th; the ship carrying its A-24s, the Meigs, could be found no escort past Hawaii before 24 November, and the convoy was turned for Australia.

The planes never reached the Philippines, and the men who were waiting for them fought as infantry on Bataan and Corregidor, most of them into captivity. The 27th's assignment to the 3rd Air Support Command lapsed around 20 November, the very week Allen's group was in the Carolina pines. The two outfits met again all the same: in March 1942, 42 officers, 62 enlisted men and 24 of those A-24s were assigned to Allen's 3rd Bombardment Group. Nothing in the interview suggests he knew at the time which way the two had been sent, or what the difference would come to mean.

Sources: 27th Bombardment / 27th Fighter Group, historyofwar.org (sailed 1 Nov 1941, Manila 20 Nov 1941, aircraft never delivered); 27th Bombardment Group, Peter Dunn's Australia @ War; 3rd Air Support Command (27th Bombardment Group assigned 1 Sep to c. 20 Nov 1941); History of Hunter Army Airfield, U.S. Army Garrison Fort Stewart (3rd and 27th Bomb Groups at Hunter, 1940–41).

CHAPTER THREE

ALLEN E. SWEIGERT, SR. · WWII & FAMILY HISTORY

Part 1

The Full Interview Transcript, July 2006

Type two letters or more to filter to the passages that mention it. Press Enter to step through them, Shift+Enter to step back, Esc to clear.

Allen mid-story, Part 1, 2006.

J **JEREMY** 00:00

First off, tell us a little bit about yourself before we even get into the war stuff.

A **ALLEN** 00:05

Where do we want to start off? I mean, what do you mean by that?

J ***JEREMY*** 00:08

Well, just a little bit about your background or how you were raised, born. You know, my name is... Okay, my name... Not yet. Stuff like that. What kind of family you were brought up on leading up...

A **ALLEN** 00:26

You know, just maybe about five minutes leading up to what made you decide to join the National Guard.

J ***JEREMY*** 00:32

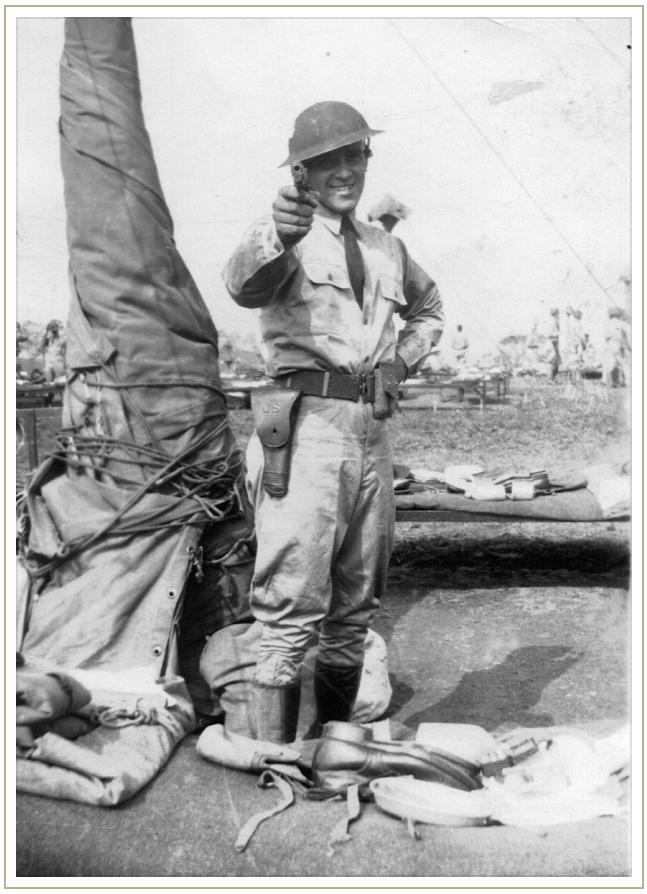
So just take it as it comes to you.

A **ALLEN** 00:39

All right.

J ***JEREMY*** 00:39

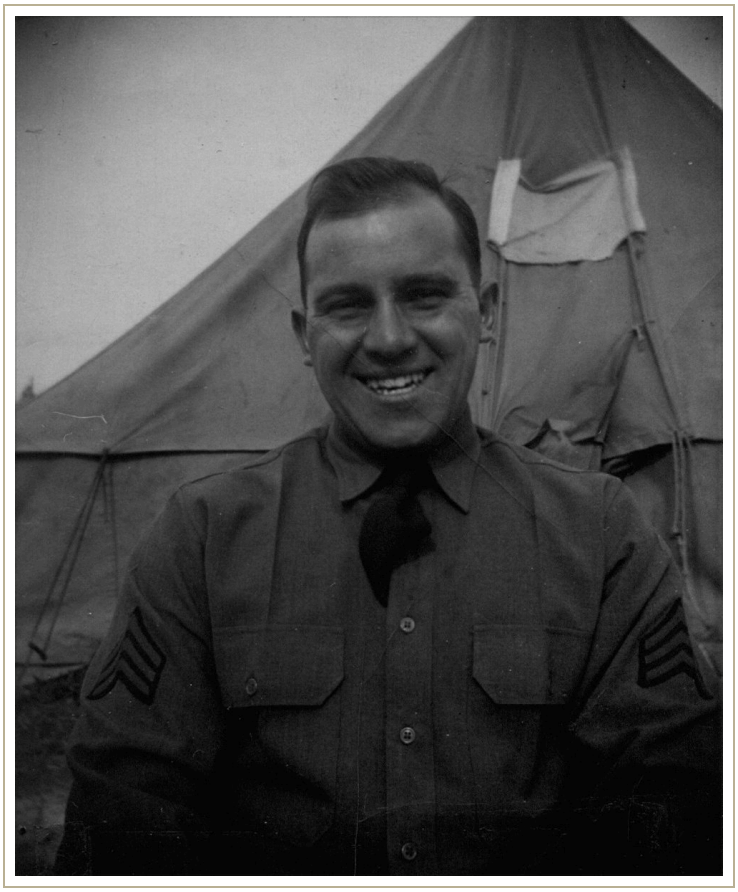
Any time now.



Allen at a Saturday inspection, Indiantown Gap, Pennsylvania, 1937.

A **ALLEN** 00:41

Okay, my name is Allen Sweigert. Born September the 9th, 1918, in Cressona. Cressona, Pennsylvania. Went to the Cressona schools. Graduated from high school. Graduated from high school in 1936. It was in the midst of the Depression. There wasn't too much doing in the town. I did get some part-time jobs. And I also enlisted in the Pennsylvania National Guard to get a little extra money. We had to go to weekly drills and summer encampment. And I belonged to the Guard from 19... Late 1936 all the way up till 1940 when we were mobilized into federal service. We went to a camp in Virginia. Camp. And then stayed there a while. And then we were moved to Camp Stewart in Georgia. After about... I guess it was about nine months into that. In April of that year... Yeah, it's positive. In April of 1941, I got discharged from the National Guard and enlisted into the Army Air Force at Savannah, Georgia. And I was assigned to the 90th Bomb Squadron, 3rd Bomb Group. And shortly after I enlisted, I was sent to the radio. And I was sent to the radio. And I was sent to the radio school in Scott Field, Illinois.

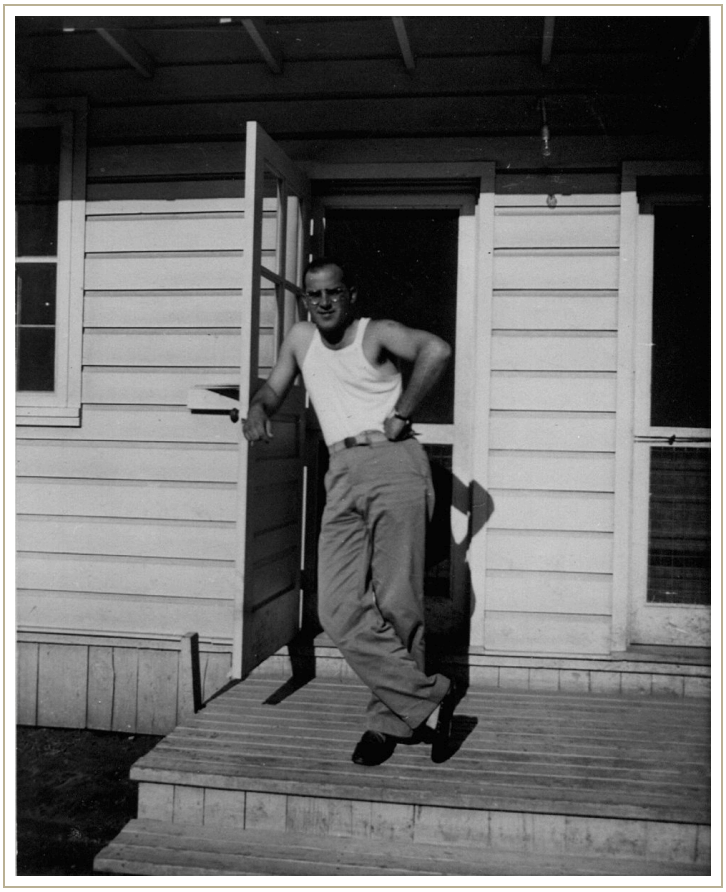


Allen at camp in Virginia, labeled "Camp Endelton, VA, '41."

Battery F, 213th Coast Artillery, "The First Defenders."

Allen at the 90th Bomb Squadron radio sign.

The 3rd Attack Group's sign: "The Grim Reapers."



Allen at Scott Field, Illinois, radio school.

"Goofing off at army radio school" — Scott Field.

J **JEREMY** 02:38

What did you... Did you pick the radio? I mean, how did that come about?

A **ALLEN** 02:43

I was in... I had been taking a home course, mail order course at home. And I was interested in being a radio man. So they sent me up there. It was, I guess, maybe June up to about October. That year. And then I returned back to the squadron at Georgia.

J **JEREMY** 03:12

What did you... What did you like about radio? Why did you choose radio? What was your main reason?

A **ALLEN** 03:18

You thought, well, radio sounds like something I do.

J **JEREMY** 03:20

What...

A **ALLEN** 03:21

Yeah, well, yeah. I was thinking about maybe being a radio repairman or in civilian life once I got out. And I did, of course, in the service center, we were doing radio, some radio repair. We were doing the equipment. Of course, at that time, radio was the main... Oh, yeah. There was nothing like television in those days. No, no. So if anything was for your future, radio would be it. Right. That's right.

J ***JEREMY*** 03:51

Where were you and when did you first hear about Pearl Harbor? Actually, before you say that, did you know anything was coming? Did you think that you were going to be deployed somewhere?

A **ALLEN** 04:09

Well, even in the National Guard, before we were mobilized, we went to... summer maneuvers up in New York State, and not the customary two weeks time, but this time it was three weeks, and we sort of sensed a feeling that something was brewing somewhere. And we know the relationships with the Japanese was not the greatest, so we figured something was going to happen down the pike.

J ***JEREMY*** 04:39

What were your personal feelings on that? Were you dreading that or...

A **ALLEN** 04:43

We didn't think too much about it, really.

A **ALLEN** 04:49

I don't know, we just, if it happens, it happens. I mean, and now when I got out of the radio school, back to the squadron, I was only back a short while, and we went on maneuvers. with the regular army at Fort Bragg, North Carolina. So after that was over, that was it. I think it was in November of that year, and then on December the 7th, I had the weekend off at Savannah, and I decided to go over to Camp Stewart, Georgia, see my old buddies in the old outfit. And while I was there chatting with the lads in the tent, a guy come in and says, the Jets just bombed Pearl Harbor. Well, okay. And then very shortly after that, another one of my buddies come back in, he says, do you belong to a third bomb group over at the air base? I says, yes. And he says, well, you're supposed to come back to the base immediately, all members. So that wound up the visit and back to the base I go. Just like that.

J ***JEREMY*** 06:20

So how long was it until you were deployed overseas?

A **ALLEN** 06:25

Okay, now, from then, then things were, it was real hectic, and it was a lot of indecision, it seemed,. from the higher-ups, because you didn't know what was going on. They got back to the base that day, and already they had some of the lads digging foxholes for fear of some kind of an air raid. And then they moved us from Savannah up to Augusta, Georgia, further inland,. and they weren't there too long until,. I believe they were,. they separated us, and I was one of what they called a cadre to go to Palm Beach, Florida, and form an anti-submarine group to show you how the indecision was. We got down there one day, and the next day they sent us back, back to Georgia. And they get back there, the orders were we're packing up to go to San Francisco, we're going overseas. So we packed up. Got on a train, took a ride back over to San Francisco, and we were there, yeah, maybe, maybe three, four days, and then we boarded ship, and started out not knowing where we were going to go.

J ***JEREMY*** 07:47

You had no idea where you were going to go?

A **ALLEN** 07:49

No idea.

J ***JEREMY*** 07:49

We, there was a lot of speculation, are we going to the Philippines, are we going to Hawaii?

A **ALLEN** 07:55

We had no idea where we were going.

J ***JEREMY*** 07:59

Let's backtrack a little bit.

A **ALLEN** 08:01

Family. Family. One day they, I mean, obviously they knew you were going over there, and obviously,. Gram and Katherine, how did that all come about, like breaking the news, and how did

J ***JEREMY*** 08:15

they feel about it?

A **ALLEN** 08:17

Well, they were, they were quite worried. I got told, I don't remember if I called a telephone, or did I just write a letter, I guess I called on the telephone and told them that we were going, going to, we were going, West Coast to get on, to be shipped up, and I says, I don't know where, I says, somehow I'll try to let you know where we are, but I, of course, I figured everything would be censored from there on, so I wouldn't be able to tell them exactly where we were going. They had, what I did, I had some kind of a little code, that I could say, like, dear mom and dad, or dear mother and dad. I wrote it out. Dear mom and dad, we're going to, that means we're going to Hawaii. Dear mom and pa, we're going to, this, different, different, same way with, with my wife, girlfriend at that time. It depends how I address it, you know where we're going to go.

J ***JEREMY*** 09:27

How long, how long were you dating Gram at the time, before you were a?

A **ALLEN** 09:32

Well, we started back in, maybe, 38, 39. Maybe about two years, a year and a half. Boy, that must be something to get up and out of your home and just, yeah. All right. Well, what, now, you weren't, going, going overseas, of course, we were over in a big convoy out of San Francisco. I don't know how many, up in the teens, I don't know how many ships there were, and,. you know, one morning, one morning, we, we woke up. We looked out. There was only half of them there. Some of them had broken off, and where they went, I don't know. They went to some other place, and, and then, maybe the next day or so, we look out in the horizon. Well, the destroyers were quite busy going around, and looking out in the horizon, here comes a, another group, and joined us. Then we had a big convoy. There, there were instances where there was alerts on submarine, uh, attacks and all that. Eh, eh, it didn't take much of it. Uh, and then...

J ***JEREMY*** 10:47

What else can you tell me about, uh, the trip overseas, not knowing where you were going, and just being on this ship?

ALLEN 10:53

Well, it just, just... Because that must have been at least, you know, a few days. Yeah, we left, uh, we left, uh, San Francisco on January the 30th of 42, then got to Brisbane,. Australia, February the 25th. So, it was quite a lengthy trip. The day before we got to Australia was the first time we knew where we were going. Uh, we were up, we were up, up topside on the deck. Most everybody up, was upside, up there. And, uh, announcement came over, this is your captain, uh, he's going to inform you that barring any, uh, uh, unforeseen circumstances or trouble, tomorrow morning you'll be looking at the friendly shores of Australia. And that's the first we knew. We knew where we were going. Hmm.

A postcard Allen kept of the rotunda in Lissner Park, Charters Towers, Queensland — an early 3rd Bomb Group base before the move to New Guinea.

JEREMY 11:50

What'd you think about that?

ALLEN 11:51

Well, that, that sounded all right.

J **JEREMY** 11:53

Let's get off this, get off the water.

A **ALLEN** 11:55

Yeah, let's get on, put your feet in the ground. We're quite happy about, about that. All right.

J **JEREMY** 12:05

So, you land, uh, you land on Australia, and what's the first thing you do there?

A **ALLEN** 12:13

First thing we do, they, they, they put us in a, in tents on a, at some racetrack. And, uh, there again, then it was, then it was quite a time getting used to the, uh, the Aussie money. And, uh, then, of course, there was some Australian troops there, too, we mingled with. And it was quite interesting listening to their lingo. And, and they're trying to understand us. And because we come from all, every state in the Union, I guess, everybody seemed to have a different dialect or whatever you want to call it. Uh, so you, you go to the PX and you give, you give them a dollar or a five dollar bill and they'd come back with a, a bunch of things. Uh, and, and, *and all that stuff, if they had, you know, had a lot of, uh, uh, nets, uh, uh, uh, pond notes and adds shillings and florins and all that kind of stuff and you didn't know what you had. Now I got used to it and, and then, uh, after they had the, the, the, uh, ship unloaded, I might add there, too, when they're unloading the ship when it comes tea time, eeh, everything seizes. And we're gonna have tea. But once the ship was unloaded and everything was, then we, they put it on a train, everything was put on a train. Uhah.* and at that time you went so far because we understood each state or province in Australia had a different gauge track. In other words, the trains could run so far then you had to take stuff off and put it on a train to run on those tracks. So we went from Brisbane up to Tonsville and then again we switched things up and went west to Charters Towers, a small town about 90 mile inland. We got there, looked around, put us out in some kind of a field or some scrubbed trees grew there, very dry, dry season and the ground was baked real hard and there we were, well,. where's the airfield? There isn't any yet, we're working on it. There was no airfield but here's an Air Force outfit with no airfield and besides that we didn't have any planes. Our planes from Savannah, where they went I don't know but they didn't go with us. So we're over there and I might add too that it's only about one-third of the original squadron. That arrived in Australia. The others were broken up and some went somewhere else to form new outfits or whatever because they had to train people in a hurry.

The tea that stopped the ship LIKELY

What Allen watched on the Brisbane wharf was the smoko, and it was not idleness. The smoko is a sanctioned pause in Australian working life, taken mid-morning and again in the afternoon, named from the call to down tools for a smoke — the earliest spellings end in an H, "smoke-oh" — traceable to the Victorian goldfields of the 1850s and first recorded in print in a Queensland paper, the Moreton Bay Courier. It began as a tobacco break, but by 1942 it was as fixed a part of the working day as the day itself and the billy had long since joined the pipe.

To newly landed Americans, who had just spent twenty-five days at sea and wanted their kit off the ship, a wharf that simply stopped was incomprehensible. Friction over Australian waterfront practice was real and there were ugly incidents in Queensland ports that year, but how far it amounted to obstruction of the war effort is still argued over by historians and should not be settled in a caption. Allen's own telling carries no bitterness in it at all, only astonishment, and that is probably the truest note to keep.

Sources: The history of the Australian slang term 'smoko' — ABC News; Smoko; United States forces in Australia — Australian War Memorial (friction between US and Australian personnel).

Pounds, shillings and florins

Australia in 1942 still ran on British money, and nothing about it mapped onto a dollar. A pound was twenty shillings and a shilling was twelve pence, which made two hundred and forty pence to the pound, and the coins in Allen's hand would have run from the halfpenny and penny up through threepence, sixpence and the shilling to the florin, which was two shillings. There was no Australian half-crown at all — almost alone among the sterling countries, Australia never issued one — and the five-shilling crown had been struck only in 1937 and 1938 and was already unpopular.

Notes came in ten shillings, one pound, five pounds and ten. On top of the arithmetic there was an exchange problem: from the devaluation of December 1931 until decimal currency arrived in 1966 the Australian pound was held at sixteen shillings sterling, so it was not even worth the same as the British pound whose names it borrowed. A young man from Schuylkill County handing a five-dollar bill across a PX counter and getting back a fistful of unfamiliar silver had every reason not to know what he had.

Sources: Australian pound — denominations and the sterling peg; Before decimal currency — what did Australia use? (Royal Australian Mint factsheet); United States forces in Australia — Australian War Memorial.

A different gauge in every state

Allen had this right as a fact about Australia and slightly wrong about his own journey, and the difference is worth keeping. The Australian colonies had built their railways to different gauges before federation, and on the east coast the break bit hardest at Wallangarra on the Queensland-New South Wales border, where Queensland's 3 ft 6 in narrow gauge met New South Wales's 4 ft 8 1/2 in standard gauge across a single island platform, each side under its own railway's signage, and every man and every crate had to change trains.

The war made the problem notorious: fourteen breaks of gauge were still in use in 1939, upwards of 1,600 service personnel and many more civilians were employed shifting 1.8 million tons of freight across them, and rail movement in Australia was not brought under central direction until early 1943. Allen's own run, however, was entirely inside Queensland, Brisbane to Townsville on the North Coast line and then west on the Great Northern to Charters Towers, both of them 3 ft 6 in. The change he remembers at Townsville was a change of line and of train, not of gauge, though the story he was told aboard, that every state used a different track, was perfectly true.

Sources: Wallangarra railway station — break of gauge, Queensland/NSW; Rail gauge in Australia; Australia under attack: Rail transport and Australia's war effort — Australian War Memorial; Great Northern Railway (Mt Isa line) — Townsville to Charters Towers.

> *"There was no airfield, but here's an Air Force outfit with no airfield, and besides that, we didn't have any planes."*
>
> ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

J **JEREMY** 15:13

How many people do you have estimated in your troop? Estimated?

A

ALLEN 15:21

I had 130, 150 when we got there. I know that our radio crew we had, there were six of us, normally we had about 20 and. in Savannah and no planes. But then we finally, they finally gave each squadron, I think it was, we each got one. And what made it interesting, these planes that we got and later on we each got three I think it was, these planes had the Dutch Air Force markings on. They were originally consigned to the Dutch Air Force in the East Indies. The instruction pamphlets that came with it was written in Dutch. My Pennsylvania Dutch didn't help too much, I'll tell you. So it was just, you know, the stuff looked the same so you just come up with your own ideas of what it was. Oh, wow. A little bit of dangerous flying there. All right, Battle of the Coral Sea. So there then we gradually then we got more planes and. *two of our two of my buddies in the tent radio people they they lost one of them in a crash and then they lost the next one. So there was only*

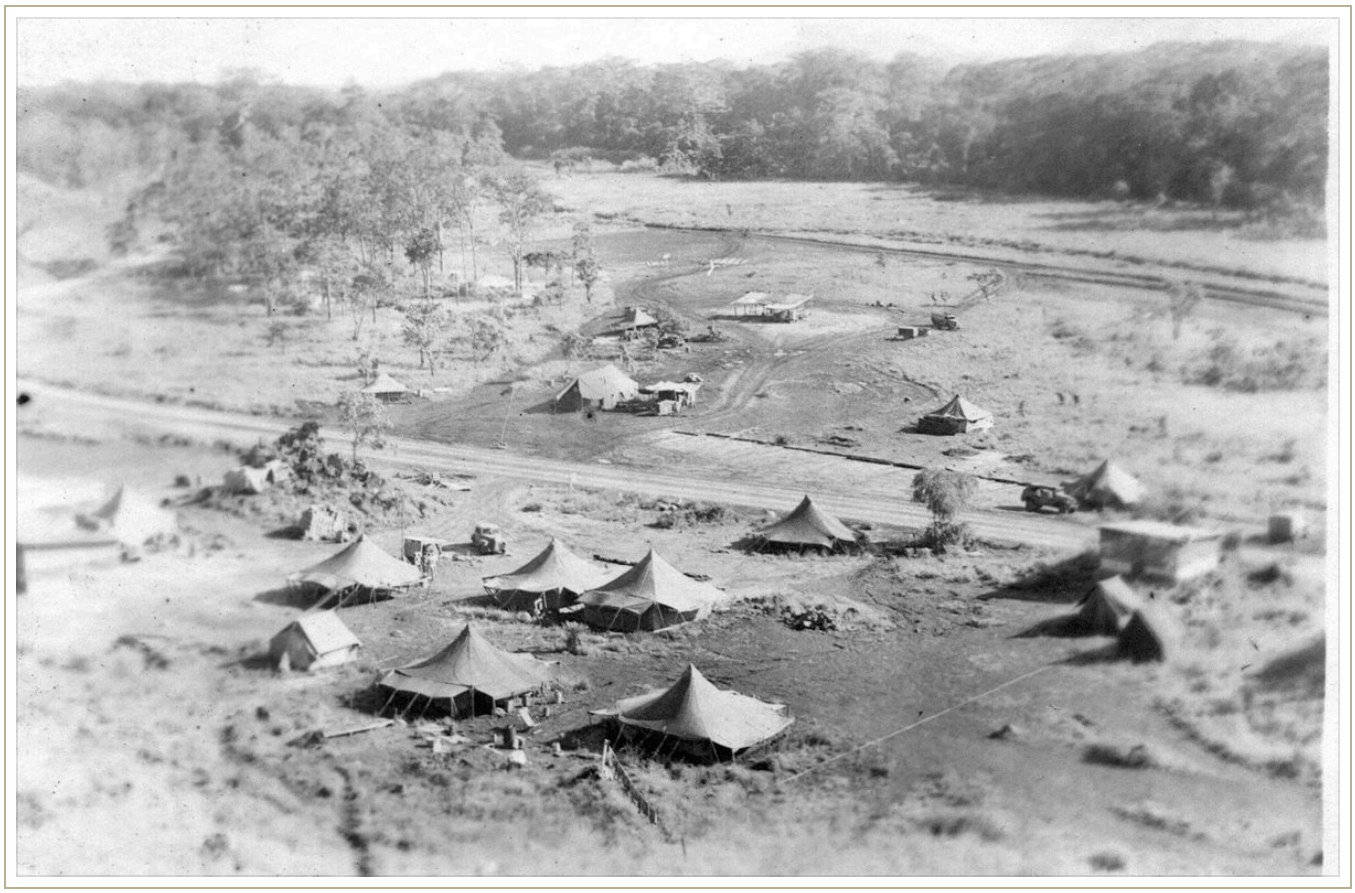
"The instruction pamphlets that came with it was written in Dutch. My Pennsylvania Dutch didn't help too much, I'll tell you."

ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

J

JEREMY 17:10

How did that happen?



A 3rd Attack Group tent camp, New Guinea, 1943.

A **ALLEN** 17:12

Well New Guinea is a funny place when you try to come over the mountains over the old Stanley mountains, you've got to be real careful. And at the time we didn't have real good maps and everything. You could come through what you thought was a perfect map, but then you took a really heavy landing. You just got a hot air balloon, a Pass, and actually it was just a deep valley, and you come up here, and up here it's solid, and you're in there, and before you know it, you're up against that, and they crashed into the mountains there. So there was three radio guys left. You ask about the Carl C. Battle, well, of course the Japanese were real busy coming down through the Pacific at that time. They'd come down, and then they had the battles at Henderson Field in the islands right below Australia, and then we got word that the Japanese were going to attempt to land at Port Moresby in New Guinea, which would be on the west coast of New Guinea facing Australia, and they expected that when they came around there, they would possibly try to land there. They had a bomb like Townsville in Australia, which was just east of us then. So somebody got the, to us, a brilliant idea, a dumb idea, I guess you could say, to send,. well, they woke me up early one morning, it was dark, and they says, you're going on a mission. Okay. We get dressed, go out. They took us to... To the airfield, and there we stood. We didn't know, nobody seemed to know what was going to happen. Finally, a guy come out and said, what's going to happen? They expect the Japs to bomb, and if they come in there, once they leave, we'll take off from here and follow them out to sea, and you will send radio signals so the rest of the squadron can home on it and come out. Yeah, we're going to circle the Jap fleet. And I'm going to send radio signals. Well, all right, I know how to do that. But then, later in the day, another visitor to the airplane, and he says, do you know how to fire the guns? I said, I don't know anything about them. He said, well, we're going to give you a course on the lower turret, because you might have to be a gunner. So I got a real fast 10-minute instruction. Period on how to work the twin .50 caliber machine guns in the lower turret.

J ***JEREMY*** 20:18

What were your thoughts when they were telling you all this?

A **ALLEN** 20:25

Well, like all of us in the crew figured, well, this is it. This is a suicide mission. There's no way anybody's going to come back after this.

> *"This is a suicide mission. There's no way anybody's going to come back after this."*
>
> ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

J **JEREMY** 20:43

So then what happened?

A **ALLEN** 20:44

Well, they, we were there. We sent out that airplane for. I guess, I don't know, it was two or three days like that, just waiting for things to happen. And it was kind of a long day with nothing to do except just sit there and waiting. And every time you heard a truck or a car coming, you figured, oh, here it comes. And it was nothing. But then the one day they come out, and they said, which one of you guys is flying? I said, right here. He says, how do you feel? I feel all right. Why? He says, are you still sick? I says, I'm not sick. And then I, the two of them said, let's get out of here. And away they go. Later on, I found out that my communication officer had tried to get me off because of the shortage of radio men and have one of the guys from headquarters go out and do the radio work. Because they were well stuck. We weren't. So, but that didn't work out because they didn't notify me that I was sick. No, it stayed the same. Well, the Jap fleet was intercepted in the Carl Sea by our Navy, and the battle ensued there, and they never did get to their destination. So, basically, that guy that was supposed to relieve you pretty much was hoping that you were not sick, and then pretty much took off.

Allen (left) on the back of a truck.

J **JEREMY** 22:12

Is that basically what that was about?

A **ALLEN** 22:14

That's what it seemed like, yeah. Like, to hell with that. I'm not staying. Yeah. He says, let's get out of here. I said, okay. Well, in the meantime, I'm staying there not knowing what's what. All right.

J **JEREMY** 22:33

How'd you end up in New Guinea?

A **ALLEN** 22:34

Well, we operated out of Charter's Towers. They did some, a lot of reconnaissance flights to find out what the Japs were doing up along the coast. They even went to Darwin in the northern part of Australia, and they flew up into the Philippines at the Japs' landing. They flew up into there at some remote airfield, and they conducted some raids, and then they brought back as many experienced flyers or air crews that they could possibly haul in the ships and came back. And then we'd operate out of Charter's Towers, fly up across the Carle Sea into Port Moresby, and you would stay there for a while until... The Japanese, their reconnaissance found out you were up in there, and then they'd start raiding, and you'd be on the safe side. You had to pull your planes back, because there wasn't too much defense there. When they walked, they would ask for volunteers to go along with the crew to service them and everything. And I did, there was three of us that were pretty friendly there, and we volunteered to go. And it was interesting, to say the least. And then we'd fly back, and, boy, we weren't back too long, and if they were going up again, off we go, we'd go back up again. Well, the one return trip was rather hectic. Going along, and it was a beautiful day, and flying over... And looking over, and you're over the Carle Sea, and you look down at those Carle beds, and it was really beautiful. It was the first time I'd flown over the Carle Sea and it was the first time I'd flown over one of those Carle Beds, and it was just a beautiful moment. I mean, I remember, the first time I'd flown, I was in the Carle Sea, I was in the Carle *We're going back, and you can see a big cloud formation looming up way up ahead of you. And the fact that it was interesting because the pilot, the two of us, the crew chief and myself,. sit in the chair and handle the controls of the plane. And I was the second one to sit there, and it was, you know, just have your hands on the control of the plane.* But then it started to get too close to the storm, and he says, better let me in there, Al. So we're not equipped to fly over. It was pretty high. We didn't have oxygen for everybody, so you couldn't fly over the storm. And certainly we didn't want to fly through it because they're wicked. So they dip down. You're only flying, skimming up over the waves in the sea. You could see them lashing around. And we ran around the storm and got off course doing it, overland, and the co-pilot went 12th in there and he says, Boy, I don't know where we're at. And he says, Al, what do you know about this radio compass? Oh, I said, that's simple. I said, I know the frequency of the radio station at Townsville. I think at the time, I think it was something like 610. I think it was something like 610 KC's, and I said, we'll turn it on, and the needle on your indicator. towards the broadcast station, which it did, it was off to our right. So he said, well, if we go that way, we'll go back over to the sea again, Al. That's right, but let's try it. You go back over to the sea, and then this needle had come the other way. We approached Townsville,

and sure enough, we come in right over the... Right over the dock in Townsville and landed there because we, at that time, we didn't have enough gas, so we had to stop the refuel, and they said, where have you guys been here? We figured you guys were missing, but then we took off from there and came back to Townsville. Now, these trips to New Guinea, yes, I feel awful lucky about that. There was a case where it was really wicked. Coming back, and then we weren't back maybe a week or two, and they asked for planes up in New Guinea again. We said, yeah, we'll go, and then the communication officer says, no, no, not this time. You guys made three trips now. Let somebody else go. It's not right, but you go all the time. So a whole new crew went up, and I'm working the radio that day in contact with the flights going up,. and I heard them say that number so-and-so just went in, which meant they went into the sea,. and there was one of the radio guys. If we had, if we'd have went down there, what plane would it be?

A beacon the enemy could use too LIKELY

The property that brought Allen's aircraft home was the same one that worried the Navy. A broadcast station is a free beacon for anyone with a loop aerial, and Australian authorities acted on it: 4KA at Ayr, on the coast some fifty miles south-east of Townsville, was banned by the Navy from broadcasting at night from 3 March 1942 to 12 April 1943, on the grounds that its signal could be used as a homing device by enemy bombers. Allen's flight was a daylight one — he describes a clear run over the Coral Sea before the storm forced them down to the waves — so a north Queensland station would have been on the air for him. Whether 4TO itself came under the same night restriction is not recorded in the sources consulted here. The detail is worth keeping anyway, because it shows how thin the line was between navigation aid and liability in 1942.

Sources: Australian Radio History: Qld AM Stations — Wikibooks (4KA Ayr banned by the Navy from night broadcasts 3 Mar 1942 – 12 Apr 1943 as a possible homing device); Queensland A.M. Radio Stations (Australian AM Radio History).

Homing on Townsville LIKELY

The radio compass on that flight deck was almost certainly the SCR-269, standardised in January 1940: a BC-433 receiver, a rotatable loop aerial, a BC-434 control box and an I-81 or I-82 needle indicator, tuning 200 to 1,750 kilocycles, a range that swallows the whole commercial broadcast band. Tune it to a strong station and the needle points at the transmitter, which is precisely the procedure Allen describes to the co-pilot. The station is harder to pin down than the method.

Townsville's commercial station was 4TO, opened by AWA on 5 October 1931 — the mayor at the microphone, two hundred local artists in the Theatre Royal — running only about 200 watts through the war years and not raised to 500 until 1948; a Townsville broadcast year book for 1946-47 records it at 384 metres, 780 kilocycles. The ABC's 4QN, opened 26 November 1936, also served the town. No Townsville broadcaster has been found on 610 kilocycles, and Allen himself hedged the figure sixty-odd years after the fact; the number is uncertain, the technique is not.

Sources: Radio Compass SCR-269 (BC-433 receiver, LP-21 loop, I-81/I-82 indicators, 200–1750 kc) — Radiomuseum; SCR-269 — RadioNerds; 4TO Townsville, North Queensland — Radio Heritage Foundation ("384 Metres 780 K/C's"); Australian Radio History: Qld AM Stations — Wikibooks (4TO opened 5 Oct 1931 on 200 watts, 500 watts in 1948; 4QN opened 26 Nov 1936).

> *"Now, these trips to New Guinea, yes, I feel awful lucky about that."*
>
> ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

A **ALLEN** 28:18

You'd end up, well, eventually you ended up in New Guinea. Yeah, then we drove all the way over to Townsville, loaded on a boat, and went up to Port Moresby and unloaded there. And then we set up, there was, I think, four airfields in New Guinea at that time. It was assigned to, they were named 3, 3-7, 14, and 17, I think, which was how many miles inland you were from the coast. We were going to 17, furthest inland, and it was a little strip, and a defense around it. It was difficult. It was a different place, cut out, called Revent, where you parked the planes. And then what you had to do, we were lucky, we had to set up the radio right away because you had to check out your equipment and try to work your, and those guys, it was two trees there. I remember you had regulations, how you had to put up an antenna. Yeah. It had to be so many feet long, and then where you tapped in, it had to be so, so. So I said, go up there and just make a tap, and we'll see what, just enough that we can have radio signals here between the base and planes on the field. Just to check out the radios. Well, would you know that, that worked like under the tree, because it worked good, and I could work the planes on the other side of New Guinea or across the mountain. And we were the only squadron that could. And we were the only squadron that could do it. And then the one day, they'd come around, they'd inspect your, and he says, oh, it's no good. He said, you have to tear that down, he said, and put it up according to the book. And our officer says, you don't get anywhere near that. We're the only squadron in the group that can work the planes on the other side of the mountain. Hands off. So why it worked as well as it did, I don't know. Because it was against all the rules. It was against all the rules of whatever. Yeah, too bad. Yeah. Living conditions. Natives.

“Revent” Was a Revetment

One word in the transcript looks like machine-transcription noise and is in fact a precise piece of airfield vocabulary. Allen describes “a different place, cut out, called Revent, where you parked the planes.” He is saying revetment — an earth-walled bay, bulldozed or dug out well away from the runway, into which a single aircraft was taxied so that a bomb falling on one machine would not take the whole squadron with it.

The record for 17-Mile describes exactly this: dispersal and camp areas southeast of the runway, with revetments carved into the hillsides and the taxiways raised so they would drain. At 7-Mile the Americans began building them in earnest right after the heavy Japanese raid of 17 August 1942, and a few of those bomber revetments survived at Jacksons airport into this century. Sixty-odd years on, Allen was still reaching for the right technical term for a hole in a Papuan hillside.

Sources: Pacific Wrecks — 17 Mile Drome (Durand, Waigani); Pacific Wrecks — 7 Mile Drome (Jackson Airport).

> *“Our officer says, ‘You don't get anywhere near that. We're the only squadron in the group that can work the planes on the other side of the mountain. Hands off.’”*
>
> ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

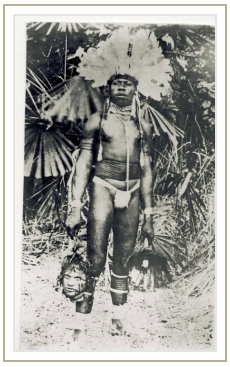
The People of New Guinea

Allen's own photos of the New Guinea villagers his unit encountered.

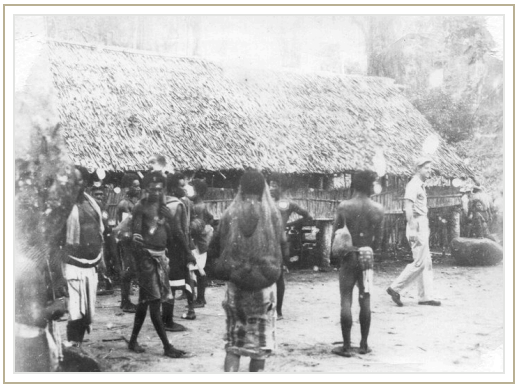
New Guinea villagers gathered in traditional dress at a ceremonial event.

New Guinea villagers gathered, traditional dress and ornamentation.

A local New Guinean man stands beside a serviceman in a pith helmet.



A New Guinea highlander in ceremonial headdress — one of the photographs Allen brought home documenting local custom.



A gathering outside a thatched longhouse; a serviceman walks through, one villager carrying a woven net bag.

New Guinea highlanders in elaborate feathered headdresses and shell nose ornaments, spears in hand.

Three servicemen sit on a fence rail in front of a thatched hut, local children visible behind them.

J **JEREMY** 31:11

How you got up there? How you ate?

A **ALLEN** 31:14

We elected not to stay in the camp area. The guys in this one, I guess there were four, six of us. We said, no, we don't want to stay in the camp area. We'll stay at the tent where the radio equipment. It is right along the strip with the air crews and the mechanics. Most of those guys, at least the crew chief and a couple others, they had their tents out there. You were close to that. So what we did, you can't put your tent up here, they said. What we did, we built a, there was a big irrigation ditch we had dug there. We got a tree, felled a tree. We didn't put it over there. We made a little bridge and put our tent over right in the jungle. You put your cots in our little platform. It was a little bucket of oil because if you didn't, the ants would crawl up and join you in bed.

J **JEREMY** 32:29

These aren't regular ants either, are they?

A **ALLEN** 32:33

They're regular big ones, yeah. So. And everything, and it rained. Well, of course, it rained all the time, it seemed. And you're always slogging around in mud. Mosquitoes were in droves, you couldn't believe.

J **JEREMY** 32:56

Did you want a break for lunch?

A **ALLEN** 32:58

Yeah. Yeah. All right. That took me cold. All right.

J **JEREMY** 33:03

What do you mean the mosquitoes?

A **ALLEN** 33:05

Like you wouldn't believe.

J **JEREMY** 33:07

You got bit pretty much regularly?

A **ALLEN** 33:09

Yes, yes. Going to bed at night was an ordeal. But I didn't undress. Outside your bunk, you had a mosquito netting that you fit over the bunk and what you would do is get something and swoosh around there and get them away from there and then you'd quick dive in under the netting and you'd undress and then pile your clothes along the side, hold your light up at the mosquito bar, you could see there they were, all lined up waiting for you to roll over against the netting. It's crazy. Yeah. Even in the daytime, in the radio tent, you're sitting there under the table and you're always swatting that at your legs because you're lucky enough to have a movie some nights up in the hill.

"Hold your light up at the mosquito bar, you could see there they were, all lined up waiting for you to roll over against the netting."

ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

Off Duty

Allen's own snapshots of the lighter moments — hunting, a pipe, feeding pigeons on leave.

Allen sitting in the jungle in fatigues and cap.

Allen smoking a pipe, looking up — a candid, lighter moment.

Allen, grinning, leans against a fence post.

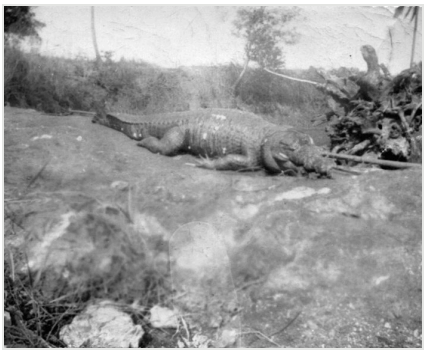
Allen, hands on hips, in front of the jungle tree line.

A shirtless serviceman relaxes in camp, tents visible behind him.

Allen crouched, aiming a pistol in the Australian bush.

Allen with a belt of machine-gun ammunition draped over his shoulder, cattle grazing behind him.

Three servicemen hold up a large snake they caught.



A crocodile the men caught — by the family's own label, 350 pounds and eight feet long.

Allen feeds pigeons on a park bench while on leave.

J **JEREMY** 34:17

What kind of pictures did you see? Well, what did the movie tent look like? How was it?

A **ALLEN** 34:23

The screen out there was no tent. There was a screen out there on the hill. You were sitting on the side of the hill looking at it. You might have watched it. You might wear your raincoat if it was raining or not just to keep mosquitoes off you.

J **JEREMY** 34:39

What kind of pictures did you get to see?

A **ALLEN** 34:41

Oh, they were, they were just the first line at the time. I don't know the names of it anymore. Yeah, you had to see good things. It's something to see when you're halfway around the world in the middle of nowhere, I imagine. Oh, yeah. You get to appreciate things. You betcha. The one, the one place we had our tents, it was platforms. They did that at Quartermaster or somebody. Whoever went ahead of us, I don't know, made platforms and then you put your tent up in the platform. You were up about maybe three feet off the ground, maybe four. People were waiting in the crimbers. We would notch into the jungle to get bamboo. And you learned the technique. Cutting these bamboo shoots and stripping them and then you'd wind up with a bamboo floor in the tent. The tents didn't last too long because of the rain and the humidity and everything. It sort of rotted away and shorted. What you'd have is the tent above you and then you had a frame over your bunk. And then maybe you'd have another piece of old canvas or something. Something over the top of that because no matter how rainy it would drip, drip, drip, and you just kept additional coverage over you like that.

J *JEREMY* 36:32

What about the natives?

A **ALLEN** 36:33

They were friendly. They were quiet. They didn't mingle. You didn't see too much of them, really, except certain times maybe a couple of them would be walking around looking for something. I don't know what. But it was interesting. The male of the family or whatever they were, he walks along with just a stick, like a cane. And the woman, she has to have a baby in like an orange knitting hanging around tied to her head somehow or other and down the back. And maybe some kind of a packet, kind of all this stuff they picked up. He's going along doing nothing.

A **ALLEN** 37:33

That's interesting. We made several trips up to the native village to see how it was. The first time, this is something that you might have seen back in school in the National Geographic magazine or something, you know. And you couldn't imagine that humans were living like that. Probably still live like that. I don't. And we often wondered what they ate because you go up in the village and you didn't see anything. There's no signs. There's no signs of any garden or anything. They said, well, they ate the wallopies, which is a small version of the kangaroo, and wild boars, which we never saw. We never saw any. They did kill a crocodile up behind our camp one time. And we went up to see that. It was laying on the ground above the pool that was there. And the Australian that was with us said, what they do, they haul that out of there and they'll let it lay there until the evil spirits are out of it. And then they'll haul it up to their putts and then cut it up.

The crocodile above the pool

Three crocodiles are now recognised on New Guinea. The saltwater or estuarine crocodile, Crocodylus porosus, is the largest living reptile, with the largest reliably measured animal at a total length of at least 615 centimetres, and it ranges from southwestern India and Sri Lanka through southeast Asia and the Indonesian archipelago to the Solomons; it tolerates everything from fresh water to full-strength sea water and moves well up rivers and into swamps and lagoons.

The New Guinea crocodile, Crocodylus novaeguineae, is a smaller freshwater animal, the males reaching about three and a half metres, living in the swamps, marshes and lakes of the northern half of the island; a third, Hall’s New Guinea crocodile, was separated from it in 2019 and belongs to the country south of the central ranges. Allen’s squadron was on the northern side, which leaves the saltwater crocodile and the New Guinea crocodile as the candidates, and the record does not settle which one it was. The explanation he was given, that the carcass would be left to lie until the evil spirits were out of it before it was butchered, came from an Australian standing beside him rather than from the men who had killed it, and it is best read as one European’s gloss on a practice he had watched, not as any Papuan’s account of his own belief.

Sources: Estuarine Crocodile, The Australian Museum; New Guinea crocodile (Crocodylus novaeguineae); Saltwater Crocodile, Queensland Museum Collections; Hall’s New Guinea crocodile (Crocodylus halli), described 2019.

Why the villages were so quiet

Allen noticed that the people kept their distance and that he saw few of them, and there is a documented reason beyond shyness. From 21 March 1942 the Australian New Guinea Administrative Unit, ANGAU, governed civil affairs in both Papua and the Mandated Territory, and its largest single task was raising and directing indigenous labour for the Australian and American forces. At its September 1944 peak more than thirty-five thousand men were involved in the organisation, directed by some two thousand Australian officers, first carrying and portering, later building; the airstrips, roads and supply dumps the Americans used were in substantial part their work.

Recruitment was not voluntary: an order of June 1942 let ANGAU contract Papuans for up to three years and forbade them to desert or refuse work, and the carrier rolls went from about two thousand that month to over sixteen thousand by December. The cost is on the record: at least 2,024 ANGAU carriers and labourers died during the war, mainly of infectious disease such as malaria and dysentery, with 46 killed by enemy action and 91 wounded. A village whose fit men were away under indenture would look to a passing airman much as Allen describes it. This is a group-level fact about the Territory rather than a finding about the particular hamlets he walked into, which the record does not identify.

Sources: Casualties in Australian Military and Indigenous Para-Military Units in Papua New Guinea during the Second World War, Journal of Military and Veterans' Health; Australian New Guinea Administrative Unit; The Fuzzy Wuzzy Angels: looking beyond the myth, Australian War Memorial.

The bag, and the man with the stick LIKELY

What Allen saw tied over the woman's forehead was a bilum, the looped string bag of New Guinea, made by hand from spun plant fibre in a technique passed down between generations. Its band goes across the forehead so that the bag rides on the back and the carrier's hands stay free, and the bag stretches to hold whatever is put into it; the Museum of New Zealand's catalogue note on one collected example says bilums are used by men and women to carry yams, taro and other foodstuffs, and sometimes even babies. That also answers the thing which puzzled him, that he could see no gardens near the hamlets, because the garden produce he did not see was moving past him inside the bag he did see.

The division of carrying he read as a man doing nothing had been read the same way by outsiders before him, among them Matthew Stirling, on the 1926 Dutch and American expedition to Dutch New Guinea, who wrote on 7 May that year, at Soeroei on Japen, that the women invariably carried all the load while the men walked alongside quite unburdened — though that was an island a thousand miles west of Allen's coast and other people entirely. What the arrangement meant to the families walking that track is not something a young American passing on a road could establish, and the record does not settle it. What can be said is that the bilum itself was a valued made thing, and not merely a load.

Sources: Bilum (string bag), Museum of New Zealand Te Papa Tongarewa collections; Matthew Stirling journal, 7 May 1926, Smithsonian-Dutch New Guinea Expedition, Smithsonian Libraries; All about the bilum, QAGOMA Stories.

From Allen's collection at the Lone Pine Koala Sanctuary, Queensland — a popular stop for servicemen on leave.

"The Australian that was with us said, what they do, they haul that out of there and they'll let it lay there until the evil spirits are out of it."

ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

J **JEREMY** 39:01

Eat it?

A **ALLEN** 39:02

Yeah. That's got to be dangerous. I mean, letting something out there rot before eating. Yeah. We had different reports that came up. You move into another territory. You've got... I'm not sure what to expect, what language they used. Most of it was Pidgin English. Along the coast there, these natives had got in contact with the missionaries before that. They were partially civilized, I guess you could say. You'd find out what kind of a disease is to expect in there. I don't know. One place we went into where they said the life expectancy of that tribe was about 32, 34 years.

What the briefings told them: 32 to 34 years, and do not go west LIKELY

Two things Allen carried away from his briefings are worth unpicking. A life expectancy of 32 to 34 years is a period life-table figure, an average across everyone born, and in a population with heavy infant and child mortality it is dragged down hard by deaths in the first few years; it never meant that the adults in front of him would be dead at 33, and populations with such figures routinely contain old people. No census had counted most of the interior in 1943, so any number handed to American troops was an estimate rather than a measurement.

The rule against going west rested less on a proven belt of headhunters than on the limits of the colonial administration itself: the country beyond the patrol posts was, in the administration's own language, uncontrolled, and the last of the great exploring patrols into it, led by the patrol officer Jim Taylor with John Black, came out of the country between Mount Hagen and the Sepik in 1939, only a few years before Allen reached New Guinea — a journey the historian Bill Gammage reconstructed in The Sky Travellers. Headhunting is documented for particular peoples in particular places, but the blanket claim he was given was a colonial commonplace rather than a description of the country a day's walk inland from his strip. The order also made plain military sense, because west and north-west was where the Japanese were. His words here come through the transcript garbled, and are given as recorded.

Sources: Life expectancy: how is it calculated and how should it be interpreted? Our World in Data; Papua New Guinea population and demography country profile, Our World in Data; Jim Taylor (explorer), on the 1938-39 Hagen-Sepik Patrol with John Black; The Sky Travellers: Journeys in New Guinea 1938–1939, Bill Gammage (1998).

The missionaries, and what had happened at Dobodura LIKELY

When Allen said the people along that coast had been in contact with the missionaries, he was describing a ruin rather than an institution. The Anglican mission of the Territory of Papua held stations on the north coast at Gona and inland at Sangara and Isivita, in Orokaiva country, and the Japanese came ashore at Gona on 21 July 1942. In the months that followed the Gona party of a priest, a nursing sister and a teacher was broken up, and the two women were killed on Buna beach; the Sangara and Isivita party of two priests, a layman, a nurse and a teacher was taken by villagers and handed over to the Japanese at Dobodura, whence they were taken to Buna and killed.

Dobodura is the plain the Americans then turned into a complex of fifteen landing grounds, and where Allen's squadron moved on 21 May 1943, nine months after that handover. Churches commemorate 333 church workers of all denominations, Papuan and foreign, killed in New Guinea in 1942 and 1943, on 2 September. That villagers did the handing over belongs in the account as well, and it cannot be read simply as treachery, because the Orokaiva were caught between two armies in their own gardens and had reasons of their own which the mission's wartime publications were in no position to weigh.

Sources: South Sea Epic, compiled by Ruth Henrich (1944), Project Canterbury / Anglican History; Martyrs of New Guinea; Among the Ruins: The Story of the New Guinea Martyrs, Arthur Bell (1946), Project Canterbury; Dobodura Airfield Complex (1942).

Which pidgin he was hearing

Allen remembered the contact language on the coast as Pidgin English, and in one sense he was right, in that the Americans were meeting a trade language rather than a village one. But the language that carried across the Territory of Papua, where he spent 1943 at Port Moresby and Dobodura, was not Tok Pisin. It was Police Motu, a simplified form of the Motu language of the Port Moresby coast, which spread with the Papuan constabulary — hence the name — and became the administration's working tongue through Papua, and which was officially renamed Hiri Motu in the early 1970s, on the reasoning that the language's history was older than the name Police Motu implied.

Tok Pisin, the English-vocabulary pidgin that Americans usually meant by the phrase, had grown out of the Pacific labour trade and the plantations of the Bismarck Archipelago, and spread through the former German territory in the north; its expansion south into Papua was, in one survey's words, much more restricted until recent years. Allen would have come within its range only in February 1944, at Nadzab in the Markham valley. The likeliest reading is that Pidgin English was his catch-all for whatever contact speech he heard, which is what the phrase generally meant in an American's mouth in 1943.

Sources: Tok Pisin survey chapter, APiCS Online (Atlas of Pidgin and Creole Language Structures); Hiri Motu (Police Motu); Hiri Motu, Encyclopaedia Britannica; 90th Attack Squadron (formerly 90th Bombardment Squadron) — WWII stations list.

> *"One place we went into where they said the life expectancy of that tribe was about 32, 34 years."*
>
> ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

J **JEREMY** 40:02

You never went too west into the New Guinea jungle, right?

A **ALLEN** 40:06

No.

J ***JEREMY*** 40:06

And why was that?

A **ALLEN** 40:09

Well, it's a known fact that the western part of New Guinea, there's not even headhunters still. I might add, not too far from where we were either. Anything that was going on up until that time, coconut groves and all that kind of stuff. All that stuff was... The coast. And the missionaries had these different stations along with them. This is where these people were. But even today, and I know not too long ago, this one of the people were in Western New Guinea,. that they ran into a place, I don't know what expedition went in there, and they found animals that never knew existed. Sixty-some years later, still uncharted. There was nothing there when we went in there. They weren't doing anything like that. There was no other construction going on. Now I read about three-, four-story motels and all that kind of stuff in there.

"They found animals that never knew existed. Sixty-some years later, still uncharted."

ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

J ***JEREMY*** 41:26

In New Guinea?

A **ALLEN** 41:27

Yeah.

J ***JEREMY*** 41:30

What dangers did you face in the jungle?

A **ALLEN** 41:37

I mean, besides the obvious, you know, don't go west. Well, malaria was our greatest enemy. I mean, when I thought that, I could... I contacted that, spent some time in the hospital over there. It's a wicked disease. I mean, you're really sick when you get that. But the same token, there was another fever, dengue,. which is similar to, well, not as bad, but when you got sick with it, at first you didn't know what you had. You had dengue. You understood it. Malaria, you have to catch that on the onset. It proved that it's malarial.

Allen, at home in 2006, hands folded, mid-story.

> *"It's a wicked disease. I mean, you're really sick when you get that."*

ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

ALLEN 42:33

You had to be careful of your feet, you know, getting wet all the time. And then we, I know I had to get there. You reported back to the medics, and they put some kind of solution in your ears. You didn't get fungus in there.

ALLEN 43:08

We had to have a telephone responsibility.

JEREMY 43:10

You had a telephone responsibility in the town?

ALLEN 43:14

Well, yeah. In the department, they not only had to service the radio equipment in the planes and have a ground radio station,. they also had to lay telephone lines between all the operational buildings and certain tents for some of the crew chiefs or the people in charge. So we had to... And a guy... *I had one antique as you look at it today where little flappers would drop down when a call came in and you'd take the cords and put it in there and then you'd take another cord and plug it into the party where they wanted to take a crack and ramp it with operated telephones*

JEREMY 44:13

You had to keep lines open or something like that?

ALLEN 44:17

We had to string lines. We were quite a chore stringing them in Australia. because the ground was that hard you'd really have to dig or sweat to get across a road, a dirt road. You'd try to get up on the trees and swing them across. Most of the time, like in New Guinea then, you'd get them off the ground a little bit so they weren't laying down and they weren't wet or in the mud. Just get up out of the way. I imagine that was an important responsibility. Well, yeah. The group headquarters in charge of the flights in our squadron. when I talked to them, well, that all had to come through and then he had to call into the different officers' tents to get these guys scrambled to get down to the operations tent so yeah, it was very important

ALLEN 45:39

Radio stories in the jungle

JEREMY 45:43

Anything that sticks out?

A **ALLEN** 45:48

Radio stories I don't have any stories that don't work on the radio in the jungle Yeah, one unfortunate Yeah, we got the call that the guy was coming in and his landing gear wouldn't come down he had to have a belly landing so I'm on the radio, I reported it to 101 flight with our pilots and he come over. and. I said, what should I tell him? He said, tell him to go to, I think it was the 7 mile strip and come in on the dirt, not the metal strip, the dirt strip. And I got ahold of the plane, that pilot and I said, you are to land at 7 miles on the dirt strip, not the metal strip Repeat. He says, right he says, I'm going to land on the dirt strip. Okay. We'll have the emergency equipment. And you're coming in and following him in, he's approaching

J ***JEREMY*** 47:04

What did he do?

A **ALLEN** 47:06

He would come in on the metal strip. Just like hit it and slide it. Right off the runway and one car was killed

The switchboard with the little flappers

The board Allen calls an antique was almost certainly one of the Signal Corps' local-battery field switchboards, the six-line BD-71 or its twelve-line twin, the BD-72. Each line carried a hinged shutter, a "drop", released by the ringing current when a subscriber wound the hand crank on his telephone, so the shutter fell open and showed the operator which line was calling; a night alarm buzzed until it was reset. The operator listened on a chest set, plugged a cord into the called party's jack and turned the board's own magneto crank, about a hundred volts, to ring the bell at the far end.

The instruments on the other ends of those lines were EE-8 field telephones, adopted in 1935, powered by dry cells with a hand-cranked generator for signalling and good for something like seven miles of field wire. Allen was right about the design if not the date: cord-and-drop switchboards were a nineteenth-century idea still standard issue in 1942, because they needed nothing but batteries, wire and a man's arm. The wire was the other half of the job, and the hard half — he remembers baked Australian ground that had to be dug or the line swung up through trees to cross a dirt road, and lines kept off the mud in New Guinea.

Sources: Field Telephones, BD-71 Switchboard and Residential Crank Phones (operation of the drops, magneto ringing, BD-72 as the 12-line version); BD-71 Field Switch Board and EE-8B Field Telephones — USRadioguy; TM 11-330, Switchboards BD-71, BD-72 (War Department Technical Manual, 1 Dec 1944); The EE-8 Field Telephone — The National WWII Museum.

Guinea Gold

New Guinea was the only WW2 theater where U.S. troops relied on a locally produced paper instead of *Stars and Stripes*. *Guinea Gold* began daily publication 19 November 1942 in Port Moresby, ran continuously for 1,320 days, and carried General MacArthur's communiqués 20 hours ahead of the rest of the world's press. At its peak it reached roughly 37,000 U.S. troops daily. The family holds an original February 1944 issue.

Source: Australian War Memorial.

A **ALLEN** 47:24

Crucial moments. Crucial moments Crucial moments

J **JEREMY** 47:32

What do I mean by that?

A **ALLEN** 47:38

I'll tell you one the day we got the red alert, the enemy aircraft approaching within three minutes of the airfield Everybody figured out where they're going to hide, where they're going to jump in the hole or what. And nothing happened, nothing happened in three minutes, the five minutes and by the ten minutes I think. And nothing. And we're all standing up there How come we didn't get an all clear? And all of a sudden, you know what? Somebody looked up and said, that's why we didn't get the all clear and there's a squadron, a flight of Japanese bombers and fighters they estimated about a hundred right above us Went over the airfield and went down and hit the next two airfields Not ours, but a few of them and I understand there was quite a few airbags down near Port Moresby at the time

Where The Warning Came From

The alert that emptied Allen's part of the strip came out of one of the more remarkable improvisations of the Papuan campaign. In January 1942 Major Donald Small, chief signals officer of the 8th Military District, threw a ring of wireless observation posts around Port Moresby at a radius of roughly 150 kilometres; the New Guinea Air Warning Wireless, known to everyone as the Spotters, grew from sixteen stations to sixty-one with 180 men by the end of 1942, and to more than 150 posts by late 1944, absorbing Army, RAAF and civilian coastwatcher stations under one command from October 1942. Two rings did the work.

The outer gave about an hour's notice; the inner ring, at some fifty kilometres, gave ten minutes. Radar helped too, and on 12 April 1943 the incoming formation was tracked by the set atop Paga Hill as it crossed the range. That arithmetic is exactly the experience Allen describes: against high-flying aircraft coming over the mountains the warning arrived measured in minutes, and a formation at 25,000 feet could be directly overhead before anyone on the field had looked up.

Sources: New Guinea Air Warning Wireless (Wikipedia); Pacific Wrecks — Operation I-Go: April 12, 1943 (radar atop Paga Hill); Battle of Port Moresby — Virtual Remembrance Trail (Australian Government).

The Raid That Went Over Their Heads LIKELY

Allen gives no date, and the transcript cannot supply one. But the numbers he remembers narrow the field sharply. The 3rd Bomb Group was based at Port Moresby from 28 January to 20 May 1943, and in that window only one Japanese raid came anywhere near a hundred aircraft: the strike of 12 April 1943, flown as part of Admiral Yamamoto's Operation I-Go. Pacific Wrecks counts roughly 175 machines; the bomber force was some 43 or 44 G4M Bettys and the escort at least 131 Zeros, with the sources differing on the exact split.

It is recorded as the largest force ever sent against Port Moresby; it climbed in tight V formations and bombed from about 25,000 feet between 10.15 and 10.25 in the morning. Five strips were bombed and only four are named in the record: 5-Mile (Wards), 3-Mile (Kila Kila), 12-Mile (Berry) and 14-Mile (Schwimmer). Allen's own 17-Mile Durand is not among those four, though the unnamed fifth leaves real room for doubt, and 12-Mile and 14-Mile are the two strips nearest his. The match is close enough to be worth saying out loud and loose enough that it must be offered as the likeliest candidate rather than a certainty.

Sources: Pacific Wrecks — Operation I-Go: April 12, 1943, last major Japanese air raid over Port Moresby; Pacific Wrecks — Japanese air raids and missions against Port Moresby; 3rd Bombardment Group — base list with dates (historyofwar.org); Operation I-Go (Wikipedia).

> *"Somebody looked up and said, that's why we didn't get the all clear. There's a squadron, a flight of Japanese bombers and fighters. They estimated about a hundred right above us."*
>
> ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

J **JEREMY** 48:42

What were your thoughts at that time?

A **ALLEN** 48:46

Words exchanged between people. Well, I mean, you look up and you see about a hundred planes

J ***JEREMY*** 48:54

What do you say to each other? What do you do, you know?

> *"Into the ditch. No messing around, let's get in. Forget about the water and the mud in the air. The mosquitoes, into the ditch."*
>
> ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

A **ALLEN** 48:57

Into the ditch. No messing around, let's get in Forget about the water and the mud in the air the mosquitoes, into the ditch. Well, I guess that kind of falls under the same category as close calls Yeah, I would say

J ***JEREMY*** 49:13

Do you have a close call?

A **ALLEN** 49:20

No, not really

J ***JEREMY*** 49:23

When you come under a close call

A **ALLEN** 49:26

Well, it would circle the airfield and what was the camp there they never knew when or if it was going to drop any bombs. And they just let them fly up there they didn't put any attack up on them or nothing. They had searchlights, they didn't put them on

J **JEREMY** 49:49

Why give away the position?

A **ALLEN** 49:51

They left the joker circle up there and you never knew how many people they were holding. I don't remember it it never hit them Me neither Well, communication with home, letters back and forth

J **JEREMY** 50:11

Can you remember anything about that? How you received your mail? How you sent it out? How often did you do it? How often did you get stuff?

A **ALLEN** 50:20

You never knew when you were Every letter had to be dropped off at a tent. You had to read it over and then send it out you had to leave your envelope unsealed. And then they'd come up with what they called V-mails it was something that they could send it out in miniature form it wouldn't take up as much room on the ship. And the mail went out and then they'd call me Well, you may not get mail for a while They'd all want you to get a whole bunch of them. Especially like newspapers or magazines and then they'd get a big dump they wouldn't call their name off of that They'd dump it out in a pile someplace and they'd say, papers up there? They'd go out there and read through it and say, what was yours? Wow, nothing was really sorted. No, no, no Your letters were. You'd get picked up there. They weren't delivered to you I don't know Like mail or something I remember that. But you'd go there and pick up your private letters but the other stuff

The Tent With the Unsealed Envelope

The procedure Allen describes was the Army's standard method, and the unsealed envelope was the whole point of it. A soldier overseas was forbidden to use a civilian mailbox; War Department Pamphlet 21-1, issued 29 July 1943, told him under the heading "Enlisted Men" to "Place your letter unsealed in your organization mail box, never in any civil post office box," and reminded him, "You are required to use the Army Postal Service, and the Army Postal Service only." A censor officer of his own organization read it before it travelled on, and the Army required mail to be "completely through censorship within 48 hours." The signature he may have seen belonged to the officers' rule alongside his own: an officer censored his own letter, sealed it, and signed the lower left-hand corner, his mail still "subject to further censorship examination by base censorship detachments." Ten "don'ts" were set before him.

Eight were subjects — the location, strength, materiel and equipment of Army units, military installations, transportation facilities, convoys with their routes, ports and time en route, movements of ships, troops and aircraft, plans and forecasts for future operations, the effects of enemy operations, and casualties before official release — and two were habits: no code or cipher, and no disclosing his location except as authorized. The envelope was policed as tightly as the letter, since "No geographical location of sender may be shown on an envelope or other outside cover" — which is why an APO number, and not a place, was all his family ever saw. The officer who did the reading in the 90th Bomb Squadron has not been identified from the surviving records.

Sources: Secrecy in Wartime: U.S. War Department Pamphlet No. 21-1, "When You Are Overseas These Facts are Vital" (29 July 1943); Mail Call: V-mail, The National WWII Museum; Safeguarding Military Information, Army Regulations No. 380-5, 28 September 1942 (archival record).

Why Nobody Turned On A Light LIKELY

Allen supplies his own explanation, and it is the one the record supports. A single aircraft circling in the dark did little harm by itself; its real work was to scout, to keep men out of their cots, and, when it carried flares, to mark for someone else. On the night of 13-14 October 1942 at Henderson Field the battleships Kongo and Haruna opened fire at 01:33 and shelled the Lunga perimeter for 83 minutes with more than 900 fourteen-inch rounds, destroying 48 of the 90 aircraft on the field, burning nearly all the aviation fuel and killing forty-one men.

Set against a risk like that, a searchlight beam and a stream of tracer amounted to a free fix on the runway and on the gun pits themselves. The contrast with daylight is stark: during the 12 April 1943 raid the Australian anti-aircraft batteries around Port Moresby fired 1,112 rounds and claimed no hits at all. By day there was nothing left to conceal; by night there was everything.

Sources: Washing Machine Charlie (Wikipedia) — purposes including flare-dropping for naval and ground forces; Henderson Field (Guadalcanal) (Wikipedia); Battle for Henderson Field (Wikipedia) — 13-14 October 1942 battleship bombardment; Pacific Wrecks — Operation I-Go: April 12, 1943 (1,112 AA rounds, no hits claimed).

The Joker Who Circled: Washing Machine Charlie

Allen never gives the aeroplane a name; he calls it the joker. Allied troops across the Pacific had a name for it, and it came from the sound. A pilot flying a twin-engined machine could throw his engines out of synchronisation to produce a slow, uneven throb, loud enough to wake a camp and then keep it awake, and so the lone nightly visitor became Washing Machine Charlie; the comparison to a pre-war Maytag is often repeated but we could not source it.

The types varied, from ship- and shore-based single-engined seaplanes of the R-Area Air Force to Mitsubishi G4M Betty bombers flown deliberately out of step, and the jobs varied with them: scouting, dropping flares for Japanese naval or ground forces, bombing airfields and installations, and simply keeping a whole base awake and braced. A companion nickname, Bedcheck Charlie, belonged chiefly to the lone Luftwaffe visitors over Europe but reached the Pacific too, in an Associated Press despatch from the Gilberts dated 12 January 1944. The names are best documented at Henderson Field and across the Solomons and travelled to other Allied bases; nothing in Allen's account shows the 90th Bomb Squadron used them, so the nickname belongs on the page as context rather than as his word.

Sources: Washing Machine Charlie (Wikipedia); Charlie — Wordorigins.org (earliest 'Bedcheck Charley' citation, AP, 12 January 1944); Henderson Field (Guadalcanal) (Wikipedia) — checked, contains no mention of Louie the Louse or Washing Machine Charlie.

V-Mail

The censorship Allen describes — envelopes left unsealed for an officer to read before sending — was standard practice; V-Mail (Victory Mail) was the answer to what came next. A letter written on special stationery was censored, then photographed onto microfilm, shipped home at a fraction of the bulk of the original paper, and printed back out at about one-quarter size for delivery. A letter on microfilm took roughly 1/37th the cargo space of the same letter on paper; over a billion V-Mails were sent between June 1942 and November 1945.

Source: National Postal Museum; The National WWII Museum.

J **JEREMY** 51:35

How did you make it sound for a family?

ALLEN 51:42

Or Gram, when you would. Obviously you wrote them. While you were in the Well, the first thing he did for instance, when we landed at Brisbane He'd go to Some kind of government officer or get sent telegrams So, there it was posted. He arrived in where you were. And once we left there on the Northern West Strait we landed at APO number I knew where that was. You couldn't tell him All he could say is Somewhere on Oceania

JEREMY 52:32

When you went to New Guinea

ALLEN 52:33

You never could say where you were. You had obviously I mean, we're going to show some of these pictures you had tons of pictures a lot of them that you took Some you got from other people

JEREMY 52:44

How did you get a camera? Did you have a camera with you?

ALLEN 52:46

Oh yeah, I took that along

JEREMY 52:47

You took that along?

ALLEN 52:49

I took all that along I took my portable radio along it lasted for quite a while but then I couldn't get batteries anymore at that time they were revolting batteries in those days they weren't you couldn't get batteries they worked alright for on an earthquake but all you could pick up

JEREMY 53:09

Was the O.C. stations around here

ALLEN 53:15

And there weren't too many of those. We did have a show with the radio equipment the squadron radio equipment I did have a group of foreign broadcasters. And we'd pick up the BBC. In London and San Francisco a lot of music shows and everything from San Francisco. Giving you the news back home Yeah, it was. Any significant Just to start with Too far away Any significant news back home that you heard on the radio

J **JEREMY** 53:54

That was good to hear?

A **ALLEN** 53:56

Well, yeah

J **JEREMY** 53:57

What was good to hear

A **ALLEN** 53:57

We could follow the baseball and the football games. And I got the idea then to you know Listen to the the news and the sports and then. We learned to write real fast I didn't write and we put up a sheet Put it on a bulletin board and then we even got to the point then that at the movies. Before the movies started I would I would plug in and read the latest news before the movies. Yeah I imagine Just little things like that Really you know. They Helped morale Yeah they helped because

J **JEREMY** 54:44

When

A **ALLEN** 54:44

I know the orange squadron. Just. Asked the guys How are you getting this news. And they told them and they said Well, can we get it Yeah you run a line up here and we plug in Yeah. And so. That night

J **JEREMY** 55:00

When there wasn't a movie

A **ALLEN** 55:01

There just there was Maybe a loud speaker Outside the tent One tent and we'd. We'd read the news after that. We'd see what was going on you know you were so in other words you were kind of a DJ and and your son Al was a DJ and Your grandson Jeremy turned out to be a DJ That's a little ironic isn't it. Yup Swagger Experience Has been going for seven years. Pretty something

J **JEREMY** 55:31

Let's see

A **ALLEN** 55:31

Okay you you had a darkroom Huh. Somehow Somehow in the jungle you were able to Well they had one

J ***JEREMY*** 55:40

Now, was that just for the soldiers, or was that mainly, I mean, was that like secondary use for the soldiers?

A **ALLEN** 55:46

That was secondary, yeah. But mostly it was for, I guess you would imagine. Yeah, they'd take pictures on reconnaissance flights and then develop them. Yeah. But they had enough equipment and supplies to let anyone use it. Again, I mean, that helps morale. I mean, if you had nothing to do out there, I'd see that you would go crazy. Did you have anybody ever, I don't want me to ask you too many things, but anybody ever, like, it just became too much for them? No, not that I know of in our group, no.

APO 1106 — The Number That Isn't There

Seven of Allen's eight numbers decode. The first one does not, and the reason is worth recording precisely rather than guessing around. The Army Postal Service's own master register of every APO used between January 1942 and November 1947 runs 1102, 1103, 1105, then jumps to 1112: there is no APO 1106 in it at all, and the surrounding 1100-series numbers were routed through New York and opened in 1945 and 1946 for occupied Europe, not the Pacific. The San Francisco-routed numbers above 1000 were assigned to the Philippines and the Ryukyus in 1945, after Allen was already home. So 1106 cannot be a place he served under, and the honest conclusion is that this figure is either something other than an APO — a unit number, a shipment or class number, a date — or a slip of the pen or of the copying. The page in the book is worth looking at again with fresh eyes.

Sources: Numerical Listing of APO's, January 1942 – November 1947 (AGO), p. 198 – the sequence runs 1102 (Le Mans), 1103 (Tannenberg/Marburg), 1105 (France, then Manila), 1112 (Berlin); no 1106 is listed; WWII Army Post Office (APO) Locations – database transcribed from the 1949 AGO listing; no entry for APO 1106; APO-locations.csv – full 1100-series enumeration confirming no APO 1106 and New York routing throughout.

APO 501 — The Theatre Address LIKELY

APO 501 was the theatre headquarters post office for United States Army forces in the Southwest Pacific, and the Army's own register tracks its moves well to the rear of the fighting: Melbourne from January 1942, Sydney from September 1942, Brisbane from February 1943, then forward to Hollandia on 25 November 1944, Tacloban on Leyte on 5 February 1945, and Manila on 7 March 1945, closing on 5 May 1946. Allen landed at Brisbane on 25 February 1942, in the weeks when 501 was still physically at Melbourne — which is the point of the number rather than a contradiction of it.

A theatre-level APO was an address, not a place; it was what a man newly arrived in Australia and not yet on any base-section roll could give his family. That 501 heads the Australian part of his list, ahead of the local Queensland numbers, fits that reading, though nothing in the record states which address his first letters home actually carried.

Sources: Numerical Listing of APO's, January 1942 – November 1947 (AGO), p. 121 – APO 501: Melbourne 1/42, Sydney 9/42, Brisbane 2/43, Hollandia 25-11-44, Tacloban 5-2-45, Manila 7-3-45; Army Post Offices in Australia during WW2, Peter Dunn's Australia @ War; Army Post Offices in Australia during WW2 – APO 501 listed as "Hqs. U.S. Army Forces Far East" (no dates given).

The news before the movie

The two voices Allen names were the two that carried to the Southwest Pacific. KGEI was built by General Electric for the Golden Gate International Exposition on Treasure Island in 1939, and moved in 1941 to the Redwood Peninsula three miles east of Belmont, California — a 50-kilowatt transmitter behind three-foot concrete walls, floors and ceilings. For a time it was, in its own historians' words, the only station on which news from the United States could be heard in the Pacific.

From London, the BBC's Overseas Service ran a dedicated Pacific Service, and by the end of December 1941 the Corporation's three daily services to the Pacific, the East and Africa, together with the nightly service to Canada and the United States, totalled over twenty-one hours out of every twenty-four. What makes Allen's bulletin board remarkable is the date. Organised forces broadcasting only reached New Guinea in 1944 — the station at Milne Bay on 26 January, 9PA at Port Moresby opened by General MacArthur on 26 February, the AFRS Jungle Network headquartered at Hollandia — so for a year and more the only news a squadron got was whatever a radio man could tune, write down fast and read out loud. The neighbouring squadron running a line over to hear it was not a small courtesy; it was the local news service.

Sources: KGEI History — The Radio Historian; KGEI — Wikipedia; BBC Year Book 1942 (three daily services to the Pacific, the East and Africa; over 21 hours out of 24); AFRS Jungle Network — Radio Heritage Foundation.

> *"That helps morale. If you had nothing to do out there, I'd see that you would go crazy."*
>
> ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

J **JEREMY** 56:21

No, what were you doing?

A **ALLEN** 56:24

I mean, we had some equipment. We had footballs, we had baseballs, and all that, or softballs. And we might have a game or stand out there in the hot sun throwing a football around. They'd eat it. Because they're sitting under the shade trees looking at us as if we're nuts. But we'd do things like that just to keep busy. Yeah.

J ***JEREMY*** 56:47

How was the food? What'd you eat?

A **ALLEN** 56:53

Whatever was prepared.

A **ALLEN** 57:00

I guess the one thing we had a lot of was corned beef, which we called bully beef. And it was made in different ways, but it was always the same thing. We had a lot of soups. Fresh meat and stuff like that was very simple. It was always canned stuff, you know. Drinks, I would imagine, was mostly water. Or a lemonade made with powdered crystals or something like that, something like that. Coffee a lot. I think there was tea.

J ***JEREMY*** 57:46

Did you have a little makeshift bar? A what? Didn't you have a bar?

A **ALLEN** 57:52

I'm afraid not.

J ***JEREMY*** 57:53

And nowhere in the jungle you had a bar?

A **ALLEN** 57:56

Yeah. Every once in a while it was shipped in and you got, I know one place you got, each guy was issued two bottles of beer.

J ***JEREMY*** 58:05

Remember that?

A **ALLEN** 58:06

Each guy got two bottles of beer. Yeah. And if it was a dim drink, you could sell it for a pretty good price. I imagine so. Yeah.

J **JEREMY** 58:20

Did you ever sell beers?

A **ALLEN** 58:22

Yeah. You could sell a beer for, and the guy would say, I'll give you a bond.

J **JEREMY** 58:28

No Aussie money for, oh, what are you going to do with a note?

A **ALLEN** 58:33

There's no place to spend it, you know. That's what they'd do with the guys. Some guys would sell their beer and then they'd have card games. They'd use this currency for the game. You're wasting. I thought you had like, you had like, it looked like a little, a bar in a tent. Of course they had some naked one up on top of the bar.

J **JEREMY** 58:59

You didn't have that?

A **ALLEN** 59:00

I don't know what that was. There was no bars. Don't forget that. Well, I know now. It was the same thing with the, like, cigarettes was another thing. You might be issued some of those times a year. They issued you cigarettes. Yeah. Of course, at that time, you smoked a pint. Yeah.

J **JEREMY** 59:19

Or did you get the tobacco for that?

A **ALLEN** 59:21

That's a good question. Well, you could buy it in Australia. Yeah. Probably. Probably bought some of the cans or something like that and take home.

A **ALLEN** 59:40

Some of the things.

J **JEREMY** 59:41

Well, how often did you get leave in the jungle? When did that come around?

A **ALLEN** 59:46

Oh, you get two or three days off. You get a day off, a weekend off.

J **JEREMY** 59:49

How did that work out?

A **ALLEN** 59:50

No, no, No days off. You got to, you got to rest.

J **JEREMY** 59:57

Which basically meant?

A **ALLEN** 59:59

You know, one time I went, I went down to Brisbane and received, that was out of, I don't know, I guess that was still in Australia. I went down there. That was by train and another time I went down to, I guess I had about three times in that, that I can recall, twice from New Guinea to Australia. I went to Brisbane twice and to a place called Rockhampton along the east coast one time.

J **JEREMY** 60:46

Did you do?

A **ALLEN** 60:49

Yeah, they had movies. They had stores. They had.

J **JEREMY** 60:55

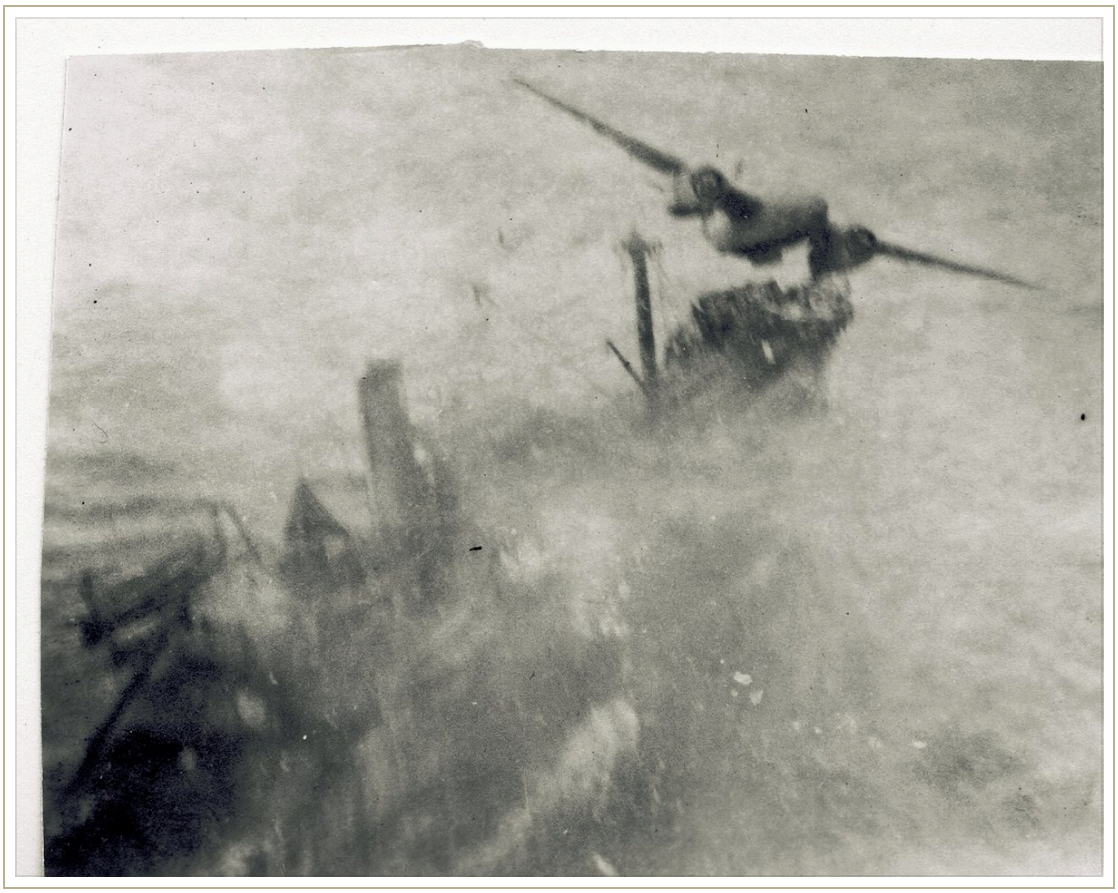
Did you run into your cousin one time on leave?

A **ALLEN** 60:57

Yeah. We had to, had to land for some reason or another in Rockhampton at that time. I don't know why, but I know in landing the nose wheel went kaput on the plane and we had to stay there until they flew one in the next day. Replace that. That's another thing. Maybe you see it across your fingers because going down, we had. In the B-25 bomber, we had something like 16 people aboard to make the trip and we landed there and then with this nose wheel bit and some guys sort of opted out. This is, they're not going to, they're not going to be in the plane when it takes off. They're going to go the rest of the way by train. So some of them did, but until it was all said and done, some more signed on and we had, I remember that well. 21 aboard for the rest of the trip. So the question is, do we have enough runway to get up, enough speed to get up? Yeah, we did.

A U.S. Army Air Force aircraft in flight.

An attack in progress on a New Guinea beachhead, photographed from the air — smoke rising from the tree line as landing craft sit offshore.



Allen's own photograph, taken from his aircraft during a low-level attack run — blurred by the plane's speed and vibration, but one of the few images in his collection shot in the middle of an actual mission.

Allen (with his cousin) on an Australian street, outside the Edgar V. Hudson electrical shop — the reunion he describes below, half a world from home.

J **JEREMY** 62:12

But how'd you, now, again, how'd you run into your cousin and the story, the story how it was mixed back home? Let's hear all that again.

A **ALLEN** 62:20

I went over on the hangar that time and spent some time and find out what spot were we going to stay for the night and all that. And I noticed an ambulance there with the. Marking, so when I knew my cousin was in that outfit, I asked the guys, did they know him? They said, oh, yeah. I said, well, we'll go back, tell him to come up. His cousin is from time from home, wants to see him out here. And he came and we went out and went to the mess hall at night, had dinner together and then went to a movie together. Of course, the story calmed a little bit. Yeah. But one of the two other times I met somebody from one was when we went down in Brisbane, right after we landed there, a gang of us went in town to look around. And it's so far by truck. And then we the rest of the street. I see a guy at one of the crossings, just ready to step off the curb, go across the street. And I recognized him. And I grabbed him by the shoulder and pulled him back and said, where do you think you're going? He was surprised, too. And we often talked about it, you know, in our years about how we met over there. And then another kid younger than me, he was in this neighborhood from here in Persona, met him over there.

A **ALLEN** 64:07

Christmas. Christmas in the jungle. Not very nice. Not very nice.

J ***JEREMY*** 64:15

Like it was?

A **ALLEN** 64:20

Back to the old story, that one, I guess. It was Christmas Eve. I'm sitting in my tent with another guy. We were writing letters and listening to the radio. And I just happened to glance up and I look over and tears are running down his cheeks. That's another way. I said, let's get off. Let's go to the movies. This is driving me nuts. Okay, so I'm ready to go down to the movies and I said, wait a minute, I'm going to get some chewing gum out of my bag here. So I reach in the bag to get the chewing gum, one curtain squirt, and after that I come out of the bag with a scorpion hanging on my fingers. And then I had to go down to the medics, kind of a shot, and then we went to the movies. Happy, Merry Christmas.

Christmas in the Southwest Pacific, and Somewhere to Go

The services worked hard to mark the day at the far end of the supply line. The Army Postal Service told families to mail Christmas parcels for men overseas between 15 September and 15 October, months ahead, and the mail itself came in two forms: ordinary letters, which the men much preferred — Navy personnel in 1944 got about six of them for every V-mail — and V-mail, the photographed and shrunken letter written on a single sheet that folded into its own envelope, of which more than a billion were processed between June 1942 and November 1945. Either way it came in surges, which is why Allen remembers weeks of nothing and then a whole bundle at once.

Turkey dinners were pushed forward wherever the logistics reached, and across the theater men improvised the day out of what was at hand. And there were the pictures. The Army's motion picture service ran 260 film libraries feeding sixty bases on six continents, moving reels by boat, plane, train, automobile, motorcycle, camel caravan and Arctic dog sled, and in the South Pacific the men built their own theaters — benches cut from palm trunks and a white sheet hung from the branches. That is the theater Allen was headed to with a scorpion on his hand, and the one where, by his own account, he used to plug in his shortwave set and read the day's news aloud before the show started, until another squadron ran a line up to his tent to hear it too.

Sources: How the U.S. Army Served its Movie-Mad GIs during World War II — National Archives, The Unwritten Record; Mail Call: V-mail — The National WWII Museum; Wrap Securely, Address Correctly: Innovations of Postal Mail during World War II — Kentucky Historical Society; Christmas for Australians away from home during World War II — Anzac Portal, DVA.

The Scorpion in the Barracks Bag

Of roughly 2,770 described scorpion species, only about 104 — 3.8 percent, and almost all of them in the family Buthidae — are considered medically significant, and the dangerous ones are concentrated far from New Guinea: Androctonus, Buthus and Leiurus across North Africa, the Middle East and Asia, Tityus in South America and the Caribbean, Centruroides in Mexico, Central America and the American southwest, with Mexico, Brazil, Iran, Algeria and Morocco carrying the deaths. No Australasian region appears on that list. New Guinea's own scorpions are a smaller cast — four genera in two families, the hormurids Hormurus and Liocheles alongside the buthids Isometrus and Lychas.

The Australian Museum, describing the twenty-nine species in six genera found across Australia, puts the likely outcome plainly: they can give a painful sting causing inflammation and pain for several hours, treated with a cold pack and a doctor if the pain persists. What the medics at Dobodura had to offer was therefore symptomatic — and for any puncture of the skin, a needle. The Army had been immunizing every soldier with tetanus toxoid since 1941, boosting with toxoid rather than horse serum at the time of a wound, a regime so effective that the whole Army recorded just twelve cases of tetanus in the war, one per million soldiers, and most of those twelve had not been fully immunized. Allen's shot was most plausibly that, or morphine for the pain; the record does not settle which, and the honest reading of the episode is that he was in real pain, in no real danger, and back in his seat before the picture finished.

Sources: Scorpionism: a neglected tropical disease with global public health implications — Frontiers in Public Health; Scorpions — Australian Museum; Atlas of Australasian hormurid scorpions I: the genus Hormurus in Papua New Guinea — Revue Suisse de Zoologie; Early U.S. Military Immunization Against Tetanus and Diphtheria: Historical Context and Current Importance.

Which Christmas: Dobodura, 1943

The interview never dates the story, but the group's own movements narrow it to one night. The 3rd Bombardment Group reached Charters Towers in Queensland on 10 March 1942, moved up to Port Moresby on 28 January 1943, to Dobodura on 20 May 1943, and on to Nadzab on 3 February 1944; Allen went home in the autumn of 1944. That leaves Christmas 1942 spent in the dry savanna country of north Queensland and exactly one Christmas in New Guinea — 25 December 1943, at Dobodura, on the grass flats inland from the northern Papuan coast.

He calls it Christmas in the jungle, and Dobodura is the only Christmas that fits the phrase. It was not a quiet week: the 1st Marine Division went ashore at Cape Gloucester on 26 December 1943, and the group supported those landings, including an attack on Japanese machine-gun positions on 28 December flown by its A-20 squadrons. Whether Allen's own 90th Bomb Squadron flew on Christmas Eve or Christmas Day itself, the record consulted here does not say.

Sources: 3rd Bombardment Group — historyofwar.org; Dobodura Airfield Complex (1942) — Wikipedia; Neutralisation of Rabaul — Wikipedia.

There Was No Station Yet: How the Music Got In LIKELY

Allen sets the scene simply — two men writing letters with the radio on — but in December 1943 there was still no Allied forces station broadcasting from anywhere in New Guinea for that radio to tune. RAAF Radio Milne Bay, the first of the Jungle Network stations in the islands, did not open until 26 January 1944; the Australian Army's 9PA at Port Moresby was opened by General MacArthur and the ABC's Sir Charles Moses on 26 February 1944, and relayed to every ABC station at home; Nadzab followed in June 1944, staffed out of Milne Bay, and Madang in October.

The Armed Forces Radio Service itself had been established by War Department order on 26 May 1942, with headquarters in Los Angeles, and by VJ Day it had pressed its millionth transcription disc; it fed set pieces like the Command Performance Christmas special of 24 December 1942, carried by all four networks, and the ninety-minute 1943 edition. But with no local transmitter in range, what came into that tent almost certainly came the way Allen describes everywhere else in his interview: shortwave, out of KGEI in San Francisco, which had been beaming to American forces in the Pacific since February 1939 and was carrying Command Performance to the South Pacific by mid-1942. The inference about his particular set is ours; the station dates are documented.

Sources: Australian Military WWII Broadcasting Stations; Christmas on the Air — Wartime Radio Programs Revisited — The National WWII Museum; Armed Forces Radio Service — Museum of Broadcast Communications; AFRS Jungle Network — Radio Heritage Foundation.

> *"I just happened to glance up and I look over and tears are running down his cheeks."*
>
> ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

J **JEREMY** 65:35

How about it?

J **JEREMY** 65:40

White Christmas?

A **ALLEN** 65:43

Yeah, the middle of you on the shoes, yeah.

J **JEREMY** 65:46

Oh, I mean, did you get to hear that while you were over there? White Christmas?

A **ALLEN** 65:51

Oh, that's what they play, that white Christmas inside at night. That's still, I don't know, I haven't heard that yet today. Your thoughts go back.

J **JEREMY** 66:14

How do you feel about coming out?

A **ALLEN** 66:19

I don't know, they just put me in.

A **ALLEN** 66:30

I don't remember which base we were at anymore because there were two shows posted. one was the Bob Hope show and one was, I don't know, it said some lady. Truba Girls, I don't know what it was but you drew which ones you wanted to go because you only let half the crew go to that one and half go to the other one so I was lucky enough to get to the Bob Hope. I was a double bonus, you get Bob Hope and girls. the guys thought

The Song He Still Cannot Hear Straight Through

Irving Berlin wrote "White Christmas" before the war — by one account in January 1940 — and Bing Crosby gave it its first public airing on his NBC program The Kraft Music Hall in the last days of December 1941, within weeks of Pearl Harbor; sources disagree on whether that broadcast fell on Christmas Eve or Christmas Day, and the point is not settled. Crosby recorded the version America knew on 29 May 1942 at Radio Recorders in Los Angeles, for Decca, with the John Scott Trotter Orchestra and the Ken Darby Singers, in a session that took eighteen minutes. It was released on 30 July 1942 in the six-disc album of 78s from the film Holiday Inn, won Best Original Song at the Academy Awards ceremony held in March 1943, and reached the top of the Billboard chart on 31 October 1942, where it stayed eleven weeks and on into the new year.

Crosby grew wary of singing it for men overseas: he said he hesitated because it invariably caused such a nostalgic yearning among the men that it made them sad — and by his own account they kept asking for it anyway. The pressing Allen would have heard in a tent in New Guinea was that original 1942 master, which Decca wore out from sheer use; Crosby had to re-cut the song on 19 March 1947 to replace it. Seventy years later he told his interviewer he had not heard it once that day without his thoughts going back, which is precisely the effect the singer had been afraid of.

Sources: White Christmas (song) — Wikipedia; Dreaming of a "White Christmas" — The National WWII Museum; The sad story behind 'White Christmas' — KUOW; Holiday Inn (film) — Wikipedia.

Taken by a squadron photographer, not by Allen: Bob Hope on stage, pith helmet and all, at the 90th Squadron's own Hollandia base. A squadron photographer, Jack, took it and five others of the same show (Frances Langford, Jerry Colonna, Patty Thomas, Judith Anderson) and shared them decades later on the 3rd Bomb Group's own history website — Allen's own unit, at a base he himself confirms landing at later in this interview. It isn't certain this is the very performance Allen attended, but it's the 90th Squadron's own Bob Hope show, photographed from the crowd he would have been standing in.

Source: OzAtWar (Peter Dunn, ozatwar.com), photo courtesy of Jack, a 90th Squadron veteran.

Bob Hope's "Pineapple Circuit"

In summer 1944 Bob Hope led a USO troupe on a roughly 13,000-mile, 52-day tour of the Pacific, nicknamed the "Pineapple Circuit" — over 80 shows, including a welcome in Sydney on 15 August 1944 and stops at New Guinea-area bases. Its known August 1944 New Guinea/Australia leg matches Allen's account of attending a show.

Source: The National WWII Museum.

> *"I was a double bonus, you get Bob Hope and girls, the guys thought."*
>
> ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

J **JEREMY** 67:13

when they come back

A **ALLEN** 67:14

they were thoroughly disgusted they thought they were going to see some. some hot stuff with this group of girls and what it was was some some kind of a they put on. fully clothed. yeah, they were very much put on well, can you tell me all you can

J **JEREMY** 67:38

from what you remember from the Bob Hope?

A **ALLEN** 67:41

no, it was I know there was one. Blank, I think the name was I don't know, I can't remember the name but it was a great show and you'd be right some of the jokes you heard there it was a great show it was a little better than him on the radio yeah, when the guys were hooting and hollering the whole time it was really something

J **JEREMY** 68:15

how many people got to go to like one show?

A **ALLEN** 68:18

like when you, I mean oh, jeez, that must have. the side of the hill there thank God, there must have it was in the hundreds, I don't know because he was from all the squadrons all the groups around there it didn't matter whether they were sitting on the ground there you know what I mean

J **JEREMY** 68:41

who cares what was where else are you going to get to see Bob Hope?

A **ALLEN** 68:48
yeah. well, I'm in person

A **ALLEN** 68:56
captured prisoners of war

J ***JEREMY*** 68:59
do you have any contact with them?

A **ALLEN** 69:01
the only contact I had with that

J ***JEREMY*** 69:03
was when we landed at

Hollandia

From 30 March to 3 April 1944, Fifth Air Force conducted surprise raids on Hollandia's airfields, destroying roughly 400 Japanese aircraft. Ground forces captured the main airfield 22 April 1944 (Operation Reckless); unlike many Japanese strongholds, large numbers of defenders abandoned their positions or surrendered rather than fight to the death — consistent with Allen's account of prisoners taken there.

Source: Wikipedia, Bombing of Hollandia, citing Craven & Cate, USAAF in WWII.

A **ALLEN** 69:05
Hollandia. they had just had the battle there the troops had gone the infantry had gone in I guess a day or two before and we came in with the LSTs and waded in there and then everybody was standing around the beach where do we go, you know and they marched a bunch of these prisoners by us there. that they had captured that's pretty much it there. you just want to show off the money and say just basically what that was or how you came about it where it came from

J ***JEREMY*** 69:55
anytime you're ready

A **ALLEN** 70:03

okay. so. here we have a couple of worthless little documents. Japanese. invasion money that they intended to use. when they got into Australia. half a shilling and a one pound note. absolutely worthless

The Prisoners on the Beach

What Allen saw was genuinely unusual. Hollandia was held by about 11,000 Japanese, but only some 500 of them were ground combat troops, drawn from antiaircraft batteries; the rest were service and headquarters personnel of the 6th Air Division of the Fourth Air Army and of the Second Army, and when the landings came at dawn on 22 April they broke and went into the bush, making for Genjem and the long overland route west to Sarmi.

Most Japanese losses at Hollandia therefore came during the weeks of mopping up that followed, with men taken in small groups — starving, sick and cut off. The US Army's official history records that by 6 June 1944, "611 Japanese were captured and over 3,300 killed." Its casualty table, whose New Guinea figures run to early October 1944, credits the Hollandia operation with 655 prisoners against 4,475 killed; set beside Aitape's 100 prisoners taken against 8,825 killed, or Wakde-Sarmi's 55, that is the largest take of prisoners anywhere in the campaign, with Biak's 460 the next nearest. Mid-May, when Allen waded ashore, was precisely the season of those round-ups, and a column of prisoners moving along the beach is exactly what the record would predict.

Sources: HyperWar — US Army in WWII: The Approach to the Philippines, ch. III, "The Hollandia Operations" (Robert Ross Smith); HyperWar — The Approach to the Philippines, Appendix: Table 2, Japanese casualties April–December 1944; Battle of Hollandia — garrison composition and withdrawal to Genjem and Sarmi.

Up the Coast by LST

Allen's account of the move to Hollandia can be dated almost to the day from the official Army Air Forces history, which records that the 3rd Bombardment Group's waterborne echelon, moving directly from Nadzab via Lae without staging, reached Humboldt Bay between 12 and 15 May 1944. That is his "got on boats up the coast of New Guinea": down the Markham Valley to Lae, then north-west along the coast and into Humboldt Bay, and off the bow ramps of LSTs into the shallows, which is how ground echelons and their equipment came ashore there. The standard USAAF station list gives the group at Hollandia from 12 May 1944.

One point should be stated plainly rather than smoothed over: the infantry assault had gone in on 22 April, three weeks earlier, not "a day or two before" — sixty years on, the beach was still raw, and the memory has compressed the interval. The aircraft were not waiting for them either. The doldrums had given way to summer drought, and the captured strips were so dusty that on 16 May only one A-20 squadron could be called forward: the 8th, one of the four squadrons of Allen's own group.

Sources: HyperWar — The Army Air Forces in World War II, Vol. IV, ch. 18 (Craven & Cate, official history); Army Air Corps Museum — 3rd Bombardment Group station list (Hollandia, 12 May 1944); HyperWar — US Army in WWII: The Approach to the Philippines, ch. III (LSTs at Humboldt Bay).

The half-shilling note Allen shows on tape: Japanese invasion money for the intended occupation of Australia.

The one-pound note from the same set.

The surrender pass Allen describes: "The bearer has ceased resistance..."

> *"Here we have a couple of worthless little documents — Japanese invasion money that they intended to use when they got into Australia. Half a shilling and a one pound note. Absolutely worthless."*

ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

J **JEREMY** 70:27

how did you get those? they just dropped them?

A **ALLEN** 70:33

I don't know how I got a hold of them. I know there was zillions of them around but I don't know how I got a hold of them alright

J ***JEREMY*** 70:41

tell me just exactly what

A **ALLEN** 70:43

I can repeat it there about these suckers

J ***JEREMY*** 70:47

this thing?

A **ALLEN** 70:48

yeah these fake pieces of paper oh

J ***JEREMY*** 70:50

what do you have there?

A **ALLEN** 70:53

we have here a pass that that was dropped these were dropped to the Japanese. the bearer of this pass is voluntarily surrendering and should be treated with courtesy and conducted to the nearest commanding officer for transfer to a rear area. Well, that all depended on the mood of the captor, I might say, because with the annex or the stuff that they pulled in the Philippines, there was not too much love for the Japanese, and I guess it was more or less considered the only good Japanese was that didn't, because I don't know if that would have helped them any if they'd have waived this thing. Especially what they had just, maybe just done to one of the guy's buddies, maybe ours before, something like that.

J ***JEREMY*** 71:51

Tell us a little bit about this group you're in. The who?

A **ALLEN** 71:55

Oh, I mean the name of your group.

J ***JEREMY*** 71:57

Oh, the group? Show us the front there.

This exact moment on tape: Allen holds up his own copy of "The Reaper's Harvest" as he says, "This is a book put out by our third bomb group of some of the actions in our time over there."

A **ALLEN** 71:59

All right, this is a book put out by our third bomb group of some of the actions in our time over there. In New Guinea and Australia.

A **ALLEN** 72:21

What we had was a Mitchell B-25 medium bombers. When we first got there, it carried a crew of the two pilots, a bombardier, two gunners. And a video man. We soon learned that that was not necessary, because they took the bomb site out of there, and we were changed to a low-level strafing outfit. The lower turret was taken out. Machine guns were put into the front, into the nose, where the bomber usually was. And we had the machine guns. The machine guns out on the wings. We had just the one gunner and the two pilots as a crew. We no longer used the radio man, either.

"We soon learned that that was not necessary, because they took the bomb site out of there, and we were changed to a low-level strafing outfit."

ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

ALLEN 73:31

Four squadrons in the group. The 8th, the 13th, the 89th, and the bomb squadrons. Each one had their own insignias, and each one was still a different era than that is at Fort Mooresville. I'm not too sure where. I guess we're all pretty old again over here. You know how handy we were. And the other places we were was a place called Dogadura, which was on the east coast of New Guinea, below the bay. And then from there, we had moved up the Markham River Valley up into inland New Guinea. To a place called Nazab. That was one of the best places that we were at, because it was away from the jungle. And it was nice up there, really. It seemed like every afternoon the air currents would change, and it would come up the valley. And it was real pleasant in the evening there. In Nazab, we went again. We went again. We had another move, went down, got on boats up the coast of New Guinea, and then landed up at Hollandia. Hollandia, that was a big operation. We had to fight the bombers. It was quite busy. Years from there, that's where I left then to come back home. And came back on what had been a passenger ship. We had to get for the bats and lions before the war. It was going from California, where it was, to the Pacific. So that launched up the city of New Guinea. I never had a chance to go back. I wouldn't imagine so. And, well, we moved out yesterday.

JEREMY 76:02

Who's in the world?

ALLEN 76:04

You're gone.

JEREMY 76:07

You're not going to elaborate on that again?

A **ALLEN** 76:08

Well, we knew that there was some kind of a scheduled location, the time spent in the service. And there were so many for each month, supposedly. And it took a long time to find out. But I found out then that I was supposed to be going the July quarter to go home. Well, it turned out. The May quarter was still there in September. So as far as being on the July quarter, I sort of missed there for a while. So things were going slow. And what happened is one night, it was on my birthday. So on the night, I was at a movie up in the hills. And when I come back to the camp, there was a lot of shouting going on and yelling. And I got on the telephone I had in my tent. And the guy says, you're going home tomorrow. And I thought, this is kind of a cool joke. Shouldn't be saying things like that. Circled around and found out, yeah, this is true. And it turned out that the next day, the July and August quarters were all going. And the pre-quarters had a bit of sunshine. And sure enough, the next day, we were in Truxton all that night. All that nice stuff.

A **ALLEN** 77:56

And things would come in there. Turned out to help process the paperwork to get on. And I went on board the ship. And we take off. And I'm on the sergeant's guard. No more on the ship. I had to wait. I had to be there at a certain time. And they had to go. So they couldn't get up. People's process said, oh, well, I'll just do that. And so we come back across the Pacific all by ourselves in one ship. And the rest of us know nothing. I'll tell you, when we came inside on in California and approached into the bay, everything was quiet. We just stood there and just watched. We sailed under the San Francisco, the Golden Gate Bridge. And once we were under that, it seemed like everybody on board ship left a hoot. Because they figured, if it's now, we can go the rest of the way. And, well, we come into the pier. And it's quiet. It's quiet. We're not going on there.

Why the May quarter was still there in September

On 5 April 1944 Fifth Air Force announced that ground personnel who had served "faithfully and continuously overseas for at least eighteen months" might be selected for return to the United States, with preference going to men with six months or more in the islands north of Australia. Allen qualified on both counts and more, but the quotas were minute — about one per cent of the air force's total ground strength each month.

The entire June-to-August allotment for the 54th Troop Carrier Wing was one officer and five enlisted men. The Army's own historians calculated that at 1944 rates a complete turnover of Far East Air Forces ground personnel would have taken more than eight years, and the Air Evaluation Board concluded flatly that "the rotation program as executed in the SWPA had a more adverse effect on morale than any other factor." His one dry sentence about the May quarter still sitting there in September is that policy felt from the inside: his name was on a list, and the list was not moving — which is why the shouting in the camp on his birthday sounded to him at first like a cruel joke.

Sources: Craven & Cate, The Army Air Forces in World War II, Vol. V: The Pacific — Matterhorn to Nagasaki, Chapter 11 (HyperWar).

How the Next Men Went Home

No paper has been found for the day Allen left Hollandia. Fold3's morning reports begin in 1945, and the 90th Squadron's reports for 1944 are at the National Personnel Records Center in St. Louis and have not been seen. His going is known from his service book, which closes the squadron at 9-10-44, from his discharge, which has him back in the United States on 29 September, and from what he says here.

The squadron's own reports from the following winter show the road the next men took. By then the squadron was at San Jose on Mindoro, in the Philippines, with its rear echelon still at Hollandia. The report of 27 January 1945 transfers six men to the Base G Rotation Detachment at Hollandia, effective 12 January, under Special Orders No. 12 of V Bomber Command. One of the six is Staff Sergeant John F. Heyn, who had crossed the Pacific on the Ancon with Allen in 1942. Parties of eight and four followed in February. From March the rotation parties went instead to Base K, APO 72.

Sources: morning reports, 90th Bomb Squadron, 3rd Bomb Group, 27 January, 10 and 14 February and 14 March 1945 (National Archives, Army morning reports, 1945), via Fold3; his service record book; Enlisted Record and Report of Separation, 8 June 1945.

One ship, no escort LIKELY

Allen's ship cannot be identified from what he says, and it would be wrong to put a name to it. What he describes, though, is a recognisable type: pre-war passenger liners requisitioned in 1941-42 and run as fast troopships under the War Shipping Administration. Matson Line's Lurline, Matsonia, Mariposa and Monterey had been built for the Hawaii and Australasia runs out of California, calling at Samoa, Fiji, New Zealand and Australia; all four passed into government hands within weeks of Pearl Harbor — Monterey was handed over at San Francisco on 3 December 1941, four days before the attack — and by Matson's own reckoning the four made 119 wartime voyages and carried 736,000 troops, a count that comes from the company rather than from a government record.

Because they were fast they frequently ran without a convoy — Monterey "served as a fast troop carrier, often operating alone so she would not be slowed by formation navigation in a convoy" — which is precisely the crossing he remembers, "all by ourselves in one ship," with everyone aboard letting out a hoot the moment the Golden Gate Bridge passed overhead. One note for the family, offered as a reading and not as evidence: the machine transcript's nonsense phrase "we had to get for the bats and lions before the war" looks very much like the speech-recogniser mangling "Matson Lines," which would fit his own description of a California-to-the-Pacific passenger run. Even so, without a sailing list the ship stays unnamed.

Sources: SS Monterey — Wikipedia; SS Lurline (1932) — Wikipedia; Matson — Company History; SS Mariposa (1931) — Wikipedia.

Out of the Jungle: The Markham Valley LIKELY

There is a geographic reason Nadzab felt like relief. The Markham Valley runs roughly 160 kilometres inland from the sea at Lae, climbing about 500 metres along its length, and its floor is a flat expanse of dry kunai grass rather than rainforest — open country, hot and often bone dry, burnt off by local people once a year. Dobodura had been kunai too, but a narrow plain hemmed in by the swamp and bush behind the Buna beaches, and before that came Port Moresby's dust; Nadzab sat in an open corridor well inland, with the jungle pushed back to the ranges on either side.

Allen's afternoon change of air is exactly the behaviour such a corridor produces: the valley opens onto the Huon Gulf, and as the inland plain heats through the day it draws air up the valley from the sea. No period meteorological record naming that wind has been found, so the mechanism here is offered as consistent with the geography rather than as documented fact. It is worth noting that other veterans remembered Nadzab as hot, dusty and wet; Allen's "best place we were at" is a comparison, and the thing he is comparing it to is the jungle.

Sources: Markham Valley — geography, length, elevation and grassland; Pacific Wrecks — Nadzab Airfield (Nadzab No. 1 Strip, East Base), Morobe Province, PNG; Landing at Nadzab — Markham Valley airfield development; Pacific Wrecks — Dobodura Airfield: "the land is mostly kunai".

Nadzab: The Jump He Arrived After

Nadzab was taken by the first major airborne assault of the Pacific war, on 5 September 1943, months before Allen's squadron ever saw it. The US Army's official history records an armada of 302 aircraft drawn from eight different fields: six squadrons of B-25 strafers worked the field over with nose guns and parachute fragmentation bombs, six A-20s laid smoke once the last bomb had gone off, and eighty-one C-47s carrying the 503rd Parachute Infantry Regiment were emptied in four and a half minutes, watched by Generals MacArthur and Kenney from a flight of three B-17s overhead. Australian gunners of the 2/4th Field Regiment jumped with them, and an Australian pioneer battalion that had walked and rafted in began work on the strip the same day.

Within a fortnight the engineers had two parallel 6,000-foot runways down and six more strips started. The 90th Bombardment Squadron flew in from Dobodura on 30 January 1944, with group headquarters following on 3 February — nearly five months after the drop, to a base already largely built. Secondary accounts credit the six smoke-laying A-20s to the 89th Bombardment Squadron, a sister squadron in Allen's own group, but the official history does not name the unit and that attribution should be treated as unconfirmed.

Sources: HyperWar — US Army in WWII: CARTWHEEL, The Reduction of Rabaul, ch. XI (official history); Landing at Nadzab — forces, casualties and airfield development; Pacific Wrecks — Allied units based at Dobodura Airfield (90th BS departs for Nadzab, 30 Jan 1944); Army Air Corps Museum — 3rd Bombardment Group station list (Nadzab, 3 Feb 1944).

Dobodura: "Below the Bay"

Allen's "Dogadura" is Dobodura, a plain of kunai grass lying inland from Buna on the north-east coast of Papua rather than the east coast proper. American engineers and infantrymen began clearing there early in November 1942 to support the Buna fighting: a rough strip was usable by 21 November, and three more were finished by 12 December, one with a 4,200-foot runway. The complex kept growing — eleven interconnected strips in the main group, and by Pacific Wrecks' count fifteen or more runways in the vicinity, many linked by taxiways — until it was one of the great Allied air-base areas of New Guinea.

Nothing about it was self-sufficient: supplies came overland from the harbour at Oro Bay, and the bay was what fed the field. Station records compiled by Pacific Wrecks place the 90th Bombardment Squadron at Horanda strip, also called Dobodura No. 4, from 21 May 1943, having moved up from Port Moresby, with group headquarters logged the day before; the standard USAAF station list gives the 3rd Bombardment Group at Dobodura from 20 May 1943. The squadron stayed there about eight months, longer than at any other New Guinea station. Allen's "below the bay" is a fair description of the place: Oro Bay lay to the south-east.

Sources: Pacific Wrecks — Allied units based at Dobodura Airfield; Pacific Wrecks — Dobodura Airfield (Dobodura Airfield Complex), Oro Province, PNG; Army Air Corps Museum — 3rd Bombardment Group (station list after Maurer, USAF Historical Division); Dobodura Airfield Complex — Oro Bay port and road (overview).

> *"We sailed under the San Francisco, the Golden Gate Bridge. And once we were under that, it seemed like everybody on board ship let out a hoot."*
>
> ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

A **ALLEN** 79:27

And March is through. The pier. And on the other side, we're right under another boat. Oh, my God, they're going to take us back over there again. And, you know, we went down the bay to an Army depot there, Angel Island, I think they called it. And then we were issued new uniforms, new this, new that. And then the next day, we headed for Fort Dix, New Jersey. Again, in Karen and I. And I called home and had my dad on the phone, told him I'd be home the next day.

"Angel Island, I think they called it"

The depot Allen remembers is Fort McDowell, the Army post on Angel Island's east garrison, and by 1944 it was part of the San Francisco Port of Embarkation alongside Fort Mason, the Oakland Army Base and Camp Stoneman. Fort McDowell had been the Army's Overseas Discharge and Replacement Depot since November 1922, and in the war it worked in both directions: it staged more than 300,000 men out to the Pacific, and it took them back in, re-clothing them and straightening their records before loading them on trains east. Men crossed to it on the Army ferry General Frank M.

Coxe, which during the war made as many as eight scheduled runs a day between Fort Mason and Fort McDowell, with periodic stops at Alcatraz. That geography explains the moment of panic in his account — marched off one pier only to find himself alongside another ship, "Oh, my God, they're going to take us back over there again" — because the transports and the island ferry used the same stretch of waterfront. The island's mess hall was serving more than 12,000 meals a day; the flag came down at Fort McDowell for the last time on 28 August 1946.

Sources: Historic California Posts: Fort McDowell (California State Military Museum); Ft. McDowell (aka East Garrison) — Angel Island Conservancy; USAT General Frank M. Coxe — Wikipedia; San Francisco Port of Embarkation — Wikipedia.

> *"Oh, my God, they're going to take us back over there again."*
>
> ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

J

JEREMY 80:06

What did he say?

A

ALLEN 80:13

Okay. He was real happy. And, of course, the next day, he took us into Trenton, New Jersey, on a train there in Philadelphia, and then made connections to come up, up into home. And there were a lot of train and traffic people riding those days. And, of course, a guy in uniform getting on a train was, you know, I don't know what, everybody was real nice to you. And coming off the train and had these insignias on and the different stripes and medals and whatnot that you wore in your uniform. And I guess you were just a sort of a center of attraction. A celebrity, basically. I got a little excited then when I got to Coastal. I was close to getting off at the station. It was in Schuylkill Haven. I looked out the window and it was raining. So I'm trying to get my bag open to get my raincoat on. I'm all fingers and all thumbs and all what. I don't know. But all excited. Finally got it out, got it on. And when the train was that long that the coach I was in was, oh, maybe about 50 yards down from the station. And I got off the train and started carrying my bags up toward the station. And my mother and dad and two of my neighbors were there to meet me. And I heard one of them say, oh, here he comes now.

"Coming off the train and had these insignias on and the different stripes and medals and whatnot that you wore in your uniform. I guess you were just a sort of a center of attraction."

A **ALLEN** 82:13

That started the celebration. Well, you got home. I got home. And you got to see your wife-to-be for the first time. Yeah. The last time I was home was Friday. It was my favorite day of 41. You got home. I was only there for about a half a day. And now here it is, September or October the 7th of 44. And let me pause one more time. The celebration is beginning. You arrive home. I come in. And they were in the back porch. And they had the light turned on. And my girlfriend was running off. Take your time, Pat.

A **ALLEN** 83:49

Well, that was a little celebration right there. Pretty much three years. I heard my dad say to our dog, who was never got any other name but Puppy. Puppy's out on the porch. She come running out, jumping all over. That's her doggy. All that time.

"I heard my dad say to our dog, who never got any other name but Puppy: 'Puppy's out on the porch.' She come running out, jumping all over."

ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

A **ALLEN** 84:30

And she hung with me all that night until I went to bed that night. The dog was right there.

J ***JEREMY*** 84:41

How old was Pup then? Hmm? How old was Pup then?

A **ALLEN** 84:45

Oh, well, he had to be, he had to be about six, seven, eight years old, I guess. Wow. He was getting. That's pretty amazing. Because I had it quite a while before I went away. I know that.

A **ALLEN** 85:23

Yep. It wasn't much. I don't even, I don't know if we had a little snack that night. I don't know. I don't remember. I really don't. It was probably the best sleep we've had in a long time. But I'll tell you that night, well, it was out on the seventh. And we decided right then and there we were getting married the next Saturday.

J *JEREMY* 85:51

That same night?

A **ALLEN** 85:53

Because when I, when I came up, I told my parents, I said, we're getting married next Saturday. A week right after the day you got home. We had, we had to, the next day, Sunday, I went, I went over, went to church. And a lot of people then, even, even one of the guys that was in the service, he had, he was home. He had, a tank was burned. He was burned up pretty good. Met him. We had, we had a big Sunday dinner. I don't know what we had. I don't know. But the story goes, they got out, they went to China and everything. Big celebration.

A **ALLEN** 86:52

It's the last time that China was used. Yeah. Well, I don't know. I'm not used to war, but I know that.

> *"I'm not used to war, but I know that."*
>
> ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

Prisoners and Losses

Two moments Allen's camera recorded near Hollandia, and the cost of the campaign.

Armed soldiers escort a Japanese prisoner of war past an aircraft.

A muddy track through a grove of palms stripped bare and killed by the fighting — the campaign's toll on the land itself.

Rows of white crosses beneath the palms mark a wartime cemetery for fallen troops.

In Memoriam

The 3rd Bomb Group's own history book closes its record of the war with a memorial roll: roughly 350 names of the group's own men who did not come home, prefaced by a short poem signed Edward Fenton — "All that I have I give. Yet all the world's abounding words cannot decrease my wonderment unending, as death, my sole release, buys your salvation: peace." Allen's own name is not on that list; he is one of the ones who did come home, which is the reason this document exists to tell his story at all.

Source: The Reaper's Harvest, 3rd Attack Group Association.

Documents He Brought Home

The New Guinea field newspaper, a signed occupation note, and Japanese-language leaflets Allen kept from his service.

U.S. News Flashes From Coast To Coast

ELECTION SPOTLIGHT PLAYS ON FRANKLIN D. ROOSEVELT & GEN. DOUGLAS MacARTHUR

Roosevelt Answers Sick Woman's Plea

SPOTLIGHT ON SPORT

Clare Luce Supports Gen. MacArthur

OTT MOST POPULAR

Limited Service' Jobs To Be Filled By Veterans

OHIO GAS CRISIS ENDS

STOLE FROM CHURCH TO PAY GREEN FEE

FIRE TRAGEDY: 3 DEAD

3 DROWNED WHEN TAXI PLUNGES INTO RIVER

BRONX PLANS CIVIC CENTER AND HELICOPTER FIELDS AFTER WAR

CLARK GABLE IS SUED

THREE BOYS CHARGED OVER COACH'S DEATH

Latest Casualty List

Escapes From Japs Gave Life To Save Others

MIRACULOUS ESCAPES

K.K.K. QUINTET NOT GUILTY BY JUDGE'S DIRECTION

SNOWBOUND TOWNS WILL BE FED BY AIRPLANE

Classmate Of Pershing Dies

Thief Hunt With Diamonds Ends In Arrest

AERO WORKERS FORM COMPANY ON NOVEL BASIS

"Guinea Gold," the New Guinea field newspaper: U.S. wire-service news. Credit: Guinea Gold, the Australian Army's field newspaper in New Guinea; from his own copy.

Polish Executioners Hit Boldly At German Tyrants In Streets Of Warsaw

WORLD NEWS IN BRIEF

Australian Hotels To Have Less Butter

Conflicting Reports On Finn's Dilemma

LONG DISTANCE WALKS BANNED FOR DURATION

Changed Outlook By Polish Government Reported

Valuable Radio Equipment Destroyed In Sydney Fire

Promoted To Marshal

SERVICE SECTION

WANTED TO SELL

MISCELLANEOUS

B.M.A. OPPOSES GOVT'S FREE MEDICINE PLAN

LOST AND FOUND

ROUND-UP OF WEEK-END SPORTS

ROOSEVELT WINS ROUND IN U.S. SUBSIDIES BATTLE

"Guinea Gold" carrying European war news and sports. Credit: Guinea Gold, the Australian Army's field newspaper in New Guinea; from his own copy.

2000 U.S. AIRCRAFT MAKE HEAVIEST DAYLIGHT RAID IN HISTORY ON TARGETS IN GERMANY

Another U.S. Success In Marshalls

COAL BILL CRITICISED BY C.I.O. LEADER

Eisenhower's Visiting List Contains Only One Name

RAID ON ADMIRALTY

Bibendrop's Father-in-Law Killed In Air Raid

Everyone Talkative But Chaplin In Hollywood Paternity Case

Damage Caused By Nazi Raid On London

RUSSIANS MASSING FOR NEW ASSAULTS IN DNIEPER BEND

RAF Continues Blitz: Stuttgart Raided

Polish Compromise Sent To Stalin

Another 123 Tons Of T.E. On Raised

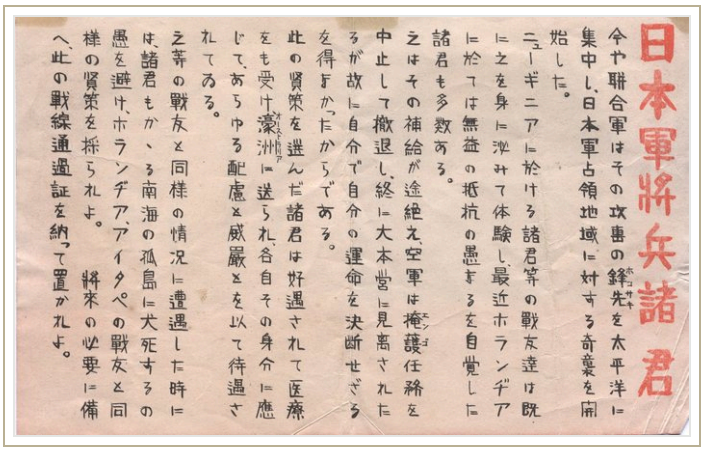
Seven Pijens Decorated

Argentine Police Say Rival Spy Rings Worked In S. America

"Guinea Gold" reporting a 2,000-plane raid on Germany. Credit: Guinea Gold, the Australian Army's field newspaper in New Guinea; from his own copy.

A Japanese occupation "One Shilling" note covered in servicemen's signatures — a wartime "short snorter." Legible names include Marvin H. Sabel, Harold E. Bryant, Edward S. Klak, Louis F. Carpenter, and Joseph H. Thompson; several more signatures are present but too faded or overlapping to read with confidence.

A Japanese-language leaflet illustrated with a U.S. bomber, addressed "To the Japanese Officers and Men."



日本軍將兵諸君

今や聯合軍はその攻勢の鋒先を太平洋に集中し、日本軍占領地域に対する奇襲を開始した。

ニューギニアに於ける諸君等の戰友達は既にその身に沁みて体驗し、最近ホランヂアに於ては無益の抵抗の愚まるを自覺した諸君も多數ある。

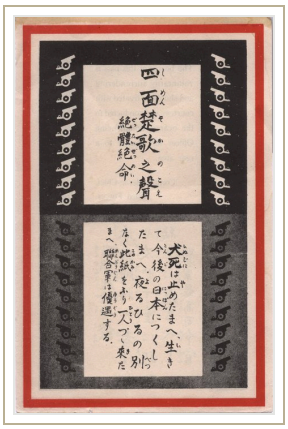
之はその補給が途絶え空軍は掩護任務を中止して撤退し、終に大本営に見棄されたるが故に自分で自分の運命を決断せざるを得なかったからである。

此の賢策を選んだ諸君は好遇されて医療をも受け濠洲に送られ、各自その身分に應じて、あらゆる配慮と威嚴とを以て待遇されてゐる。

之等の戰友と同様の情況に遭遇した時には諸君もかゝる南海の孤島に犬死するの愚を避けホランヂア、アイタペの戰友と同様の賢策を採られよ。

将來の必要に備へ、此の戰線通過証を納って置かれよ。

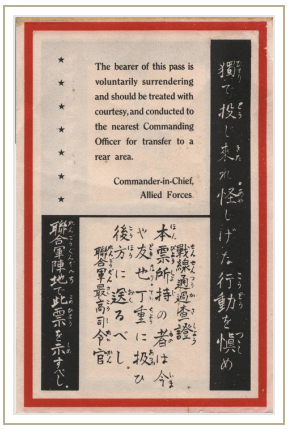
A leaflet addressing Japanese soldiers, its text referencing New Guinea and Hollandia.



四面楚歌之聲

犬死は止めたまへ、生きて今後の日本につくし、たまへ、祖國をふたゝび踏まへ聯合軍は優遇する。

A red-bordered leaflet titled with the phrase "surrounded on all sides."



The bearer of this pass is voluntarily surrendering and should be treated with courtesy, and conducted to the nearest Commanding Officer for transfer to a rear area.

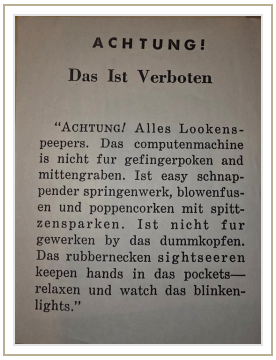
Commander-in-Chief, Allied Forces.

獨で投し來が怪しげな行動を慎め

本票所持の者は今や戰意なく丁重に扱ひ後方に送るべし。

聯合軍陣地此票を示すべし。

The reverse: a bilingual safe-conduct pass promising courteous treatment to any soldier who surrendered with it.



ACHTUNG!

Das Ist Verboten

"ACHTUNG! Alles Lookens-peepers. Das computenmachine is nicht fur gefingerpoken and mittengraben. Ist easy schnappender springenwerk, blowenfusen und poppencorken mit spittzensparken. Ist nicht fur gewerken by das dummkopfen. Das rubbernecken sightseeren keepen hands in das pockets—relaxen und watch das blinkenlights."

"Achtung! Das Ist Verboten" — a tongue-in-cheek mock-German warning sign from Allen's own collection, GI humor kept alongside the wartime documents.

Psychological Warfare Branch Leaflets

General MacArthur's Southwest Pacific Area Psychological Warfare Branch, formed in Brisbane in June 1944, produced close to 200 different leaflets in its "J1" numbered series — small codes like "25J1" or "159J1" printed directly on the leaflet identified which one it was. The Sixth Army's own Psywar Branch, formed that same September at Hollandia, used a separate "J6" series. No printed code is visible in these particular photographs, so which specific leaflet numbers Allen's are couldn't be confirmed without a clearer scan of the corners and margins where the SWPA numbering was usually stamped.

Sources: psywarrior.com; arsof-history.org.

CHAPTER FOUR

ALLEN E. SWEIGERT, SR. · WWII & FAMILY HISTORY

Part 2

Continuation, Recorded the Following Day

Type two letters or more to filter to the passages that mention it. Press Enter to step through them, Shift+Enter to step back, Esc to clear.

J **JEREMY** 00:00

I'll go from, uh, you just got married. Just wrap it up.

A **ALLEN** 00:05

Okay, like I said, we got married a week after I came home. And what they did when we got home, they gave us immediate, what they called a 21-day delay en route. In other words, 21 days of vacation. *We went on a honeymoon for a week. We couldn't go too far because, uh, well, car, and we drove, we drove around, went in, not too far. Spent some night, places here and there, and different friends we knew. And then we had to report a hotel in Atlantic City for reassignment. Well, this, this was just a, like a continuation of the honeymoon because it was, it was really,* it was really great. We, we, there were all kinds of shows we could go to, uh, dances, uh, uh, we got a kick out of, uh, one of the shows, I don't know, I don't know if you remember or ever heard of the song, Begin the Begin. Yes. Okay. So they- I like that song, actually. Okay. So they, they did this and they had a, a crew come out with mops, mops and booms on the stage. And they... They substituted the words when they cleaned the latrine and it was, it was a riot. And then it was a, a case of, uh, well, one, one of my buddies, he is from Massachusetts. and everybody was wondering where we were going to be sent, uh, and they told us, uh, we will attempt to send, to place you as near to home as possible. We had to go in for interviews and, uh, they asked me, you know, I said, uh, you know,

The mop crew was an official program LIKELY

The stage crew Allen watched may well have been working from a kit. The Army's Special Services Division ran a formal soldier-show program, issuing complete do-it-yourself packages that contained the script, orchestrations, set and costume designs, choreography and even program templates, so that men at a station could build the scenery, play the instruments and perform for each other. Four of these Blueprint Specials reached the field — About Face!, written by Frank Loesser, Arnold Auerbach and others; Hi, Yank!, built around Sgt. George Baker's Sad Sack; P.F.C.

Mary Brown; and OK, USA! — and alongside them came the USO-Camp Shows "At Ease" volumes and the Army's numbered Soldier Shows Folios, of which the surviving collection runs from No. 9 to No. 31, the latest of them dated 1945. A 1944 sketch-writing contest, the joint work of the Writers' War Board and the Army's Special Service, produced GI Prize Winning Blackouts, a published collection of short comic scenes about Army life chosen from hundreds submitted worldwide. A "blackout" is precisely the shape of what Allen saw: men, props, a known tune, a substituted lyric, and a fast curtain. No source names the show at Atlantic City, or puts that latrine lyric in any printed script — only the machinery that made such evenings routine.

Sources: Soldier Shows — U.S. Army "Blueprint Specials" and Other Soldier Shows, University of North Texas Libraries; Soldier Shows Collection — UNT Digital Library; The Comedy Propaganda Machine: The Soldier Sketch Writing Contest of World War II — University of Maryland.

Parody was the enlisted man's own repertoire

The Army tried to give soldiers a songbook. The Army Song Book of 1941 offered sixty-seven patriotic, folk and service numbers and organized sing-alongs to go with them, and the men largely declined; their rule was spontaneous or nothing, and they snubbed the Army's own song sessions.

What they sang instead were parodies, new words fitted to tunes everyone already carried, and the practice is documented in detail: "Bless 'Em All" was the song American servicemen most liked to sing and to rewrite, and men set their own verses to "The Battle Hymn of the Republic," "Down in the Valley," "Mademoiselle from Armentieres" and "As Time Goes By." Eric Posselt collected such material in Give Out! in 1943, and postal authorities called it lewd and obscene and banned it from the mail, while the FBI took an interest in "Gee, But I Want to Go Home" before concluding it was good-natured griping about Army food. Paul Fussell, writing later about his own war, described soldiers' profanity as a licensed way for millions of conscripts to register bitterness and anger they could not otherwise speak; the parodies did the same work with a tune underneath. Allen's latrine version of "Begin the Beguine" is a specimen of exactly that genre, and one of its mildest and most repeatable.

Sources: World War II Soldiers Loved to Sing — Provided They Got to Sing Their Way — HistoryNet; Blood on the Risers — Wikipedia; Soldiers' Songs: The Folklore of the Powerless — Buffalo State College.

The song everyone in the room already knew

Cole Porter wrote "Begin the Beguine" on a 1935 cruise aboard the Franconia, between Kalabahi and Fiji, and gave it to the Broadway musical Jubilee, where June Knight introduced it at the Imperial Theatre in October 1935; the show failed, the song did not catch, and the musicologist Alec Wilder later called it "a maverick, it is an unprecedented experiment," a tune he could not sing or whistle through without the printed music. What made it universal was Artie Shaw. Shaw recorded Jerry Gray's arrangement at RCA Victor's Studio 2 in New York on 24 July 1938; the men at RCA thought the idea "a complete waste of time" and put it on the B-side of "Indian Love Call," the number everyone, Shaw included, expected to sell.

The disc jockeys chose the beguine side instead. It reached number three, made Shaw a national figure, and by the 1960s was reckoned to have sold some six and a half million copies. The Library of Congress essay on the record adds one detail this family will want: Porter's tune, it says, was inspired by a folk number he had heard in New Guinea. That is the reason the gag Allen describes worked at all — by the autumn of 1944 a stage crew had only to walk out with mops and brooms and hit the first phrase, and every man in the hall supplied the original words in his head while the substituted ones landed on top of them.

Sources: Begin the Beguine — Wikipedia; "Begin the Beguine" — Artie Shaw & His Orchestra (1938), National Recording Preservation Board essay, Library of Congress; Artie Shaw — Wikipedia; Artie Shaw And His Orchestra, Begin The Beguine (1945 jukebox pressing) — Discogs.

“A 21-day delay en route” — and a hotel in Atlantic City

“Delay en route” is not soldier’s slang; it is an Army administrative term for authorised travel time granted between duty stations, governed for enlisted men by the Army’s regulations on furloughs, passes and delays. For Army Air Forces men back from overseas, that leave at home was followed by a redistribution station, and Allen’s was the first one the AAF ever opened. The AAF activated its Redistribution Center at Atlantic City on 15 August 1943, along with Redistribution Station No. 1 there and Station No. 2 at Miami Beach, with the mission “to receive all Army Air Forces Personnel returning to the continental United States from overseas” and then, after examination and re-evaluation, to assign them to appropriate stations, detail them to rest camps or effect their separation from the service.

The hotel he reported to was one of forty-seven Atlantic City hotels the Army had leased at a dollar a day per room; Chalfonte-Haddon Hall and the Traymore had together become Thomas M. England General Hospital, the Traymore holding its convalescent centre with its rehabilitation equipment for amputees. So his two interviews — the one where he named three stations near home, and the one where he was offered Atlantic City itself at the price of two grades — were the “examination and re-evaluation” the directive describes, and the dances, the shows and the mops-and-brooms latrine version of “Begin the Beguine” were part of the design rather than a windfall. At the Santa Monica station the Army set aside a whole hotel for married soldiers, and something like it at Atlantic City is the likeliest reason the honeymoon could simply carry on.

Sources: Craven & Cate, The Army Air Forces in World War II, Vol. VII: Services Around the World, Chapter 17 (HyperWar); “War at the Shore” — Atlantic City Weekly; Atlantic City Training Center — Wikipedia; Camp Boardwalk and Atlantic City Veterans — Atlantic City Free Public Library, Heston Archives.

> *“They substituted the words when they cleaned the latrine, and it was a riot.”*
>
> ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

J **JEREMY** 02:17

where would you like to be stationed?

A **ALLEN** 02:20

So I, I had thought about it and I mentioned three different, three different places, uh,. uh, one in New, one in New York, one was in, uh, Washington, uh, uh, or in that area and I, I don't know where the other one was, uh, all local, you know, uh, in the next, uh, United States. And, uh, went back up for the, the re, the re... Uh-huh. ...re, the return of the reviewer, these request, and he says, we can't, we can't send you, they don't have any openings any of those places you asked for. He said, would you like to be stationed here in Atlantic City? And I had never thought of that, and I said, yeah, that's all right. He said, well, if, if we can get you in here could you have to be reduced two grades in your rank? I says, no, no thank you. I says, I worked hard to get up there. I'm not going to give it away that quickly. *quick. I said, we'll see what we can do. So I guess it was a day or two later, my one buddy come back. He says, oh God, he said, it's just posted, Don. You know where you're going? No, I haven't looked at the bulletin board. He says, you're going to DeRidder, Louisiana. Well, isn't that fine? I said, that's really close to home. And one guy, and then he says,* I don't know where I'm going yet. And then backtrack a little bit. One of the guys in our tent was from Coffeyville, Kansas. And we used to be kidding him all the time, especially this buddy of mine used to be kidding a guy about this Coffeyville, Kansas. By God, we went down to go to the show that night and looked at the bulletin board. And he said, the following men will report to Coffeyville, Kansas. Who's on there but Henry Miller. Oh my God. And we went back up and met Hank Comadon, he and his wife. And Hank, you're posted down there in the bulletin board. You know where you're going. And I had a big grin on my face. He says, no, no, He says, that's impossible. No, no. And there he found out he's going to Coffeyville. Oh God, that was funny. So I guess a day or two

What two grades were worth LIKELY

Under the Pay Readjustment Act of 1942, effective 1 June 1942, which set the rates for nearly the whole war, a first-grade noncommissioned officer, a master sergeant, drew $138.00 a month in base pay under three years of service and $144.90 with more than three years; two grades below him, in the third grade, a staff sergeant or technician third grade drew $96.00 and $100.80. For a man who had been in federal service since 16 September 1940, and so past the three-year mark, accepting the Atlantic City posting on those terms meant handing back $44.10 a month, a little over thirty percent of his base pay, along with the standing of the top enlisted grade he had reached overseas.

The structural reason such an offer could be made at all is the Table of Organization, the document that "established a unit's strength by duty position and grade": when every authorized slot at a grade was filled, no further man could be carried in it, and the making and breaking of noncommissioned officers ran on the Army's own enlisted-grade regulations rather than on a commander's goodwill. Allen's account of DeRidder shows the same squeeze from the other side, a base authorized one master sergeant with five returned master sergeants standing in front of it and a major proposing a school and a competition for the single place. What the record does not settle is whether a formal Army Air Forces policy in 1944 and 1945 directed redistribution stations to seek such reductions — the official history of the redistribution program is silent on grade — or whether it was a local expedient; on that, his sentence is the evidence.

Sources: 1942–1946 Military Pay Chart (Pay Readjustment Act of 1942) — NavyCS; Comparison of military and civilian pay in WWII, Barron's (reprinted); Assignment & Promotion — The American Soldier in World War II; United States Army enlisted rank insignia of World War II — Wikipedia.

Coffeyville, Kansas, was a real station

The town the tent used to laugh about had an Army airfield seven miles to its northeast, on a 1,456-acre tract where construction began on 1 June 1942; it was activated on 17 June 1942 as an Army Air Forces basic flying school, one of more than a dozen AAF fields Kansas would hold before the war ended. Basic pilot training in BT-13 Valiants opened on 14 November 1942 with Class 43-C, of whose 137 cadets 116 graduated on 13 January 1943, and in sixteen classes some 4,840 cadets and aviation students began the course while 3,881 finished it.

On 1 June 1944 the field passed to Third Air Force, which organized there the Coffeyville Replacement Training Unit (Photo Reconnaissance), redesignated three months later the Coffeyville Combat Crew Training Station (Photo Reconnaissance); the first pilots reported on 12 June 1944, and more than 460 finished their training in the twelve months that followed, first on the F-10, the camera version of the B-25, and then increasingly on the F-5, the unarmed camera version of the P-38. That is the station waiting behind the name on the Atlantic City bulletin board in the autumn of 1944, and its first camera ships were built on the same airframe Allen's own squadron had flown across New Guinea. A War Department telegram of 2 October 1945 authorized announcing the field's temporary inactivation, and the deed passed to the city on 21 July 1947; it is the Coffeyville Municipal Airport today.

Sources: Coffeyville Army Air Field — Wikipedia; Kansas World War II army airfields — Wikipedia; Coffeyville Municipal Airport — Wikipedia.

> *"I worked hard to get up there. I'm not going to give it away that quickly."*
>
> ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

J **JEREMY** 04:49

later, why?

"We left Atlantic City and I got a board train and went to DeRidder, Louisiana. Got there in the dark, at nighttime, dark, raining, cold."

ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

A **ALLEN** 04:50

We left Atlantic City and I got a board train and went to DeRidder, Louisiana. Got there in the dark, at nighttime, dark, raining, cold. I get in the barracks, I feel better. I didn't have barracks, I had tents. So they were not set up properly to handle people, handle a number of people there. And even in the mess wall, I mean, they'd be running out of food. And it was not very, very good at all. And then I had to go for an interview. And some major is interviewing me. And he says, now look, he says, forget the rank. He says, I just want you to talk as whatever comes in your mind. And I said, well, I said, this, I find out this base is a air raid warning school. Mainly, yeah. He says, I said, but the, the, it only calls for,. one master sergeant. And I'm well aware that there are five of us here in this group that came back from overseas, different squadrons. I says, he says, well, he said, we'll give you some schooling and then you'll compete for the position. I said, well, that's not fair. I says, people who are doing that for years, and then somebody's going to get a crash course in it. That's not fair at all. Well, all right. He says, well, what would you like to do? I says, you asked me to talk whatever comes in my mind. Yeah. I said, I'm going to get the hell out of here. This, them words. He said, where'd you like to go? I says, back into bombardment. Well,. he says, I don't know. We don't have a bomb outfit on the, on the, the base. We have fighters,. fighter squadron. Good enough. He said, let me see what I can do. And on the phone, he called up somebody. He says, I got a, my number, like my,. what there's class test. We've got a 501 here. I'd like to be reassigned. Do you have, do you have any openings? You have three of them. Oh, good. He says, sure. Well, I got one here. He wants to get back into, the radio man wants to get back into bombardment or fighters will be fine. Okay. I'll send him over. And I went over and I got in the. 399th fighter squadron, 369th fighter group. And I got over there and all that was kind of ticklish because I come in as a master sergeant. And the guy that was in charge was a tech sergeant. So immediately I outranked him. And it wasn't too friendly, uh, because, uh, the communication officer was a, was a Mexican descent and he was pretty friendly with his motherland, but. it went, it went okay. Uh, some of the things I, I had them do, they, they didn't like, but, uh, I had the backing of the, the CEO. So everything was all right. It worked out good. I had a good time there. Good bunch of guys worked out. The only thing is as soon as I know sooner got there. And then, uh, I got, I got, uh, vacation time real quick. I leave right quick. I come home and my wife says, I said, do you want to go along back with me? I have, uh, two, uh, two weeks. Go off, go along back. Okay, great. We made, we started out, we got back to New Guinea, okay, New Guinea, back into DeRidder, got in the hotel. I wasn't feeling good at all. Next day, somehow or another, I get back to the base and I wound up in the hospital, malaria. She was stuck down there,

what, in the hotel, what should have been a, a nice vacation time. She was stuck in the hotel. She would come out to the base every, every day. She would come out every day to visit me and, uh, there I am in the hospital. And, uh, the, the day, the day before I got out of the hospital, that squad, the outfit moved from DeRidder. up to, uh, Stuttgart, Arkansas. So I got out of the hospital, spent the night in the hotel at DeRidder, and the next day we were on the train, uh, coming up the, I got off at the, I got off at the, at Little Rock. I got off at Little Rock, Arkansas, off the train there. Gram kept going home.

The 369th, and a move he missed by one day

The outfit Allen joined had a short and entirely domestic life. The 369th Fighter Group was constituted on 26 May 1943 and activated at Hamilton Field, California on 1 August 1943; it worked as a fighter Replacement Training Unit through Marysville and Oroville, came back to Hamilton, then moved to DeRidder Army Air Base on 28 March 1944, where it took part in air-ground manoeuvres and demonstrations including the Louisiana Manoeuvres of summer 1944.

It flew P-39 Airacobras, then A-36 Apaches, P-40 Warhawks and finally P-51 Mustangs, and it never went overseas; it was inactivated on 10 August 1945. On 31 January 1945 Stuttgart Army Air Field, Arkansas — built in 1942 under the 70,000 Pilot Training Program, first a glider school and then an advanced twin-engine flying school, with four 5,000-foot runways and seven auxiliary fields — was transferred to Third Air Force and became a replacement training school under the 369th. The group moved there on 8 February 1945, which is the move Allen missed by a single day, lying in the DeRidder hospital with malaria while his wife waited at the hotel in town.

Sources: 369th Fighter Group — Wikipedia; 369th Fighter Group — Army Air Corps Museum; 369th Fighter Group — History of War; Stuttgart Army Air Field (Arkansas) — Wikipedia.

DeRidder: one slot, five master sergeants LIKELY

DeRidder Army Air Base had been built on land leased from the Beauregard Parish Police Jury from 1 July 1941, and by the wet night Allen arrived it was in its last phase: on 31 March 1944 the II Tactical Air Division of III Tactical Air Command was assigned there to conduct replacement training, and training at DeRidder ceased altogether in February 1945. We could not find any published source describing DeRidder as an "air raid warning school," so that part of his account stands on his word alone — and the command's own stated mission runs to dive bombardment, light bombardment and reconnaissance training, with no mention of aircraft-warning work, so the record neither backs him nor contradicts him here.

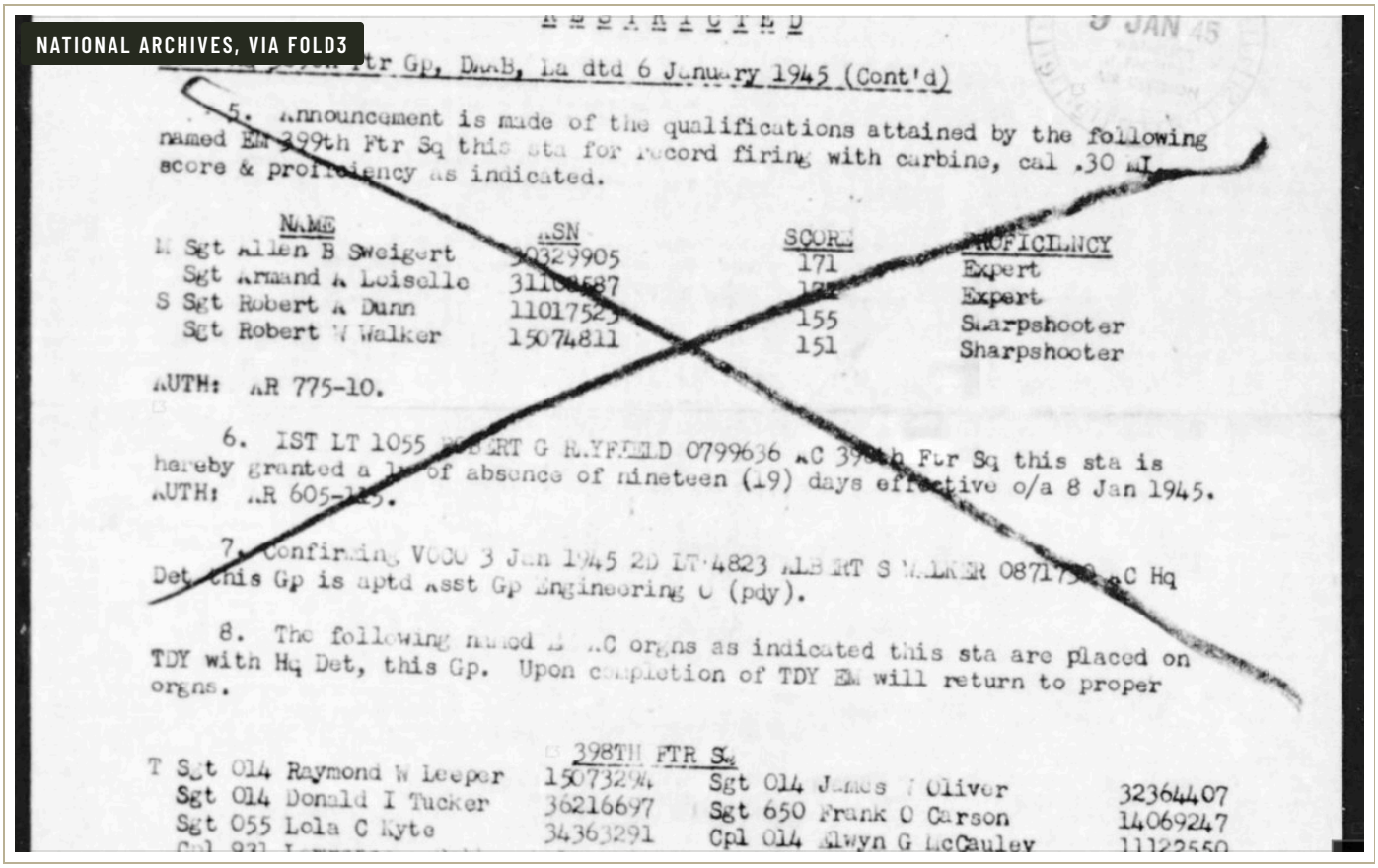
What the record does confirm is the door he talked his way through. The 369th Fighter Group, with its 398th, 399th and 400th Fighter Squadrons, had been stationed at DeRidder since 28 March 1944 — so a major picking up a telephone and finding three openings in a fighter squadron is entirely consistent with what was sitting on that same field. His own explanation of why he refused the competition is worth keeping as he said it: men who had done the work for years should not have to compete against someone given a crash course in it.

Sources: Beauregard Regional Airport (DeRidder Army Air Base) — Wikipedia; 369th Fighter Group — Wikipedia; III Tactical Air Command — Wikipedia; World War II DeRidder Army Air Base Memorial Historical Marker (HMdb).

The 399th Fighter Squadron

The 369th Fighter Group — its 398th, 399th, and 400th Fighter Squadrons — activated August 1, 1943, at Hamilton Field, California, and moved to DeRidder Army Air Base, Louisiana, on March 28, 1944. It was a training group, not a combat unit: through 1944 its pilots flew P-39 Airacobras, A-36s, and P-40s in air-ground maneuvers, including that summer's large-scale Louisiana Maneuvers, before re-equipping with P-51 Mustangs in 1945. The group moved to Stuttgart Army Airfield, Arkansas, on February 8, 1945 — matching Allen's own service record exactly — and was inactivated that August, days after the war's end.

Sources: Air Force Historical Research Agency; Army Air Corps Museum.



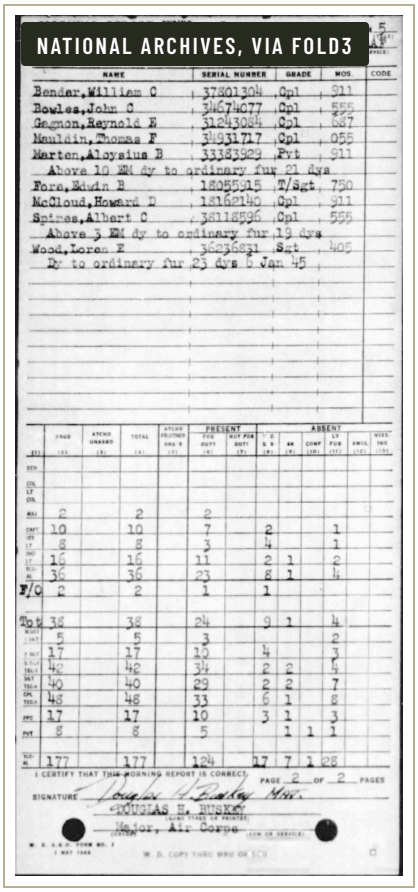
Special Orders No. 6, 369th Fighter Group, DeRidder Army Air Base, 6 January 1945, paragraph 5: "M Sgt Allen B Sweigert", score 171, Expert, in record firing with the .30-calibre carbine. The middle initial and the first digit of the serial are typing errors. The cross runs across the whole page. Credit: National Archives, Army morning reports, 1945, via Fold3.

Expert With the Carbine, January 1945

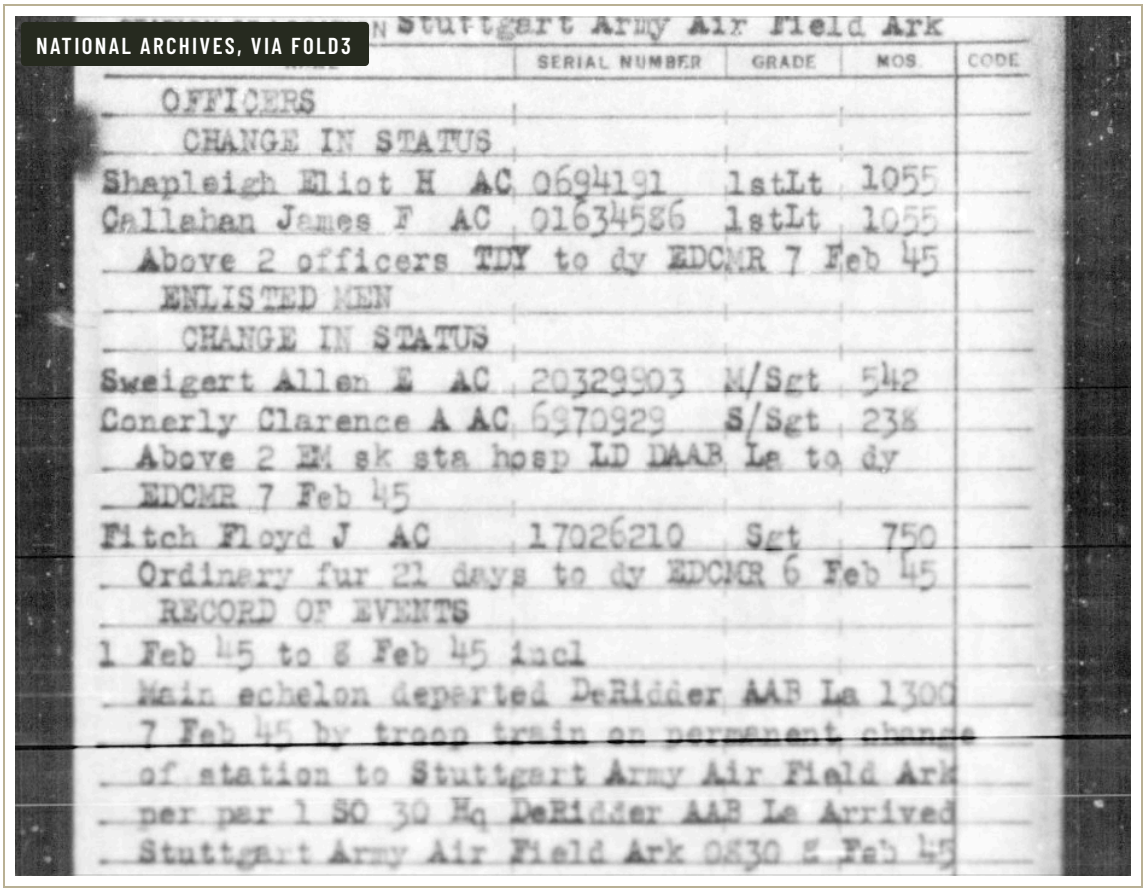
Paragraph 5 of Special Orders No. 6, issued by the 369th Fighter Group at DeRidder on 6 January 1945, announces the scores of four men of the 399th Fighter Squadron in record firing with the .30-calibre M1 carbine. The first line reads “M Sgt Allen B Sweigert”, score 171, proficiency Expert, the highest of the Army’s three grades. The typist got his middle initial wrong and the first digit of his serial number. The grade, the squadron and the rest of the number are his.

A large cross is drawn over the page. It runs through every paragraph on the sheet, and on the four microfilm copies Fold3 holds it falls a little differently each time, so it is no mark against his line. The order is a unit paper, kept with the group’s morning reports.

Source: Special Orders No. 6, Headquarters 369th Fighter Group, DeRidder Army Air Base, 6 January 1945, para. 5 (National Archives, Army morning reports, 1945, indexed as “Sweigert, Allen B”), via Fold3.



Morning report of the 399th Fighter Squadron, DeRidder Army Air Base, 9 January 1945, page 2 of 2. Page 1 lists Allen, typed "Sweigert Allan E", with four other men under "change in status". Five more names finish the list here, and the line beneath them gives the reason: "Above 10 EM dy to ordinary fur 21 dys", from duty to an ordinary furlough of twenty-one days. Credit: National Archives, Army morning reports, 1945, via Fold3.



Morning report of the 399th Fighter Squadron, Stuttgart Army Air Field, 8 February 1945. Under Enlisted Men, "Sweigert Allen E", specialty 542, back to duty from the DeRidder station hospital with effect from 7 February; his serial is typed with a 3 where the last digit should be 5. Below, the record of events: the main echelon left DeRidder by troop train at 1300 on the 7th. Credit: National Archives, Army morning reports, 1945, via Fold3.

The Hospital and the Train, in the Squadron's Own Reports

The 399th Fighter Squadron's morning reports for early 1945 survive on microfilm, and they name him. The report of 9 January lists him with nine other enlisted men under "change in status", and its second page gives the reason: "Above 10 EM dy to ordinary fur 21 dys", from duty to an ordinary furlough of twenty-one days. The day it began is not typed against their names, and the report does not say where he went. Allen speaks of a leave from DeRidder in the answer that begins at 04:50: soon after he joined the squadron he got "vacation time real quick" and went home, and Catherine came back with him.

The report of 31 January returns him and nine others from furlough to duty, and further down its second page moves him from duty to "sick in station hospital, line of duty". The Army's hospital admission file has a card for that stay: admitted in Louisiana in January 1945, diagnosis "Malaria, vivax (tertian)", entered as a disease, not a traumatism, and discharged to duty from a station hospital in February. Fold3 carries the card as an index entry only, so the hospital's name and the length of the stay are not on it.

The report for 8 February gives the rest. He and a staff sergeant named Conerly came off the sick list and back to duty with effect from 7 February. The same page records that the main echelon of the squadron left DeRidder by troop train at one o'clock that afternoon and reached Stuttgart Army Air Field the next morning. He remembered the outfit leaving the day before he got out, and a night at the hotel in DeRidder before he and Catherine took the train. The report puts his return to duty on the day the train left, and it says nothing about how he travelled.

Sources: morning reports, 399th Fighter Squadron, 9 January 1945 (pp. 1–2), 31 January 1945 (pp. 1–2) and 8 February 1945 (National Archives, Army morning reports, 1945); US, WWII Hospital Admission Card Files, 1942–1954, Sweigert, Allen E, admitted January 1945 (National Archives, Record Group 112); both via Fold3.

Allen, animated, telling the story of getting home.

"People who are doing that for years, and then somebody's going to get a crash course in it. That's not fair at all."

ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

“I said, I'm going to get the hell out of here.”

ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

“I come in as a master sergeant, and the guy that was in charge was a tech sergeant. So immediately I outranked him. And it wasn't too friendly.”

ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

“She was stuck down there in the hotel, what should have been a nice vacation time.”

ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

A

ALLEN 10:13

That's with a bunch of guys there at, uh, and at Stuttgart. Uh, it was, it was nice. It was, but I, I wound up in the hospital again there with malaria. Hmm. Spent another weekend there. And then in June, June or, yeah, either May, May the 30th or, or in June, May, I guess it was in the, in the May or June, uh, uh, I got noticed that I was, was going to be discharged. Go to, go to Fort Dix to be discharged. I had a number of points of need and everything. And the night before I was to leave, I felt this coming on again. Malaria. Do you want to go to the hospital? I said, nope. I'm not going to the hospital, because then I'll be stuck here for another couple of weeks. I said, this way, I'm on my way home. I'm not going to stop. I'm going to... So I laid down. I got the fevers and the chills. It lasted about an hour and a half or so. The guy said, are you going up to Chau? I says, no, not now. I said, I'll get something later. I, she says, well, we're going, are we going to the movies? I said, I'm going to go with you. And they come back from Chau. They say, how do you feel? I says, oh, a lot, a lot better. I says, we'll go to the movies. So I did. I went to the movies that night. Next day, I'm on the train coming home. That's it. Got into Fort Dix. Spent, I guess, two or three days there. Finally got the papers all cleared. Had another interview. Do I want to reenlist? No, I don't think so.

“A number of points” — and Fort Dix

The points were the Adjusted Service Rating Score, the War Department’s attempt at an equitable order of discharge, announced on 10 May 1945, two days after the German surrender. A man earned one point for every month of service counted from 16 September 1940, a second point for every month of that service spent overseas, five points for each decoration or campaign participation star, and twelve points for each dependent child up to three; an enlisted man needed eighty-five to be considered for release.

Allen had entered federal service on 16 September 1940, the very day the clock began, had been overseas from January 1942 to the autumn of 1944, and was credited with five campaigns — which on the published rule puts him comfortably above the threshold rather than near it. (That is arithmetic applied to the regulation and his campaign credits, not a figure copied from his papers; the score as actually computed would be in his separation records.) He was discharged at Fort Dix on 8 June 1945, four weeks after the system was announced — a place that would put more than 1.2 million soldiers back into civilian clothes before it was finished with the job. He turned down the reenlistment interview, and got on the train.

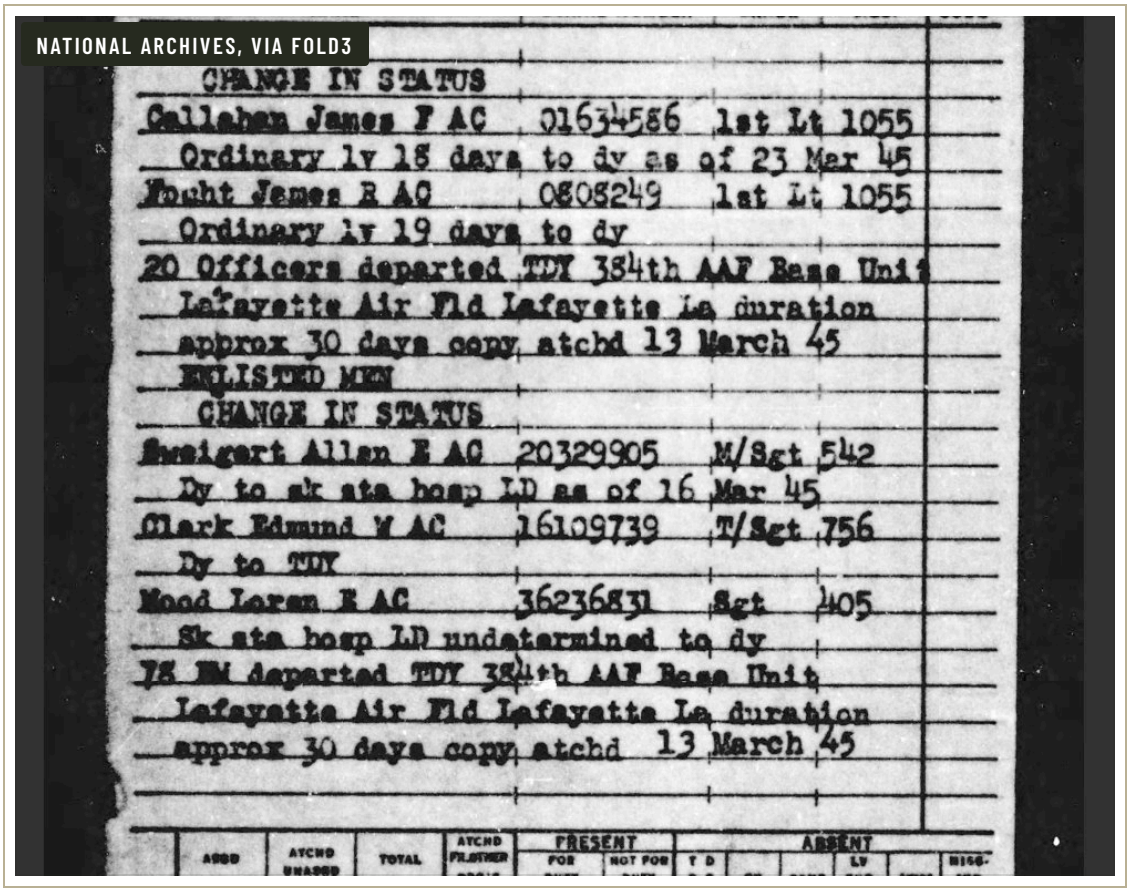
Sources: Adjusted Service Rating Score — Wikipedia; Demobilization of United States Armed Forces after World War II — Wikipedia; Fort Dix — GlobalSecurity.org; Fort Dix — Wikipedia.

Three More Attacks, and the One He Refused to Report

The attacks Allen suffered at DeRidder and Stuttgart were not new infections. Plasmodium vivax, the relapsing one of the two New Guinea malarias, leaves dormant parasites in the liver, and neither quinine nor Atabrine could reach them — the drugs suppressed the blood stages only, so relapses typically began about four weeks after a man stopped taking them. Among Allied soldiers with up to a year's exposure, more than 80 per cent relapsed; in one series of 328 Pacific veterans followed in Minnesota after their suppressive drugs were withdrawn, a quarter of the relapse histories ended within the first year, 53 per cent ran on through the second, and 18 per cent were still going in the third, with a few men relapsing out to four years.

No radical cure existed during the war — primaquine came afterwards — and the Army designated general hospitals in the States as centres for tropical disease, among them Harmon General at Longview, Texas, which also ran a laboratory for imported malaria studies. That is the context for the hardest detail in Part 2: the night before he was to leave for Fort Dix, Allen felt an attack coming and said nothing. The Army had announced its 85-point discharge score on 10 May 1945 and he had the points; a fever reported to the orderly room would have cost him his place in the queue, so he lay down, took the fevers and the chills for an hour and a half, and went to the pictures.

Sources: Plasmodium vivax Relapse Rates in Allied Soldiers during the Second World War: Importance of Hypnozoite Burden, American Journal of Tropical Medicine and Hygiene 107(6), 2022; Demobilization of United States Armed Forces after World War II (Adjusted Service Rating Score, announced 10 May 1945, critical score 85); Preventive Medicine in World War II, Vol. VI, Chapter X: Southwest Pacific Area; Harmon General Hospital, Handbook of Texas, Texas State Historical Association.



Morning report of the 399th Fighter Squadron, Stuttgart Army Air Field, 24 March 1945: "Sweigert Allen E", specialty 542, "Dy to sk sta hosp LD as of 16 Mar 45", from duty to sick in the station hospital, in line of duty. Credit: National Archives, Army morning reports, 1945, via Fold3.

The Second Stay, March 1945

He told the camera he was in the hospital again at Stuttgart and "spent another weekend there". The squadron's report of 24 March carries him from duty to the station hospital as of 16 March, a Friday, and the report of the 25th returns him to duty, so by the squadron's count the stay ran about nine days. A second card in the hospital admission file matches it: admitted in Arkansas in March 1945, "Malaria, vivax (tertian)" again, discharged to duty the same month.

No third card turns up for the end of May. His own story would lead you to expect that, since the attack he felt the night before he left for Fort Dix was the one he kept to himself.

Sources: morning reports, 399th Fighter Squadron, 24 and 25 March 1945 (National Archives, Army morning reports, 1945); US, WWII Hospital Admission Card Files, 1942–1954, Sweigert, Allen E, admitted March 1945 (National Archives, Record Group 112); both via Fold3.

The Point System

The “number of points” Allen mentions was the Adjusted Service Rating Score, announced May 10, 1945, two days after Germany's surrender: one point per month of service, one more per month served overseas, five points per battle star or decoration, and twelve points per dependent child (to a maximum of three). Eighty-five points was the initial threshold for discharge eligibility, later lowered to as few as fifty as the Pacific War wound down. Troops called it simply “the point system.”

Source: The National WWII Museum, “The Points Were All That Mattered.”

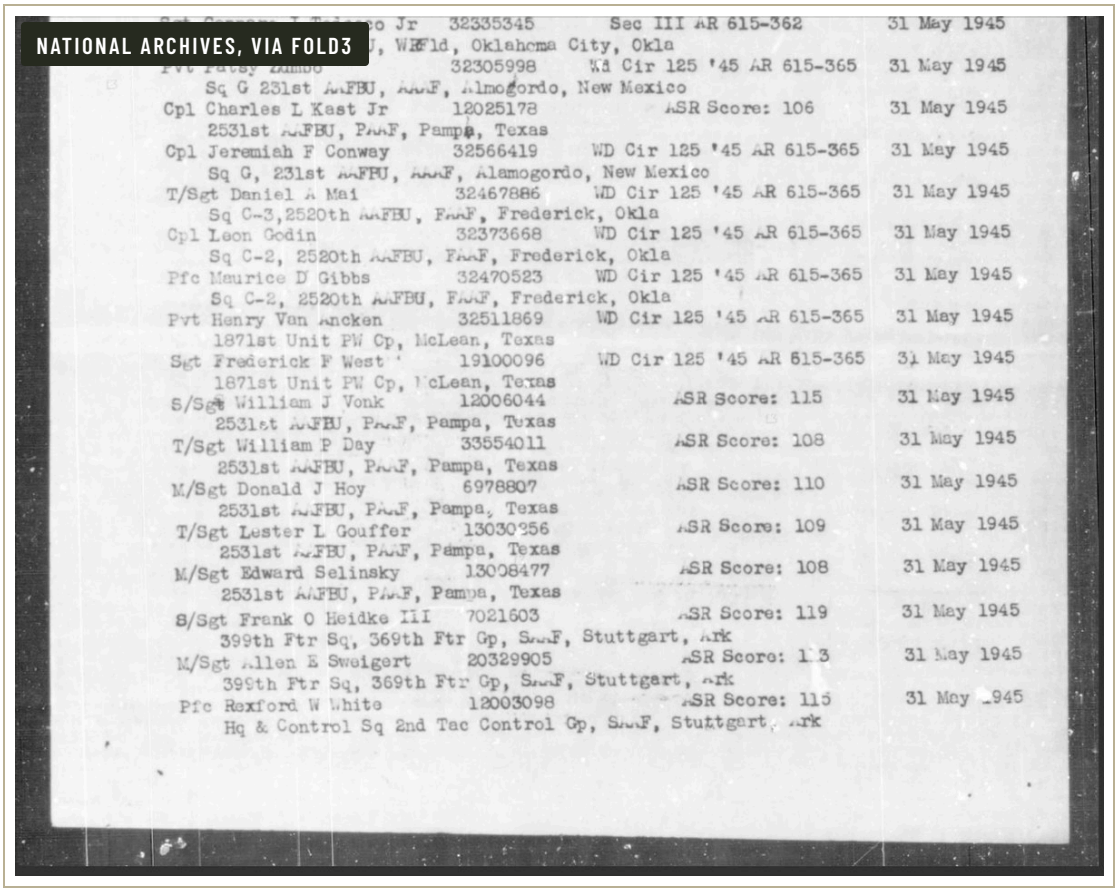
His Score, and the Papers That Took Him to Fort Dix

The sidebars above could only do the arithmetic. The score itself has since turned up, on the shipping list that sent him east: "M/Sgt Allen E Sweigert 20329905, ASR Score: 1_3", the middle digit smudged on the microfilm. The likeliest reading is 113. Worked from the published rule, his months of service from 16 September 1940, his months overseas and his five campaign stars come to within a point or two of that, so the reading is probably right. Whatever the smudged digit is, he was well past the 85 he needed.

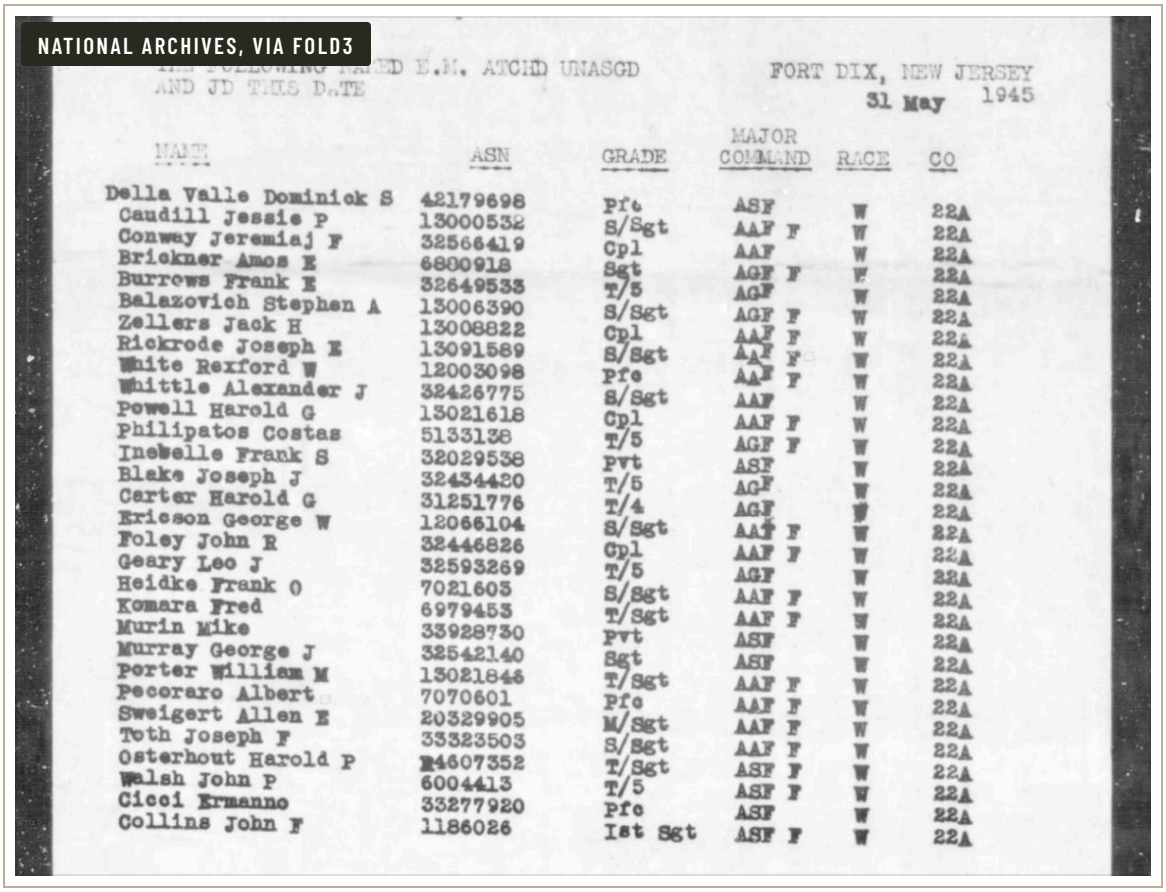
The other papers fill in his last fortnight. On 28 May he and eight other men from Stuttgart were attached to the station complement at Camp Joseph T. Robinson, near Little Rock, "pending consolidation of shipment" to Fort Dix, on the same day his service book closes the 399th. The squadron's report for 31 May records him relieved and transferred to the separation center at Fort Dix under Special Orders No. 136 of Headquarters Stuttgart Army Air Field, on the authority of a headquarters message of 11 May and AR 615-365, the regulation printed on his discharge. Shipping List No. 9 is dated the same day. So is Roster 10 at Fort Dix, which takes him on, attached and unassigned, in Company 22A of the separation center.

He remembered two or three days at Fort Dix. The papers carry him there from 31 May to 8 June, though none says when the train pulled in. A separation-center roster filed with the report of 6 June lists him again in Company 22A, above a printed timetable for his last two days. It is faint, and not every line can be read with confidence: orientation in Chapel 8 at ten on 7 June and counselling at two; on 8 June a physical in the morning, signing of papers at two, final pay at half past three, a final talk at ten past four and transportation at a quarter to five. The last line is read from a second copy of the same roster, filed as inclosure no. 1; he is line 521 on both.

Sources: morning report (continuation), Enlisted Detachment, 1861st Service Command Unit, Camp Joseph T. Robinson, Arkansas, 28 May 1945; morning report, 399th Fighter Squadron, 31 May 1945; Shipping List No. 9, destination Fort Dix, 31 May 1945; Roster 10, Separation Center, Fort Dix, 31 May 1945; roster and schedule, Separation Center, Fort Dix, inclosure no. 3 to the morning report of 6 June 1945, p. 13 (indexed as "Weigert, Allen S"), and a second copy, inclosure no. 1, p. 9, line 521 (indexed as "Weigert, Allen"). All National Archives, Army morning reports, 1945, via Fold3.



Shipping List No. 9, for discharge, destination Fort Dix, 31 May 1945: "M/Sgt Allen E Sweigert 20329905 ASR Score: 1_3", 399th Fighter Squadron, 369th Fighter Group, Stuttgart. The middle digit of the score is smudged on the film; 113 is the likeliest reading. Credit: National Archives, Army morning reports, 1945, via Fold3.



Roster 10, Separation Center, Fort Dix, New Jersey, 31 May 1945: the men "attached unassigned and joined this date", among them "Sweigert Allen E", 20329905, master sergeant, Army Air Forces, Company 22A. Frank O. Heidke, who left Stuttgart with him, is on the same list. Credit: National Archives, Army morning reports, 1945, via Fold3.

The Squadron He Had Left, May 1945

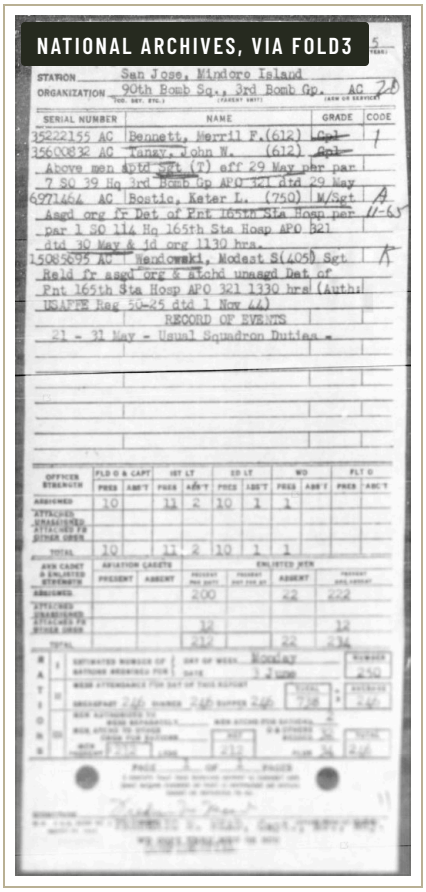
Allen's foreign service had ended on 29 September 1944, and the 90th Bomb Squadron's reports for May 1945 do not name him. The reports for 8 to 31 May survive on reel 777 of the Army's morning reports for 1945, one for every day, with lists of "Officers and others messed" and three squadron orders filed among them. Every report is headed San Jose, Mindoro Island. The orders are signed by Major Samuel M. Frederick, commanding, and the daily reports by the squadron adjutant, Captain Frederic M. Mead.

The report for 8 May, V-E Day in Europe, has a single entry: a first lieutenant attached from group headquarters for duty, quarters and rations. Neither it nor any later report that month mentions the war in Europe, and none reports a man killed or missing.

On 8 May the squadron had thirty-eight officers and 232 enlisted men, twenty of the men absent; on 31 May it had thirty-five and 222, twenty-two of them absent. On 10 May two officers and six men left for the 345th Bomb Group. On the 11th three sergeants went to the rotation detachment at Base K, APO 72, as the rotation parties in Part 1 had since March, and one more man followed on the 23rd. From 17 May eight men were relieved from the squadron and attached to the detachment of patients at the 165th Station Hospital, a captain among them; two came back before the month was out. The report of 16 May makes a staff sergeant, Delmar W. Haskin, a technical sergeant. The specialty number typed beside his name is 542, communications chief, the number on Allen's discharge.

On 28 May, when the papers above place Allen at Camp Robinson waiting on shipment to Fort Dix, the 90th's report sent Captain Donald Macomber to the hospital and took back Staff Sergeant John C. Laughlin, eleven days after he went in. On 31 May, the date of Shipping List No. 9 and of Roster 10 at Fort Dix, the report from San Jose made two corporals sergeants. Its record of events for 21 to 31 May reads "Usual Squadron Duties", the same words as the records for 1 to 10 May and 11 to 20 May.

Sources: morning reports, 90th Bomb Squadron, 3rd Bomb Group, San Jose, Mindoro Island, 8 to 31 May 1945, with the lists of officers messed and Squadron Orders 12, 13 and 14 filed with them (US, Morning Reports, 1945, reel 777, pp. 29834–29883; National Archives, Army morning reports, 1945), via Fold3; Enlisted Record and Report of Separation, 8 June 1945, for specialty 542.



Morning report of the 90th Bomb Squadron, 3rd Bomb Group, San Jose, Mindoro Island, 31 May 1945, the date of Allen's Shipping List No. 9. Two corporals are made sergeant, one man comes back from the 165th Station Hospital's detachment of patients and another goes into it; the record of events for 21 to 31 May reads "Usual Squadron Duties". Allen is not named. US, Morning Reports, 1945, reel 777, p. 29882. Credit: National Archives, Army morning reports, 1945, via Fold3.

> *"I'm not going to the hospital, because then I'll be stuck here for another couple of weeks. I'm on my way home. I'm not going to stop."*
>
> ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

A **ALLEN** 12:08

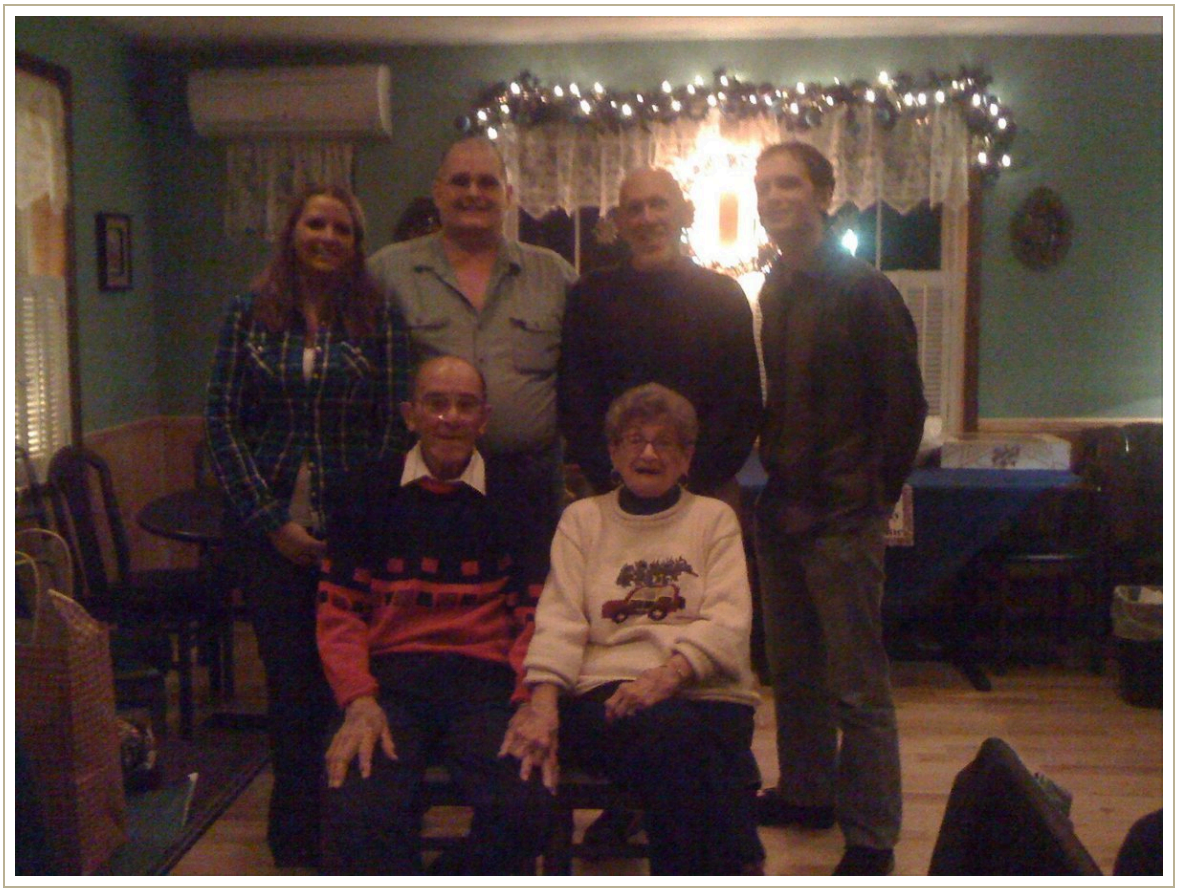
And just, all I need now is just that final wrap-up of, you know, after everything, you know. Okay. You went on, built your house, had two children. Oh, man. And, and at that time, what was that, Zalcoa now, was some, they were processing *all material that was brought back from the war zones and everything, and getting everything. redistributed through there. And I got a job over there. I worked over there for two or three weeks. And then I went to Chicago to a radio and electric school. And when I got out of there, I worked for a radio man, a radio distributor in Chicago for a while. And then I come home to start up my own business and radio repair in Persona. And for a while,* and then went to work at Alcoa. Worked at Alcoa for about 30 years until the plant shut down. In the meantime, two sons, one grandson and one granddaughter. We are a fine group.

"Worked at Alcoa for about 30 years until the plant shut down."

ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

"In the meantime, two sons, one grandson and one granddaughter. We are a fine group."

ALLEN E. SWEIGERT



The fine group itself, gathered for the holidays, December 2011 — Allen and Catherine with their sons, John and Allen Jr., and grandchildren Jeremy and Jessica. The last time the whole family got a photo together.

J **JEREMY** 13:33

And anything else you want to add? Anything at all? If not, that's fine.

"You just can't help but sort of relive a lot of your things that you did."

ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

A **ALLEN** 13:44

No, you just can't help but sort of relive a lot of your things that you did. Lots and lots of good memories in the 80-some years. Good.

"Lots and lots of good memories in the 80-some years."

ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

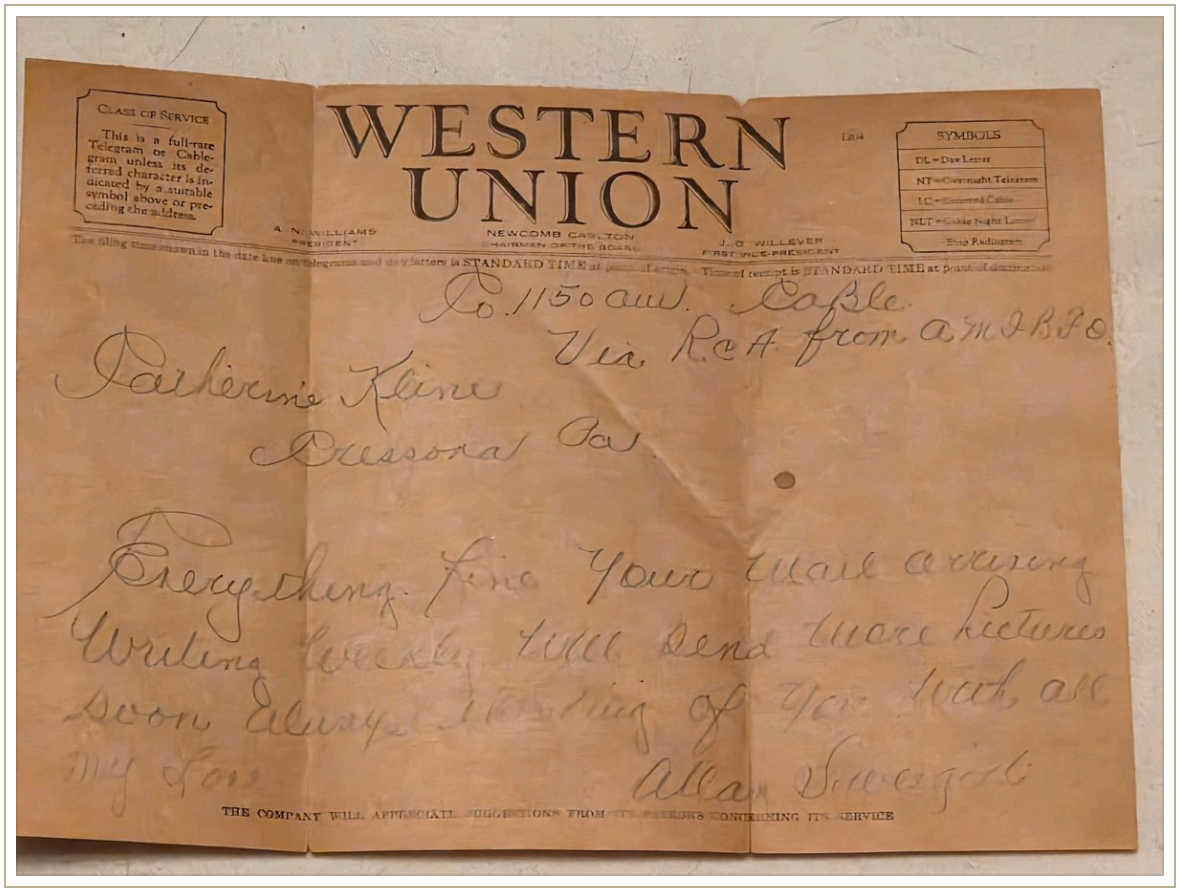
CHAPTER FIVE

The Home Front

Family, Courtship, and Life After the War

Dear Catherine

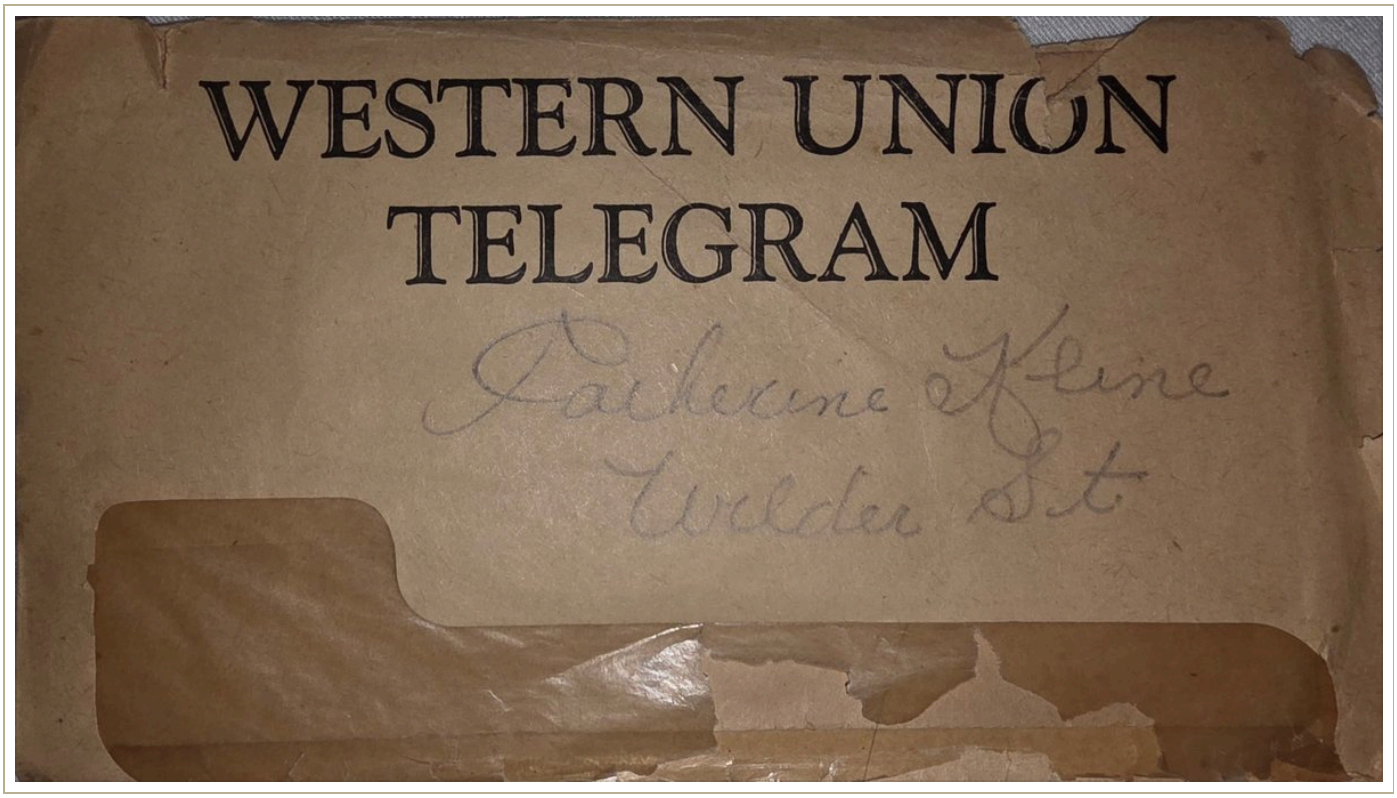
Through nearly three years overseas, Allen and Catherine — not yet married, still Catherine Kline of Cressona — kept in touch by mail and, when a letter was too slow, by cable. This telegram, sent via RCA from his Army Post Office overseas, is one that survives.



Western Union cablegram, Allan Sweigert to Catherine Kline, Cressona, Pa., sent via RCA from his overseas Army Post Office.

“Everything fine. Your mail arriving. Writing weekly. Will send more pictures soon. Always thinking of you, with all my love.”

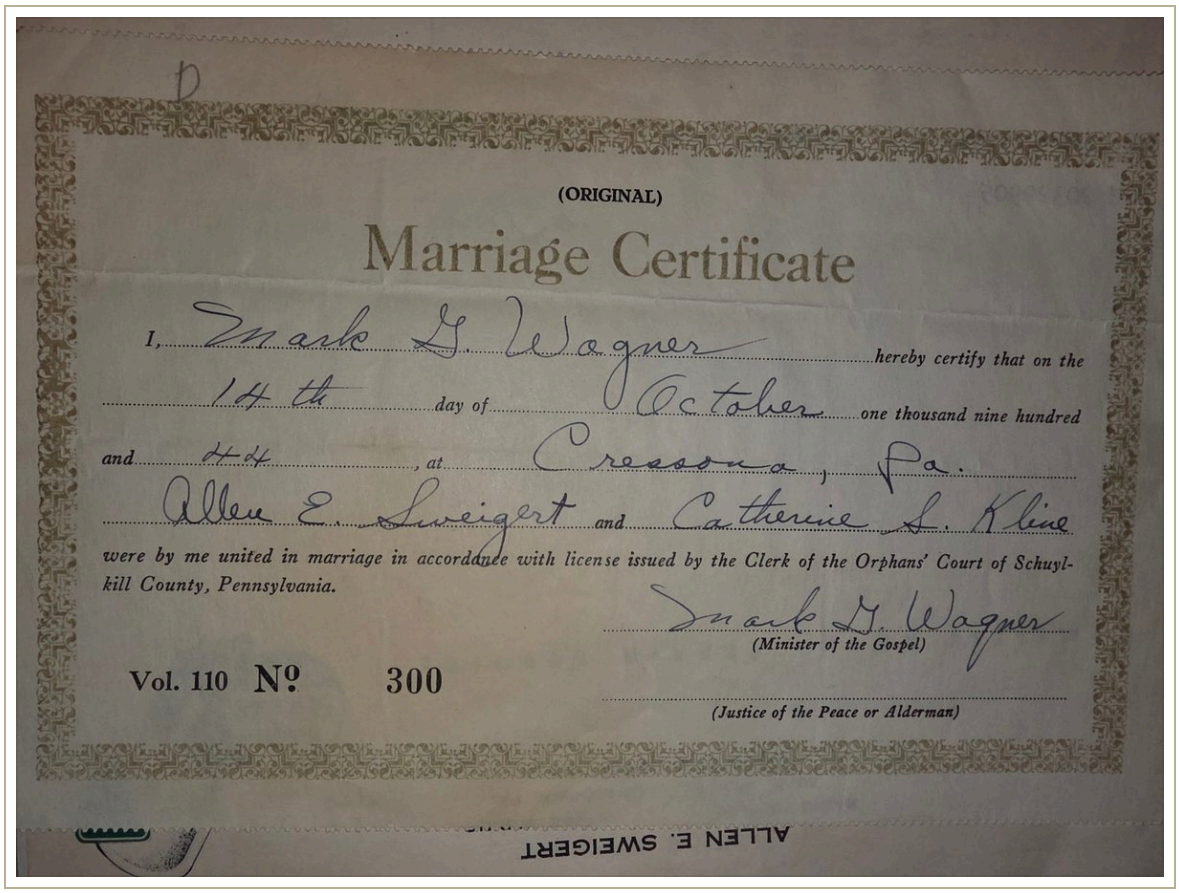
ALLAN SWEIGERT, TELEGRAM TO CATHERINE



The telegram's delivery envelope, addressed to Catherine Kline, Cressona, Pa.

They married on October 14, 1944, a week after Allen came home. The Rev. Mark G. Wagner officiated, on a license issued by the Clerk of the Orphans' Court of Schuylkill County.

Allen and Catherine, their wedding portrait — his master sergeant's chevrons still on his sleeve, her veil and corsage just visible.



(ORIGINAL)

Marriage Certificate

I, Mark H. Wagner hereby certify that on the 14th day of October one thousand nine hundred and 44, at Cressona, Pa. Allen E. Sweigert and Catherine S. Kline were by me united in marriage in accordance with license issued by the Clerk of the Orphans' Court of Schuylkill County, Pennsylvania.

Mark H. Wagner
(Minister of the Gospel)

Vol. 110 No. 300

(Justice of the Peace or Alderman)

ALLEN E. SWEIGERT

Allen E. Sweigert and Catherine S. Kline's original marriage certificate, October 14, 1944, Cressona, Pa.

COMMONWEALTH OF PENNSYLVANIA • DEPARTMENT OF HEALTH
VITAL RECORDS
Certification of Birth

DATE OF BIRTH 12-21-19 (MO. DAY. YEAR)
FILE NO 201993-19
DATE FILED 1-8-20 (MO. DAY. YEAR)
COUNTY OF BIRTH SCHUYLKILL
DATE ISSUED 12-20-85 (MO. DAY. YEAR)

SUBJECT CATHERINE SARAH KLINE
SEX FEMALE
FATHER EARL AMBROSE KLINE
MOTHER SARAH MARION REIGER

This is to certify that this is a true copy of the record which is on file in the Pennsylvania Department of Health, in accordance with Act 66, P.L. 304, approved by the General Assembly, June 29, 1953.

Charles Hardester
CHARLES HARDESTER
STATE REGISTRAR

H105. 105 (Rev. 10-83)

COMMONWEALTH OF PENNSYLVANIA ★ DEPARTMENT OF HEALTH ★

WARNING: IT IS ILLEGAL TO DUPLICATE THIS COPY BY PHOTOSTAT OR PHOTOGRAPH.

Catherine's own certification of birth: Catherine Sarah Kline, born December 21, 1919, Schuylkill County, to Earl Ambrose Kline and Sarah Marion Reiger.

Allen and Catherine, decades later, at one of Catherine's birthdays — still together.

Before and After

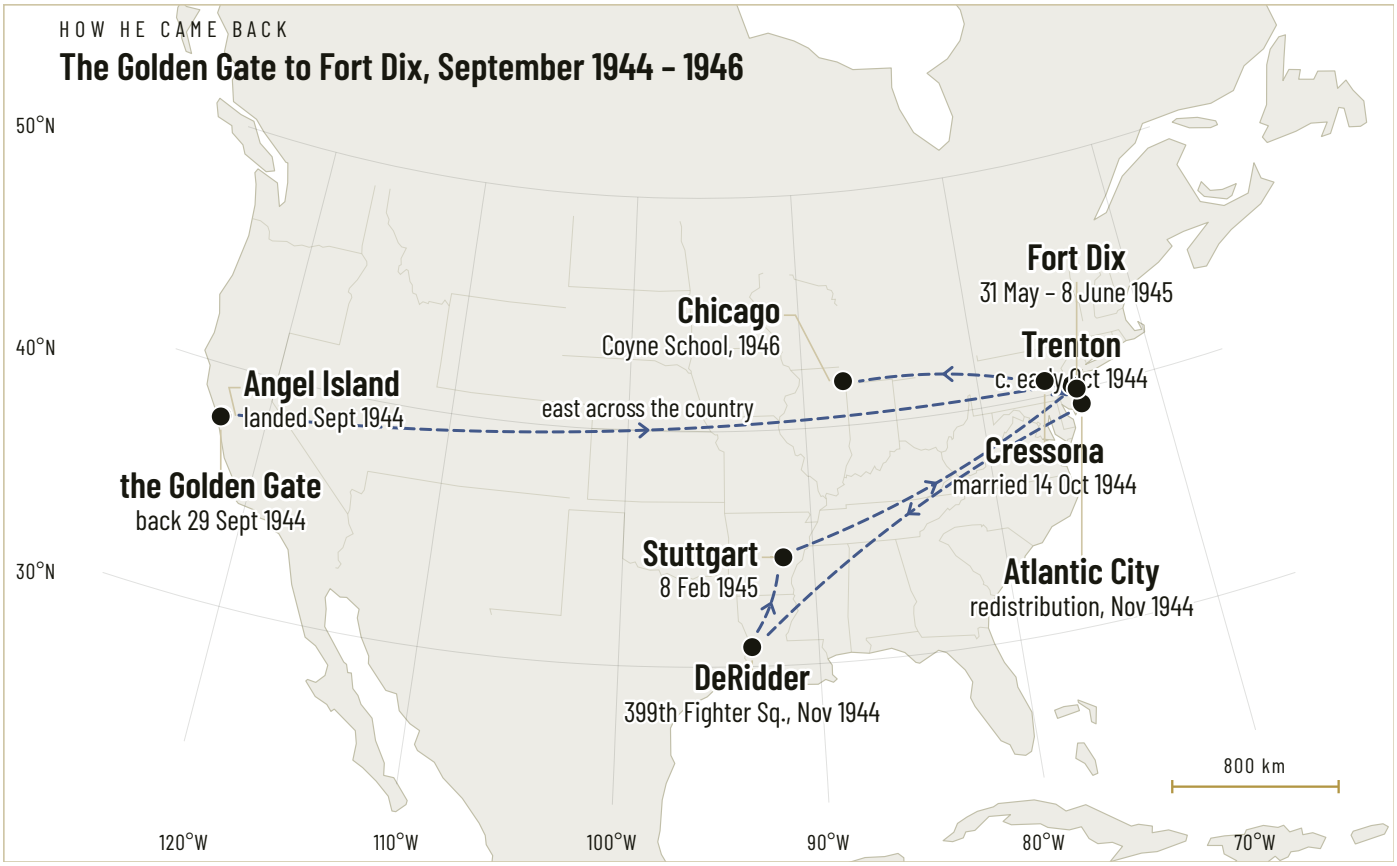
Atlantic City, Named in Print

The redistribution station has rested on his own memory. The Pottsville Republican of Tuesday 7 November 1944 puts it in print, with the station's own designation, five weeks after he landed:

"M/Sgt. Allen E. Sweigert, son of Mr. and Mrs. Earl J. Sweigert, Railroad st., Cressona, has reported to the AAF Redistribution Station No. 1, Atlantic City, N. J., after thirty-two months of service overseas in the Asiatic-Pacific theatre of war. Sgt. Sweigert served as a communications technician on a B-25 Mitchell, A-20 Havoc, while overseas."

Three things come out of four sentences. The station has a number, No. 1, which no other source here gives. The thirty-two months appear for the third time, from a third direction — his discharge paper, his wedding notice and now a news item, none of them copying another. And the aircraft are named: a B-25 Mitchell and an A-20 Havoc, the two types the 90th Squadron flew, which is the nearest thing in the collection to a statement of what he actually worked on.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 7 November 1944, p. 9.



How he came back: the Golden Gate to Fort Dix, September 1944 – 1946. His way home, drawn here for the first time.

▼ THIS DRAWING, SET OUT IN WORDS

- Angel Island in San Francisco Bay, where he landed in late September 1944. His foreign service ends on the 29th.
- East across the country to Trenton, and home to Cressona, where he married Catherine on 14 October 1944.
- Atlantic City, the redistribution station, in November.
- DeRidder, Louisiana, with the 399th Fighter Squadron from 16 November 1944.
- Stuttgart, Arkansas, where the squadron's troop train arrived on 8 February 1945.
- Fort Dix, New Jersey, on the separation center's roll from 31 May 1945, where he was separated on 8 June.
- Chicago, for the Coyne Electrical School, in 1946.
- A filled disc marks a place he is documented to have been. An open square marks a place documented for his unit rather than for him. An open square with a diagonal tick marks his own squadron. A dashed circle marks a place that is inferred rather than recorded.
- A brass ring crossed by a bar marks a place he never stood on — a target, or somewhere his group went without him. Each carries the words HE WAS NOT THERE.

- A solid line is a journey whose means of travel is recorded. A dashed line is a move that is documented while the means is not. A dotted line rests on his own account alone.
- No drawing here works out a distance for you. His own "about 12,000 miles" already stands beside a measured 9,500 to 10,200, and a third figure, quietly arrived at, would only muddy the two that were honestly come by.

Unit Foreman, Electrical Department, January 1958

He was certified as an electrician in 1951, after a three-and-a-half-year apprenticeship, and he spent the rest of his working life as an electrical foreman, retiring in 1977. What the family's own papers never say is when he stopped being the one and became the other. A local paper does.

"Allen E. Sweigert, Cressona, has been named unit foreman in the electrical department at the Cressona Alcoa plant. He had been serving as temporary foreman." Title, department and month, in two sentences. The same four lines also carry the war, as his own town had it and owing nothing to his discharge paper: "He is a veteran of World War II, serving as master sergeant in communications with the Army Air Force. He served in New Guinea." It prints no suffix after his name, though Allen Jr. was then ten.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 31 January 1958, p. 16.

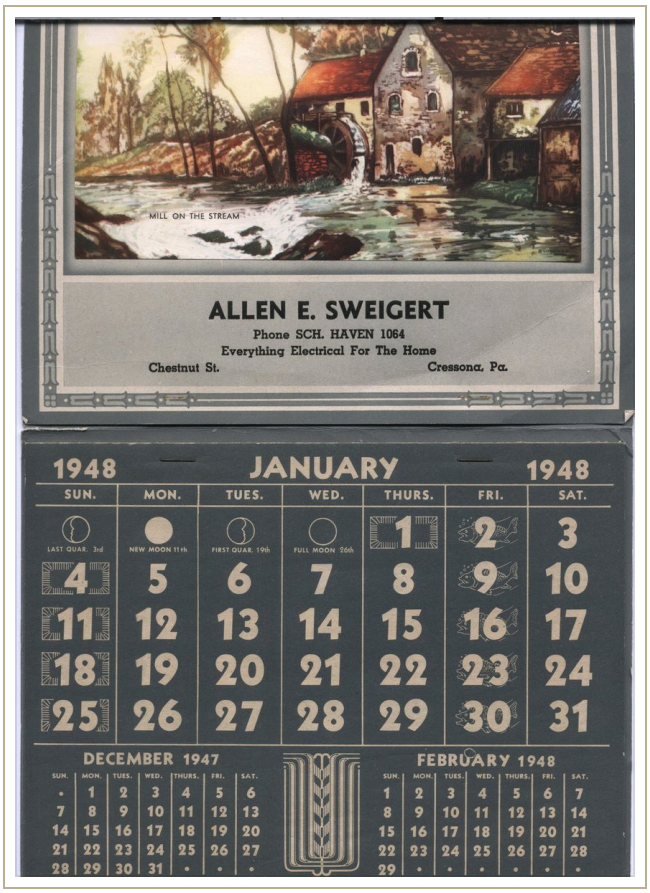
Cressona Man Named Foreman

Allen E. Sweigert, Cressona, has been named unit foreman in the electrical department at the Cressona Alcoa plant.

He had been serving as temporary foreman. He is a veteran of World War II, serving as master sergeant in communications with the Army Air Force. He served in New Guinea.

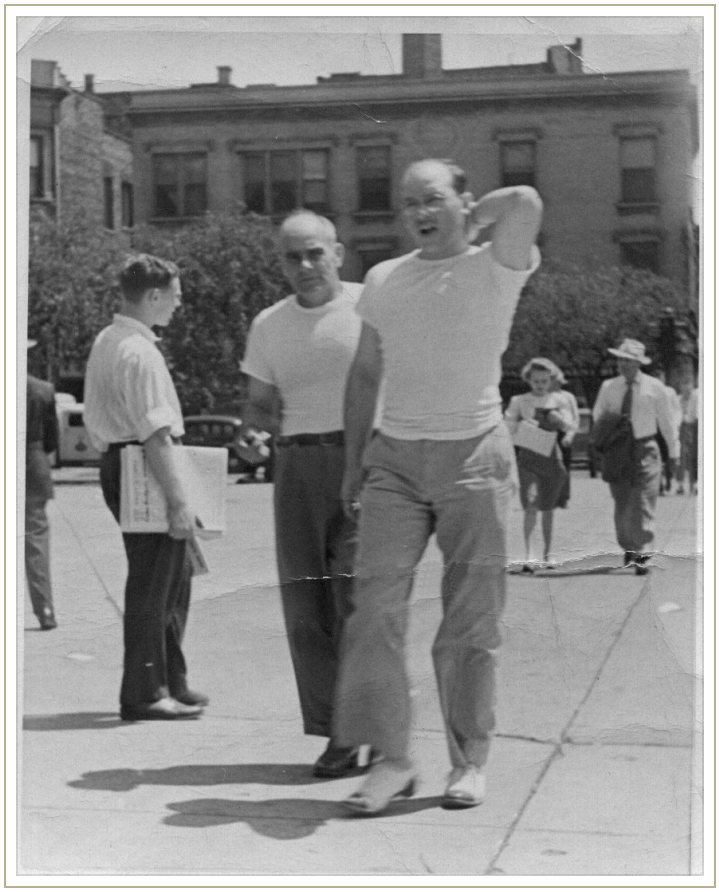
Pottsville Republican, Friday 31 January 1958. Four lines that put a date on the promotion. Credit: Pottsville Republican.

Radio operator training became a trade. After the war Allen finished Coyne Electrical School in Chicago, where his department grades were 91.3 in General Electricity and 94.5 in Radio-Electronics, and then came home and opened his own shop on Chestnut Street in Cressona, selling and repairing radios and electrical appliances. The rest of his working life went to Alcoa, where he was certified as an electrician in 1951 after the prescribed 3½-year course of training.

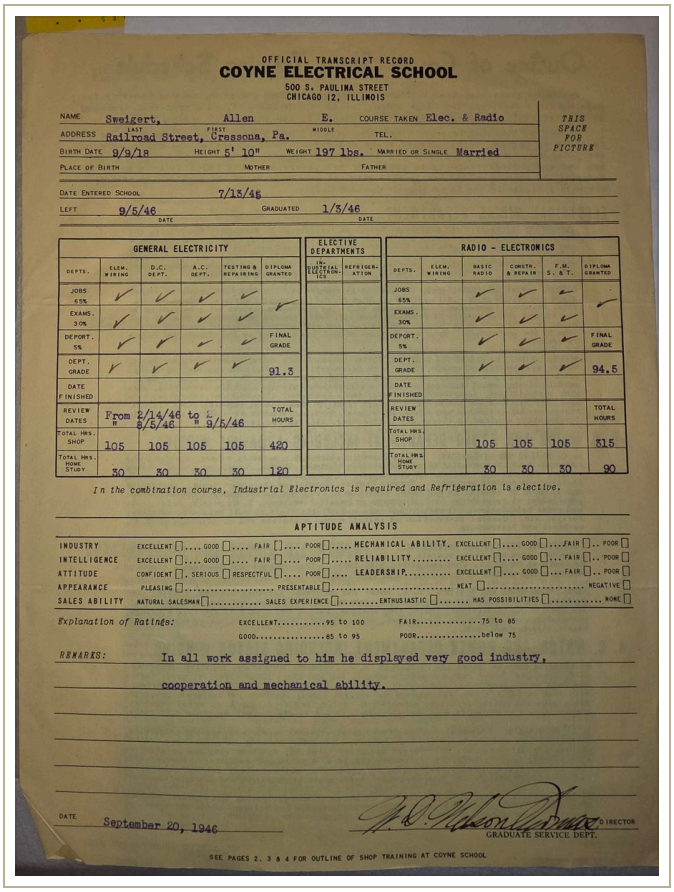


A 1948 advertising calendar for Allen's shop.

A second 1948 calendar: "Allen E. Sweigert, Radios - Electrical Appliances, Chestnut Street, Cressona, Pa."



Allen and his father, Earl J. Sweigert, on a Chicago street, 1945 — while Allen attended Coyne Electrical School.



OFFICIAL TRANSCRIPT RECORD

COYNE ELECTRICAL SCHOOL

500 S. PAULINA STREET
CHICAGO 12, ILLINOIS

NAME Sweigert, (LAST) Allen (FIRST) E. (MIDDLE) COURSE TAKEN Elec. & Radio

ADDRESS Railroad Street, Cressona, Pa. TEL.

BIRTH DATE 9/9/18 HEIGHT 5' 10" WEIGHT 197 lbs. MARRIED OR SINGLE Married

PLACE OF BIRTH (MOTHER) (FATHER)

THIS SPACE FOR PICTURE

DATE ENTERED SCHOOL 7/13/45

LEFT 9/5/46 (DATE) GRADUATED 1/3/46 (DATE)

GENERAL ELECTRICITY

DEPTS.	ELEM. WIRING	D.C. DEPT.	A.C. DEPT.	TESTING & REPAIRING	DIPLOMA GRANTED
JOBS 65%	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
EXAMS. 30%	✓	✓	✓	✓	
DEPORT. 5%	✓	✓	✓	✓	FINAL GRADE
DEPT. GRADE	✓	✓	✓	✓	91.5
DATE FINISHED					
REVIEW DATES	From 2/14/46 to 9/5/46				TOTAL HOURS
TOTAL HRS. SHOP	105	105	105	105	420
TOTAL HRS. HOME STUDY	30	30	30	30	120

ELECTIVE DEPARTMENTS

(No. ELECTRONICS)	REFRIGERATION

RADIO - ELECTRONICS

DEPTS.	ELEM. WIRING	BASIC RADIO	CONSTR. & REPAIR	F.M. S. & T.	DIPLOMA GRANTED
JOBS 65%		✓	✓	✓	✓
EXAMS. 30%		✓	✓	✓	
DEPORT. 5%		✓	✓	✓	FINAL GRADE
DEPT. GRADE		✓	✓	✓	94.5
DATE FINISHED					
REVIEW DATES					TOTAL HOURS
TOTAL HRS. SHOP		105	105	105	315
TOTAL HRS. HOME STUDY		30	30	30	90

In the combination course, Industrial Electronics is required and Refrigeration is elective.

APTITUDE ANALYSIS

INDUSTRY	EXCELLENT ☐ .... GOOD ☐ .... FAIR ☐ .... POOR ☐	MECHANICAL ABILITY.	EXCELLENT ☐ .... GOOD ☐ ... FAIR ☐ .. POOR ☐
INTELLIGENCE	EXCELLENT ☐ .... GOOD ☐ .... FAIR ☐ .... POOR ☐	RELIABILITY.....	EXCELLENT ☐ .... GOOD ☐ ... FAIR ☐ .. POOR ☐
ATTITUDE	CONFIDENT ☐ . SERIOUS ☐ RESPECTFUL ☐ .... POOR ☐	LEADERSHIP.....	EXCELLENT ☐ .... GOOD ☐ ... FAIR ☐ .. POOR ☐
APPEARANCE	PLEASING ☐ ..... PRESENTABLE ☐	NEAT ☐	NEGATIVE ☐
SALES ABILITY	NATURAL SALESMAN ☐ ..... SALES EXPERIENCE ☐	ENTHUSIASTIC ☐	HAS POSSIBILITIES ☐ ..... NONE ☐

Explanation of Ratings:

EXCELLENT.....95 to 100 FAIR.....75 to 85
GOOD.....85 to 95 POOR.....below 75

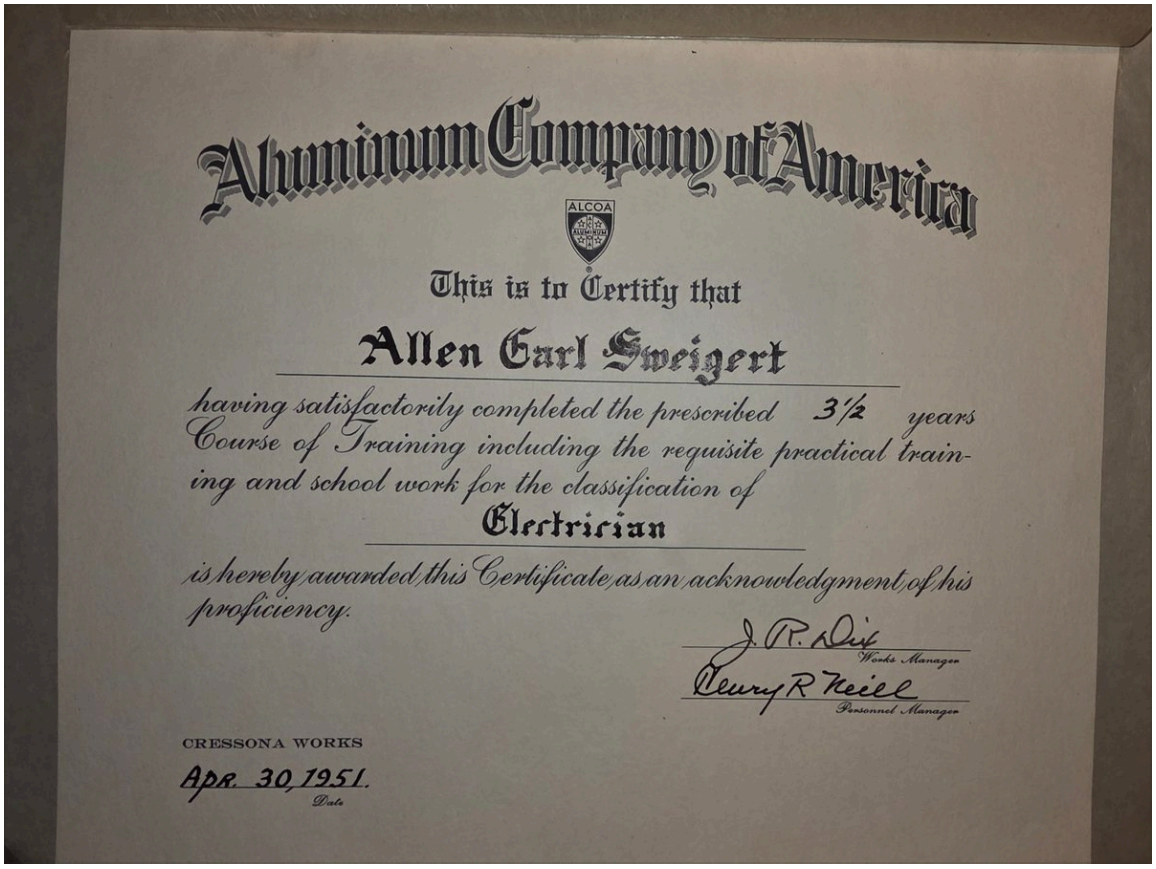
REMARKS: In all work assigned to him he displayed very good industry, cooperation and mechanical ability.

DATE September 20, 1946

DIRECTOR
GRADUATE SERVICE DEPT.

SEE PAGES 2, 3 & 4 FOR OUTLINE OF SHOP TRAINING AT COYNE SCHOOL

His official Coyne Electrical School transcript, Chicago — graduated January 1946; instructor's remark: "In all work assigned to him he displayed very good industry, cooperation and mechanical ability."



Aluminum Company of America

ALCOA

This is to Certify that

Allen Earl Sweigert

having satisfactorily completed the prescribed 3½ years Course of Training including the requisite practical training and school work for the classification of

Electrician

is hereby awarded this Certificate as an acknowledgment of his proficiency.

J. R. Dick
Works Manager

Henry R Neill
Personnel Manager

CRESSONA WORKS

Apr. 30, 1951.
Date

His Alcoa electrician's certificate, Cressona Works, April 30, 1951.

ADEQUATE WIRING CERTIFICATE

This is to Certify that the home located at

19 CHARLES ST., CRESSONA, PA.

has an adequate and flexible wiring installation designed for Electric Living which assures a full measure of Convenience, Comfort and Economy. This wiring installation provides for:

- Present and future electrical needs.
- Expansion at minimum cost.
- Full efficiency from lighting and appliances.
- Maximum flexibility in the use of portable lamps and appliances.

This certificate is evidence that those responsible for the design and construction of this home have complied with the Electrical Industry Standard of Residential Wiring Design, as approved by The National Adequate Wiring Bureau.

ADEQUATE WIRING Certified

This certificate is not issued in lieu of, or supplementary to, any required municipal, state or underwriters inspection certificate or wiring affidavit.

Certifying Authority: Central Eastern Pa. Adequate Wiring Bureau (A non-profit organization)

City: Allentown State: Pa.

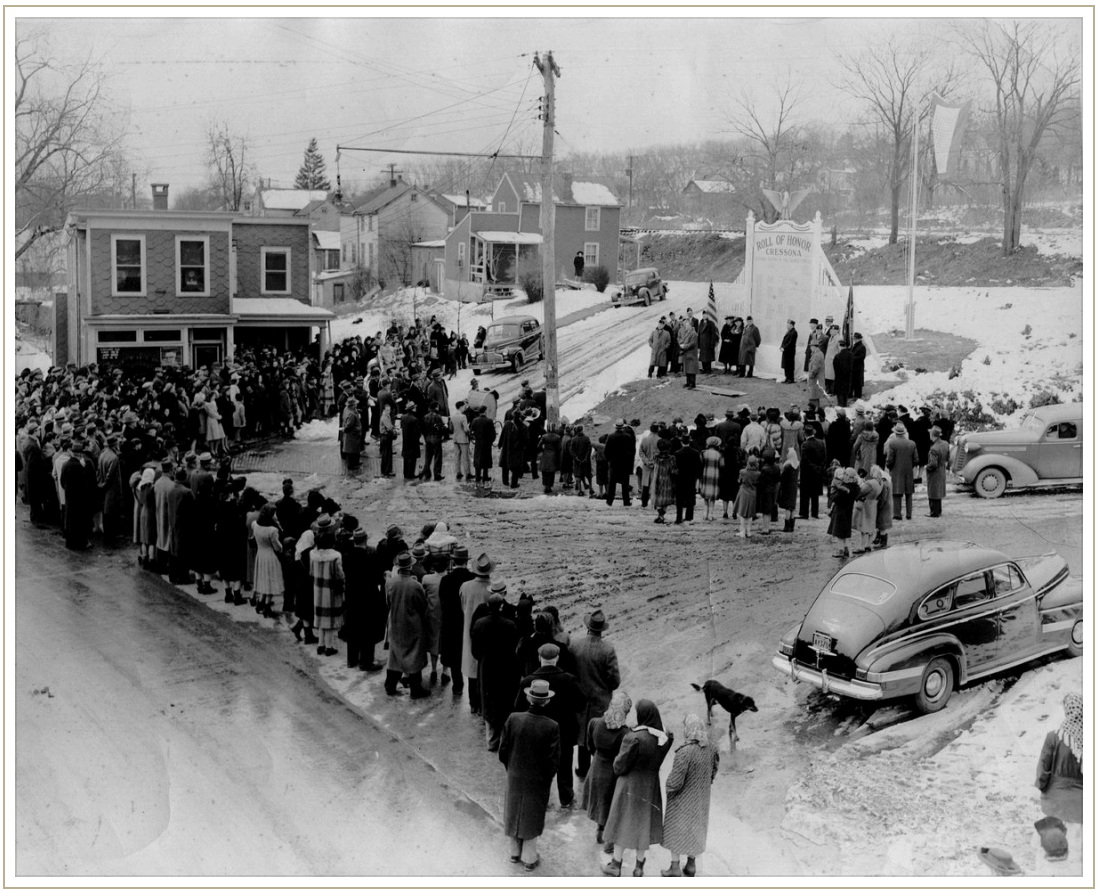
Built by: Father and Son

Wiring installed by: Mr. Allen Sweigert

Certificate Number: SCH-119 Date: February 6, 1957

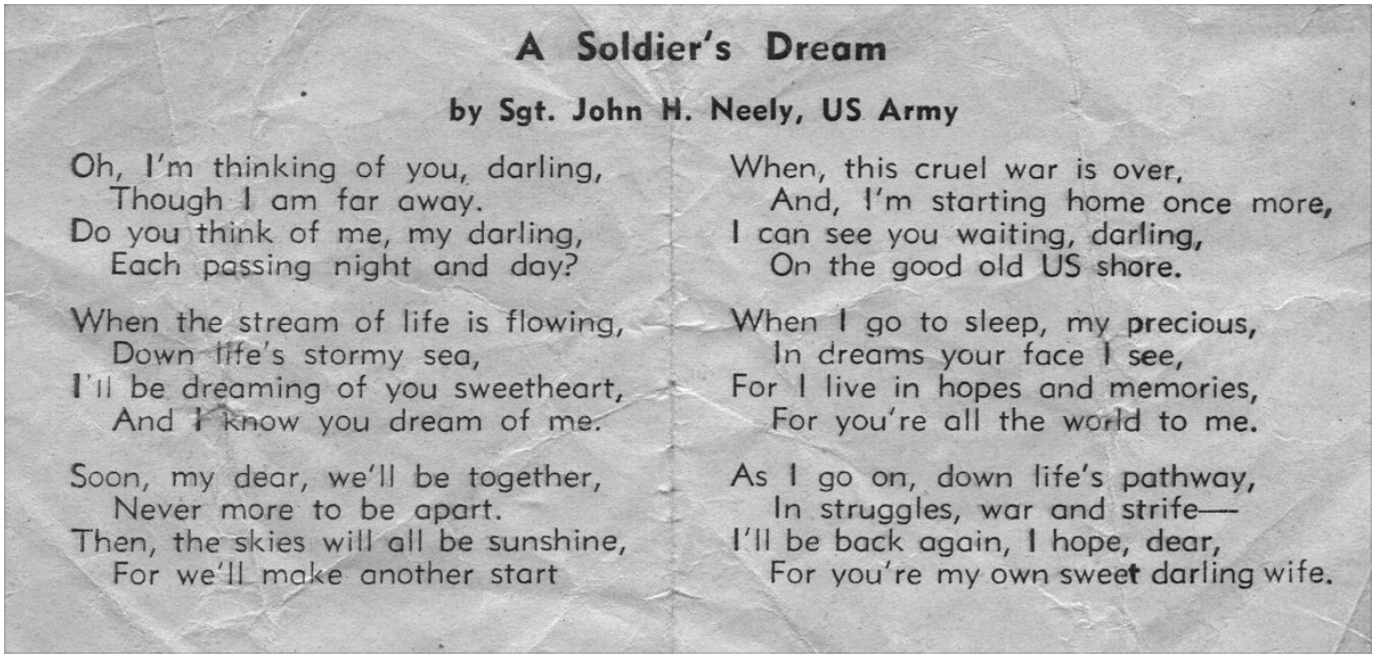
G. E. Solley SECRETARY

An Adequate Wiring Certificate for the Sweigert home on Charles Street, Cressona, 1957 — built by "Father and Son," wiring installed by Mr. Allen Sweigert himself.



The 1943 dedication of the Roll of Honor, Cressona, Pennsylvania, honoring residents serving in the armed forces.

Program for the Cressona Welcome Home Celebration, November 16, 1946, "dedicated to those who served during World War II."



A Soldier's Dream

by Sgt. John H. Neely, US Army

Oh, I'm thinking of you, darling,
Though I am far away.
Do you think of me, my darling,
Each passing night and day?

When the stream of life is flowing,
Down life's stormy sea,
I'll be dreaming of you sweetheart,
And I know you dream of me.

Soon, my dear, we'll be together,
Never more to be apart.
Then, the skies will all be sunshine,
For we'll make another start

When, this cruel war is over,
And, I'm starting home once more,
I can see you waiting, darling,
On the good old US shore.

When I go to sleep, my precious,
In dreams your face I see,
For I live in hopes and memories,
For you're all the world to me.

As I go on, down life's pathway,
In struggles, war and strife—
I'll be back again, I hope, dear,
For you're my own sweet darling wife.

"A Soldier's Dream," by Sgt. John H. Neely, U.S. Army — a wartime keepsake kept among Allen's things.

Courtship, College, and Home

Catherine Graduates from Kutztown, May 1941

She has been in this document as the girl who waited on the tables in 1935 and the young woman at the hot-dog roast in 1939. Here she is on her own account, on the front page of her own county's weekly. The Call of Friday 23 May 1941, under the heading WILL GRADUATE AT KUTZTOWN: "Misses Betty Fitzpatrick and Jean B. Reber, Roy A. Brown, alumni of Schuylkill Haven High School, and Miss Catherine Kline of Cressona, will graduate from Kutztown State Teachers' College on Monday, May 26. The commencement will take place in the new Nathan Schaeffer auditorium just completed this year."

Catherine Kline took a teaching degree, and she finished it on Monday 26 May 1941, at twenty-one. The hall was brand new that year; Kutztown's Schaeffer Auditorium still stands.

The timing is worth holding still for a moment. Six weeks before she walked into that auditorium, Allen had handed back his sergeant's stripes at Camp Stewart and enlisted in the Army Air Corps; by the following February he was on a ship for Australia. She spent the war years with a teaching qualification and he spent them in New Guinea, and they married a fortnight after he landed in San Francisco Bay.

Sources: The Call, Schuylkill Haven, 23 May 1941, p. 1; Pottsville Republican, 12 April 1941, p. 4.

A Doggie Roast on the Blue Mountain, June 1939

Allen put the start of it at "maybe 38, 39" and left it there. The Pottsville Republican of Thursday 15 June 1939 supplies a date, a place and eleven other names. Under the heading CRESSONA: "A group of young people from town held a doggie roast on the grounds of the Scout Camp on the Blue Mountain, Wednesday evening. Those in the party were: Miss Catherine Kline, Miss Hilda Bittle, Miss Marie Wagner, Miss Claire Wagner, Miss Arlys Yiech, Miss Claire Specht, Robert Seitz, Allen Sweigert, Charles Beck, George Strauch, George Buttler, Clark Rauch and Robert Dando."

Six young women and seven young men, on the Wednesday evening of 14 June 1939. She was nineteen and he was twenty. This is the second time a newspaper puts the two of them in one place — the first was the school banquet of May 1935, where he gave a talk and she waited on the tables — and the first time they are in the same small group rather than the same large room.

It does not say they went together, and this page will not say so either. Thirteen young people at a hot-dog roast is a crowd and not a couple. What it does is put his own "38, 39" on firmer ground than a man's memory at eighty-seven, and it says where they were: up on the Blue Mountain at the Scout camp, on a summer evening five years and four months before they married.

The setting is worth a second look. Four months after this, the same paper has him running a Boy Scout troop in Cressona. The camp on the mountain was already his ground.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 15 June 1939, p. 17; Pottsville Republican, 26 October 1939, p. 2.

The Banquet, May 1935

The Pottsville Republican of Monday 27 May 1935 reported the Cressona High School junior-senior banquet at length, down to the menu: fruit cup, Irish potatoes, peas and lettuce, pickles, olives, celery, saltines, French rolls, nuts, mints, cake and ice cream. Three names in that report belong to this document.

Among those who gave short talks during the evening: **Allen Sweigert**, then in the junior class, sixteen years old.

Among the sophomore girls who served the tables: **Catherine Kline**.

And among the mothers who aided in preparing the menu: **Mrs. Earl Sweigert** — his own, Helen.

He told his grandson in 2006 that he thought he had started courting Catherine "maybe 38, 39." That is his own memory and it stands. What this adds is that they were in the same school hall on a May evening in 1935, he on his feet giving a talk and she carrying plates, nine and a half years before they married in St. Mark's. One more name in the serving list is worth marking: **Hilda Bittle**, who in October 1944 stood up with Catherine at that wedding in a blue silk street length dress.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 27 May 1935, p. 8; The Call, Schuylkill Haven, 20 October 1944, p. 4; his interview, 2006.

Pretty Wedding For Cressona Couple In St. Mark's Evang. & Ref. Church

Catherine Kline Becomes Bride Of Sgt. Allen Sweigert

The marriage of Miss Catherine Kline, daughter of Mr. and Mrs. Earl Kline, of Wilder St., Cressona, to M/Sgt. Allen Sweigert, son of Mr. and Mrs. Earl Sweigert, of Railroad St., Cressona took place on Saturday afternoon at two o'clock in St. Mark's Evangelical and Reformed Church. The ceremony was performed by the Rev. Mark Wagner.

Mrs. Clark Rauch, church organist, played the wedding marches and accompanied Miss Claire Speacht, the soloist, who sang several selections before the ceremony. Miss Hilda Bittle and Clark Rauch, both of Cressona, were the attendants.

The bride was dressed in a street length two-piece frock of fuschia silk with which she wore a blouse of white lace, black accessories and a white orchid corsage.

Miss Bittle wore a blue silk street length dress, black accessories and an orchid corsage.

Following a reception held in the social rom of the church, the couple left on a wedding trip.

Mrs. Sweigert was graduated from Cressona High School in 1937 and from Kutztown State Teachers' College in 1941. She is now a member of the faculty of Cressona High School.

M/Sgt. Sweigert was graduated from Cressona High School in 1936 and recently returned from New Guinea, having served overseas for 32 months.

MRS. ALLEN SWEIGERT

M/SGT. ALLEN SWEIGERT

The Call, Schuylkill Haven, Friday 20 October 1944, page 4. The wedding was the Saturday before — 14 October, at two o'clock, in St. Mark's Evangelical and Reformed Church, the Rev. Mark Wagner officiating. Credit: The Call, Schuylkill Haven.

MRS. ALLEN SWEIGERT. Catherine, as the paper captioned her six days after the wedding.

M/SGT. ALLEN SWEIGERT. Twenty-six, a master sergeant, three weeks home from New Guinea after thirty-two months overseas.

The Notice, and the Two Portraits

This is the best photograph of Allen in the collection and the earliest picture of Catherine as a married woman. The paper set them one above the other in the right-hand column and captioned them MRS. ALLEN SWEIGERT and M/SGT. ALLEN SWEIGERT.

The notice also settles two things from outside the family's own papers. It gives his rank as master sergeant in October 1944, which is the grade on his discharge eight months later, and it says he had "recently returned from New Guinea, having served overseas for 32 months" — a figure that matches, to the rounding, the 31 months and 29 days his own discharge paper carries and the 32 months the Commonwealth of Pennsylvania computed when it paid his compensation in 1950. Three documents, three different purposes, six years apart, one number.

Sources: The Call, Schuylkill Haven, 20 October 1944, p. 4 (Newspapers.com image 302604466); Enlisted Record and Report of Separation, 8 June 1945; Pennsylvania WWII Veterans' Compensation application, April 1950.

Her Side of the Notice

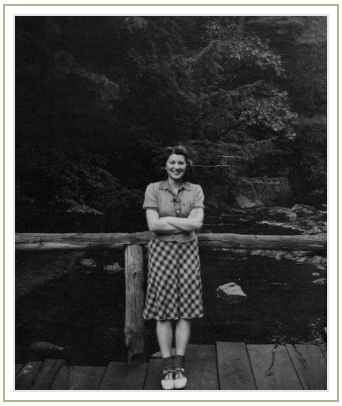
The notice is as much a record of Catherine as of Allen. It names her parents as Mr. and Mrs. Earl Kline of Wilder Street, Cressona — her father's name and the family's street, set down by a stranger rather than by the family. It has her out of Cressona High School in 1937 and through Kutztown State Teachers' College in 1941, which is exactly what she says herself on her own tape in 2013. And in October 1944 it places her on the faculty of Cressona High School.

The detail the paper thought worth printing is the dress: a street-length two-piece frock of fuschia silk, a blouse of white lace, black accessories, a white orchid corsage. Her attendant Miss Hilda Bittle wore blue silk. Mrs. Clark Rauch played the organ, Miss Claire Speacht sang, and Clark Rauch stood with Miss Bittle as the attendants. The reception was in the social room of the church, after which "the couple left on a wedding trip."

Sources: The Call, Schuylkill Haven, 20 October 1944, p. 4; home-front.html, Catherine's own interview, 2013.

Catherine at Kutztown State Teachers College, and the family before and after the war.

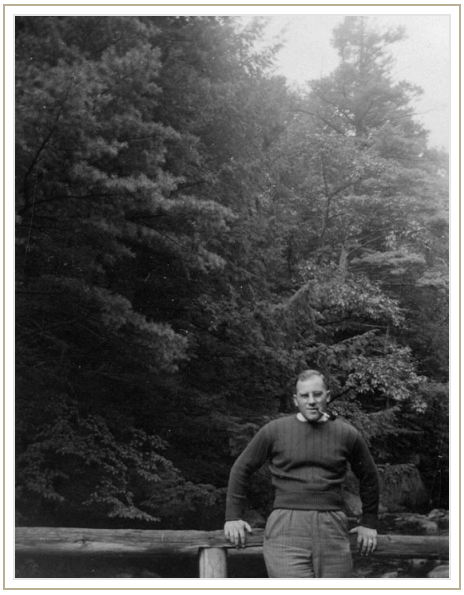
Allen and Catherine dating, before the war — she crosses a woodland stream on stepping stones.



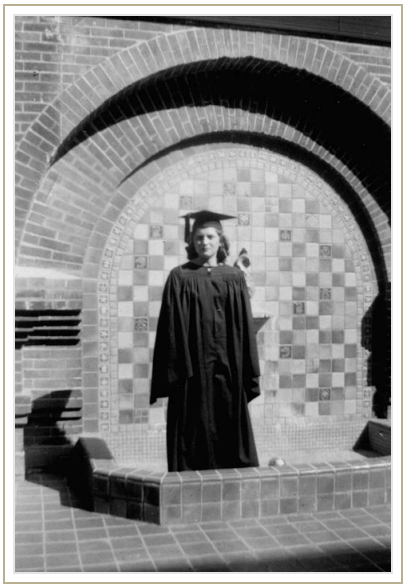
Catherine leans on a footbridge railing — Allen and Catherine dating, before the war.

Catherine poses playfully on a boulder in the woods, the same outing.

Allen and Catherine, arm in arm, both smiling broadly.



Allen leans on a wooden bridge railing, smoking a pipe — the same courtship-era outing.



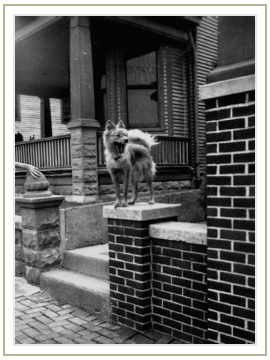
Catherine in cap and gown at her Kutztown State Teachers College graduation, 26 May 1941.

Catherine and friends beside a sign: "Kutztown State Teachers College, Class of 1938."

Catherine and college friends pose around a lion's-head fountain on campus.

Catherine swings a bat playing ball with friends in a wooded park.

A 1930s sedan parked on a street of Victorian rowhouses.



The family dog barks from atop a brick porch pier.

Coyne, Chicago, 1946 LIKELY

The "radio and electric school" in Chicago was Coyne — spelled with an e, where the family's records have "Coyn." Coyne began in Chicago in 1899 as a branch of the Coyne Electrical School of Boston, started advertising radio classes in 1922, and from 1925 to 1929 even owned a Chicago radio station, until the head of its radio division decided a school had no business running one. By the 1940s its radio instruction was its strongest suit, and Allen's year there falls right in the middle of it: the school's own Coyne Electronical and Radio Troubleshooting Manual and the Coyne Radioman's Handbook both carry 1946 imprints, the year he finished. His own transcript, shown above, gives his graduation as January 1946, which puts the course itself across 1945.

He was formalising a trade he already had — Scott Field had taught him the Army's version of it, and eight airstrips from Charters Towers to Hollandia had taught him the rest. The family says he went on the GI Bill, which is what thousands of veterans did at schools like Coyne; his enrolment record has never been seen, so that part rests on family memory. He finished, worked for a Chicago radio distributor for a while, and then took the trade home to Cressona and opened his own shop.

Sources: Coyne College — Wikipedia; Coyne American Institute: A 100-year-old training gem — ACHR News; Coyne Electronical and Radio Troubleshooting Manual (Coyne Electrical School), 1946 — Internet Archive; Coyne Radioman's Handbook, 1946 (World Radio History).

“Somewhere on Oceania”

An Army Post Office number was a deliberate blank. It let a soldier be reached by mail while telling nobody — not the enemy, not his mother — where he actually was, and Allen understood exactly how the trick worked from the inside: he knew the place the number stood for, and he could not write it down. Read against the Army Postal Service’s own register, the eight numbers he later copied into his service record book turn out to be a route, in order: 501 for the theatre headquarters in Australia, 922 for Townsville, 710 for Charters Towers, 929 for Port Moresby, 503 for Oro Bay, the port that supplied the Dobodura strips, 713 for Lae, downriver from the Markham Valley fields, and 565 for Hollandia.

Several name the mailing point rather than the airfield, but each one serves a stretch of the 3rd Bombardment Group’s advance, and no register date contradicts the group’s own. Even the order of them tells you something: 922 comes before 710 because the Townsville post office opened on 18 March 1942, eight days after the group reached Charters Towers, while no post office was established at Charters Towers itself until 17 September 1942. The first number on his list, 1106, is the only one that will not decode.

Sources: Numerical Listing of APO’s, January 1942 – November 1947, Army Postal Service and Strength Accounting Branches, Adjutant-General’s Office (1949); WWII Army Post Office (APO) Locations — searchable transcription of the 1949 AGO listing; 3rd Bombardment Group station list, HistoryOfWar.org; APO-locations.csv — structured transcription of the 1949 AGO numerical listing (4,948 rows), armypostoffices.org.

They built the plant on the fairground

The factory Allen would spend his working life in stands on the ground where Schuylkill County used to hold its fair. The Cressona fairgrounds were big enough that local boosters claimed them in 1931 as the largest by area in the United States, with the fastest horse track east of the Mississippi. The Depression and the loss of the trolley service finished the fair; the last one of that era ran in October 1941.

The tract went at sheriff's sale and passed, by the fair association's account, through a Pottsville bank and a private buyer before it was taken in 1942 for the federal defence programme. The government put up the works there that year and handed it to Alcoa to operate; from the spring of 1943 the Cressona Works was extruding wing spars, aluminium tubing and artillery shell casings, and at its peak it employed 2,800 Schuylkill County people, a great many of them women. Allen was in the South West Pacific through all of it — while he was servicing radios in B-25s, the fairground of his boyhood was being turned into a plant that made parts for aeroplanes like them.

Sources: Ron Devlin, "Workers at Cressona defense plant played a vital role in WWII," Pottsville Republican Herald, 31 August 2025; "Schuylkill County Fair marks '40 Years of Growing the Future'" — history of the Cressona fairgrounds, the 1941 final fair and the sale to the Federal Defense Corp.; History of the Schuylkill County Fair (Schuylkill County Fair Association); Hydro Extrusions Cressona, PA — current operator of the 1942 site.

Sorting what came back

One thing Allen says about coming home can be checked against the record, and it is exactly right. He describes taking a job at the Cressona plant just after his discharge, when it was "processing all material that was brought back from the war zones" and redistributing it. The plant's own history agrees with him: from 1944 to 1946, a 2025 Republican Herald account of the wartime works records, the government-owned Cressona Works was run as a reclamation depot, before Alcoa resumed extrusion work in peacetime. Allen came home in the autumn of 1944, was discharged at Fort Dix on 8 June 1945 and left for Coyne Electrical School in Chicago in 1946, so the two or three weeks he describes fall squarely inside the depot period. A man who had spent thirty-one months in the South West Pacific came home and spent a fortnight sorting through the salvage of the theatre he had just left.

Sources: Ron Devlin, "Workers at Cressona defense plant played a vital role in WWII," Pottsville Republican Herald, 31 August 2025 — "From 1944 to 1946, the Cressona Works was used as a reclamation depot operated by the federal government".

Twenty-Five Years at the Plant, January 1973

The plant kept its own count of him, and once it printed it. The Pottsville Republican of Saturday 3 February 1973, under **5 Alcoans Enter 25 Year Club**: "The following Cressona Works employes entered the 25 Year Club during January: Raymond Carl, Schuylkill Haven; Bruce F. Hartman, Tamaqua; Leo J. Ney, Cressona; Samuel E. Beck, Pottsville; and **Allen E. Sweigert**, Cressona."

Each of the five then gets a paragraph of his own working life, and Allen's is the only account of his Alcoa career in anybody's words but his: "Allen Sweigert was hired as an engineering and maintenance electrical trainee. Al has been classified in engineering and maintenance hourly and salaried positions. At the present time, he is a mill maintenance shift foreman, the post he assumed on **April 1, 1969**."

Three things come out of that. The company called him Al. The word for how he started is *trainee*, which is what the apprenticeship certificate of 1951 describes from the other side. And the note above this one has him named unit foreman in the electrical department in January 1958; this one has him a mill maintenance shift foreman from 1 April 1969. Two foreman's posts eleven years apart, neither of which the family papers record.

The month is worth something too. Twenty-five years counted back from January 1973 puts his service date at about January 1948. The apprenticeship certificate, counted back three and a half years from 30 April 1951, puts the start of his training at about the end of October 1947. The two are roughly ten weeks apart and this document does not merge them: a company's service date and a trainee's first day are not obliged to be the same thing, and neither figure is exact.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 3 February 1973, p. 8; Pottsville Republican, 31 January 1958, p. 16; Alcoa apprenticeship certificate, Cressona Works, 30 April 1951.

Thirty years, and then the plant shut down

Allen says he ran his own radio shop in Cressona "for a while" and then went to Alcoa for about thirty years, "until the plant shut down." He had the end of it right: Alcoa operated the Cressona Works until 1977, which puts his hire somewhere around 1947 or 1948 and makes his own arithmetic sound. The site did not stay dark — it reopened in 1979 as the Cressona Aluminum Company, and since 2017 has been run by Norsk Hydro as the largest aluminium extrusion plant in North America. Some of the original wartime extrusion presses, built in Germany in the 1930s, were still standing in the building into the 2020s, which means the machines Allen worked around for three decades were the same ones installed to make aeroplane parts while he was overseas. His working life began and ended with that plant, and so did the war's physical presence in his home town.

Sources: Ron Devlin, "Workers at Cressona defense plant played a vital role in WWII," Pottsville Republican Herald, 31 August 2025 — Alcoa operated the plant until 1977; 1930s German-built presses still in place; Hydro Extrusions Cressona, PA — site history, 1979 Cressona Aluminum, 2017 Norsk Hydro; Hydro Cressona Expands with New Extrusion and Recycling Capacity, Light Metal Age; Hydro Cressona Expands with New Extrusion and Recycling Capacity — Light Metal Age ("the biggest aluminum extrusion plant in North America"; plant built 1942; two presses built 1938).

The roll of honor, 1943 LIKELY

The family archive holds a photograph of a roll-of-honor dedication in Cressona in 1943, and the object in it would have been familiar in every small American town that year. These were community-built boards — painted panels under an eagle and a flag, the names of the borough's serving men and women listed in columns — put up by fire companies, churches and Legion posts and unveiled with a parade, a band and a short address.

They were dedicated as the lists filled: one New York fire district, by its local historian's account, dedicated its board in June 1943 for ninety men; Hopewell Borough, New Jersey, chose 16 May 1943, "I Am An American Day"; Baraboo, Wisconsin, dedicated its own on 12 December 1943 with 1,370 names. Allen's account of running into a younger Cressona boy on the far side of the Pacific is the same fact from the other end — a borough of seventeen hundred people had men scattered from New Guinea to Arkansas, and the board on the square was how the town kept them all in one place. Nobody has yet turned up a printed account of the Cressona ceremony itself, so for now the family's photograph is the whole record of it.

Sources: "World War II: Honoring those in service was a way to raise morale on the home front," The Altamont Enterprise — Westmere honor-roll plaque dedicated June 1943, ninety men, first parade in the district's history; "Where are the Hopewell Valley WW II Honor Rolls?" Hopewell Valley History Project — dedication of 16 May 1943; World War II Honor Roll, Acton Historical Society — construction and appearance of a typical board; Baraboo Veterans Honor Roll — 1942 and 1943 dedications and name counts.

The One Thing He Was Expressly Forbidden To Do

Of everything the Army told a soldier to keep out of his letters, the one thing Allen actually did was the thing it warned about most sharply. War Department Pamphlet 21-1 instructed him plainly: "Don't attempt to formulate or use a code system, cipher, or shorthand, or any other means to conceal the true meaning of your letter," and added that violations of that rule "will result in severe punishment." The same pamphlet warned that trying to get a message out around the Army Postal Service — by civilian mail, or by handing it to someone travelling home — would bring severe disciplinary action against the sender and the go-between alike.

A salutation code was not a loophole in the censorship rules; it was the specific offence the rules anticipated, and the reason the Army anticipated it was that the trick was obvious to anyone who had thought about the problem for five minutes. Two honest qualifications belong here. The printed pamphlet is dated eighteen months after Allen sailed from San Francisco, so the wording above is not necessarily what his squadron was read at the port of embarkation in January 1942. And no record has been found of any American soldier being tried for arranging a private code with his family, so nobody can say what the punishment would have come to in practice.

Sources: Secrecy in Wartime: U.S. War Department Pamphlet No. 21-1 (29 July 1943), prohibition on codes and ciphers; 90th Attack Squadron (lineage and WWII stations: arrived Archerfield, Brisbane 25 February 1942).

He Was Not the Only One Who Thought of It LIKELY

Private arrangements of this kind were widespread enough that Australian researchers describe them as ordinary: “Many troops would devise codes etc to allow them to keep their family informed of their whereabouts,” Peter Dunn’s Australia @ War records, and he offers his own father, James Thomas “Jim” Dunn of the 42nd Battalion, who used a numbered code in his letters home to his mother in Rockhampton. At the more elaborate end, British prisoners of war ran genuine ciphers past German camp censors inside letters about the ordinary business of the camp; a code buried in the letters John Pryor, a young Royal Navy officer, sent home from Germany went unread for some seventy years, until historians at the University of Plymouth worked it out.

Allen’s version is worth keeping for how little machinery it needed. He did not hide anything in the body of the letter, where the censor was looking; he put the message in the greeting, a place a reader’s eye passes over on the way to the text, and he needed no key beyond a slip of paper his mother and his girl kept at home. No published example of this particular salutation trick has turned up anywhere else, so his account stands as a rare first-hand description of something historians believe was common and which, by its nature, left almost nothing behind.

Sources: Censors in Australia during WW2, Australia @ War (Peter Dunn); Secret code within WWII POW’s letters cracked 70 years later, CBS News.

V-Mail Caught Up With Him Overseas

Allen remembers V-mail as something that appeared after he was already in the theatre, and the dates bear him out: the service opened in June 1942, five months after he sailed, and ran until November 1945. And he had the reason for it exactly right. A letter written on the standard one-page form was censored by the unit officer, then photographed onto 16mm microfilm at a laboratory near a designated Army Post Office, flown as film, and printed back onto paper at about a quarter of the original size — a finished sheet some four and a quarter inches by five — so that thirty-seven sacks of ordinary letters collapsed into a single sack of film, at roughly sixteen hundred letters to a hundred-foot roll.

The cost was intimacy. The form held a single sheet with no enclosures, the reduced print was hard on the eyes, and many servicemen thought the glossy little photograph less than a real letter. More than a billion V-mails were processed before the war ended, yet ordinary first-class letters stayed far more popular with the families who wrote them: in 1944 a Navy man received something like six of them for every V-mail that reached him.

Sources: Mail Call: V-mail, The National WWII Museum; Victory Mail, Smithsonian National Postal Museum; Innovations of Postal Mail during World War II, Kentucky Historical Society; Wrap Securely, Address Correctly: Innovations of Postal Mail during World War II, Kentucky Historical Society (six regular letters per V-mail, 1944).

Why the Papers Came in a Pile and the Letters Came by Name

Allen had spotted something the Army arranged on purpose: his own letters were addressed to him and had to be collected personally, while the newspapers and magazines came off the truck in a heap with no names called. Most of that reading matter was never individually addressed in the first place.

Special overseas editions of popular magazines were printed small and light with the advertising stripped out and shipped in bulk to hospitals, headquarters and individual units through the Army's Special Services Division rather than through the mails; Time's "Pony Edition," Newsweek's "Battle Baby" — never for sale, and obtainable only if the Army or Navy handed it to your unit — and The New Yorker's "pee wee edition" all appeared in this form in 1943, and the Saturday Evening Post's sixty-four-page "Post Yarns" booklets followed in 1944, ten million copies given away in boxed libraries of thirty-six. Yank, the Army Weekly, written by enlisted men, reached a circulation above two and a half million across twenty-one editions, and the one that served his part of the war, the Down Under edition, began with its first number on 6 August 1943, while Allen was at Dobodura. So the heap on the ground with men picking through it was not the postal service failing; it was how free bulk periodicals were meant to arrive, and that is exactly why nobody called out a name over it.

Sources: Magazines, The Best-Read Army in the World: the Power of the Written Word in World War II, Grolier Club; Magazine Editions of Yank: the Army Weekly, Library of Congress Research Guides; Yank, the Army Weekly; 90th Attack Squadron — WWII stations (Dobodura, New Guinea, 21 May 1943 to 5 February 1944).

Catherine

Catherine sat for her own interview in 2013, recorded the same way as Allen's: a family member asking the questions, Catherine answering in her own words. Three passages from those recordings follow, chosen by the family.

Catherine, mid-story, 2013 interview.

Kutztown State Teachers College

CATHERINE 00:03

Yep. Hello, my name is Catherine Sarah Sweigert. My father's name was Earl Ambrose Kline, and my mother's name was Sarah Marion Reiger, and I was born on December the 21st, 1919, on Grove Street in Cressona, Pennsylvania. *I have one, I had one sister, who was Betty Ann, and she married Harold Straub. I married Allen Sweigert on October the 14th, 1944. We had two boys, Allen Jr. and John. Allen was the son of Earl Joshua Sweigert and Helen Fessler.*

JEREMY 01:01

A little bit about your schooling, and then your full-time job.

C **CATHERINE** 01:10

I went to, uh, Cressona schools, uh, graduated from Cressona High School in 1937. And that fall, I went to Kutztown State College, and I was there for four years and received my Bachelor of Science degree with... with, uh, a major in Library Science and in Social Studies and a minor in English. I, uh, taught at Port Carbon High School for one year after I graduated. Then I came to Cressona for three years, and then I got married, and I had children, two boys, uh, and I didn't go back to school to teach again. Uh, and I didn't go back to school to teach again. Gee, I don't remember what year it was, but I was at Schuylkill Haven for thirteen years. Schuylkill Haven High School, where I was a high school librarian. Ah, that's about all I can tell ya.

J ***JEREMY*** 02:25

All right. Um, what year did you graduate Kutztown?

C **CATHERINE** 02:30

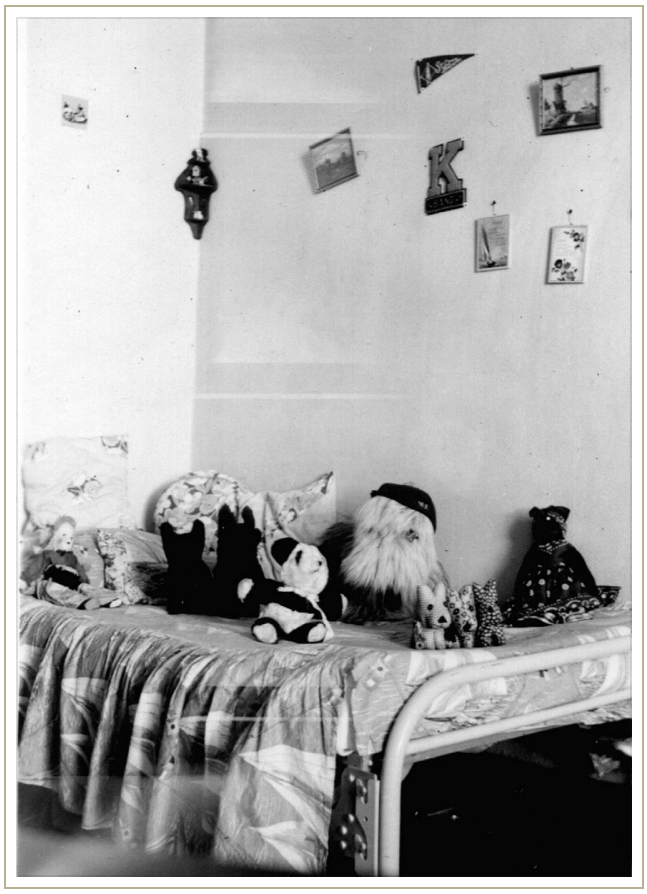
1941.

J ***JEREMY*** 02:33

Now, correct me if I'm wrong, but wasn't that pretty extraordinary at the time? What?

C **CATHERINE** 03:05

Well, I was pretty fortunate in being able to go. I made a lot of great friends there.



Catherine's dorm room at Kutztown.

Catherine, a formal portrait from her Kutztown years.

"I think the reason I lived this long was I was well taken care of, because I had a husband that was one of the best in the world. And he lived a long life, too, so I guess we got along well."

CATHERINE S. SWEIGERT

A Husband, A House, A Tree House

The House They Sold to Build This One

Catherine describes the house going up without dating it: “He built the house we’re in right now… One Thanksgiving, he was up putting the roof on this house.” Two Cressona addresses had come down with the papers — Railroad Street, his father’s, off the dog tags, and the Charles Street house of the 1957 wiring certificate, built by Father and Son. What paid for the second, nothing in them said.

The Pottsville Republican of 29 September 1955 gives the earlier address and the moment one house turned into the other. “The dwelling property of Mr. and Mrs. Allen E. Sweigert at 30 N. Fourth Street, Cressona, was purchased by Mr. and Mrs. George A. Head of R. D., Pottsville, Pa.” — and then: “The Sweigert family are planning to build a new home, construction of which will start in the immediate future.” The sale went through the office of Walter F. Mullen, local realtor, and Head was another Alcoa man. So the roof went on in the Thanksgiving of 1955 or 1956, and the Charles Street snapshots of raw earth and new concrete belong to those two years.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 29 September 1955, p. 26; Catherine S. Sweigert, interview, 2013.

BUYS CRESSONA PROPERTY

The dwelling property of Mr. and Mrs. Allen E. Sweigert at 30 N. Fourth Street, Cressona, was purchased by Mr. and Mrs. George A. Head of R. D., Pottsville, Pa.

Head is employed at the Alcoa Plant, Cressona. Mr. and Mrs. Head expect to move into their new home in the near future.

The Sweigert family are planning to build a new home, construction of which will start in the immediate future. Sweigert is also employed at the Alcoa Plant in Cressona.

The sale of the property was through the office of Walter F. Mullen, local realtor.

Pottsville Republican, Thursday 29 September 1955. The sale of 30 North Fourth Street — and, in the same paragraph, what it was for. Credit: Pottsville Republican.

J **JEREMY** 00:00

Okay, there's another question. This one might be mind-boggling, but what do you believe is the secret to your longevity?

C **CATHERINE** 00:11

Well, I really don't know, because at one time I smoked, and I'd take a drink once in a while, not often. You like your Yuengling Lager, I believe.

J **JEREMY** 00:20

Huh?

C **CATHERINE** 00:21

I think you like your Yuengling Lager. Yeah, I like that, a little bit. Not a lot. I'm not much of a beer drinker. I like scotch and soda better. Whew! That's heavy stuff. But, I tell you what, I think the reason I lived this long was I was well taken care of because I had a husband that was one of the best in the world. And he lived a long life, too, so I guess we got along well. Yes, we did. He built the house we're in right now. Yes, he built it. He sure did. One Thanksgiving, he was up putting the roof on this house. He and George Strach and Johnny Green.

C **CATHERINE** 01:17

And it was a Thanksgiving day, I remember.

J ***JEREMY*** 01:20

Let's not forget the second house he built. What was that? Oh, you don't remember?

C **CATHERINE** 01:26

He built a three-story house for his grandson. Oh, yes, he did. He built a tree house out back. Oh, that was a while. That was a wild time. That was a wild time.

J ***JEREMY*** 01:38

Let's see how many floors we can put on this baby.

C **CATHERINE** 01:41

It got pretty high. That was all right. No girls allowed. The word is a lud. Ay, ay, ay. Some of the best times we all had was when we went to the shore. Oh, yeah. We all liked the shore. Going to Wildwood.

Allen and Catherine with their grandchildren, 1986.

Advice to the Youth Today

Late in the second recording Jeremy put the questionnaire down and asked her something it did not cover: what a woman born in 1919, who spent her working life in a classroom, would say to children now. The passage below runs from there to the end of the tape.

J **JEREMY** 03:03

All right. Now, we're going to go completely off interview topic here for a minute. We're going to ask a question. Now, as you have grown up during what they call the greatest generation, and you were in... You were in... You got to teach children in school. And you see how the world is today. What advice, not just for Braxton your great grandson, but what do you think about how things are in the world today and what the best way is to... Today, with all the distractions, the best path to take to stay on the straight and narrow? In your opinion, if you could speak to the youth today, if you went back to school and you were teaching...

C **CATHERINE**

Listen to your parents, for one thing. And listen and pay attention in school. Kids today do not pay attention. And I could see that that was… When I stopped teaching, I could see it changing then. You could see the change. I wouldn't venture to give kids advice today because they just laugh, I think.

C **CATHERINE** 04:21

And I think this happened… It happened over the years when Mom went to work. Hmm. I think that's what… My mother never worked. She was at home. My husband's mother never went to work. She was at home. And I think that made a big difference. We didn't come home to an empty house or a babysitter. We didn't know what a babysitter was.

C **CATHERINE** 05:01

Kids today have it pretty easy, don't they? Yeah, I guess. Maybe a little too easy.

J ***JEREMY*** 05:08

Well, I probably would have did better in school myself if I wasn't surrounded by so many distractions.

The speaker labels here are the ones the transcribing software assigned, not anyone's later judgement. At 05:01 the whole exchange — "Kids today have it pretty easy, don't they? Yeah, I guess." — is given to Catherine, though the reply in the middle is almost certainly Jeremy's. It has been left as the machine heard it rather than quietly corrected. Nothing in this passage came back marked doubtful.

The Philco Dealer for Cressona

Which Came First, the Shop or the Plant

His grandson's instinct was that Alcoa came after the radio shop, and Allen says exactly that on the tape: "I come home to start up my own business and radio repair in Cressona. And for a while, and then went to work at Alcoa." Two passages in this document had the order reversed, with the shop opening before he had finished the school that qualified him for it, and they have been put right.

The certificate dates the second half of it. It reads "having satisfactorily completed the prescribed 3½ years Course of Training… for the classification of Electrician", and it is dated at Cressona Works on 30 April 1951. Count back and the training began about the end of October 1947. That is firmer than the estimate this document used to carry, which was thirty years counted back from the 1977 shutdown — and thirty years was his own round number, not a date.

Which answers something left open on the Philco page. The dealership was announced on 3 December 1947, about five weeks after the apprenticeship started, and the shop's own advertising calendars are printed for 1948. So the shop did not close when he went into the plant. For a year at least he was an Alcoa apprentice by day and the Philco dealer for Cressona by name, with a wife, a baby son born that January, and a shop on Chestnut Street.

One more thing is on that certificate, and it settles a question from the other end of his life. The company wrote his name out in full: **Allen Earl Sweigert**. His birth certificate says the same, in a registrar's hand in 1918; this is an employer saying it in 1951.

Sources: Allen E. Sweigert, interview, July 2006, Part Two; Alcoa electrician's certificate, Cressona Works, 30 April 1951; Pottsville Republican, 3 December 1947, p. 9; two 1948 advertising calendars, family collection.

The Army taught him radio, sent him to Scott Field for twenty-two weeks, and then spent his war on it. He went on selling and servicing it under his own name. In December 1947 Philco took a full page in the *Pottsville Republican* for its Christmas trade, and listed its dealers across Schuylkill County town by town. Pottsville has ten. Saint Clair, Minersville and Frackville have two each. Orwigsburg has one. And under CRESSONA there is a single name, which is his.

The foot of the right-hand column: CRESSONA, and one dealer for the town.

The dealer list entire, from the same page — Philco's own account of who sold its sets in Schuylkill County that Christmas.

Pottsville Republican, Wednesday 3 December 1947, page 9 — the whole page as it ran. The Philco 1270 at the lower left is $359.50, about four months' wages for a man in the aluminium works. "Wednesday is Bingsday: Philco Radio Time with Bing Crosby — 10 PM, WPAM, 1450 on your dial." Credit: Pottsville Republican.

One Name, and No Address

Philco listed dealers, not employees. The name under CRESSONA is Allen E. Sweigert's own, with no shop name, no street and no company attached to it, which is how a one-man dealership appears in a manufacturer's advertising. He is the only Philco dealer the town had.

The advertisement gives no premises, no trading name, no first day and no last. It is one of two dated points. The other is three weeks earlier: the Pottsville Republican of Wednesday 12 November 1947 runs the same dealer list under the headline "America has bought 20,000,000 Philcos", towns set in italic capitals with the dealer beneath — FRACKVILLE, The White Shop and Bowe Electric; **CRESSONA, Allen E. Sweigert**; ORWIGSBURG, Claude Stoyer. So he was Philco's man in the town by the second week of November 1947 at the latest. It was a crowded moment to be one. He was twenty-nine, married three years, and Allen Jr. had been born that year. It falls between two fixed points in his life — the Coyne Electrical School in Chicago in 1946, and thirty years in the aluminium plant at Cressona — and the dealership ran alongside the plant work: the apprenticeship began about the end of October 1947, a fortnight before the first of these two advertisements.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 3 December 1947, p. 9 (Newspapers.com image 450337336).

The House, the Dog, and the Years After

"Mrs. Earl Kline", Absent LIKELY

The caption's list of those absent includes Mrs. Earl Kline, history and invitations. Catherine's certification of birth names her parents as Earl Ambrose Kline and Sarah Marion Reiger, of Cressona. A woman styled Mrs. Earl Kline on a Cressona committee of the late 1960s could therefore be Allen's own mother-in-law, on the same committee as her son-in-law.

It is a lead and it is written as one. The Pottsville Republican's death index carries exactly one Earl Kline across its run, with an obituary in October 1974, and a Sarah M. Kline in December 1980 — so both were alive when this was taken, and no second Earl Kline exists in that index to compete for the name. But the index is comprehensive only for certain windows, the caption gives her no first name and no relationship, and the same index holds a different Sarah Kline. Until a vital record or an obituary settles it, this is probable and unconfirmed.

Sources: Pottsville Republican death index, Pottsville Free Public Library; Catherine's certification of birth, 21 December 1919.

A Committee Seat Called Alcoa

A borough of under two thousand people had a committee seat named after a factory, which tells you what the factory was. The works went up in 1942 as a federal defence plant and was handed to the Aluminum Company of America to run, extruding aluminium shapes for the war. Alcoa operated it until 1977. Cressona absorbed it so completely that the borough's street grid includes an Alcoa Street.

It is also where Allen worked for thirty years, and where he was named unit foreman of the electrical department in January 1958. So the man sitting on this committee as utilities chairman had spent his working life inside the plant the man two seats along was there to liaise with.

Sources: Hydro Extrusions, Cressona — plant history; Pottsville Republican, 31 January 1958, p. 16.

Utilities Chairman, About 1969 LIKELY

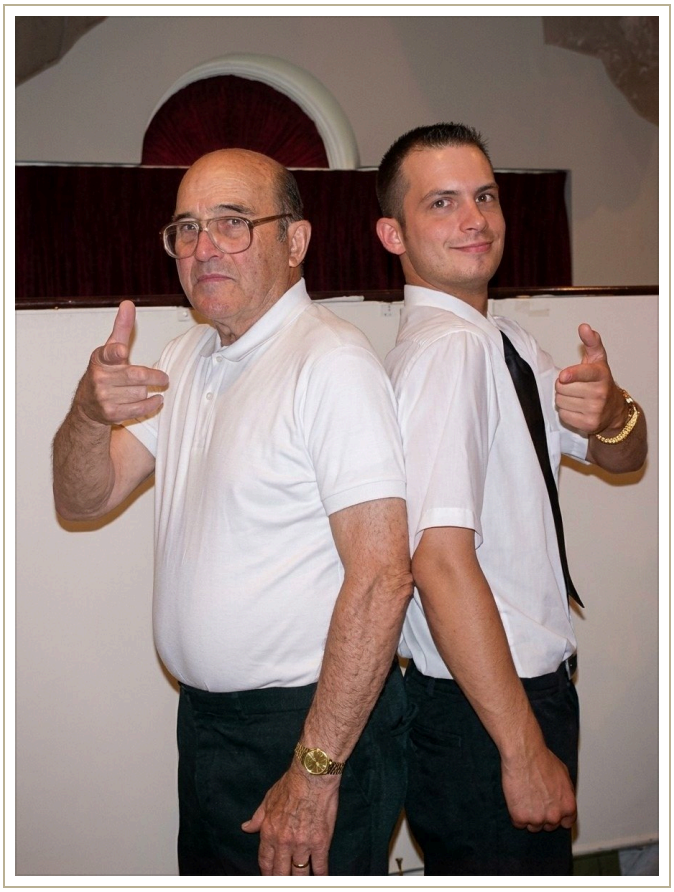
Three things bracket the picture. The Cressona Homecoming that Merlyn J. Jenkins chaired — and the caption seats Jenkins as general chairman — is on the record in the Pottsville Republican in June and July 1969, launched with a concert by the Cressona Band. Jack March, whom the caption calls mayor, is documented in that office in June 1967. And the committee has an Alcoa chairman, a title that has to predate 1977, when Alcoa shut the Cressona plant.

The clothes agree without adding precision: sleeveless shifts, two teased bouffants, narrow lapels and narrow ties, heavy rectangular frames. The economical reading is that this is the committee for the 1969 Homecoming, taken in the run-up to it. That is a reading and not a dateline. Nothing in the frame carries a year, a paper's name or a photographer's credit, and if the Homecoming recurred and Jenkins chaired it more than once, the picture could belong to another year of the same series.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 12 June and 1 July 1969, p. 16; The Call, Schuylkill Haven, 8 June 1967; Hydro Extrusions, Cressona — plant history.

CRESSONA HOMECOMING COMMITTEE—Seated, left t› right: Herb Rosenblatt, co-chairman; Mrs. Harold Miller, refreshment chairman; Mrs. Willard Sites, general secretary; Merlyn J. Jenkins, general chairman; Miss Larue Miller, finance chairman; McKinley Hoover, co-chairman. Standing, left to right: Allen Becker, decoration chairman; Mayor Jack March, parade chairman; Harry Raudenbush, Alcoa chairman; Glenn Kerschner, dedication chairman; Allen Sweigert, utilities chairman; Harold Schaffner, co-chairman; John Singley, grand prize chairman. Absent: Mrs. Earl Kline, history and invitations; Harold Luckenbill, youth activities; James Romberger, schools; William Boussum, public relations; Albert Scott, carnival; Norbert Moyer, fun; Steve Comisac, transportation.

The Cressona Homecoming Committee. Allen stands fifth from the left in the back row, listed in the caption as utilities chairman. About 1969 — the photograph carries no date, and the reasons for that year are set out below.



Allen and his grandson Jeremy, 2001. Five years before the afternoon Jeremy set up a camera and asked him to start at the beginning — the recording this whole document is built on.

Elder, and Chairman of the Pulpit Committee

The church office his obituary gives him is member and property committee chairman of St. Mark's United Church of Christ. The Pottsville Republican of 7 March 1966 gives him a different one, and an earlier one. The caption to a photograph of an installation ends: "Rev. Rumley and Elder Allen E. Sweigert, chairman of Pulpit Committee of S. Mark's Church."

Elder is a lay office. The pulpit committee is the body that finds and calls a minister. So in the spring of 1966 he chaired the committee that brought the Rev. James D. Rumley Jr. to the congregation, and there he is in the photograph at the installation, on the Sunday evening before a Monday paper. It is a second office rather than another name for the first, and the earliest dated evidence of any church office he held at all. The caption garbles twice, printing "St. John's Pnited Churcho f Christ" and "S. Mark's"; both are the paper's, and it also calls Rumley second from right while listing four names left to right.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 7 March 1966, p. 5.

St. Mark's United Church of Christ, Cressona, Sunday evening 6 March 1966. Allen at the right, the only man in the frame not in clerical dress, at the installation of the minister his committee had called. Identification is by the caption's left-to-right order.

The Church Had Another Name Then

His obituary calls him a member and property committee chairman of St. Mark's United Church of Christ. In April 1956 the same congregation is named on this page as "St. Mark's Evangelical and Reformed church," and the page says why that was about to change: an item on the Rev. George C. Hosler's pulpit exchange ties it to "the union of the two denominations scheduled for June 1957."

The forecast was right. The Evangelical and Reformed Church and the General Council of the Congregational Christian Churches united as the United Church of Christ at the Uniting General Synod in Cleveland on 25 June 1957. St. Mark's was Evangelical and Reformed for the first thirty-nine years of his life and United Church of Christ for the last fifty-five. Catherine is in this page too, in the cast of a play at the reception for new members.

Sources: The Call & Orwigsburg News, 12 April 1956, p. 9; United Church of Christ.

Fifty-Eight Dollars and Sixty-Eight Cents

The same Lions item reports that "The April paper and scrap drive netted the Lions $58.68 which will go to the development of the Veteran's Memorial playground." The story does not connect him to it and says nothing about anyone's service. It did not need to: five years earlier he had signed the charter of the association the playground was being built by, which is set out further down this page.

The Cressona Lions describe a long history of providing playgrounds for the town's children, and Veterans Memorial Park, about ten acres, stands in Cressona today. So the newsprint records to the cent one stage in building a veterans' memorial playground in his town, with him in the room, eleven and a half years after he came home from the war. Whether he worked on it, voted for it or proposed it, nobody set down. The apostrophe is the paper's: it printed Veteran's, singular.

Sources: The Call & Orwigsburg News, 12 April 1956, p. 9; Cressona Lions Club; Cressona parks listing.

Father and Son on One Page, 1956

This page was once the earliest dated evidence of his Lions membership anywhere in the collection, and the only source for it other than his obituary. It is neither of those things now. The club's charter of 18 June 1947 carries his name, and the county papers put him in the room in April 1948, June 1949, May 1950 and November 1953. What this page still does, and nothing else in the collection does, is print father and son together. The sons-and-daughters night lists "Allen E. Sweigert Sr." among the Lions present and "Allen E. Sweigert, Jr." among the guests; Allen Jr., born in 1947, was nine.

The pairing is not a guess about suffixes. The first ten surnames of the guest list run in the exact order of the member list — Strauch, Schwartz, Kunsman, Kurtz, Becker, Schappell, Sweigert, Beck, Ferrier, Butler — skipping only the two members with no child present, and the correspondence continues more loosely afterwards. The two lists were taken down in one pass, member and child together. The obituary's word "charter member" is not just the obituary's, and it is no longer undated: the club was chartered on 18 June 1947 and he is on the printed roll of charter members, as set out further down this page. So this 1956 item finds him nine years into the club, not at the start of it.

The suffix was in the same column seven months earlier. The Cressona News of 8 September 1955 carried a standing list headed "Birthdays," and under "September 9" it printed his name with Sr. after it — the day before he turned thirty-seven. No earlier printing of it has been found: the seven matches in the same newspaper search that predate it were read on 24 September 2026 and none carries the suffix, but sixty-nine of that search's hundred and two matches are still unread. It is not the earliest use of it either. He signed himself "SWEIGERT, SR" on his compensation application in April 1950, five years before it turns up in any newspaper here. The 1955 item is a transcription and not a page image, so how the name was actually set is not established.

Sources: The Call & Orwigsburg News, 12 April 1956, p. 9, "Cressona News" by Albert L. Krommes; The Call & Orwigsburg News, 8 September 1955, p. 3, "Cressona News"; Pennsylvania WWII Veterans' Compensation application, April 1950.

CRESSONA NEWS

by ALBERT L. KROMMES

St. Mark's Church Holds Reception for New Members

On Friday evening a reception was held in St. Mark's Evangelical and Reformed church for the new members received into the church recently. The Womens' Guild was in charge with Mrs. George Strauch as the chairman of the committee which consisted of Mrs. Martin Blechschmidt, Mrs. Harold Fegley, Mrs. John Jacoby, Mrs. John Singley, Mrs. Charles Beck and Mrs. Nora Heberling.

The worship service was conducted by Mrs. John Singley. The president of the various organizations of the church gave greetings to the new members. Youth fellowship was represented by Barbara Reed, The Women's Guild by Mrs. Charles Beck, Choir director, Clark Rauch, The Brotherhood by John Singley and the minister, Rev. George Hosler.

A hill billy band dressed in overalls and straw hats entertained. The band was composed of Pansy Erb, piano; Clark Rauch, violin; Mrs. George Strauch, violin; Rev. Hosler, mandolin; George Strauch, jug; Fred Miller, washboard. The vocalists were Mrs. Claire Bubeck and Mrs. William Strauch.

A play entitled "The Ah! Stunt" was presented by Mrs. John Singley, Mrs. Charles Beck, Mrs. William Strauch, Mrs. Francis Rubright, Mrs. George Strauch, Mrs. Ray Bubeck and Mrs. Allen Sweigert.

Each new woman member received a mixed corsage of spring flowers and the men, a boutoniere.

A lunch of ice cream, cup cakes, pretels, soda and coffee was enjoyed.

Lions Entertain Sons And Daughters

The Lions members had sons and daughters as their guests, Monday evening. Entertainment was provided by R. C. McCaukey magician, of Tremont. The April paper and scrap drive netted the Lions $58.68 which will go to the development of the Veteran's Memorial playground.

Guests present were Jean Strauch, Brenda, and Linda Schwartz, Ann and Billy Kunsman, Samuel Kurtz, Jr., Jean Becker, Joanna Schappell, Allen E. Sweigert, Jr., Carol Ann Beck, Billy, Lee, and Johnny Ferrier, Brenda Butler, Terry Halye, Avalon Knoll, Dave Somers, Jr. Wayne Schaffner, Gary Schaffner, Gerry Reber, Charles Scott, Paul Fulton, Robert Fulton, Rebecca Strauch, Linda Lee Wike, Dennis Meck, Sylvia Seitz, Jean Seitz.

Lions present were Rev. George Hosler, George Strauch. Reynold Schwartz, Elvin Kunsman, John Faust, Samuel Kurtz, Allen Becker, Kenneth Schappell, Allen E. Sweigert Sr., Charles Beck, Wm. Blair Ferrier, Paul Butler, Roy Wagner, William Boussum, Theodore Halye Sr., Albert Scott, Theodore Darcas, Mason Wagner, Charton Bittle Sr., David Somers, Sr., Harold Schaffner, Clark Rauch Francis Fulton, John Hayoway, William Strauch, Heber Riland, Arthur Berger, Lester Felsburg, Sterling Hepler, William Nunemacher, Harold Meck, James Seitz.

Guest Speaker At Rally Day Service

Rev. Herbert Cassel, East Weissport, will be the guest speaker at the spring rally day service Sunday in Bethany E. C. church Prior to the service an orchestra under the direction of Harry Yeich will give a concert. Linda Koerper will present an accordian solo accompanied by Mrs. Frank Parry. Miss Claire Bowman, Sch. Haven will present a group of soprano solos. Also included on the program will be a 15 minute hymn sing. Rev. Cassel is the son of the late Rev. W. K. Cassel, who was pastor of Bethany E. C. church 1929-1934. Francis Reed will serve as the superintendent for the service.

The rally day committee consisted of Harry Yeich, Francis Reed, Robert Hughes and Luther Geary.

Income tax time always brings on the need for extra money. Get it with the economical Call Classified Ads.

Rev. Hosler Preached In Springfield, Mass.

The Rev. George C. Hosler, pastor of St. Mark's Evangelical and Reformed church, Cressona. took part in a unique pulpit exchange program on Sunday, April 8.

Rev. Hosler preached at the Park Congregational church in Springfield, Mass., while the Rev. Felix M. Davis, pastor of that church, filled the pulpit at St. Mark's church, Cressona.

The exchange is part of a nationwide program of Congregational Christian and Evangelical and Reformed churches in preparation for the union of the two denominations scheduled for June 1957.

While in Cressona, Rev. Davis was entertained at the home of Mr. and Mrs. George Strauch. Mr. Davis was born in Oklahoma City, Okla., April 23, 1929, living in the course of his child hood in St. Louis, Chicago, New York and finally in Seattle, Washington, where he graduated from high school in the spring of 1947. In the fall of the same year, he entered Wesleyan university in Middletown, Conn., graduating with a bachelor of arts degree in June, 1951. The following September he entered Union Theological Seminary, New York City. He was married in December of the same year. After graduating in 1954 he became pastor of Park Congregational church, Springfield, Mass. Pastor and Mrs. Davis have one child, a six-months-old daughter.

P.T.A. To Discuss Safety of Child

Corporal James McGrew of the Pennsylvania State Police will be the guest speaker at the monthly meeting of the P.T.A. on Wednesday at 7:30 p.m. The theme for the evening is "How Is Your Child Protected?"

It will be fathers night and all the fathers are urged to attend. The program will be in charge of Miss Erb.

Choral Concert
May 26

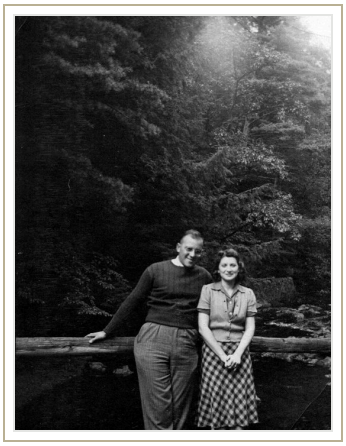
The community grove trustees are planning to present the "Textile Aires," a mixed chorus from Reading in a concert in the grove, Saturday, May 26.

Trade your house with a classified ad in The Call.

The Cressona News column in The Call & Orwigsburg News, Thursday, 12 April 1956. Allen and Catherine and their nine-year-old son are all on this one page — he at the Lions with Allen Jr. as his guest, she in the cast of a play at St. Mark's. Credit: The Call and the Orwigsburg News.

"Puppy's out on the porch. She come running out, jumping all over. … And she hung with me all that night until I went to bed that night."

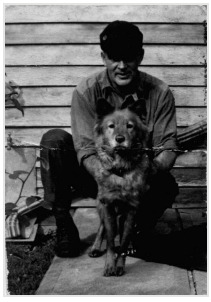
A colour snapshot of two people on a dark green sofa banked with orange cushions: Allen in heavy-framed glasses and a red plaid shirt, and his son John in similar glasses and a blue plaid shirt, with a black-and-white dog lying between them. One of them reaches a hand out toward the camera; the wall behind carries a printed scenic wallpaper and the corner of a gilt picture frame shows at the top left.



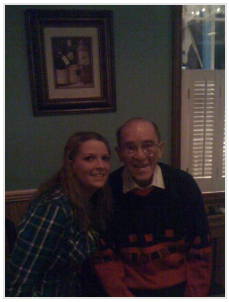
Allen, in a crew-neck sweater and wire-rimmed glasses, leaning on a rustic log rail beside Catherine in a short-sleeved buttoned blouse and a checked skirt, her hands clasped in front of her. Dense conifers and hardwoods cover the slope behind them.

A thick-coated dog in a tagged collar stands on the concrete cap of a brick porch pier, the clapboard wall and shuttered window of a house behind it. Its tail is blurred by movement.

A two-tone four-door sedan with whitewall tyres on a paved road below a wooded ridge of bare trees. John Sweigert, Allen's younger son, looks out through the front side window, with two further figures indistinct in the back seat.



Earl Joshua Sweigert, Allen's father, in a dark flat cap, a work shirt with the sleeves rolled back, dark trousers and high boots, sitting against the clapboard wall of a house and holding a thick-coated dog steady between his knees. A creeper climbs the wall at the left.



Allen sits cheek to cheek with his granddaughter Jessica in a restaurant, in a red and navy patterned sweater and heavy-framed glasses; she is in a green plaid shirt. A framed still life of wine bottles hangs on the wall above them and white louvered shutters stand at the right.

A single-storey house seen from the driveway, with a brick chimney, two-tone siding, a shingled roof and a decorated front-porch railing. A two-tone sedan is parked on the drive, the concrete walk and steps are newly poured, and mounded bare earth fills the foreground.

The front of the same low house from across the street, evergreen garland swagged along the porch railing with a pale ornament in each loop and the front of a car cut off at the left edge. The new concrete walk runs down to two freshly poured steps set in raw earth and gravel at the street.

A thick-coated dog lies at the edge of a concrete walk with both forepaws over a large bone, a picket fence and a flowering shrub behind it.

A June Wedding Is Being Planned, October 1975

The Pottsville Republican of Thursday 30 October 1975 ran a page of photographs headed *Area Couples Engaged To Wed*, and one of them is **Keim — Sweigert**.

"Mr. and Mrs. Kenneth R. Keim of RD1 Tower City announce the engagement of their daughter, Kathy Marie, to John Samuel Sweigert, son of Mr. and Mrs. **Allen E. Sweigert** of Cressona. Miss Keim is a 1975 graduate of Williams Valley High School. She is employed by Bestok factory, Tower City. Mr. Sweigert is a 1973 graduate of Blue Mountain High School and a 1975 graduate of The Pennsylvania State University, where he received a technician's degree in pesticide technology. He is employed at Gold Mills, Pine Grove. A June wedding is being planned." A photograph of Kathy runs with it.

The Call carried the same announcement a week later, on 6 November, under *Engaged to Wed*, and closes it with the year: "A June 1976 wedding is planned."

This is Allen's younger son and the woman he married — the grandson who set the camera up in 2006 was born to them in 1978. The document already had the year of Kathy Keim's birth, 1957, and nothing else about her. Here she is at eighteen, out of Williams Valley High School that summer and working at a factory in Tower City, and John is twenty, out of Penn State the same year.

The wedding itself is not in these papers. A search of the whole archive for Allen's name turns up no 1976 report of it, which may mean it was not published, or was published without naming him, or is simply not digitised. The engagement is dated; the marriage is not.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 30 October 1975, p. 23; The Call and the Orwigsburg News, 6 November 1975, p. 6.

Still Holding Hands

No document in this collection would tell you this, and nobody outside the family could. Well into their eighties, Allen and Catherine still went out to restaurants together, still held hands across the table, and were affectionate enough about it in public that their grandson noticed — his word for it is "kissy." They had been married fifty-five years by the time both of them were in their eighties, and they carried on exactly like that.

He also walked. A few miles a day in his eighties, on purpose, to keep himself in shape. Set that beside the photograph the Republican and Herald ran in October 2005 — eighty-seven years old, at an 1855 grave, with a walker — and the two do not contradict each other. They are in order.

Source: Jeremy Sweigert, his grandson, September 2026.

The Borough Cemetery, and Twenty Years On Its Commission

He Helped Found the Veterans' Memorial Park, June 1951

The Pottsville Republican of Saturday 2 June 1951: "Charter application for the Cressona Memorial Park Association has been filed in the office of Prothonotary Noakes. Listed as incorporators are the following: Elvin H. Kunsman, Allan A. Becker, Theodore Hayle, William H. Laubenstein, William S. Boussum, A. C. Kantner, Allen E. Sweigert, Adam D. Singley, Francis E. Hanney, all of Cressona. The purpose of the association is to develop playgrounds as a memorial to war veterans."

Nine men, and he is one of them. This is the strongest civic evidence in the collection: not attendance at a meeting but a name on a charter, filed by a Pottsville law firm, for a body set up to build something.

It also corrects this document. The 1956 Lions item that records $58.68 raised "for the development of the Veteran's Memorial playground" was written up here with the caution that the story "does not connect him to it" and that he was a member in the room when it was read out. He was more than that. Five years before that collection was counted, he had put his name to the charter of the association it was being raised for. Veterans Memorial Park, about ten acres, stands in Cressona today.

Three of the nine were his own Legion officers eight months earlier — Adam Singley and Francis Hanney, with Allen himself in the chair as commander. The post founded the park.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 2 June 1951, p. 12; Pottsville Republican, 5 October 1950, p. 21; The Call & Orwigsburg News, 12 April 1956, p. 9.

Executor, by June 1978

The document has followed Allen's father through a marriage in 1914, forty-three years on the Reading Railroad, a retirement in June 1959 and a golden wedding in October 1964, and then loses him entirely. It has no date for his death. This is the nearest thing to one.

The Pottsville Republican of Monday 5 June 1978 printed its weekly column of property transfers, and in the middle of it: "**Allen E. Sweigert**, executor of the estate of **Earl J. Sweigert, deceased**, to Terry L. and Brenda L. Ellex for $17,000 in Cressona."

So Earl was dead by the first week of June 1978, and his only son was settling what he left. What the seventeen thousand dollars bought is not named in the column. The golden-wedding notice of 1964 gives Earl and Helen's address as 147 Railroad Street, Cressona, which makes that house the obvious candidate and does not make it a fact.

A dollar figure sits oddly beside the other one in these pages. Thirty North Fourth Street came to Allen and Catherine for a dollar in December 1948. Thirty years later he sold his father's property for seventeen thousand, as executor rather than as owner, and the same column does not say what became of the money or whether Helen was still living.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 5 June 1978, p. 24; The Call and the Orwigsburg News, 15 October 1964, p. 7; Pottsville Republican, 23 December 1948, p. 16.

His Parents' Golden Wedding, October 1964

Searching the papers for St. Mark's turned up something much larger than a church item. The Call of Thursday 15 October 1964, page 7: **MR. AND MRS. EARL SWEIGERT OBSERVES 50TH ANNIVERSARY**. In four hundred words it sets down more about Allen's parents than everything else in this collection put together.

"Mr. and Mrs. Earl Sweigert, 147 Railroad St., Cressona, celebrated their golden wedding anniversary Saturday. The couple was married Oct. 10, 1914 at St. Mark's Church, Cressona, by the Rev. Schaeffer." The date was already in this document from their marriage record; the church and the minister were not, and it is the same church Allen would marry in thirty years later.

Then the part that was missing altogether. "Mr. Sweigert retired June 14, 1959 after being employed as an engineer for the Reading Railroad Co. for 43 years." Forty-three years on the railroad, from about 1916, and a member of the Brotherhood of Railroad Engineers. Allen grew up in a locomotive engineer's house on Railroad Street, and went into radio.

It also reaches back a generation further than anything else here. Earl was "the son of Joshua and Sara Lengle Sweigert"; Helen, "the former Helen Fessler, was born at Friedensburg, the daughter of Samuel and Esther Nagle Fessler." Those are Allen's four grandparents, in print, and the Fessler and Nagle names match the family's own handwritten tree.

And one sentence settles a question that had been left open. "The couple has one son, Allen E. Sweigert, and two grandsons, Allen and John Sweigert, all of Cressona." Allen was an only child. So the other Sweigerts who turn up in the Cressona papers are not brothers and sisters: Merlin Sweigert, on the Gettysburg Scout train with him in 1931, is named here as Earl's brother — Allen's uncle. Earl also had a sister, Mrs. Ida Stichler of Schuylkill Haven; Helen had a sister, Mrs. Annie Berger of Cressona, and two brothers, William Fessler of Cressona and Sterling of Baltimore.

The celebration itself was a family dinner on the Sunday at Reeser's Restaurant in Reading, and the guests begin: "Mr. and Mrs. Allen E. Sweigert and children."

Sources: The Call and the Orwigsburg News, 15 October 1964, p. 7.

The Last Time, September 2011 — and the Flag That Replaced Them

The final appearance of his name in a newspaper before his obituary is six months before he died, and it is this. The Republican and Herald of Tuesday 27 September 2011, in the state police round-up, under a heading about flags and rods stolen from a front porch:

"Troopers said Allen E. Sweigert reported that someone stole two flags and the rods that they were attached to from holders on the front porch of his home and fled. The flags, one an American flag and the other a New York Yankees flag, are about 3½ feet by 2½ feet in size, troopers said." It happened between six on the Thursday evening and seven on the Friday morning.

He was ninety-three. A master sergeant of the 90th Bombardment Squadron, thirty-two months in the South West Pacific, a past commander of his Legion post and twenty years on the borough cemetery commission, ringing the state police because somebody took the flag off his porch in the night. And beside it a Yankees flag, which is the kind of detail no record sets down about a man unless something goes wrong.

Three days later his son answered it in print. The Republican and Herald of Friday 30 September 2011, page A11, under *YOUR VIEWS*: **Theft of flags is thoughtless act**.

"I was sitting here at my desk when the phone rang and on the other end were my parents… My mother went on to inform me that when she went out on the porch to retrieve the morning paper, she noticed that their flags were gone… they stole their U.S. flag and their Major League Baseball flag, including the poles. My parents are 93 and 92 years of age. They will be married 67 years in another month. They still live in the house, in a nice residential neighborhood of Cressona, which my father and grandfather built after World War II." Signed **John Sweigert, Bethlehem**.

The letter never prints his name. He is "my father" throughout, so the police item of three days earlier still stands as the last time his own name is set in type before the obituary. But everything else in it checks. He turned ninety-three on 9 September 2011, three weeks before it was written. They were married on 14 October 1944, so the sixty-seventh anniversary was a fortnight away rather than a month — a son rounding, not a son misremembering.

And one clause in it is worth more than the rest of the letter. **"which my father and grandfather built after World War II."** The Adequate Wiring Certificate for the Charles Street house, issued in 1957, is made out to "Father and Son". Two documents fifty-four years apart, one a utility form and the other a complaint to a newspaper, neither written to record the fact,

and they agree: Allen and Earl built that house between them. The son also calls it a Major League Baseball flag where the state police called it a New York Yankees flag, which is the difference between how a family describes a thing and how a trooper writes it down.

And the flags were replaced. The family's account is that a Pennsylvania congressman, hearing what had happened, sent him a new United States flag. This document records that as what it is — family testimony, given by his grandson — and not as a newspaper fact, because no newspaper found here reports it.

The looking was not casual, and the scope is written down so that nobody has to do it twice. Between the night of the theft and the day he died, the whole of the searchable archive carries his surname and the name of his town together on exactly two pages, and neither is about him: a court list and another family's obituary. His surname with the word *congressman*, across 2011 to 2013, returns three pages, every one of them a different Sweigert. The word *flag* beside his name over the same fifteen months returns the theft, the letter, and a run of high-school football. Whatever office sent that flag sent it without a press release — which, for a replacement flag posted to a ninety-three-year-old man whose own had been taken off his porch in the night, is rather to its credit.

One pointer for whoever looks again. Cressona lay in Pennsylvania's 17th congressional district, held from 2003 to 2013 by Tim Holden, a Schuylkill County man who had been the county sheriff before he was the congressman — and the son who wrote the letter lived in Bethlehem, in the 15th. This document does not know which office it was and does not claim to. It sets the districts down only as the place a later search should start.

Sources: Republican and Herald, Pottsville, 27 September 2011, p. A14 ("Flags, rods taken from front porch"); Republican and Herald, 30 September 2011, p. A11; Adequate Wiring Certificate, 1957. The replacement flag: family testimony, Jeremy Sweigert, September 2026.

The Gift to the Museum in New Orleans

His elder son gave to **The National WWII Museum** in New Orleans in his father's name. That is the family's own account, from Allen Jr.'s nephew, and at the time of writing it is the only account there is. When the gift was made, and what form it took, this document does not know.

The museum's public registers do not carry it, and this note sets out where the looking went so that nobody has to do it again. The Brick and Paver Locator, which indexes the commemorative bricks and pavers of the Colonel Battle Barksdale Parade Ground and Founders Plaza, returns nothing for *Sweigert* and nothing for *Sweigart*. The museum's own site search returns nothing. He is not on the Honor Roll of Charter Members. The Digital Collections oral histories hold exactly one Sweigert — a first lieutenant named phonetically by another man describing a night patrol in Holland, killed there, and no relation.

None of that argues against the gift. A museum publishes its bricks because a brick is a public object with a name cut into it. An ordinary gift is a donor record, and donor records are confidential. Finding no public trace of one is not evidence that it was not made; it is what a gift looks like from outside.

What would settle it is a letter. The museum can look a gift up by the donor's name and the honoree's, and the family has only to ask. Allen Jr. died in 2020, so an acknowledgement or a receipt, if it survives, would be among his papers. Until one of those turns up this page records the gift on the family's word, which is how it records the replacement flag above, and says plainly that it has no document behind it.

Sources: family testimony, Jeremy Sweigert, September 2026. Searched: The National WWII Museum Brick and Paver Locator (Sweigert, Sweigart), the museum's site search, the Honor Roll of Charter Members, and the Digital Collections oral histories at ww2online.org — 25 September 2026.

How They Came by 30 North Fourth Street

The house has been in this document only as something they sold. The Pottsville Republican's weekly column of property transfers, Thursday 23 December 1948, shows how they got it: "**Eva Mae Mosher to Allen E. Sweigert and his wife, Catherine, all of Cressona, dwelling at 30 N. Fourth st., Cressona, for $1.**"

A dollar is not a price. It is the figure a deed carries when a house is being handed over rather than sold — within a family, or as a settlement, or on terms the deed does not record. Who Eva Mae Mosher was to them, this document cannot say; Moshers are a Cressona family and a Mosher is on the Scout train with him in 1931.

It completes the shape of it. They took the house in the week before Christmas 1948, with a son not yet two. They sold it on 29 September 1955 to build the Charles Street house, which was roofed on a Thanksgiving day and wired by Allen himself in 1957. Just under seven years in the first house, and the rest of their lives in the second.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 23 December 1948, p. 16; Pottsville Republican, 29 September 1955, p. 26.

In the Room, 1948 to 1953

Between the charter night of June 1947 and the sons-and-daughters night of April 1956 the county papers put him at four Cressona Lions meetings. Singly they are thin. Together they are nine years of a man turning up.

April 1948 is the one worth reading twice. Under CRESSONA the Pottsville Republican has the club at Ed's Grille on Pottsville Street, and gives the evening a speaker: "Lewis H. Murray, Pottsville, program director of Station WPAM. His subject was 'Radio For The Future.'" Allen is in the list of those attending. He had been Philco's dealer in Cressona for five months by then, with a shop on Chestnut Street, and WPAM is already on this page — it is the station in his own Philco advertisement of December 1947. The item says nothing about his trade and does not say he spoke. It is only that a man who sold radios sat through a talk on the future of radio.

June 1949 and November 1953 are attendance and nothing else. Twenty-six men at the high school the first time, twenty-eight at the weekly meeting the second. Perfect-attendance buttons went to nine men in 1949 and he was not one of the nine. Neither paper dates its meeting — each dates only its own page — so both are ceilings rather than days, and neither is entered in the register.

May 1950 records an office. The Republican of Thursday the 18th, under LIONS ELECT NEW OFFICERS, has the club meeting on the Tuesday and electing a slate for the year beginning 1 July: Elvin Kunsman president, and "director, two years, Wm. Laubenstine and **Allen E. Sweigert**." The Tuesday before a Thursday paper was 16 May. He was thirty-one. Three months later he took command of Stanley Dengler Post 286, set out further down this page.

That slate also narrows something the obituary leaves open. It calls him a past president of this club and gives no year. For the year beginning 1 July 1950 the president was Kunsman and Allen was one of two directors, so the presidency was not that year. Every other year is still untested.

What none of the four items gives is anything he did. No motion, no word spoken, no committee. The only man who does anything in the 1953 report is a district governor up from Portland to talk about the International Convention. Four times across nine years, Allen is a name in a list — which is most of what belonging to anything looks like from the outside.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 14 April 1948, p. 15; 2 June 1949, p. 10; 18 May 1950, p. 2; 12 November 1953, p. 30. Obituary: Republican and Herald, 30 March 2012, p. A12.

The Mother-Daughter Banquet, by May 1949

The Pottsville Republican of Wednesday 18 May 1949 carried a Cressona item headed DAUGHTERS AND MOTHERS DINE. "The annual Mother-Daughter banquet was held in **St. Mark's Evangelical and Reformed Church**, Cressona. A ham dinner, prepared by the women of the church was served by a group of men." Then a programme, a gift list, and a long roll of those present. It is the first time the church he married in is named in full in these pages.

Four women in that roll belong to this document. Mrs. Allen E. Sweigert is Catherine. Mrs. Earl Sweigert is Helen, Allen's mother, styled exactly as the same paper styled her among the mothers at the 1935 school banquet. Mrs. Earl A. Kline is almost certainly Catherine's mother — her certification of birth names her father as Earl Ambrose Kline — though a church attendance list is not a vital record. Mrs. Wm. Fessler is thinner still: William Fessler of Cressona was Helen's brother, but the paper gives this woman no first name and nothing here names his wife.

One run of five names is worth more than the rest of the column: "… Mrs. Harold R. Straub, Betty Jane Straub, **Mrs. Allen E. Sweigert**, Mrs. Emma Bartholomew, Mrs. Earl A. Kline …" Catherine said on her own tape in 2013, "I had one sister, who was Betty Ann, and she married Harold Straub." That sentence has until now been the entire record of her sister. Here is a Mrs. Harold R. Straub in print, two places from Catherine, carrying a middle initial the document did not have. Betty Jane Straub, who took the gift for youngest daughter, stands between them and is listed without a Mrs., so she reads as a child. Catherine said Betty Ann and the paper says Betty Jane. Whether that is a mother and her daughter, or one woman whose name one of the two sources has wrong, nothing here settles.

Allen is not in it. The men served the dinner and the paper names none of them, so nothing in the column puts him in the building. Nor does it date the banquet: 18 May 1949 is the day it was printed and the latest it can have been.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 18 May 1949, p. 18; 27 May 1935, p. 8; Catherine's own interview, 2013; Catherine's certification of birth, 21 December 1919.

The Women's Guild at St. Mark's, 22 August 1950

Fifteen months later the same paper has the women of the church at work. Under CRESSONA — WOMEN'S GUILD MEET AT CHURCH: "The Women's Guild of St. Mark's Church at Cressona held their monthly meeting in the social room in the church, Tuesday evening. Due to the inclement weather, they had to postpone their meeting at Brommer's cabin. A ham dinner was served…" The paper is dated Wednesday 23 August 1950, so the Tuesday was the 22nd.

The business of the evening was this: "A pre-school clothing drive for needy children in Europe was discussed… It is planned to have things for needy children such as old clothing which the children of the church can't wear." Five years after the war, in a borough of under two thousand people, the women of St. Mark's counting out what their own children had grown out of. The item records a plan and not a report; whether the drive was held, it does not say.

Catherine is in the attendance list, and so is Helen, and directly before Helen stands Mrs. Wm. Fessler again. Catherine holds no office in it: not on the committee, not among the four delegates picked for the annual Guild meeting at Schuylkill Haven in September.

Immediately after her the paper sets **BUDDY SWEIGERT**. It gives no relationship and no age. The nickname is not in doubt — his obituary in 2012 calls him Allen E. "Buddy" Jr. — and Allen and Catherine had exactly one child in August 1950, John not being born until 1955. The column also sets the same surname twice running all the way through, the older person first: "Mr. and Mrs. Ray Bubeck, son Billy", "Mrs. George Strauch, Jean Strauch". What the paper establishes is that a Buddy Sweigert was in the room. The rest is this document's reading, and on that reading it is the earliest appearance of Allen Jr. in a newspaper found so far — three and a half years old, at a church meeting, with his mother.

One other name. The item has "Rev. George Hosler" giving a few remarks and "Rev. and Mrs. Geo. C. Hosler" among those attending, without calling him the minister of St. Mark's. The only other Hosler date in this collection is April 1956, so this puts him at the church five years and eight months earlier than anything else here does.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 23 August 1950, p. 6; The Call & Orwigsburg News, 12 April 1956, p. 9; The Call, Schuylkill Haven, 15 October 1964, p. 7; Republican and Herald, 30 March 2012, p. A12.

The Lions Charter, 18 June 1947

The obituary called him a charter member of the Cressona Lions and this document could not date it, because nobody had found the club's charter. Here it is. The Call of Friday 20 June 1947, on its front page: "Cressona Lions Club Chartered Wednesday Night. The Charter Night banquet of the Cressona Lions club was held on Wednesday evening at the Necho Allen hotel, Pottsville, with Schuylkill Haven as the sponsoring club." Wednesday was 18 June 1947.

The Pottsville Republican of the day before, 19 June, prints the whole roll under CRESSONA LIONS GET CHARTER, and Allen is on it: "The charter members are: Cloyd Bagshaw, Mark H. Bast, C. Fred Beck, Allen A. Becker, Arthur R. Berger… William H. Strauch, George W. Strauch, **Allen E. Sweigert**, Russell Wagner, Mason Wagner, Rev. Mark G. Wagner, Maurice D. Walborn and Chester A. Wilson." Thirty-seven men, and he is one of them. He was twenty-eight, with a five-month-old son and a shop on Chestnut Street.

The same report lists who came, and he did not come alone: "Mr. and Mrs. Allen E. Sweigert." Catherine was at the charter night too.

One name in that list is already in this document for another reason. The Rev. Mark G. Wagner, a director of the new club, had married Allen and Catherine at St. Mark's two and a half years earlier.

And the rest of the list is the same small group of men who keep reappearing. Archibald Kantner was the club's first secretary, William S. Boussum its tail twister and Francis Hanney its lion tamer; four years later Kantner, Boussum and Hanney signed the charter of the Cressona Memorial Park Association with Allen, and in between Hanney was the acting commander who handed the Legion post over to him. A borough of under two thousand people ran on about forty men, and he was one of them from the age of twenty-eight.

Sources: The Call, Schuylkill Haven, 20 June 1947, p. 1; Pottsville Republican, 19 June 1947, p. 20.

Commander of Post 286, October 1950

His obituary calls him a past commander of the Cressona American Legion post and gives no date. The Pottsville Republican of Thursday 5 October 1950 gives both the date and the post's own name. Under the heading LEGION HEADS ARE INSTALLED: "The monthly meeting of the Stanley Dengler Post 286 was held at the Legion Home, with Acting Commander Francis Hanney in charge. The newly elected officers of the Post were installed by the Commander of the 13th District, Joseph Halka of Mahanoy City. They are: Commander, Allen E. Sweigert; Sr. Vice Commander, Adam Singley; Jr. Vice Commander, Thomas Callahan; Adjutant, Clair Artz; Finance Officer, Francis Rubright; Historian, Charles Beck; Sgt.-at-Arms, Charles Marberger."

He was thirty-two, five years out of uniform, with a three-year-old son and a shop on Chestnut Street. Post 286 is *Stanley Dengler Post*, a name this document did not have.

The officers around him are the same men again. Charles Beck was at the hot-dog roast on the Blue Mountain in June 1939 and away at Guard camp that August. Francis Rubright was on the school Press Club staff with him in 1935. Adam Singley and Francis Hanney turn up again eight months later, on the charter of the Cressona Memorial Park Association.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 5 October 1950, p. 21.

A Third Borough Body: the Police Pension Committee

His obituary lists the offices in a row and the eye slides over them. Read one at a time against the rest of this document, every one of them is here already — the Lions, the Melvin Jones Fellow award, the American Legion Post 286 command, St. Mark's — except one. "He also belonged to the Cressona Police Pension Committee."

Nothing else in the collection mentions it, and the obituary gives no dates. A police pension committee in a borough of that size is a small standing body that looks after the fund the borough's officers retire on, and a man sits on it because he is trusted with other people's money over a long horizon. That makes three borough bodies he served on at one time or another — the cemetery commission, the police pension committee, and the Homecoming committee where the caption seats him as utilities chairman.

Sources: Republican and Herald, Pottsville, 30 March 2012, p. A12.

September 2004, and What the Silence Is Worth

2004 is the year the 2005 feature points to when it says the commission witnessed a changing of the guard. Apart from the Legion's Service to America certificate of 29 May, it is the only thing in the collection from that year, and it mentions neither the cemetery nor any borough office.

What it does show is a man of eighty-six at a public gathering of Cressona's World War II veterans, eight months into that year: out in his town and in company, and nothing beyond that. Silence in a photograph caption proves nothing either way. Two cautions go with it. The caption calls him an Air Force veteran; he served in the Army Air Forces, and the United States Air Force did not exist until 1947. And it says medals were presented to the veterans recognised, not that he received one — the medal visible in the frame hangs at Frei's chest, and nobody recorded what it was.

Sources: Republican & Herald, 23 September 2004, p. 4.

NICK MEYER/Staff Photo

Friends Allen E. Sweigert, Cressona, Air Force veteran, right, Warren H. Frei, Marines veteran, and his wife, Jean S., talk after a breakfast Wednesday at the River Inn, Cressona, where state Rep. Bob Allen, R-125, recognized area World War II veterans and presented them with medals.

Republican & Herald, Thursday 23 September 2004. Allen at eighty-six, right, with Warren H. Frei and his wife Jean S., after a breakfast at the River Inn, Cressona, where the county's surviving World War II veterans were recognised. Photograph by Nick Meyer, staff.

The Rest of That 1982 Slate

The item names the whole slate, which is worth keeping, because otherwise only two of the commission's members are known — Allen and Emmett Rauch — with the rest of the borough out of the frame. Appointed with him were Forrest Schwartz to the sewer authority for five years; Daniel Dauksis to planning and zoning for four; Lori Reichert and Marilyn Reedy to recreation for five; and Robert Llewellyn to the zoning and hearing board for three.

None of them goes to the cemetery, and the item never names his fellow commissioners, so it does nothing to date Rauch's service. The paper also uses a different word from the ordinance — cemetery committee, where the borough code provides for a Cemetery Commission of three citizens. The three-year term it reports is the term the ordinance sets, and on that one point the newspaper and the borough code agree.

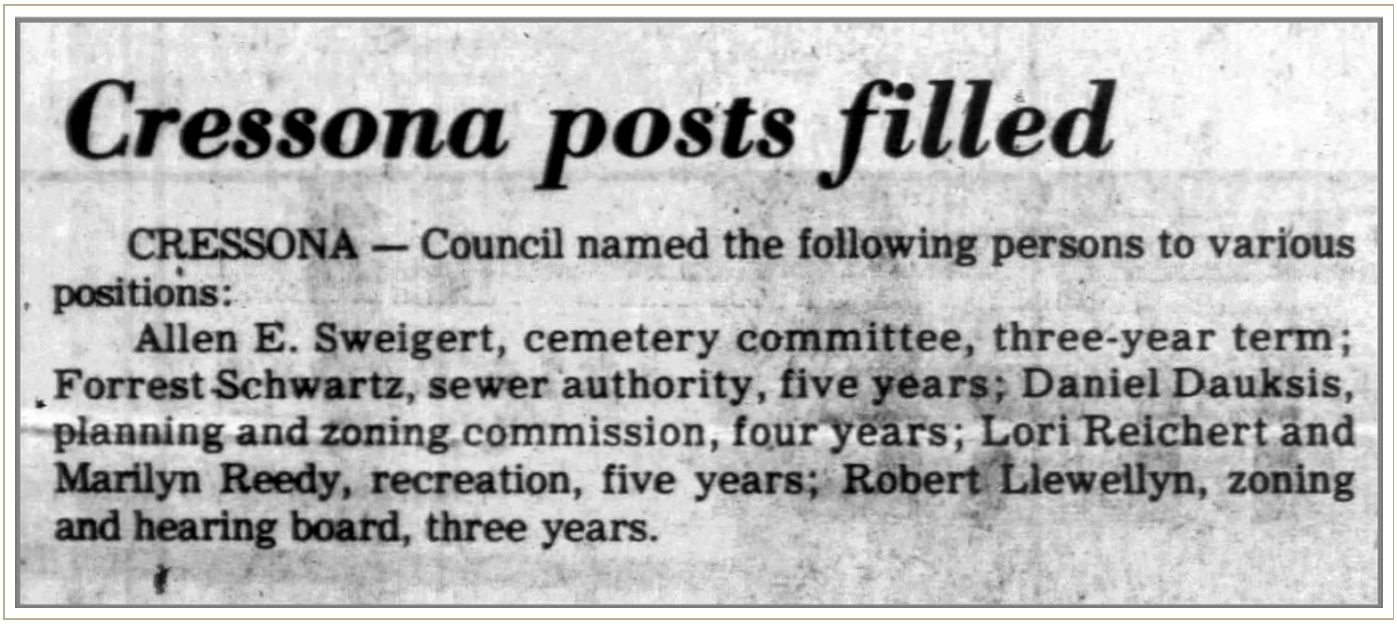
Sources: Pottsville Republican, 5 February 1982, p. 1; Cressona Borough Code § 33.35.

February 1982: the Twenty Does Not Fit

Counting twenty years back from a step-down in 2004 puts the start of his service at about 1984. The Pottsville Republican of 5 February 1982 rules that out. "CRESSONA — Council named the following persons to various positions: Allen E. Sweigert, cemetery committee, three-year term."

He held the seat in 1982, so he cannot have begun in 1984 or 1985. Whether February 1982 was his first appointment or a reappointment, the item does not say. If it was his first, then service running to a step-down in 2004 comes to twenty-two years and not twenty: he was rounding, not counting terms. If it was a reappointment, he began earlier still. One more caution. A change of commissioner ought to register in January, at council's organisation meeting; these appointments were reported on 5 February.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 5 February 1982, p. 1; Republican & Herald, 16 October 2005, p. C1; Cressona Borough Code §§ 33.35–33.36.



Cressona posts filled

CRESSONA — Council named the following persons to various positions:

Allen E. Sweigert, cemetery committee, three-year term; Forrest Schwartz, sewer authority, five years; Daniel Dauksis, planning and zoning commission, four years; Lori Reichert and Marilyn Reedy, recreation, five years; Robert Llewellyn, zoning and hearing board, three years.

Pottsville Republican, Friday 5 February 1982 — the item that will not fit the twenty. He was already on the cemetery committee two years before a 1984 start would allow. Credit: Pottsville Republican.

In October 2005, when he was eighty-seven, a reporter from the *Republican & Herald* came to Cressona to write about the borough's cemetery, and the man she quoted at length was Allen. He had sat on the three-person commission that ran it for twenty years, and had stepped down the year before. He never mentioned it on the tape, and his obituary does not mention it either: that lists the church, the Lions, the American Legion and the police pension committee, and leaves the cemetery out.

Cressona Cemetery, October 2005. Allen, right, at eighty-seven and on a walker, with Robert A. Barr, borough council president, at one of the earliest graves in the ground — that of Theodore Alexis Classen, a native of Finland, from 1855. Allen had come off the cemetery commission the year before, after twenty years on it. Photograph by Jacqueline Dormer, Republican & Herald.

Cressona Cemetery, October 2005. Allen at the right, reaching across to point something out, with Robert A. Barr, the borough council president, beside him. The paper's own caption reads: "Robert A. Barr, borough council president, left, and Allen E. Sweigert, retired cemetery commission member, right, look over the grounds at the Cressona Cemetery."

Two Photographs, One Afternoon

The Republican and Herald ran the cemetery feature across two pages on Sunday 16 October 2005, and it carried two pictures of Allen, not one. This document had only the second. The first, on the section front, is the closer of the two: he and Robert A. Barr in their coats among the stones, with the flags out along the rows behind them.

The caption names them left and right and leaves the gesture unattributed, and at a glance the pointing hand looks as though it belongs to the man on the left. It does not. That sleeve is pale, and the left-hand man's coat is black to the cuff. Allen is pointing, from the right, across in front of him.

He was eighty-seven. In the other frame, taken the same afternoon at the 1855 grave, he has the walking frame beside him.

Sources: Republican and Herald, Pottsville, 16 October 2005, pp. C1 and C3.

> *"I hear the people talk about our cemetery. All the people in Cressona are proud of it."*
>
> ALLEN E. SWEIGERT, SR., 2005

An Office Left Out of the Obituary

His obituary gives his civic life four clauses — church property committee, Lions, American Legion Post 286, Cressona Police Pension Committee — and then the line that he is buried with military honours in Cressona Cemetery. The 2005 feature adds an office none of them mention. He "served 20 years on the commission," and he and Emmett Rauch, both longtime members, stepped down in what the article calls last year.

The article calls it a three-person cemetery commission, which is exactly what the borough's own ordinance provides for, and the ordinance names the predecessor the article leaves vague as "private owners." Beyond that phrase the article gives no start year and no end year, and the twenty is his own figure rather than a count out of the books. He is buried in the ground he looked after.

Sources: Andrea T. Turano, "The borough cemetery," Republican & Herald, 16 October 2005, p. C1; Cressona Borough Code § 33.35.

How the Commission Was Made, and What It Could Do

It was a body made by borough ordinance under the Pennsylvania Borough Code. Section 33.35 of Cressona's code provides that "a Cemetery Commission of three citizens shall be appointed by the Borough Council to take care of, manage and operate the burial grounds formerly of the Cressona Cemetery Association, now owned by the said borough," and lets the commission write its own rules.

Section 33.36 sets the appointments: made by council at its organisation meeting, one commissioner a year on staggered three-year terms, vacancies filled by council, and every commissioner serving "without pay or other compensation." Section 33.37 hands the commission the powers the old association held, including a perpetual-care fund and the hiring of employees; 33.38 keeps title to every lot in the borough's name; 33.40 requires a written report to council at least once a year, and 33.41 requires the president and treasurer to be bonded. So the office he held for twenty years was unpaid, renewed a third at a time, and answerable to council in writing.

Sources: Cressona Borough Code, Ch. 33, §§ 33.35–33.41; 8 Pa.C.S. § 2801, Management by cemetery commission.

Which Twenty Years LIKELY

The article gives the figure and no dates. It appeared on 16 October 2005 and says the commission witnessed a changing of the guard "last year." Taken plainly that means 2004, and twenty years before 2004 is 1984. The ordinance settles where in the year a change would fall: commissioners are appointed at the organisation meeting of council, and Cressona's minutes put that meeting in January. So a step-down would come in January, which fixes the month of his last term but not the year his service began.

There is a looser reading. A reporter writing in October might mean by "last year" the most recent reorganisation, January 2005, which would give 1985 to 2005. Either way the finish is in the middle 2000s. The start is not in the middle 1980s: the council item of 5 February 1982 already has him on the cemetery committee, so he began in 1982 or earlier and the twenty is his own rounding. He was eighty-five at the January 2004 meeting and eighty-seven when the article ran.

Sources: Republican & Herald, 16 October 2005, p. C1; Cressona Borough Code § 33.36; Cressona Borough Council minutes, 3 February 2020 and 20 January 2025.

Emmett Rauch, and Where Both Men Lie

The other man who stepped down can be named and dated. Emmett Harold Rauch, born 3 July 1921, died 14 June 2009, is buried in the Cressona Cemetery; his wife Emma, born 1925 and died 2018, lies in the same ground, and her obituary records sixty-three years of marriage and a long residence in the borough. Her obituary does not mention his years on the commission, and nothing else does either. The 2005 article is the only source for them, and no obituary of his own has ever been found.

By those dates he came off the commission at about eighty-two, with four or five years left to him. Allen, born 9 September 1918 and died 29 March 2012, is buried in the same cemetery. The two men who handed the commission on both lie in the borough ground they had been keeping — which is what Allen meant when he spoke of residents who did not want to be left out of town.

Sources: Find a Grave memorials 112137700, 191055169 and 194484457; Obituary of Emma Elizabeth Rauch, 1 July 2018.

Resident Allen E. Sweigert, October 1990

He is seventy-two, thirteen years retired, and he has gone to the borough council meeting to complain about children.

The Pottsville Republican of Tuesday 2 October 1990 reports the meeting at length — a possible suit against an engineering company, a repaving contract for $4,088.70, fire marshals named for the year — and then: "**Resident Allen E. Sweigert** said that youngsters have been setting up ramps in a lot at **St. Mark's United Church of Christ, 30 Pottsville St.**, and their bicycles jump off and do stunts. The church's pastor, the Rev. Carl Jones, told the youngsters not to set up the ramps, but he later saw them using the ramps again. Borough Police Chief Wilfred S. Daubert said he will look into the matter."

Three things arrive with it. The church has its address here for the first time in these pages, and its post-1957 name. Its minister in 1990 was the Rev. Carl Jones, which puts a fifth name into a line of ministers that otherwise runs Schaeffer in 1914, Mark G. Wagner in 1944, George C. Hosler in 1950 and 1956, and James D. Rumley Jr. from 1966. And the councilman quoted higher up the same report is Robert A. Barr, who is council president in the photograph taken beside Allen at the cemetery fifteen years later, and who sits on the cemetery commission now.

The rest of the page is about skateboarding. The borough had just banned it, and a fifteen-year-old named David Brady told the paper: "We'll just go someplace else, but it's a shame. I mean we live here and we have to go to Pottsville or Tamaqua or Orwigsburg to skate." Allen had been a Scout at thirteen and a scoutmaster at twenty-one. At seventy-two he is the resident at the microphone about the ramps behind the church. The report says only what he said, and nothing about what he meant by it.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 2 October 1990, p. 15 and p. 16.

Robert A. Barr, Who Later Took the Seat

The man standing at Allen's left in the photograph is still at it. Cressona Borough Council minutes of 3 February 2020 have him in the roll call, moving and seconding business through the meeting, and at a council meeting of 20 January 2025 he was retained to the cemetery commission, abstaining from the vote on his own appointment.

So the borough council president photographed beside Allen in 2005 now sits on the commission Allen left. That he was president in October 2005 rests on the photograph's caption alone; nothing else found says who presided over Cressona's council that year. What is not in doubt is long and unbroken council service on both sides of the article.

Sources: Cressona Borough Council minutes, 3 February 2020; Cressona council meeting of 20 January 2025; Republican & Herald, 16 October 2005, photograph caption.

The Ground Itself, and Whose Prices Those Were

The cemetery is indexed everywhere and described nowhere. Find a Grave places it on Ash Street at a little over 3,700 memorials, seventy-nine per cent of them photographed, and the entry — created in February 2001 — still says the cemetery has no description. One contributed photograph is captioned as a Civil War section. BillionGraves and FamilySearch carry separate indexes of the same ground, and the Pottsville Free Public Library holds a plan made in the summer of 2009 showing five numbered sections, a shed and the Ash Street frontage. Not one of them gives a founding date, an acreage, or the date the borough took the ground over.

The prices Allen quoted the reporter — three hundred dollars for a full lot of twelve graves, a hundred and fifty for a half — appear nowhere in the borough's ordinances, which set no schedule of charges at all. Under section 33.35 the commission adopted such rules as it thought necessary. Those figures were the commission's own to set, and his to quote.

Sources: Find a Grave, Cressona Cemetery, cemetery ID 332878; BillionGraves; FamilySearch cemetery site 52272; Cressona Cemetery plan, Summer 2009, Pottsville Free Public Library; Cressona Borough Code §§ 33.35, 33.37, 33.38.

The Paper's Own Claim, Tested

The article's deck says Cressona is one of few municipalities to operate burial grounds. As printed, that will not stand up, and what has been found runs the other way. Pennsylvania's Borough Code gives borough cemeteries a chapter of their own, running from appropriations for upkeep through management by commission, transfer out to a company, transfer in from one, neglected and abandoned grounds, and the purchase of plots for deceased service members. A legislature does not write that chapter for one borough.

The examples are not hard to find. The Old St. Clair Cemetery is owned and cared for by the borough of St. Clair, in Cressona's own county. Carlisle and Youngwood boroughs both carry cemetery chapters. Denver Borough's code creates a cemetery association of three appointed members. No published count of municipally owned cemeteries in Pennsylvania exists; the state does not know how many cemeteries of any kind it has. Uncommon is defensible. One of few is not, and the claim is the paper's.

Sources: 8 Pa.C.S. ch. 28, Cemeteries; Borough of St. Clair; Carlisle, Youngwood and Denver borough codes; Pittsburgh Post-Gazette investigation of Pennsylvania cemetery oversight.

CHAPTER SIX

Decorations & Honors

Decorations & Honors

Allen's WW2 service medals, and his later recognition as a sixty-year member of American Legion Post 286, Cressona, Pennsylvania — the same post whose cap he wears throughout the 2006 interview. His discharge papers cite the Good Conduct Medal (General Order 3, Headquarters 3d Attack Group, August 2, 1943) and the Distinguished Unit Badge (General Order 3, Headquarters 3d Attack Group, March 25, 1944) — see his full discharge record in the Military Record section.

American Defense Service Medal

Asiatic-Pacific Campaign Medal, with battle star

Good Conduct Medal

World War II Victory Medal

His medals as mounted and kept by the family: the World War II Victory Medal (top left) and the reverse of the Good Conduct Medal (top right, "Efficiency, Honor, Fidelity"), a five-pointed star service medal, and two ribbon bars.

Sixty-Year Member, American Legion Post 286, Cressona, Pennsylvania — presented to Allen E. Sweigert, Sr.

A "Service to America" certificate of appreciation from American Legion Post 286 and its Auxiliary Unit 286, presented May 29, 2004, marking the dedication of the National World War II Memorial in Washington, D.C.

The reverse of a bronze medal: "UNITED . STATES . OF . AMERICA" arcs around the rim with the dates ". 1941 . 1945 ." completing the circle along the bottom. In the centre, "FREEDOM FROM FEAR AND WANT" is lettered above a laurel spray and "FREEDOM OF SPEECH AND RELIGION" below it. The broad red centre of the ribbon, with one rainbow-striped edge, is folded through the suspension ring at the top.

The reverse of a bronze service medal, its raised lettering reading "FOR SERVICE DURING THE LIMITED EMERGENCY PROCLAIMED BY THE PRESIDENT ON SEPTEMBER 8 1939 OR DURING THE UNLIMITED EMERGENCY PROCLAIMED BY THE PRESIDENT ON MAY 27 1941", with a small laurel spray struck beneath the last line. The suspension ring shows at the top edge of the frame.

The reverse of a bronze campaign medal: a bald eagle in high relief facing left, "UNITED STATES OF AMERICA" lettered in three lines to the right of it and the dates "1941" and "1945" to the left. A small "W" is struck into the field below the eagle's feet, and a striped ribbon shows through the suspension ring at the top.

The reverse of a bronze medal, a wreath of laurel and oak encircling a five-pointed star above a scroll, with "FOR GOOD" lettered above the star and "CONDUCT" below the scroll. The scroll, which was meant to carry the recipient's name, is blank.

His Insignia

Branch and unit insignia from his own collection: U.S. and Army Air Forces collar discs; the 213th Coast Artillery Regiment's crest, motto “Non Solum Armis” (“Not by Arms Alone”); and the “First Defenders” crest of the same regiment's Schuylkill County lineage. Below, two marksmanship qualification badges, bars reading “Coast Arty” and “Pistol D.”

Collar and unit insignia, and marksmanship qualification badges, from Allen's own collection.

An Officer He Photographed

Not one of Allen's own decorations, but a record worth setting beside them: the man whose field modification rebuilt the aeroplanes Allen kept the radios in.

Identified by the family as Maj. — later Col. — Paul Irvin "Pappy" Gunn, photographed by Allen in the kunai grass. Gunn was the officer behind the gun packs in the nose of Allen's squadron's B-25s.

“Pappy” Gunn, and His Own Decorations

Paul Irvin Gunn (18 October 1899 – 11 October 1957) was the most improbable officer in the Southwest Pacific and, for Allen’s squadron, the most consequential. He had served twenty-one years in the Navy, retiring as a chief petty officer in December 1939 after instructing at Pensacola, and was a founder’s partner in Philippine Air Lines when the Philippines fell — leaving his wife and four children interned at Santo Tomas, which is generally held to explain a good deal about how hard he fought the rest of the war. Commissioned straight into the Army Air Forces and attached to the 3rd Bomb Group, he worked with Jack Fox, North American Aviation’s field representative at Charters Towers, on the modification that turned the B-25 into a low-level strafer: eight fixed .50-calibre guns firing forward, four of them through the old bomb-aiming panel. That is precisely the aeroplane Allen describes being handed. Gunn flew B-25 #112498 on the Royce Mission to the Philippines on 11 April 1942, and General Kenney later took him onto his personal staff as his special-projects man.

He finished the war a colonel, holding the Silver Star, two Distinguished Flying Crosses, the Legion of Merit, the Air Medal, the World War II Victory Medal — and nine Purple Hearts. He was killed on 11 October 1957 when his aircraft went down in a storm over the Philippines.

Sources: Paul Irvin “Pappy” Gunn in Australia during WW2, and 3rd Bombardment Group, Australia @ War (ozatwar.com); B-25 Strafer Field Modifications, Australia @ War; Pappy Gunn, Wikipedia. The identification of the man in the photograph is the family’s.

What He Brought Home

The Oceania Notes

The two pieces of paper Allen holds up to the camera belong to a real and very short-lived series. For its Pacific holdings the Japanese Government printed only four denominations — half a shilling, one shilling, ten shillings and one pound — and Allen's pair are the first and the last of them.

The Australian War Memorial's own examples describe the half-shilling as a purple and light brown lithograph with a beach and palms, and the one pound as green and light blue with coconut palms at either border; both carry the words The Japanese Government across the face, serial letters in red block stamps, and what the Memorial calls the standard Japanese watermark of a quatrefoil kiri flower. Numismatists catalogue the series as the Japanese government-issued Oceanian pound, introduced in 1942 and abolished soon after the Co-Prosperity Sphere was dissolved in August 1945. Four denominations make it the shortest set Japan issued anywhere: money for British and Australian territory, for Guam, and for Japan's own South Seas Mandate.

Sources: Japanese invasion currency: 1/2 Shilling note — Australian War Memorial; Japanese invasion currency: one pound note — Australian War Memorial; Japanese government-issued Oceanian pound; Japanese government-issued Oceanian pound (users: Gilbert and Ellice Islands, Nauru, New Guinea, British Solomon Islands, South Seas Mandate; "shortest set … issued"; abolition after August 1945).

“When They Got Into Australia”

Allen was repeating what the Australian Government itself had told the public. On 25 September 1942 Canberra announced that Japanese banknotes “intended for circulation in Australia in the event of a successful invasion” had come into Commonwealth hands, and listed the same four denominations.

Historians have since taken that claim apart. The Imperial Japanese Navy did float a landing in northern Australia in December 1941, and the Imperial Japanese Army rejected it outright: it put the requirement at 150,000 to 250,000 men against the Navy’s 45,000 to 60,000, and would not thin the Kwantung Army to find them. By late February 1942 Japan had settled instead on cutting Australia off from America. Peter Stanley, for many years the Australian War Memorial’s principal historian, puts it flatly: no historian of standing believes the Japanese had a plan to invade Australia, and there is “not a skerrick of evidence.” What the notes really were is worth knowing all the same: money in pounds and shillings, because the places Japan had taken — New Guinea, the Solomons, the Gilberts, Nauru — used Australian currency, and Japan intended to keep them.

Sources: Japanese government-issued Oceanian pound (notes issued for Australian mandated territories and British Oceania); Oceania — Japanese Invasion Money (quotes the Australian Government announcement of 25 September 1942); Proposed Japanese invasion of Australia during World War II; Japanese Occupation Money during WW2 — Peter Dunn, Australia @ War.

"Zillions of Them Around"

On the quantity, his memory is exactly right. The 1942 Australian announcement noted that large quantities of the notes had already been captured by Allied forces in recent operations, and by the time the Fifth Air Force was working its way up the New Guinea coast the things were everywhere in Allied hands — out of abandoned Japanese pay chests and supply dumps, and off the dead.

One documented case is almost contemporary with Allen's own year at Hollandia: Clinton Palmer of the American 49th Fighter Group went back to a Hollandia beach on 24 May 1944 to recover his outfit's equipment and came away with Japanese occupation money taken from bodies lying there. The notes were abolished outright once Japan surrendered, and their worthlessness is precisely what made them free souvenirs; they travelled home in footlockers by the thousand and are still common collector pieces today. His verdict — absolutely worthless — was a fair valuation then and is close to a fair one now.

Sources: Oceania — Japanese Invasion Money (Australian Government statement: large quantities captured in recent operations); Japanese Occupation Money during WW2 — Peter Dunn, Australia @ War (Clinton Palmer, Hollandia, 24 May 1944); Japanese government-issued Oceanian pound (withdrawal in 1945; collector status); Japanese Occupation Money during WW2 — Peter Dunn, Australia @ War (Clinton Palmer, 49th Fighter Group).

The Pass That Was Dropped

The second paper is a safe conduct pass, among the most heavily produced Allied leaflets of the Pacific war. Two organisations made them in Allen's theatre.

The Far Eastern Liaison Office, an Australian-run propaganda and field intelligence unit set up on General Blamey's orders on 19 June 1942, turned out leaflets by the tens of millions, in many languages and dialects, between November 1942 and its dissolution in September 1945; its output is set out below, with the two Pidgin sheets. Its surrender leaflets, its news sheets and its nostalgia leaflets went down over Papua, New Guinea and the Netherlands East Indies. From June 1944 the Psychological Warfare Branch of MacArthur's own headquarters, under Brigadier General Bonner Fellers, did the same work on the American side. Both relied on aircraft to scatter the paper over Japanese positions, and the American air arm in the Southwest Pacific was the Fifth Air Force — the same numbered air force Allen's 90th Squadron and 3rd Bomb Group belonged to. That is explanation enough for how a communications sergeant on the ground ended up with one in his pocket.

Sources: Far Eastern Liaison Office; Guide to the Far Eastern Liaison Office (FELO) Leaflet Collection — Australian War Memorial; Leaflets from the Southwest Pacific Area — USASOC History Office (ARSOF History); Bonner Frank Fellers and Psychological Warfare Leaflets in World War II — Hoover Institution.

Why “Surrender” Became “Cease Resistance”

Allen was reading verbatim, and the leaflet he was holding is in this collection. Its English side prints exactly what he says into the camera: “The bearer of this pass is voluntarily surrendering and should be treated with courtesy, and conducted to the nearest Commanding Officer for transfer to a rear area,” signed Commander-in-Chief, Allied Forces. For a while there was nothing to go on but his voice on the tape; the sheet itself has since been photographed, and the two agree word for word. The bluntness is the point, because that kind of wording was the very thing the Allies learned they had to change.

Japanese prisoners under interrogation explained that the words for surrender, kosan and kofuku, carried a disgrace no leaflet could talk a man past, and the Field Service Code issued to every soldier by War Minister Tojo on 8 January 1941 told him “never live to experience shame as a prisoner.” So the passes were rewritten — American psychological warfare staff and the Australian Far Eastern Liaison Office each claimed the idea — so that the bearer had ceased resistance rather than surrendered, which let a man come in without ever having said the word. The later text runs: the bearer has ceased resistance, treat him well in accordance with international law, take him to the nearest commanding officer. American records show the change tracking a real shift, from one prisoner per hundred Japanese dead in November 1944 to one in seven by July 1945.

Sources: The “I Cease Resistance” Safe Conduct Passes to the Japanese of WWII — PsyWarrior; Senjinkun military code (Field Service Code, 8 January 1941); Field service code (Senjinkun), adopted by the War Dept. 8 January 1941 — National Library of Australia catalogue; Far Eastern Liaison Office (FELO credited with proposing the “cease resistance” wording).

NORTHERN EDITION (AMERICAN)

GUINEA GOLD

Vol. 2. No. 96. In the Field, Tuesday, February 22, 1944 NOT FOR SALE

19 Enemy Ships Sunk, 201 Planes Destroyed In First Two Days Of Assault On Truk

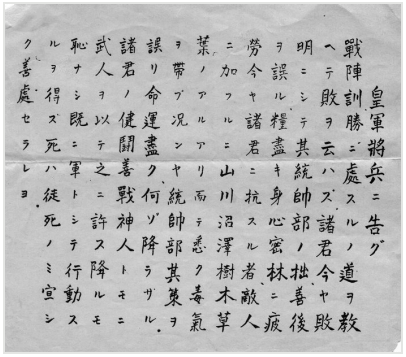
Mighty Allies For "Return To Tokio"

Jap Army & Navy Chiefs Sacked

SIX NAZI DIVISIONS FOUGHT TO STANDSTILL AT ANZIO: FIFTH ARMY ATTACKING NOW

STOP PRESS

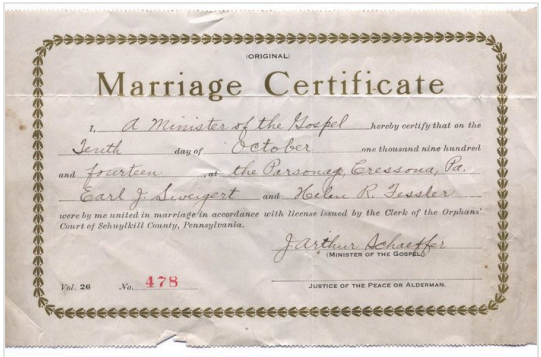
The front page of the Allied forces' field newspaper "GUINEA GOLD", the masthead marked "NORTHERN EDITION (AMERICAN)" and the line beneath it reading "Vol. 2. No. 96.", "In the Field, Tuesday, February 22, 1944" and "NOT FOR SAL..." where the sheet is trimmed. The lead headline runs "19 Enemy Ships Sunk, 201 Planes Destroyed In First Two Days Of Assault On Truk", with side columns headed "Jap Army & Navy Chiefs Sacked", "Mighty Allies For 'Return To Tokio'" and "STOP PRESS", a second banner on Anzio, and a single halftone photograph captioned "DEATH SCENE". Credit: Guinea Gold, the Australian Army's field newspaper in New Guinea; from his own copy.


皇軍將兵ニ告グ

戰陣訓勝ニ處スルノ道ヲ教ヘテ敗ヲ云ハズ諸君今ヤ敗ノ拙善後ニ疲レ勞ヲ誤ル糧盡キ身心窘林ニ抗スル者敵人ニ加ヘル山川沼澤樹木草ノ一葉ニ至ル迄惡ク毒氣ヲ帶ブ況ンヤ統帥部其ノ策ヲ誤リ命運盡ク何ゾ降ラサル諸君ノ健鬪善戰神人トモ稱スベキ武人ヨリ以テ之ニ許ス降ルモ恥ナシ既ニ軍トシテ行動ス

ルヲ得ズ死ハ徒死ノミ宣シク善處セラレヨ

A single sheet of hand-brushed Japanese text in vertical columns of kanji and katakana, read right to left, headed 皇軍將兵ニ告グ — an address to the officers and men of the Imperial Army. The body invokes the 戰陣訓 field-service code and argues that with rations gone, the men worn down in the jungle and the high command's plans miscarried, there is no shame in surrender — 降ルモ恥ナシ — and that to remain is only 徒死, death in vain; it is an appeal urging Japanese troops to give themselves up rather than a personal letter, and it bears no signature, seal or unit mark to show who wrote it.


(ORIGINAL)

Marriage Certificate

I, A Minister of the Gospel hereby certify that on the Tenth day of October one thousand nine hundred and fourteen, at the Parsonage, Cressona, Pa. Earl J. Sweigert and Helen R. Fessler were by me united in marriage in accordance with license issued by the Clerk of the Orphans' Court of Schuylkill County, Pennsylvania.

J. Arthur Schaeffer
(MINISTER OF THE GOSPEL)

Vol. 26 No. 478

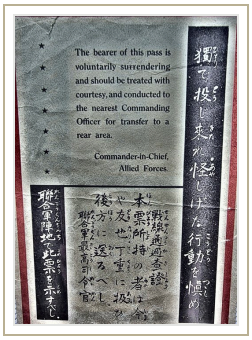
JUSTICE OF THE PEACE OR ALDERMAN.

A printed "Marriage Certificate", folded and worn at the edges, recording that on the "Tenth" day of "October" "one thousand nine hundred and fourteen", at "the Parsonage, Cressona, Pa.", "Earl J. Sweigert" and "Helen R. Fessler" were married under a licence issued by the Clerk of the Orphans' Court of Schuylkill County, Pennsylvania. It is signed "J. Arthur Schaeffer", "Minister of the Gospel", and numbered "Vol. 26", "No. 478".

A photograph of a printed wartime cartoon in two panels: above, a man in a checked jacket leans over a woman lying in bed beside a curtain patterned with stars and stripes; below, figures crawl through broad-leaved jungle undergrgrowth past a cooking pot, one of them in an Australian slouch hat. The printed caption reads "THAT GOES DOUBLE" over "The Slick Yank (in Melbourne): / Take your sweet time at the front, Aussie— / I got my hands full right now— / with your sweet toots... at home—".

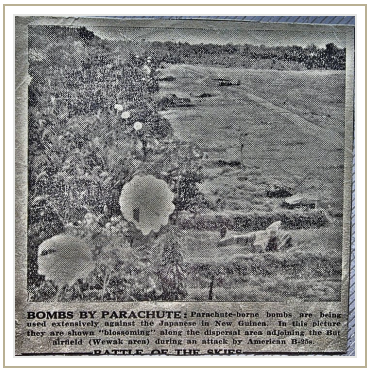
An itemised bill on the letterhead of "BITTLE BROS.", "DEALERS IN" "FURNITURE - CARPETS - RUGS" of "SCHUYLKILL HAVEN, PA.", dated "April 22" "1915" to "Mr Earl J. Sweigert". The hand-written list runs from a "Brass Bed" at 38.00 through dresser, "Chiff", parlor table, couch, rocker, mattress, "Costumer", spring and "5 yds Rug Filler", totalling "158.50" before a deduction marked "Less 10 %".

Japanese Government occupation banknote for Oceania, the obverse of the one-shilling note, printed in blue-grey with a breadfruit branch and numeral "1" at left and a palm-fringed shore at right, lettered "THE JAPANESE GOVERNMENT" and "ONE SHILLING"; a red "OC" block overprint appears twice across the top, and the Japanese line along the bottom edge reads "Government of the Empire of Great Japan".

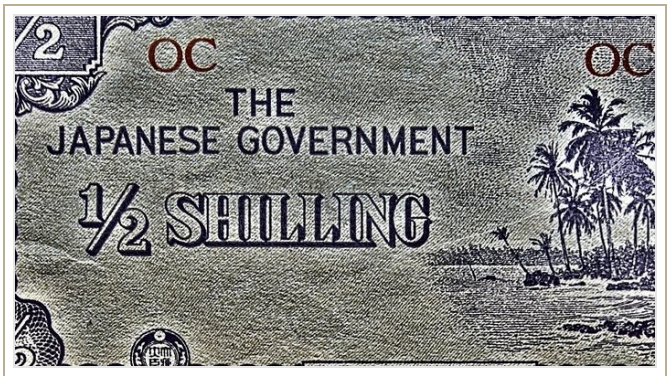


The English side of the same Allied safe-conduct leaflet, printed "The bearer of this pass is voluntarily surrendering and should be treated with courtesy, and conducted to the nearest Commanding Officer for transfer to a rear area." and signed "Commander-in-Chief, Allied Forces.", with a column of seven stars down the left margin and Japanese vertical panels at right and lower left; this is word for word the text Allen reads aloud on camera.

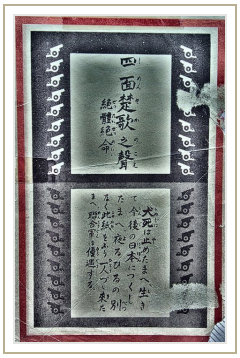
The illustrated face of a Tok Pisin leaflet, printed in colour in two panels: above, villagers in laplaps walking toward a large transport aeroplane marked with a white American star, one man carrying a bow; below, eight men paddling an outrigger canoe along a wooded shore. The lettering between them reads "GUVMENT BELOG YUMI / I REDI IM PLANTI KAIKAI / NAU SELIM NATING" — our government has plenty of food ready and is giving it out for nothing.



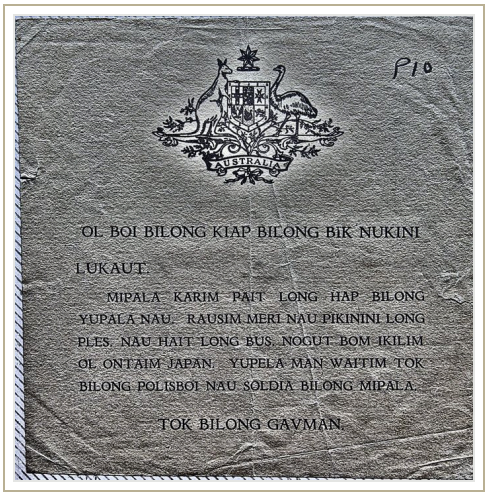
A newspaper clipping he kept: an aerial photograph in which pale parachutes hang scattered over scrub and open ground, with the printed caption "BOMBS BY PARACHUTE: Parachute-borne bombs are being used extensively against the Japanese in New Guinea. In this picture they are shown "blossoming" along the dispersal area adjoining the But airfield (Wewak area) during an attack by American B-25s." A second headline, "BATTLE OF THE SKIES", is cut off at the bottom edge. Credit: the newspaper is not named on the cutting; from his own collection.



A tight crop of one side of the Japanese Government occupation half-shilling note for Oceania, showing "THE JAPANESE GOVERNMENT" over "1/2 SHILLING", palms and a shoreline at right, the corner fraction "1/2" clipped by the crop at upper left, and the red "OC" overprint twice along the top.



The Japanese-language side of an Allied safe-conduct leaflet, in two panels inside a red printed frame with a decorative border of small artillery-piece devices: the heading is the idiom for being hemmed in on every side with no way out, and the body below tells the reader to give up dying a dog's death, to live and serve the Japan that is to come, and to bring the leaflet and come over one man at a time, by night or day, the Allied forces will treat him well.



P10

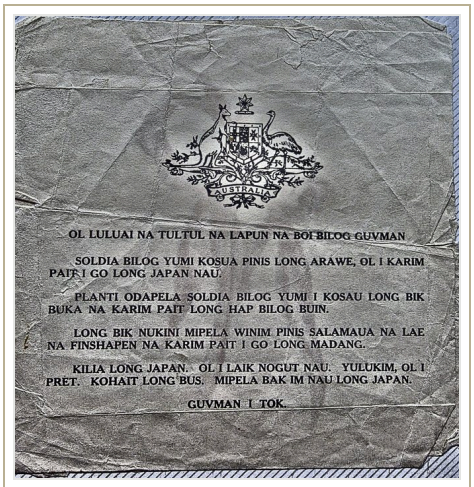
AUSTRALIA

OL BOI BILONG KIAP BILONG BIK NUKINI LUKAUT.

MIPALA KARIM PAIT LONG HAP BILONG YUPALA NAU. RAUSIM MERI NAU PIKININI LONG PLES. NAU HAIT LONG BUS. NOGUT BOM IKILIM OL ONTAIM JAPAN. YUPELA MAN WAITIM TOK BILONG POLISBOI NAU SOLDIA BILONG MIPALA.

TOK BILONG GAVMAN.

A leaflet printed in Tok Pisin beneath the Australian coat of arms, headed "OL BOI BILONG KIAP BILONG BIK NUKINI / LUKAUT." and continuing "MIPALA KARIM PAIT LONG HAP BILONG YUPALA NAU. RAUSIM MERI NAU PIKININI LONG PLES. NAU HAIT LONG BUS. NOGUT BOM IKILIM OL ONTAIM JAPAN. YUPELA MAN WAITIM TOK BILONG POLISBOI NAU SOLDIA BILONG MIPALA." and closing "TOK BILONG GAVMAN." — a warning that the fighting is coming to the reader's area, to take the women and children out of the village and hide in the bush, and to wait for word from the government's police and soldiers; "P10" is pencilled at the upper right.



AUSTRALIA

OL LULUAI NA TULTUL NA LAPUN NA BOI BILOG GUVMAN.

SOLDIA BILOG YUMI KOSUA PINIS LONG ARAWE, OL I KARIM PAIT I GO LONG JAPAN NAU.

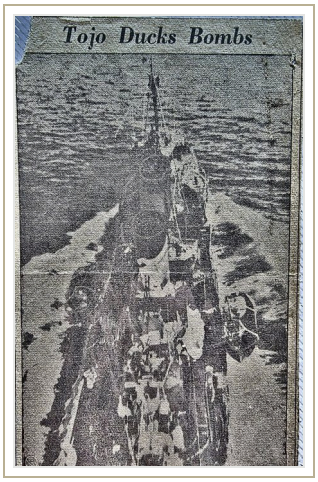
PLANTI ODAPELA SOLDIA BILOG YUMI I KOSAU LONG BIK BUKA NA KARIM PAIT LONG HAP BILOG BUIN.

LONG BIK NUKINI MIPELA WINIM PINIS SALAMAUA NA LAE NA FINSHAPEN NA KARIM PAIT I GO LONG MADANG.

KILIA LONG JAPAN. OL I LAIK NOGUT NAU. YULUKIM, OL I PRET. KOHAIT LONG BUS. MIPELA BAK IM NAU LONG JAPAN.

GUVMAN I TOK.

The printed reverse of the same Tok Pisin leaflet, a single creased and much-folded sheet headed by the Australian coat of arms on a scroll lettered "AUSTRALIA". The text opens "OL LULUAI NA TULTUL NA LAPUN NA BOI BILOG GUVMAN", tells of the fighting at Arawe and past Salamaua, Lae, Finschhafen and Madang, and closes "GUVMAN I TOK."



Tojo Ducks Bombs

A newspaper clipping he kept, headed "Tojo Ducks Bombs". Beneath it is a coarse-screen press photograph, taken from the air almost directly overhead: what appears to be a ship under way on open water, its wake spreading astern, with dark patches in the sea to either side. The newsprint dots are heavy and no marking or name can be read. Credit: the newspaper is not named on the cutting; from his own collection.

A Japanese picture postcard from Allen's collection: sheep grazing in a fenced pasture below a broad, snow-streaked volcano, with cherry trees in blossom along the treeline behind them. The printed verse down the right-hand side begins "蝦夷富士の麓の牧の遅桜" — late cherry blossom at a pasture at the foot of Ezo-Fuji — and is marked "自作", the writer's own composition.

The office that printed them

The two Pidgin sheets Allen brought home belong to a paper war the Australians fought alongside the bombing one. The Far Eastern Liaison Office was set up on 19 June 1942 under the orders of the Allied Land Commander, General Sir Thomas Blamey, and became one of four sections of the Allied Intelligence Bureau established on 6 July 1942; it was commanded by Commander J. C. R. Proud of the Royal Australian Naval Volunteer Reserve, who set down its charge in his own words: all combat propaganda in the South-West Pacific, meaning the lowering of morale in the enemy forces, the misleading of the enemy about Allied military intentions, and the influencing of native peoples in Japanese-occupied areas.

Its chief instrument was the printed sheet. The Australian War Memorial, which holds the surviving collection in forty-nine series along with miscellaneous papers and six albums, records that from November 1942 until FELO's dissolution in September 1945 the office estimated it had produced over 60 million leaflets in fourteen different languages or dialects. The American psychological-warfare literature is less tidy: 69 million in fourteen languages on one page, more than 58 million in six languages and numerous native dialects on another. The honest figure is tens of millions, and no single number will do. Pidgin was no footnote in that output: the Memorial's finding aid catalogues four series addressed to the people of New Guinea in pidgin, coded P, PF, PK and PM, and Series P alone runs to at least ninety-five numbered leaflets, with further series for New Guinea villagers filed under other codes again. Allen's sheets carry the Commonwealth coat of arms because Papua and the Mandated Territory of New Guinea were Australian-administered ground, though the arms alone cannot tell us which office set the type: the military administration on the islands, ANGAU, spoke to villagers in the government's name too.

Sources: Guide to the Far Eastern Liaison Office (FELO) Leaflet Collection, Australian War Memorial; Far Eastern Liaison Office (Wikipedia); The United States PSYOP Organization in the Pacific During World War II (psywarrior.com); US Army Psychological Warfare Branch Leaflets for the Pacific, World War II (psywarrior.com).

“Most of it was Pidgin English”

Asked what language he met along the New Guinea coast, Allen answered plainly that most of it was Pidgin English, and that the people there had been in contact with missionaries before the war. The language he was hearing is called Tok Pisin. It grew out of the nineteenth-century Pacific labour trade, when Melanesians were recruited, and in some cases kidnapped, to work plantations in Queensland and later in Samoa; when labourers were returned to New Britain and New Ireland they carried the pidgin with them, where it stabilised and took in words from German and from indigenous languages, above all the Tolai tongue Kuanua of East New Britain.

By the early twentieth century it had become the working lingua franca between the administration and the villages — the language of missionaries, and of the government’s patrol officers, the kiaps. More than eight hundred separate languages were spoken in the territory, and no single indigenous one could carry an order across a district. That is precisely why the administration printed its leaflets in Tok Pisin rather than in English. The wartime label “Pidgin English” has not aged well: Tok Pisin is now an official language of Papua New Guinea with several million speakers, and linguists class it as a creole rather than a pidgin because so many people learn it first. Allen’s ear was accurate even if the name he used has since been retired.

Sources: APiCS Online, Survey chapter: Tok Pisin (Max Planck Institute); Tok Pisin (Wikipedia); Kiap (Wikipedia).

The warning leaflet: "LUKAUT" LIKELY

The first sheet is a warning. What follows is a rendering of it rather than an official translation, and it runs roughly like this: watch out; we are bringing the fighting into your country now; take the women and the children out of the village and hide in the bush, lest the bombs strike them along with the Japanese; you men, wait for the word of the police and of our soldiers; this is the word of the Government. Two details in the Pidgin repay attention. The leaflet says mipala karim pait, using the exclusive form of "we," the one that pointedly does not include the listener: the Allies are telling villagers that somebody else's fight is about to arrive over their gardens. And the warning turns on kilim, a verb that in Tok Pisin need not mean killing outright — the unambiguous sense is carried by kilim i dai pinis.

The instruction to await the word of the polisboi and of "our soldiers" is a picture of how the administration actually reached a village: through the kiap, his appointed luluai and tultul, and the government's indigenous constables, not through any direct approach by aircrew. The opening line, ol boi bilong kiap bilong bik Nukini, is the hardest to render with confidence; a closely comparable leaflet discussed by former patrol officers opens "Ol Luluai na Tultul na Lapun boi bilong Gavaman," translated there as all luluais, tultuls and all government employees, which suggests Allen's sheet likewise addresses the people in the government's service across the New Guinea mainland, and "boi" here is the colonial usage of the day, now rightly understood as demeaning. No catalogued FELO series number has been found that fits this exact sheet. It is a FELO-type warning leaflet, then, and not, so far as anyone can show, a particular one.

Sources: English–Tok Pisin Dictionary (Humboldt University of Berlin teaching materials); Tok Pisin (Wikipedia), on the inclusive/exclusive first person; Wartime leaflet addressed to New Guinea Natives, Ex-Kiap Network Forum; Kiap (Wikipedia), on luluai and tultul.

The food leaflet: “selim nating” LIKELY

The second sheet, printed in colour with an illustration, is an offer rather than a warning. Again the English is a rendering and not an official translation: our Government has plenty of food ready and is handing it out for nothing. The grammar is doing deliberate work. Where the warning leaflet says mipala, excluding the listener, this one says GUVMENT BELONG YUMI, using the inclusive “we” that takes in speaker and hearer together, so the government is presented as belonging to the villager as much as to the Australians; and selim nating, selling for nothing, is the plain Tok Pisin way of saying it costs you nothing.

The offer was not empty. The Australian New Guinea Administrative Unit, formed on 21 March 1942, was charged with the civil administration of Papua and the Mandated Territory, and its duties expressly included the rehabilitation of the local inhabitants in reoccupied areas: rebuilding villages and gardens, and feeding and doctoring people in districts the fighting had passed through. Where gardens had been eaten out, burned, or abandoned under occupation, a free ration was both relief and argument. As with the warning sheet, no catalogued series number fits this one, and nothing shows whether it was printed while the fighting was on or during the rehabilitation that followed. Both questions are open, and it is only honest to say so.

Sources: English–Tok Pisin Dictionary (Humboldt University of Berlin teaching materials); Tok Pisin (Wikipedia), on yumi as the inclusive first person plural; Australian New Guinea Administrative Unit (Wikipedia); ANGAU rehabilitation, Bougainville (Australian War Memorial film record C188850).

Brown paper parcels tied with string LIKELY

Leaflets are only propaganda once they are on the ground, and getting them there was an aircrew problem. The American psychological-warfare literature records that FELO's bundles were at first dropped in brown paper parcels tied with string, and that the office later adopted what was called the Weigall Device, a time fuse that opened the bundle at a preset altitude so the sheets scattered over a village or a camp instead of thumping into the trees in a block. Commander Proud recorded that a team of FELO officers and non-commissioned officers was attached to RAAF and American air force squadrons, flying on leaflet-dropping missions and briefed to pinpoint the targets.

In the Pacific the work was done by whatever was going, C-47 transports, B-24s, fighters and B-25 Mitchells among them, and fighter pilots are said to have disliked the job because it meant flying low and slow within reach of anti-aircraft fire. That puts leaflets like Allen's squarely in the traffic of the war he served in. No leaflet sortie by the 90th Bomb Squadron has turned up, though, and nothing says how these two sheets came into his hands. He was candid about the same gap elsewhere in the interview, saying of the Japanese invasion money that he knew there were zillions of them around but did not know how he got hold of them.

Sources: The United States PSYOP Organization in the Pacific During World War II (psywarrior.com), on brown paper parcels and the Weigall Device; The Navy's Secret War in the Pacific, Naval Historical Society of Australia, Commander Proud on FELO teams attached to RAAF and USAAF squadrons; US Army Psychological Warfare Branch Leaflets for the Pacific, World War II (psywarrior.com), on aircraft used for leaflet drops.

Memorial Day, Cressona, 2006

The Drum in These Pictures Belongs to His Own Post

The bass drum lettered CRESSONA BAND is the drum of an organisation the American Legion put back together. The band was chartered on 31 March 1902 as the Cressona Cornet Band, was absorbed into the Bressler Band of Schuylkill Haven from 1911 to 1922, and in April 1922 was reorganised as the Cressona Band under American Legion Post 286 — the post of which Allen was a sixty-year member and a past commander.

Instruments were fetched out of attics and cellars and stored in a member's living room until players could be found for them. In August 1956, four months after the Cressona News page reproduced in the previous chapter, the band voted to build its own hall; a plot on Wilson Street was given, and the first rehearsal in the new building was held in February 1957. The band rehearses there still.

Sources: The Cressona Band, Band History, compiled by John P. Shoener.

Where These Photographs Were Made

Not at the cemetery. There are no headstones and no burial rows in any frame. One shows a rough granite boulder set with a bronze tablet, a flagpole, a clipped hedge with small flags planted along it, overhead wires and a red commercial sign at the roadside; the wide frame of the service shows banner-draped tables and a lectern on open grass, a chain-link fence and a stack of pallets behind, and timber steps climbing the bank.

That is the American Legion Plaza on Front Street, where the parade ends and the programme is held. The borough cemetery is on Ash Street, half a mile off. The distinction matters, because Allen spent twenty years running the other place, and because the observance now comes in two parts: a Legion service at the cemetery about half past seven in the morning, and the parade afterwards, forming at the aluminium works at nine and ending at the plaza.

Sources: Republican & Herald, "Around the region," 15 May 2017 (parade route); Reading Eagle, Cressona Legion Memorial Day notice, 14 April 2024; Cressona Borough Council minutes, 3 February 2020.

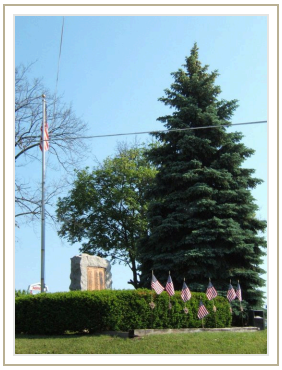
He Described a Memorial Day That Had Already Stopped

These photographs were made in the summer of 2006. Eight months earlier, a reporter asked him what he remembered best about the cemetery work, and he answered with something that had already gone: that years ago, at the end of each Memorial Day parade, the children in the parade would place flowers or flags on the graves of veterans. “That was a big day. It was a meeting place for people coming back to visit their old friends.”

The same article says plainly that the parade no longer goes to the cemetery. What he described, then, was already gone, and these pictures show what was left of the day: the band in the street, the Legion service, and small flags ranked along a hedge at a memorial stone rather than set on graves. Nobody wrote down the year the parade stopped going, and nothing since has turned it up.

Sources: Andrea T. Turano, “The borough cemetery,” Republican & Herald, 16 October 2005, p. C1.

Photographed by Jeremy in the summer of 2006 — the same season as the interview — at the service of American Legion Post 286, of which Allen was a sixty-year member and a past commander.



A village war memorial: a rough granite boulder set with a bronze tablet of names, and small United States flags in bronze grave-marker holders ranked along the hedge in front. The flag on the pole beside it hangs slack at the top of the staff in still air; overhead power lines cross the frame, and a red commercial sign behind the shrubbery is only partly readable, as "AGW...".

The same band from closer in, the "CRESSONA BAND" bass drum riding on its wheeled carriage as the drummer plays. A "STOP" sign marks the corner and the sign on the building behind is only partly readable, as "...RILL".

Allen, in an American Legion garrison cap and white polo shirt, stands behind the emblem-draped table with his hand on his walking frame, mouth open in a laugh, while those seated around him applaud; a POW-MIA cloth hangs over the chair beside him. A commercial sign beyond the chain-link fence reads "MULCH BULK + BAG".

A man in a light uniform shirt and sunglasses works the halyard with the flag hanging partway up the pole, while two colour-guard members in pale blue shirts, white belts and white gloves stand at the salute. A rough-cut granite memorial stone stands at right against the evergreens.

Allen with both his sons, shoulder to shoulder beside a corrugated-metal building — John Sweigert at the left, Allen in the centre, Allen Sweigert, Jr. at the right. His cap is lettered "286" and "PENN..." and seated with a chair or wheeled walker behind him. The man at left has a red crepe poppy pinned to his shirt, and furled parade banners on staffs stand against the wall behind, the red one partly readable as "...ROOP 130".

Folding chairs and three banner-draped tables stand ready on the grass before a service begins, the centre drape carrying the American Legion emblem and the word "LEGION", with a plain wooden lectern beside it. Two small United States flags in bronze grave-marker holders and a low white marker stone are set out at right, with a metal-sided building, a chain-link fence and stacked wooden pallets behind.

A community band plays in the street, the bass drum lettered "CRESSONA BAND" around a gold lyre; some twenty musicians in white shirts, black trousers and dark caps work through clarinets, trumpets, saxophones and a tuba. Spectators line the kerb, a "STOP" sign stands at the corner, and a small sign on the building behind reads "AMERICAN LEGION".

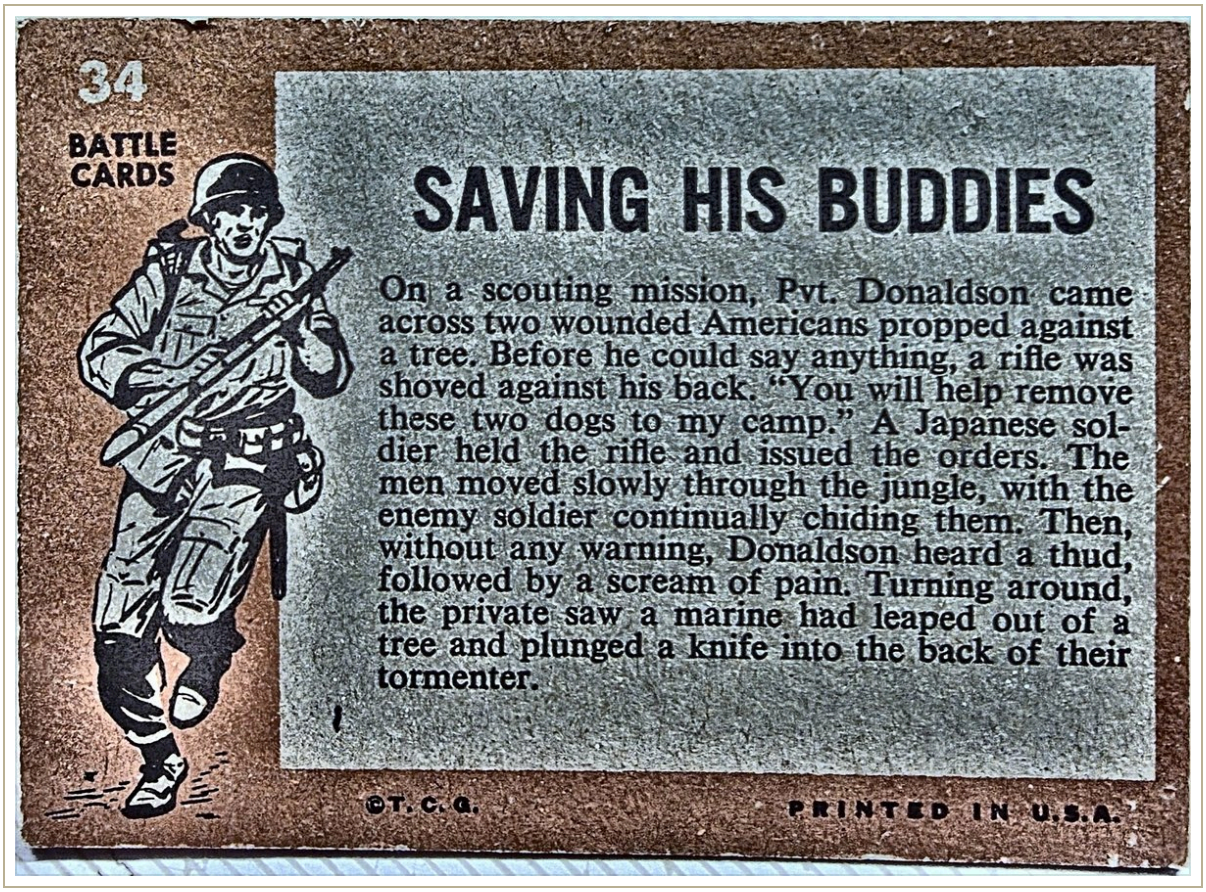
Four men stand behind a table draped with the American Legion emblem banner. Allen is second from the left, in a garrison cap and tan jacket with his hand on his walking frame and a red crepe poppy at his lapel; at the end of the row, one in a garrison cap, white shirt and dark tie, one in a red blazer and cap, and one in a dark suit. A black POW-MIA cloth is laid over the chair in front, and a United States flag on a stand rises at left.

A wide view of the service: a man in a garrison cap stands at the lectern in front of a table draped with the word "LEGION", with about a dozen people ranged behind banner-draped tables, four of them saluting and one in desert-pattern camouflage. A United States flag stands unattended in a floor stand at left and furled flags on planted poles at right; a white marker stone with two small flags sits on the grass, and timber steps climb through the foreground.

A Card That Is Not From the War

Kept with the wartime papers, but twenty years younger than they are.

The front of card 34 of Topps' "Battle" set, issued in 1965 — twenty years after the war, not during it: a painted jungle scene captioned "SAVING HIS BUDDIES" in a yellow banner at the top right. At the left a man plunges head-first from a tree, hands reaching down; at the centre a soldier in a peaked field cap marked with a red disc, a red sunburst on his sleeve, holds a bolt-action rifle across him; and at the right a bareheaded man and a man in a steel helmet sit propped together, with a further bandaged arm running off the right edge of the crop.



The reverse of the same gum card — number "34" of a series marked "BATTLE CARDS", with a line drawing of a helmeted infantryman carrying a slung rifle down the left side, and footed "©T.C.G." and "PRINTED IN U.S.A." Under the heading "SAVING HIS BUDDIES" a block of story text tells of a Pvt. Donaldson who, on a scouting mission, found two wounded Americans and was forced at rifle point to help carry them to an enemy camp.

The trading card is not from the war

The card in the collection can be pinned down exactly, and doing so takes it out of the war altogether. Its reverse carries the words BATTLE CARDS beside the number 34, the copyright mark of T.C.G. — initials Topps used for its chewing gum business — and the line PRINTED IN U.S.A. The front carries its title in a yellow panel set inside a white frame, exactly as collectors describe cards 1 to 53 of the set. Those are the marks of card 34, Saving His Buddies, from Topps' sixty-six-card set Battle, issued in 1965. A near-identical English set was put out by A. & B. C. of London, running to seventy-three cards — the seven extra ones leaders and fighters, with a checklist at the end — and later British printings quietly dropped four of the bloodiest scenes.

But the card here names its own country of manufacture along the foot, so it is the American original and not the British issue. So it is not something Allen carried home in a barracks bag in 1944. It reached the family twenty years after his discharge at Fort Dix on 8 June 1945, and nobody wrote down whose hand put it in the box.

Sources: 1965 Topps Battle: The Story of World War II — Trading Card Database; 1965 Topps Battle Trading Cards Checklist, Set Info, Buying Guide — Cardboard Connection; Non-Sports Cards — 1965 Topps Battle, PSA CardFacts; 1965 A&BC Battle Cards (England) — Dean's Cards.

Pvt. Donaldson was never a man

The printed story on the reverse follows a scout named Pvt. Donaldson who comes on two wounded Americans propped against a tree, feels a rifle shoved into his back, is ordered by a Japanese soldier to help carry the two men — 'these two dogs' — to an enemy camp, and is delivered when a marine leaps out of a tree and puts a knife into their captor. No action of the kind turns up in any record, and no soldier of that name has ever been traced. The Battle set was scripted by Len Brown of Topps with Woody Gelman and painted by Norman Saunders, and it invented its soldiers freely; collectors have catalogued its Capt. Dis Hassin bailing out of a burning plane and its Brad Barnett taken by the Germans, and Brown himself put the share of his made-up captions at eighty to eighty-five percent.

The last thirteen cards then set all of it alongside genuine men — de Gaulle, Churchill, MacArthur. The card belongs in the case, but it has to be labelled as 1965 commercial fiction, so that no reader takes Pvt. Donaldson for a man in the 90th Squadron or the scene for anything Allen witnessed.

Sources: More Topps Trading Card Madness — The Bedlam Files; 1965 Topps Battle Trading Cards Checklist, Set Info, Buying Guide — Cardboard Connection; Collecting the 1965 Topps Battle Set — PSA; Battle! Story in Text (Bob Heffner) — independent transcription of card 34, 'Saving his Buddies'.

Battle, 1965: the last of the serious war cards LIKELY

Battle ran to sixty-six cards of two and a half by three and a half inches, the first fifty-three of them combat scenes and the last thirteen given over to commanders, statesmen and checklists. Norman Saunders, who had painted Mars Attacks for the same company three years before, supplied the pictures, and every pack also held a U.S. Military Cloth Emblem, two inches by three and five-sixteenths, one of twenty-four unit patches — 7th Army, 2nd Division, the 442nd Regimental Combat Team — with card 65 printed as their checklist.

Collectors read the set as a mash-up of the Philadelphia war cards of 1938 and Topps' own Civil War News of 1962, and the link is a real one: Len Brown and Woody Gelman had built Civil War News first. It did not sell well, and collectors' accounts agree that its failure ended the company's straight-faced war sets, after which its non-sport output turned to humour. The only chewing gum anywhere in Allen's own account is the stick he reached into his bag for on Christmas Eve in the jungle, when he brought his hand out with a scorpion hanging on his fingers and had to go to the medics before the picture started.

Sources: 1965 Topps Battle Trading Cards Checklist, Set Info, Buying Guide — Cardboard Connection; Non-Sports Cards — 1965 Topps Battle, PSA CardFacts; More Topps Trading Card Madness — The Bedlam Files; Collecting the 1965 Topps Battle Set — PSA.

The wartime cards this one imitates, and the age he was when they sold

The format — a painted horror on the front, a caption in a panel, a story and a number on the back — was worked out in Philadelphia before the war by Gum, Inc. Horrors of War came out in 1938 and reached two hundred and eighty-eight cards in two series, the first two hundred and forty on the wars in Spain, Ethiopia and China and the rest on the Japanese border clashes and Hitler's move into the Sudetenland; every back closed with the line that to know the horrors of war is to want peace, and Roosevelt is said to have used them to show an isolationist country what was happening. War News Pictures, a hundred and forty-four cards, followed in 1939 and 1940 and was advertised openly as the sequel; War Gum, a hundred and thirty-two cards, ran from 1941 into 1942 and turned from enemy atrocity toward Allied heroes and commanders.

They were sold to children with bubble gum, and they caused a stir in the press from the day they appeared. What is worth noticing here is his age. Born on 9 September 1918, Allen was nineteen when the first of them reached the candy counter and twenty-three when the last did, already in Battery F and then in uniform for the duration; he was never the boy buying the war for pocket money, he was the young man the pictures were being made about.

Sources: 1938 Gum Inc. Horrors of War Trading Cards — Cardboard Connection; Non-Sports Cards — 1938 Horrors Of War, PSA CardFacts; War Gum (132), Gum, Inc. (R164) United States — Skytamer; War News Pictures (144), Gum, Inc. (R165) United States — Skytamer.

The card sells the hatred; he only admits it

Set the card beside what Allen actually said about the enemy and the contrast is the reason to keep it. His only sight of prisoners came at Hollandia, where the infantry had gone in a day or two ahead of him and he stood on the beach with no orders while a column of captured men was marched past. Reading out a Japanese-language surrender pass that promised the bearer courtesy and conduct to the rear, he answered it himself, saying it all depended on the mood of the captor, that after what they pulled in the Philippines there was not too much love for the Japanese, and then breaking off in the middle of the old slogan about the only good Japanese rather than finish it.

Somewhere in that same exchange — the tape carries no speaker marks, so it may be the interviewer closing the thought — comes the reason a captor might not honour the promise, and it arrives in the very word the card uses for its title: what the enemy had maybe just done to one of the guy's buddies. The card turns that feeling into an adventure with a knife in it and a happy ending. He states it as a fact about himself and his war, hesitates, and leaves the sentence unfinished.

Sources: Allen E. Sweigert interview transcript, Part 1 (family collection), C:/Users/jerem/AppData/Local/Temp/claude/C—Users-jerem/8f3b8b76-e39a-47f3-97b7-b6f6c902d29a/scratchpad/Pt1_clean.txt; 1965 Topps Battle card 34 reverse (family collection), C:/Users/jerem/AppData/Local/Temp/claude/C—Users-jerem/8f3b8b76-e39a-47f3-97b7-b6f6c902d29a/scratchpad/pappap2/readable/p11.jpg; Battle! Story in Text (Bob Heffner) — third-party transcription of card 34 matching the family scan.

CHAPTER SEVEN

ALLEN E. SWEIGERT, SR. · WWII & FAMILY HISTORY

The Record Behind His Words

What the documents say about the story he told from memory

About This Chapter

Allen told his story from memory, sixty-four years after it happened, with no notes in front of him. This chapter is what happens when you take him at his word and then go looking. Nearly everything he says that can be checked, checks — the dates of his crossing, the Dutch markings on his first aeroplanes, the way the Port Moresby strips were named, the ranking of malaria as the theatre's worst enemy, the reclamation depot he worked at for a fortnight after the war. Where the record corrects him, it is almost always on a detail he had already hedged himself.

Each note below is keyed to something he actually said. Every claim in them was researched on its own and then handed to a second reader whose only job was to knock it down; anything that reader could not corroborate was cut or rewritten rather than quietly left in. Where a note is marked LIKELY, it rests on a reading of the evidence rather than on a document that says so outright — and it will tell you as much in its own words.

Two things are worth saying plainly. Where a fact belongs to the 3rd Bombardment Group as a whole, it is credited to the group rather than to Allen's own 90th Squadron: the two are not the same, and what survives for the squadron is much the thinner record of the two. And where Allen himself is the only source, you will be told so — a mission that never flew, or an aerial strung between two trees against regulations, leaves no paperwork behind.

He Was Eighty-Seven in Front of the Camera

Allen was born on 9 September 1918 and the tapes were made in the summer of 2006, so he was eighty-seven when he sat down to them; he turned eighty-eight that September. What he was describing lay between sixty-two and sixty-four years behind him — he had sailed from San Francisco on 31 January 1942 and his foreign service ended on 29 September 1944. He worked without notes. His grandson asked the questions and the camera ran. Objects came into his hands as he talked, and at one point he reads a surrender leaflet aloud, but there was no script in front of him and nothing written down.

Some of what he produced unprompted, a document later confirmed. Four of the Port Moresby strips by their numbers — 3, 7, 14 and 17, every one of them real — and the naming system behind them. The date the ship tied up at Brisbane, 25 February 1942, to the day. The instruction he passed on to bring an aircraft into 7-Mile on the dirt and not the metal, which fits the strip layout recorded in a survey of 9 December 1942. The designations of the training outfit he served in for six months after he came home, the 399th Fighter Squadron of the 369th Fighter Group, both of which stand in that group's published history. And the word he was still reaching for sixty years on, when he said "Revent" — a revetment, which is exactly the thing he was describing.

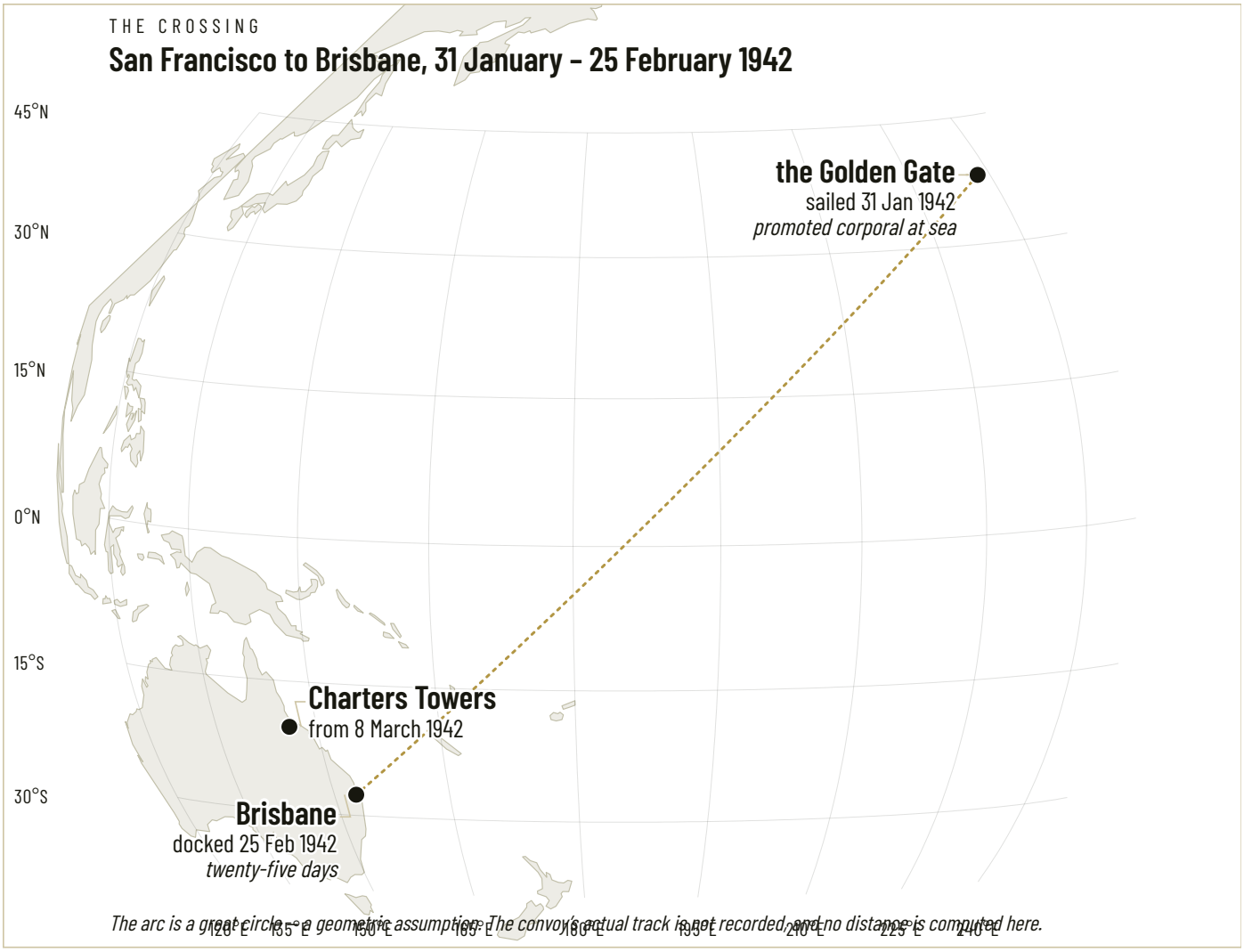
The record corrects him too, and almost always on an interval or a side rather than on a fact. He put about nine months at Camp Stewart, where the regiment had been barely seven weeks. He remembered waiting three or four days at the port of embarkation; Jack Heyn, who crossed on the same ship, logged seven. He had the infantry going ashore at Hollandia a day or two before he did, when the assault had gone in three weeks earlier. He put the strafer's extra guns out on the wings when they hung in packages on the fuselage. And in the same sentence that gets the mile numbers right, he counts them from the coast when they were counted from Port Moresby. Several of those he hedged aloud as he said them — "I guess", "maybe", "about". The mile posts and the wing guns he stated flat.

One miss is of a different kind. He said the Japanese occupation notes were printed for when they "got into Australia", and no historian of standing now believes such a landing was planned. But that was his own side's public claim at the time: Canberra announced on 25 September 1942 that the notes were intended for circulation in Australia in the event of a successful invasion. He was repeating what he had been told, which is not the same fault as misremembering.

Of the hundred and sixty-three dated entries in this document's register, nineteen carry the tapes as their source, several of those corroborated elsewhere as well; a hundred and eighteen rest on a newspaper, a unit record or an official document, twenty-one on family photographs and family memory, and five on his own wartime letters. Something over a hundred separate statements — from the tapes, from the 1942 letters and from the service record book he filled in at each posting — have been set against a document somewhere in these chapters. Eleven have nothing to test them by at all. Of the remaining ninety-eight, about nine in ten stand whole, or stand with one detail adjusted. That last figure is soft — where the line falls around any single statement moves it — and it is an estimate rather than a count.

Method: his 2006 interview, his 1942 letters and his service record book set against the documents cited in these chapters, September 2026. Counts of dated entries taken from the register. That he worked without notes: Jeremy Sweigert, who asked the questions.

The Ship, and the Road Inland



The crossing: San Francisco to Brisbane, 31 January – 25 February 1942, drawn on a globe because that is the shape of it. The arc is a great circle.

▼ THIS DRAWING, SET OUT IN WORDS

- San Francisco, where Convoy 2030 cleared on 31 January 1942 with the USAT Ancon among its transports. He was promoted corporal somewhere at sea.
- Brisbane, where the Ancon docked on 25 February 1942 — twenty-five days.
- Charters Towers, inland to the north-west, where the 89th and 90th Squadrons entrained on 8 March.
- The arc is drawn dotted and labelled as a geometric assumption. The convoy's actual track is not recorded anywhere in this collection, and no distance is computed from it.
- A filled disc marks a place he is documented to have been. An open square marks a place documented for his unit rather than for him. An open square with a diagonal tick marks his own squadron. A dashed

circle marks a place that is inferred rather than recorded.

- A brass ring crossed by a bar marks a place he never stood on — a target, or somewhere his group went without him. Each carries the words HE WAS NOT THERE.
- A solid line is a journey whose means of travel is recorded. A dashed line is a move that is documented while the means is not. A dotted line rests on his own account alone.
- No plate carries a computed distance. His own "about 12,000 miles" already stands here against a measured 9,500 to 10,200, and a third figure, quietly worked out, would only muddy the water.

He never knew the name of the ship he crossed on, or why half the convoy vanished overnight. Both are on the record.

The Ship Had a Name

Allen never learned what he crossed the Pacific on. He describes a big convoy out of San Francisco, ships that halved overnight and a group that rejoined days later, submarine alerts, and a captain who waited until the day before landfall to say where they were going. The 3rd Bomb Group's own veterans' record supplies the missing word in one line: the group **"arrived in Australia from the US on board the S.S. Ancon on 25 February 1942 without planes and a 1st Lieutenant as Group Commander."** That is Allen's date to the day, his squadron's arrival with no aircraft and no airfield — and, for good measure, an explanation of the first name on his own list of commanding officers, which is 1st Lt. Bennett G. Wilson.

Source: 3rd Bombardment Group, Australia @ War (ozatwar.com). See also the convoy note above, which identifies the Ancon as one of six transports in Convoy 2030 — the convoy itself was larger.

Convoy 2030, and the ship that never told them

Allen's dates are almost exactly right, and the documented record fills in everything he was never told. The 3rd Bombardment Group crossed the Pacific aboard the US Army transport Ancon, one of six ships in Convoy 2030, which cleared San Francisco on 31 January 1942 escorted by the light cruiser USS Honolulu and the destroyers USS Morris and USS Ellet. Men of the 39th Fighter Squadron, who sailed on the same ship, recorded boarding on 30 January and standing out into the Pacific at 1515 the following afternoon. His own group boarded at half past one on the morning of the 31st, which explains the 30th he carried for seventy years at least as well, and from closer to him. Either way, the men were aboard before the day the Commonwealth later paid him from. The convoy was never one body: the transports Ancon, Tasker H. Bliss, Hugh L. Scott and Maui were routed to one destination while the President Taylor and President Johnson were bound for two others, so the ships Allen watched vanish overnight had simply gone their own way, and the group that later appeared on the horizon was a rejoining, not a rescue. On 24 February, the day before landfall, the escorting destroyers dropped depth charges alongside the convoy and claimed a Japanese submarine, though Japanese records show no boat lost in that area. The date is the 22nd Bomb Group's, whose men were on the Hugh L. Scott; Jack Heyn, who was aboard the Ancon with Allen, put the same incident on the 23rd. The two accounts are a day apart, and both are allowed to stand. The Ancon tied up at Brisbane on 25 February 1942, the date Allen gives; the 39th's diarist puts the hour at 1300.

Sources: 3rd Bombardment Group — Australia @ War (ozatwar.com); 39th Fighter Squadron History 1941–1944 — 5th Air Force Association; 22nd Bomb Group, The Red Raiders — Australia @ War (Convoy 2030 composition and escorts); 35th Fighter (Pursuit) Group, USAAF — Australia @ War.

When the Cablegram Went, and From Where LIKELY

Neither notice is dated and neither paper has been identified, but the cable behind them can be placed. Heyn describes what the men did at Ascot in the days after landing: “We were allowed short passes and got into town 2 or 3 times, took in a couple movies, bought some necessities and sent a calbegram to the folks. Letting them know that we had arrived safely and were somewhere in Australia.”

The group came ashore on 25 February 1942, and the 89th and 90th Squadrons entrained for Charters Towers on 8 March. Cable traffic home therefore began inside that fortnight, from Brisbane, and was evidently allowed to name the country — which is what both notices report. Since the second says the sergeant’s promotion came soon after arrival, the cable cannot predate the landing, and the notices were most likely set in March or April 1942. That window is built out of Heyn’s account and the notices’ own wording, and out of nothing firmer. No cable form and no telegraph record has ever turned up.

Sources: Jack Heyn, U.S.S. Ancon — Australia @ War; 3rd Bombardment Group station dates.

Promotion at Sea: the Conditions, and No Evidence

No order, diary entry or unit history recording a promotion aboard the Ancon, or aboard any ship in this convoy, has been found. Heyn kept a dated log of the crossing — the alerts, the depth charges, the equator, the day lost at the date line, the white ship that joined on 22 February — and records no promotions at all. Nor does the 39th Fighter Squadron's history.

What the record does show is the situation that would have made promotions necessary. The group sailed having left its senior officers and, in Heyn's words, "some high ranking enlisted men" behind at Savannah, and reached Brisbane "without planes and a 1st Lieutenant as Group Commander." Grades emptied at the top have to be refilled from below. The technician grades, too, had been created by War Department circular three weeks before he sailed. None of that is evidence about Allen Sweigert's own stripes, and no order, date or morning report has been found. But the corporalcy does not rest on his parents' word alone. Answering a direct question from The Call three months later he wrote, "I was promoted to Corporal aboard ship somewhere in the Pacific" — the man himself, in writing, about fifteen weeks after the crossing.

Sources: Jack Heyn, U.S.S. Ancon — Australia @ War; 3rd Bombardment Group — Australia @ War; War Department Circular No. 5, 8 January 1942.

What He Was, Going Up the Gangway LIKELY

Both notices make corporal the first of two promotions since he left the United States, and the cabled one the second. Read at face value, that puts him on 31 January 1942 in a grade below corporal — private first class, or private. It follows that the SGT. of one headline and the Sergt. of the other describe a rank he did not hold on the voyage, and that the man who walked up the Ancon's gangway at half past one in the morning was a nine-month Air Corps private not long out of radio school.

That is arithmetic done on the notices, and it is a guess rather than a finding: no pay record, morning report or promotion order has been seen, and neither notice states his grade at sailing. It does sit easily with the rest: he enlisted in April 1941 and spent twenty-two weeks of that year in school, which is not a year in which a man collects stripes.

Sources: Pottsville Republican, 28 May 1942, p. 18; The Call, Schuylkill Haven, 29 May 1942, p. 1.

His Overseas Clock Started at the Golden Gate

Foreign service was a pay quantity before it was a biographical one, and that is why his official overseas time begins on a day he was still in American water. The Pay Readjustment Act of 1942 raised an enlisted man's base pay by twenty per cent for service beyond the continental limits of the United States, and the Comptroller General stated the rule plainly in 1943: the increase "is authorized from the date of departure from the United States," ceasing on return. The separation form followed the same accounting.

His own figure settles it arithmetically. From 31 January 1942 to 29 September 1944 is two years, seven months and twenty-nine days — the figure on his discharge paper. Measured from the Brisbane landing it would be two years, seven months and five days. The clock he was paid by started at the Golden Gate, not in Australia.

Sources: Pay Readjustment Act of 1942, Public Law 77-607, section 2; Comptroller General decision B-34809, 23 June 1943; TM 12-236, Preparation of Separation Forms, War Department, April 1945.

Five Days on a Troop Train, Seven in a Warehouse

The twelve days between leaving Savannah and standing out of San Francisco were not spent travelling. Jack Heyn, who crossed on the same ship, kept a log: "Jan. 19, '42 we boarded a troop train and headed west... It took us five days to cross the country and arrive in Oakland, Ca." He notes a delay at St. Louis, three hours near McCook, Nebraska behind a wreck on the line, and another wait in the Denver yards. "On the 24th we pulled into Oakland and were taken out to a huge new warehouse bldg., big enough to hold the whole Gp." — cots already up, each squadron its own area. "The next seven days were a waiting and wondering time."

The 3rd Attack Group Association gives the Oakland arrival as the 23rd, a day earlier than Heyn, and nothing found here chooses between them. Allen remembered "maybe three, four days" of waiting at the port. Heyn's log says seven.

Sources: Jack Heyn, The Early Days — Australia @ War; 3rd Attack Group Association, World War II; transcript-part1.html.

“Some racetrack” was Camp Ascot

The racetrack Allen could not name was almost certainly Ascot, beside Eagle Farm in Brisbane’s north. Camp Ascot was among the very first American camps in Australia: the men of the Pensacola convoy marched into it on 23 December 1941, the day after landing, and it was kept on afterwards as the staging camp where newly arrived units were parked while somebody worked out where to send them. It stayed a tent city for the duration, the tents pitched down the middle of the course, small and low and holding two to four men apiece, with some officers quartered in the converted stables and at least one block signposted simply “Camp B”, and it lay a short way from the Hamilton wharves where the transports tied up.

The 39th Fighter Squadron, who had crossed with Allen aboard the Ancon, recorded being quartered by the Australian Army at Ascot Race Track the day they came ashore. The 3rd Bomb Group was under canvas there into early March before it entrained for Charters Towers, where its station date is 10 March 1942. One caution: the neighbouring Doomben racecourse, just across Nudgee Road, was requisitioned as a camp as well, and if any part of the group was sent there instead, there is now no way to tell the two apart.

Sources: Camp Ascot, Brisbane — Australia @ War (ozatwar.com); 39th Fighter Squadron History 1941–1944 — quartered at Ascot Race Track on arrival; Charters Towers — 3rd Attack Group Association; 3rd Bombardment Group — History of War (station dates Brisbane 25 Feb, Charters Towers 10 Mar 1942).

“There isn’t any yet”

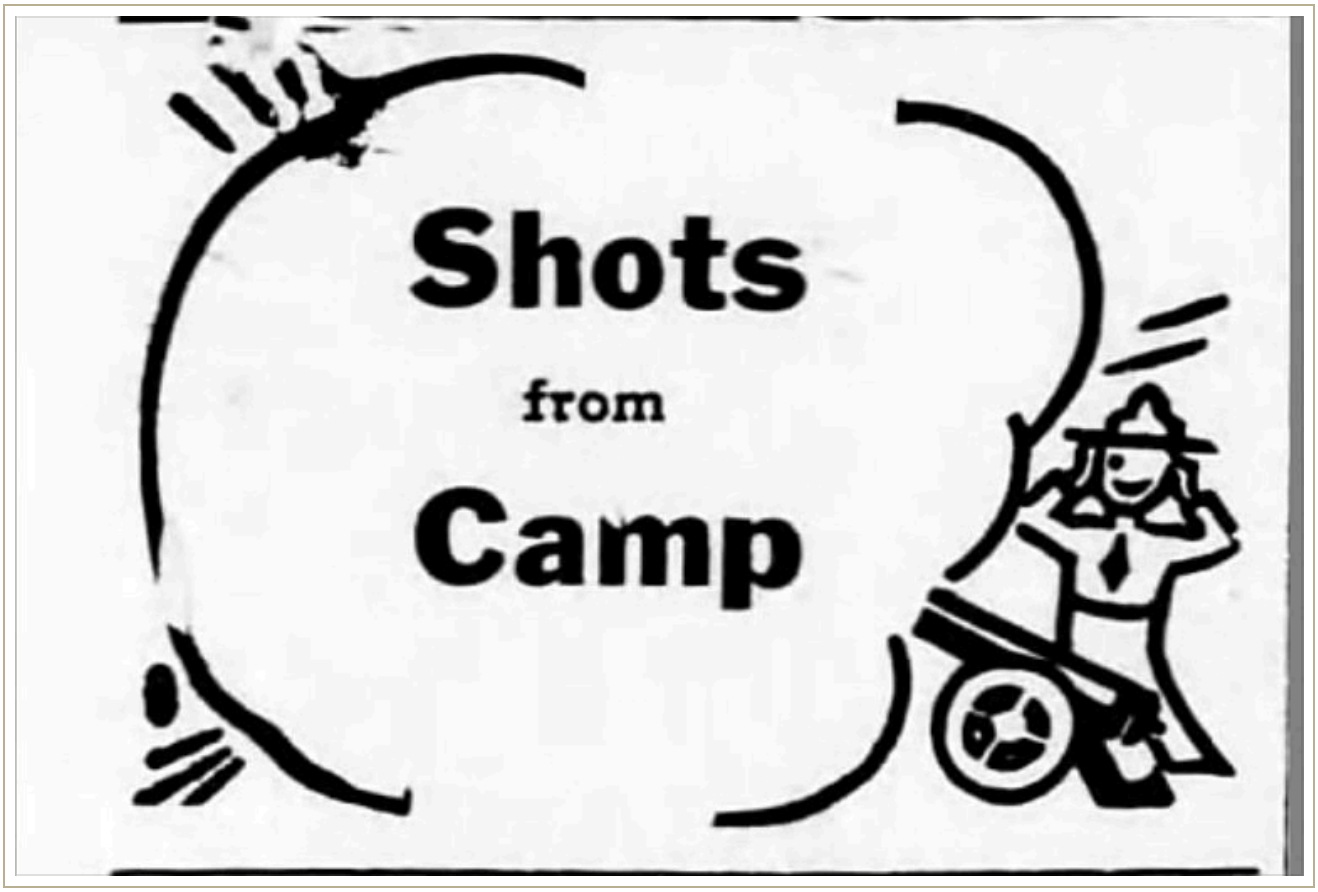
Allen was not exaggerating, and the dates make the point better than any adjective. Work began in earnest on the Charters Towers strip on 16 February 1942, nine days before his convoy reached Brisbane; hundreds of men and every available earth-moving machine were brought up from Townsville, the first gravel strip was finished in seventeen days against a fourteen-day target, and houses near the field were taken over so that personnel could be housed inconspicuously. The 3rd Bomb Group’s station date at Charters Towers is 10 March 1942, so the field Allen walked onto was days old, not years.

Nor did the group bring aircraft: it reached Australia with none, and the first machine onto the new strip was an A-24 Dauntless dive bomber, flown in during March by Major “Big Jim” Davies of the 8th Squadron. The Mitchells came after, when men of the group went down to Archerfield in Brisbane at the start of April 1942 to collect B-25Cs originally consigned to the Netherlands East Indies air force, the aeroplanes with the Dutch markings and the Dutch handbooks he remembers so vividly. The other strips that grew up around the town, Breddan to the north and Reid River out towards Townsville, came later and belonged to other outfits, so the bare, baked, treeless ground Allen describes is the Charters Towers strip itself, on the ridge at the edge of town.

Sources: Bore Sight Range and Compass Swinging Platform at Charters Towers Airfield (Queensland Heritage Register history); Charters Towers airfield (‘Charley’s Trousers’) — Australia @ War; 3rd Bombardment Group — Australia @ War (arrival without aircraft; Dutch B-25Cs collected April 1942); 3rd Bombardment Group — History of War (station date 10 March 1942).

His Own Letter Home, May 1942

Everywhere else in these pages, Allen’s voice comes from a recording made in 2006, when he was eighty-seven, remembering across sixty-four years. Not here. The Call of Schuylkill Haven — the paper a Lions Club was posting out to him in Australia — asked him for news, and he sat down and answered. It is the only thing in the collection he wrote at the time.



The standing head the paper ran his letter under.

Somewhere in Australia,

May 19, 1942

To "The Call":

First of all I want to express my appreciation to the Lions Club for having The Call sent to me. I certainly do appreciate it. It sure feels good to get the paper from around home, especially when you are about 12,000 miles from home. The mail doesn't come very often but when it comes there is always a few Calls among it.

We had quite an interesting trip over here but I can't tell about it. At present we are very busy with our work. I can't tell you what we are doing but we're right in there giving a good account of ourselves.

As for the information you asked for, I have had two promotions since I left the States. I was promoted to Corporal aboard ship somewhere in the Pacific and recently I was promoted to Sergeant and Air Mechanic First Class in radio operating and maintenance.

Previous to my service in the Air Corps I was with the 213th Coast Artillery and was inducted into federal service with that unit. It was while encamped with this unit at Camp Stewart, Ga., that I joined the Air Corps. Since then I have graduated from the Air Corps technical schools at Scott Field, Ill., on Oct. 27, 1941, and participated in the army maneuvers in the Carolinas last fall.

The most popular times here are when the mail comes, chow and the broadcasts each night from San Francisco and New York. We manage to get to a town once in a while to the movies.

The people here are very friendly and we get along fine with the Aussie soldiers that we come in contact with.

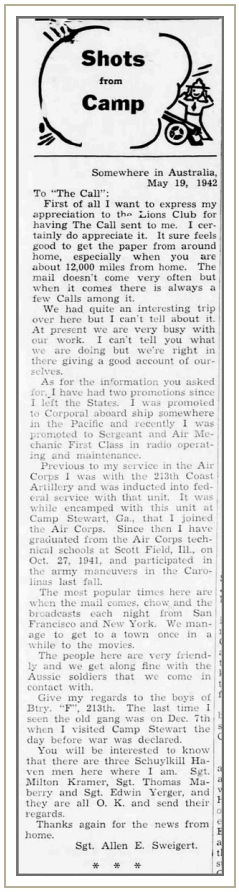
Give my regards to the boys of Btry. “F”, 213th. The last time I seen the old gang was on Dec. 7th when I visited Camp Stewart the day before war was declared.

You will be interested to know that there are three Schuylkill Haven men here where I am. Sgt. Milton Kramer, Sgt. Thomas Maberry and Sgt. Edwin Yerger, and they are all O. K. and send their regards.

Thanks again for the news from home.

Sgt. Allen E. Sweigert.

Printed under the standing head “Shots from Camp” in The Call, Schuylkill Haven, Pennsylvania, 12 June 1942, page 1. End-of-line hyphens forced by the column measure have been closed up; every other mark, including the grammar, is as set. Nothing on the clipping is illegible.



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Thanks again for the news from home.

Sgt. Allen E. Sweigert.

* * *

The whole column as it appeared: The Call, Schuylkill Haven, Friday 12 June 1942, page 1. Credit: The Call, Schuylkill Haven.

home.

Sgt. Allen E. Sweigert.

The signature: Sgt. Allen E. Sweigert.

What He Could Not Say, and Said So Twice

Set against the press rules in force on 12 June 1942, clause by clause, the letter is clean — and clean in a way that looks deliberate. He names no unit he is then serving in — not the 90th Bombardment Squadron, not the 3rd Bombardment Group — which is the one thing an Office of Censorship ruling of 28 March 1942 forbade outright. He names no place inside Australia; the dateline is the approved formula. He names no ship, no port and no date for the crossing, only "aboard ship somewhere in the Pacific." He describes no aircraft, no airfield and no operation.

Twice he says plainly that he cannot: "We had quite an interesting trip over here but I can't tell about it," and "I can't tell you what we are doing." And in a letter written from north Queensland he says not one word about the weather — at a moment when the code was asking American papers to avoid even rain, overcast, windy or clear. A man whose trade was signals knew exactly where the line was.

Sources: Office of Censorship, Code of Wartime Practices for the American Press, 15 January 1942, and the release to editors of 28 March 1942; Robert E. Summers, Wartime Censorship of Press and Radio (1942).

Twenty-Four Days, Tent to Press

He dated it 19 May 1942 and the paper printed it on 12 June. Inside those twenty-four days the letter had to be handed in unsealed, read by a unit censor, carried out of north Queensland, cross the Pacific, cross the United States, reach a weekly in Schuylkill Haven, be set in type and go to press.

Surface mail from Australia took longer than that on its own, so the letter almost certainly flew part of the way and cannot have sat about at any stage. The figure is worth keeping because it sets the scale for everything else: nothing else in the collection got from his hand to a printed page faster, and any undated letter behind a later clipping should be reckoned to have taken at least this long, and probably a good deal longer.

Sources: The Call, 12 June 1942, p. 1; War Department Pamphlet No. 21-1, 29 July 1943.

“Air Mechanic First Class” Is His Own Phrase UNCERTAIN

He writes that he was “promoted to Sergeant and Air Mechanic First Class in radio operating and maintenance.” Three weeks earlier the Pottsville Republican, working from his parents’ cable, had rendered the same thing as “1st class air merchanic sergeant.” Two papers setting the same odd words independently means the wording came from him and not from a compositor, which disposes of the easy explanation that a home-town paper garbled it.

No United States Army or Army Air Forces grade, rating or specialty called Air Mechanic First Class has been found in any source consulted. The nearest American structure is the old specialist ratings, first through sixth class, carrying extra pay — and those were replaced by the technician grades on 8 January 1942, three weeks before he sailed. Air Mechanic 1st Class was a Royal Air Force rank, and he was working alongside Australians. The likeliest explanation is a first-class specialist rating described in the language men actually used. That is a guess, and worth saying so. His phrase is quoted here rather than translated.

Sources: The Call, 12 June 1942, p. 1; Pottsville Republican, 28 May 1942, p. 18; War Department Circular No. 5, 8 January 1942.

The Broadcasts, a Week Before There Was a Service

“The most popular times here are when the mail comes, chow and the broadcasts each night from San Francisco and New York.” The Armed Forces Radio Service was established by War Department order on 26 May 1942 — seven days after he wrote that sentence.

The Radio Division that preceded it had been broadcasting overseas since the spring of 1941, as this chapter notes elsewhere, and shortwave carried news and sport from both American coasts. What the letter adds is a dated, first-hand instance, from a man whose trade was radio and who would have known what he was listening to. The San Francisco signal was almost certainly KGEI, General Electric’s shortwave station, for a time the only American shortwave station heard across the Pacific; the New York end was General Electric’s transmitters at Schenectady. And it bears out something said elsewhere here: a squadron’s news depended on whoever happened to have a receiver.

Sources: The Call, 12 June 1942, p. 1; KGEI, General Electric’s shortwave station; Armed Forces Radio Service.

A Lions Club Was Paying for His Newspaper

The letter opens with thanks "to the Lions Club for having The Call sent to me." So in May 1942 a Lions Club was buying overseas subscriptions for servicemen, and one of them reached a tent in north Queensland. It does not say which club. The Call was Schuylkill Haven's paper, Allen lived in Cressona, and he sends regards to three Schuylkill Haven men, so a Schuylkill Haven club is the obvious candidate.

The point is not settled, but it is narrower than it looks. His obituary calls him a charter member of the Cressona Lions Club, and that club's charter night is now on the record: Wednesday 18 June 1947, five years after this letter, with Schuylkill Haven as its sponsoring club. If the club posting him the paper were Cressona's, this letter would have it buying overseas subscriptions five years before its own charter night. How long a group may meet before it is chartered, this document has no source for; on its own wording the letter will not carry that weight either way, and it does not say he belonged to whichever club sent it. Five years later his name was on the printed roll of charter members at Cressona; eight years later that club elected him a director for two years; fourteen years later he was in the room when a Lions scrap drive was read out; and at some later date, which the obituary does not give, he held its Melvin Jones Fellow Award.

Sources: The Call, 12 June 1942, p. 1; The Call, Schuylkill Haven, 20 June 1947, p. 1; Pottsville Republican, 19 June 1947, p. 20; Pottsville Republican, 18 May 1950, p. 2; The Call & Orwigsburg News, 12 April 1956, p. 9; Republican and Herald, Pottsville, 30 March 2012, p. A12.

Three Other Men, and a Battery He Had Left

He names three Schuylkill Haven sergeants serving where he was — Milton Kramer, Thomas Maberry and Edwin Yerger — and reports them well. None of the three appears anywhere else in this collection.

He also sends "regards to the boys of Btry. 'F', 213th," the battery he had left thirteen months earlier, and dates his last sight of them: "on Dec. 7th when I visited Camp Stewart the day before war was declared." There is a small tangle in that sentence. 7 December 1941 was the day of the Pearl Harbor attack; the declaration followed on the 8th. So "the day before war was declared" is literally correct for a visit on the 7th, and it reads oddly all the same. Either it is his own shorthand or the visit was the 6th and the date slipped. Nobody can now say which.

Sources: The Call, 12 June 1942, p. 1.

Twelve Thousand Miles Is a Figure of Speech

"Especially when you are about 12,000 miles from home." It is the one quantity in the letter that does not check. He was rounding, not measuring.

Cressona to Charters Towers, where his squadron then was, is about 9,570 miles by great circle; Cressona to Brisbane about 9,520. The route he actually travelled — the rail journey west, the Pacific crossing and the run north from Brisbane — comes to roughly 10,200 miles measured point to point, and rather more as convoys and troop trains actually went. Twelve thousand is high by fifteen to twenty-five per cent depending on how it is counted. It was a serviceman's round number for Australia, and nothing turns on it.

Sources: The Call, 12 June 1942, p. 1; Great-circle distances computed from coordinates.

Standing By for the Coral Sea

A pre-dawn call, a ten-minute gunnery course, and three days beside an aeroplane waiting for a mission that a sea battle cancelled.

His Own Commanding Officer Flew the One Contact

There is a detail in the 3rd Bomb Group's own veterans' record that closes the circle on Allen's story, and it turns on a name in his own handwriting. Land-based aircraft took almost no part in the Battle of the Coral Sea — with one exception: a single sighting, and an hour spent trailing the Japanese ships, by **Lt. Hubbard and Lt. Rose in a B-25 Mitchell of the 3rd Bomb Group**. Hubbard is the second name on the list of commanding officers Allen wrote into his own service record book: Lt. Col. Ronald D. Hubbard, of the 90th Bomb Squadron. So the job Allen was woken in the dark to do — shadow the fleet, stay on the air, let the squadron home in on his signal — was, in the event, done in outline by his own squadron commander, in the same type of aeroplane, over the same water, while Allen sat beside a parked Mitchell in Queensland waiting for a truck that never came.

The same page carries a photograph of the group's club, "The Last Slug," at 26 Aland Street in Charters Towers, with the men named step by step. On the sixth step, side by side: Harry Rose, Bob Ruegg, "Pappy" Gunn and Bob Strickland. Rose and Hubbard, Gunn and the officers whose surnames Allen copied into his book at every posting — for a few months in 1942 they were all in one small Queensland mining town, and two of them flew the only land-based aeroplane to find the fleet.

Source: 3rd Bombardment Group, Australia @ War (ozatwar.com) — "Land based aircraft took no part in the Battle of the Coral Sea, except for a single sighting and one hour trail of Japanese ships by Lt. Hubbard and Lt. Rose in a B-25 Mitchell bomber of the 3rd Bomb group"; and the group's own transcription of Allen's service-record commanding officers.

Woken Before Dawn: What Headquarters Already Knew

Allen was pulled out of his cot in the dark, told he was flying, and then left standing by an aeroplane for two or three days with nothing to do. The reason lay in signals traffic he was never shown. Allied codebreakers at FRUMEL in Melbourne had read enough Japanese naval cipher by 9 April 1942 to name Port Moresby as the objective of what the Japanese called Operation MO, and on Anzac Day 1942 General Headquarters, South West Pacific Area, signalled the north Queensland ports about the "Possibility of AIR Raid by carrier based aircraft in force against EAST coast of Australia, by 2 May. Combined with landing attempt at PORT MORESBY." Port commanders were ordered to see that the anti-aircraft weapons on every ship in harbour were manned, twenty-four hours a day. Townsville's schools had already been closed under a ban on coastal schooling and its pupils sent inland to Charters Towers. The Japanese troopships carrying the South Seas Detachment sailed from Rabaul for Port Moresby on 4 May. Allen never dates his long, useless wait beside the aircraft — but the pre-dawn alert, the days of standing by, and the raid nobody on the flight line would explain are exactly the shape of that week in north Queensland.

Sources: Front-line Townsville 1942 — Anzac Day Commemoration Committee; Operation Mo (Wikipedia); Battle of the Coral Sea, 4-8 May 1942 — Australian War Memorial; 3rd Bombardment Group — Australia @ War.

Homing Them In: What His Job Actually Was

Allen was not sent to bomb anything. His job was to transmit, and to let the rest of the squadron find the Japanese fleet by finding him. The equipment made that genuinely possible. A B-25C carried the SCR-287 liaison set, a BC-375 transmitter with a BC-348 receiver, and the BC-375 could be tuned as low as 200 kilocycles; the aircraft's SCR-269 radio compass covered 200 to 1,750 kilocycles and swung its loop onto whatever it was tuned to.

One aeroplane keying steadily down at the bottom of that band was therefore a beacon any other Mitchell in the group could steer straight down. Shadowing an enemy fleet for hours and radioing its position was recognised work — the Royal Navy had ordered two purpose-built "fleet shadower" prototypes in 1938, before radar made the idea redundant and the project was cancelled. At Coral Sea the finding fell to others: Australian-based B-17s bombed the invasion force on 6 May and reported a carrier at sea, and it was a Yorktown scout bomber that sighted the covering force on the morning of 7 May and sent the strike that sank Shoho on its way. If the 90th Squadron ever wrote Allen's particular scheme down, the paper has not survived. He is the only source for it.

Sources: SCR-269 radio compass (BC-433, 200–1750 kc) — RadioNerds; BC-375E Technical Description (200 kHz — 12.5 MHz, liaison transmitter, SCR-287 with BC-348); Transmitter BC-375 — Radiomuseum; General Aircraft Fleet Shadower (Wikipedia) — the shadowing role.

Why the Crew Called It Suicide LIKELY

Allen says the verdict in the crew was unanimous and unsentimental, and the arithmetic behind it is not hard to reconstruct. A single B-25, unescorted at that range, would have had to hold station in daylight above a force screened by carrier fighters, and it could not go quiet to hide, because keeping the key down was the entire mission.

A transmitter that never stops hands out a bearing, and the Japanese were working the same low band themselves, with direction-finding gear aboard their warships and homing beacons of their own. Nothing in the documented record says that higher command regarded that crew as expendable, and no unit history found for this project mentions the standby mission at all — a mission that never flew tends to leave no operational trace. What survives is Allen's memory of what his crew decided about their own chances while they sat by an aeroplane in the Queensland heat and waited for a truck.

Sources: The Naval Radio Beacons of Imperial Japan (Zuikaku transmitting on 359 kHz at Coral Sea) — RealClearHistory; General Aircraft Fleet Shadower (Wikipedia) — the shadowing role; Battle of the Coral Sea, 4-8 May 1942 — Australian War Memorial.

A Ten-Minute Course on the Worst Turret in the Air Force

The guns Allen was hurriedly shown were real, and so was their reputation. The B-25B, C and D carried a Bendix retractable belly turret with twin .50 calibre machine guns that were not aimed over the barrels but remotely, by a gunner kneeling over a periscope gunsight — an uncomfortable crouch nobody could hold for long.

Gunners tracking a fighter through that lens and mirror system suffered vertigo, and the turret was hard to work and prone to jamming, often in the lowered position. Squadrons took to pulling them out in the field, the phase-out began as early as the B-25C, and on the B-25H the position was finally eliminated altogether, its weight traded for waist guns and an armoured manned tail turret. Allen gives the end of that story himself, later in the same interview and in six flat words: "The lower turret was taken out." Ten minutes was, in fairness to the man who gave the course, about as much of that turret as anyone could usefully teach.

Sources: B-25 History Project — B-25B (2 .50 calibre guns in bottom Bendix turret; jammed in the down position; often removed in the field); North American B-25 Mitchell preview — Hangar 47 (kneeling gunner over a periscope-gunsight; vertigo); North American B-25H Mitchell — aircraftinformation.info (ventral turret eliminated; waist guns and tail turret).

The Fleet That Never Arrived

Allen's ending is the right one. The light carrier Shoho was sunk on 7 May 1942, and the Japanese carrier air groups were cut about badly enough that the survivors had to go home to re-equip and retrain. The Australian War Memorial's account records that the Port Moresby landing force, aware of Rear Admiral Crace's blocking squadron and already bombed by land-based aircraft, "had turned back permanently." Port Moresby was never taken from the sea at all; the Japanese Army tried instead to walk over the Owen Stanley Range by the Kokoda Track, and failed at that too. The mission Allen waited two or three days to fly was cancelled by a battle he never saw, fought out over water he would afterwards cross by air more times than he could count.

Sources: Battle of the Coral Sea, 4-8 May 1942 — Australian War Memorial; Operation Mo (Wikipedia) — convoy sailed 4 May, turned back, Kokoda attempted instead; Battle of the Coral Sea — Britannica; Battle of the Coral Sea (Wikipedia) — Shokaku's damage and Zuikaku's aircraft losses kept both from Midway.

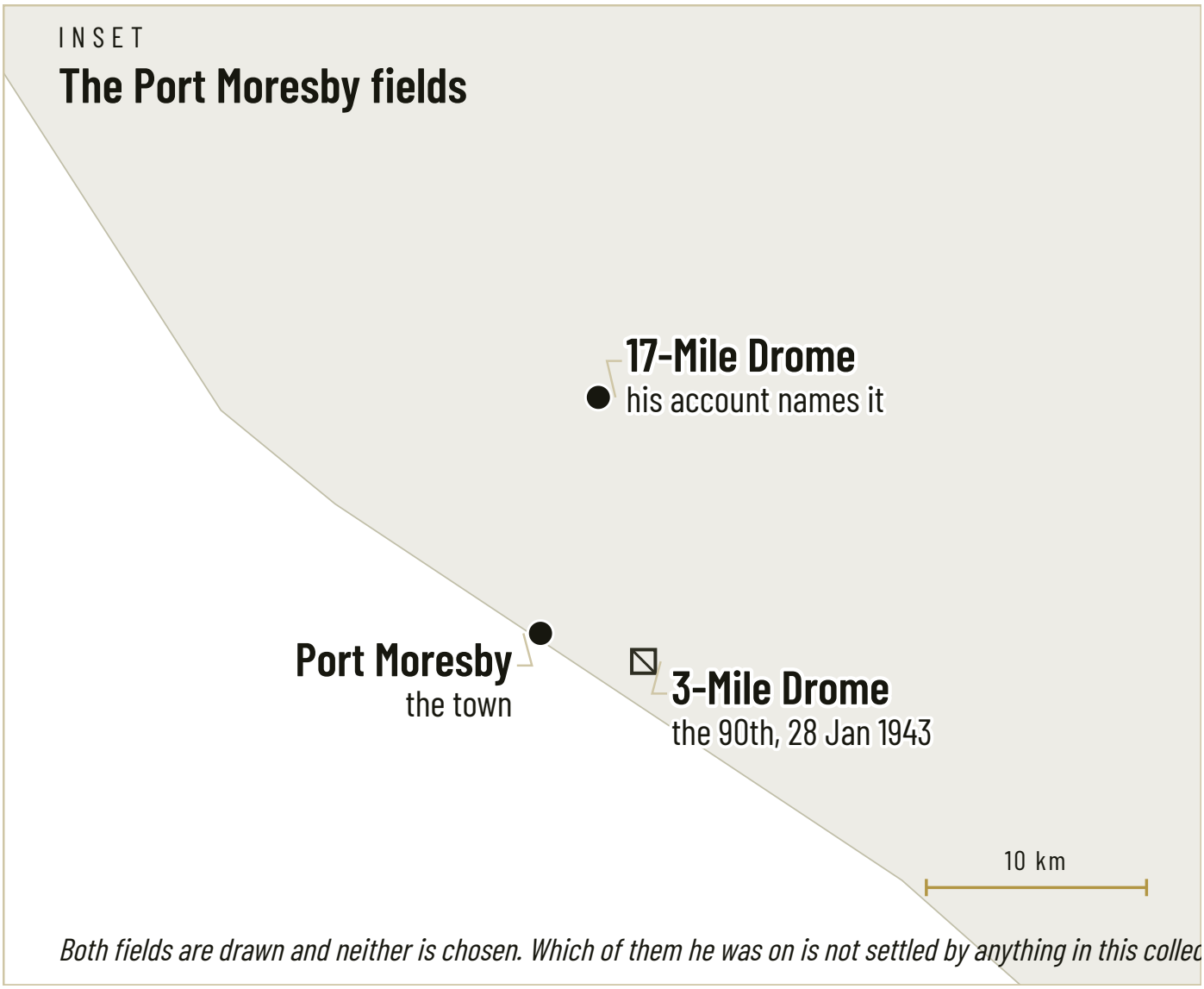
What the Coral Sea Searches Cost the 90th

The searching Allen's group was doing that autumn in Queensland was not free of cost. On 21 April 1942 a 90th Bombardment Squadron B-25C, serial 41-12455, coming home to Charters Towers from a reconnaissance search for Japanese warships in the weeks before the Coral Sea, flew into Mount Bartle Frere at about seven in the evening, striking it about 4,300 feet up. All seven men aboard were killed.

A search party reached the wreck on 29 April, but the remains were not brought down off the mountain until early December, when a local man, Ted Richards, took a pack of mules up to it; they were buried at Townsville on the 14th. The group kept at the work — more than 120 reconnaissance sorties in May 1942, in part looking for the Japanese fleet in the Coral Sea. Allen remembers losing two of the radio men from his own tent in crashes of exactly this kind, though he places them in the Owen Stanleys rather than in Queensland, and no record found here ties either man to this particular aeroplane. One point about the period is worth making alongside it. The "Fifth Air Force" of later fame barely functioned in the spring of 1942: the name was applied at Melbourne on 5 February, but the headquarters was not re-staffed, at Brisbane, until 18 September.

Sources: 3rd Bombardment Group — HistoryOfWar.org (more than 120 recon sorties in May 1942, partly looking for the Japanese fleet in the Coral Sea); Pacific Wrecks — B-25C Mitchell 41-12455, 3rd BG / 90th BS, Mount Bartle Frere, 21 April 1942; 21 April 1942 crash of a B-25 Mitchell on Mount Bartle Frere — Australia @ War; 3rd Bombardment Group unit history — Army Air Corps Museum.

The Airfields, Counted in Miles



The airfields around Port Moresby, about five units apart at the scale of the map above. Both are drawn and neither is chosen, because nobody wrote down which of the two was his.

New Guinea: Port Moresby to Hollandia, 1943 – 1944. An earlier drawing of this map put Port Moresby north of Nadzab and of Dobodura, and set Wewak at Hollandia's longitude; every point on this one is plotted from its coordinates.

▼ THIS DRAWING, SET OUT IN WORDS

- Port Moresby on the southern coast, the group's station from 28 January 1943.
- The Owen Stanley Range between Moresby and the north coast. Two of the six radio men in his section died crossing it.
- Dobodura, on the north coast, where the 90th Squadron went on 21 May 1943.
- Nadzab, up the Markham Valley, where the 90th flew on 30 January 1944.
- Hollandia, at the far north-west, from May 1944.

- Wewak, Rabaul and the Bismarck Sea are marked as places he never stood on.
- Dulag, on Leyte, lies off this panel to the north-west. His group went there on 16 November 1944, ten weeks after he had gone home.
- A filled disc marks a place he is documented to have been. An open square marks a place documented for his unit rather than for him. An open square with a diagonal tick marks his own squadron. A dashed circle marks a place that is inferred rather than recorded.
- A brass ring crossed by a bar marks a place he never stood on — a target, or somewhere his group went without him. Each carries the words HE WAS NOT THERE.
- A solid line is a journey whose means of travel is recorded. A dashed line is a move that is documented while the means is not. A dotted line rests on his own account alone.
- No plate carries a computed distance. His own "about 12,000 miles" already stands here against a measured 9,500 to 10,200, and a third figure, quietly worked out, would only muddy the water.

Allen remembered the Port Moresby strips by their distance out the road. Every number he gave is a real airfield.

The Mile Posts

Allen had the system exactly right. The airfields ringing Port Moresby were not given proper names at first, only numbers, and the number was simply how far out the road from town you had to drive to reach the strip. By 1943 there were seven of them: 3-Mile (Kila, sometimes Kila Kila), 5-Mile (Ward's), 7-Mile (Jackson), 12-Mile (Berry), 14-Mile (Schwimmer, also called Laloki for the river beside it), 17-Mile (Durand, also Waigani), and 30-Mile (Rorona, renamed Rogers in November 1942).

Allen names four of them, and every number he gives is real: 3, 7, 14 and 17. What he most likely remembered was not the whole complex but the four strips his own outfit had business with, since the 3rd Bomb Group's squadrons were spread across Kila, Jackson, Schwimmer and Durand. The three he leaves out were other men's country: 5-Mile Ward's, which by 1943 was reportedly the busiest aerodrome in the southern hemisphere; 12-Mile Berry, a fighter strip of crushed rock and pit gravel; and 30-Mile Rorona, unsurfaced and too soft for heavy bombers, further out the road again than Allen's own 17.

Sources: Port Moresby Airfield Complex (Wikipedia); Schwimmer Airfield (Wikipedia); Berry Airfield (Wikipedia); Pacific Wrecks — 17 Mile Drome (Durand, Waigani).

17-Mile: Durand Drome

The strip Allen was sent to had been cut out of a swamp only months before he saw it. During August 1942 the U.S. Army's 808th Engineer Aviation Battalion, under Captain Andrew D. Chaffin, Jr., cleared jungle north of the Waigani swamp and had a single northwest-southeast runway fit to land on in roughly three weeks; Chaffin's citation described the ground beforehand as a jungle swamp unfit even for foot travel. Gravel from a nearby quarry surfaced the runway and taxiways, revetments were carved into the hillsides southeast of the strip, and anti-aircraft gun pits were built from empty fifty-five-gallon drums packed with soil.

The Air Force's own official history says the field was made in the first place for B-17s whose missions could not wait on the unfinished runways at 7-Mile; and when torrential rain washed out the shale base at 7-Mile on 21 October 1942, two-thirds of the battalion went back to enlarge Durand for the Fortresses. Steel matting was laid over the bitumen only after the bombers had been using it a while, "a sequence that did not make for stability of the subgrade." On 10 November 1942 the field was formally named Durand, for 1st Lt. Edward D. Durand, a P-39 pilot who bailed out near Lababia Island coming home from a strafing run on Lae that April and was never found. Allen's "a little strip, and a defense around it" is a fair description of what the engineers had managed in three weeks.

Sources: Pacific Wrecks — 17 Mile Drome (Durand, Waigani); Durand Airfield (Wikipedia); The Army Air Forces in World War II, Vol. VII, ch. 10: Aviation Engineers in the War with Japan (HyperWar); Pacific Wrecks — P-39F Airacobra 41-7128 (1st Lt. Edward D. Durand, MIA 30 April 1942).

The Question Mark Beside the 90th LIKELY

There is a small gap in the published record that Allen's voice happens to fill. Pacific Wrecks lists the units based at 17-Mile Drome and shows the 3rd Bomb Group's 13th Bomb Squadron arriving with B-25s on 7 October 1942 — and then the 3rd Bomb Group's 90th Bomb Squadron with no date at all, only a question mark.

The Durand airfield entry likewise names the 90th among its residents without saying when. Yet the same archive's own page for the 90th Squadron records it moving to 3-Mile Drome (Kila) on 28 January 1943, the date the group officially changed station from Charters Towers to Port Moresby, so the two records do not sit easily together. The likeliest explanation is that the 90th operated forward from Durand alongside its sister B-25 squadron in late 1942, the period Allen describes as his three flying trips up from Australia. That is a guess, and worth saying so: no document settles it. Allen's own account, that the outfit went to 17 after unloading at Moresby, is the clearest statement anyone has of where he himself lived and worked.

Sources: Pacific Wrecks — 17 Mile Drome (Durand, Waigani), Allied units based list; Pacific Wrecks — 90th Bombardment Squadron (90th BS); Durand Airfield (Wikipedia); 3rd Bombardment Group (OzAtWar).

The Dirt Strip and the Metal Strip LIKELY

The instruction Allen passed over the radio fits a layout that was surveyed and written down. A survey of 7-Mile Drome dated 9 December 1942 records three parallel runways running northwest to southeast: in the middle the original fighter strip, 3,000 by 100 feet, surfaced with Marston matting; to the northeast a newer bomber strip, 3,000 by 150 feet, also matted and later stretched to 3,750; and on the southwest side a crash strip, 7,500 by 100 feet, for which the survey lists dimensions but no surfacing at all.

A field with a matted strip and a long unmatted strip alongside it is precisely the choice Allen was relaying — go to 7-Mile, put it down on the dirt and not on the steel. Across the complex the surfaces were genuinely mixed: Kila was black loam under steel mat, Schwimmer was matted about October 1942, while Berry at 12-Mile was crushed rock and pit gravel and 30-Mile began life unmatted. That the crash strip was bare graded earth is read out of the survey's silence rather than stated in it, and that is worth saying plainly.

Sources: Pacific Wrecks — 7 Mile Drome (Jackson Airport), runway survey of 9 December 1942; Pacific Wrecks — 3 Mile Drome (Kila Kila); Berry Airfield (Wikipedia); Schwimmer Airfield (Wikipedia).

The Belly Landing Itself UNCERTAIN

The story he tells at 45:48 in Part 1 has not been found in any record. A pilot whose landing gear would not come down was told, through Allen on the radio, to put it down on the dirt at 7-Mile and not on the metal. He landed on the metal, slid off the runway, and one man was killed. Allen gives no date and no aircraft, and no name for the pilot or for the man who died.

Three searches have come back empty. Fold3, read in October 2026, holds no Missing Air Crew Report, memorial page or unit paper that describes it; the nearest things there are a take-off crash at 7-Mile in April 1943 that killed eleven men of a B-17 group, and a 90th Squadron B-25 that bellied into a dirt field in May 1942 with nobody hurt. Aviation Archaeology's index of Army Air Forces accident reports has no 3rd Bomb Group accident at Port Moresby for 1942 or 1943, though for the Fifth Air Force in those years it lists only a few hundred reports. Its one B-25 belly landing in New Guinea in that time is B-25D 41-30275, pilot Theodore B. Swanson, 21 July 1943, report 44-07-21-504. It gives no place, no unit and no death, and the date falls two months after the 90th had left Port Moresby for Dobodura. Pacific Wrecks lists no such landing at 7-Mile.

The question stays open. The accident reports, the 3rd Bomb Group's daily operations records and V Bomber Command's records are at the Air Force Historical Research Agency at Maxwell Air Force Base. Aviation Archaeology can be asked to search the microfilm it has not indexed, and it would copy the Swanson report for twenty to thirty-five dollars, which would at least settle whether that is the one. Nothing has been bought. The second volume of *Harvest of the Grim Reapers* has not yet been read for it.

Sources: transcript-part1.html, 45:39–47:06; Fold3, searches of October 2026; Aviation Archaeology, USAAF accident report index, searched October 2026 (record 43558, file 44-07-21-504); Pacific Wrecks, 7 Mile Drome (Jackson Airport).

Marston Mat

The “metal strip” was pierced steel planking, universally called Marston matting. Each panel was a length of hardened steel ten feet long and fifteen inches wide, fourteen hundredths of an inch thick, punched with eighty-seven holes in three rows of twenty-nine, weighing sixty-six pounds; interlocking slots and tabs along the edges let men with sledgehammers link them into a continuous deck, laid over graded earth or, on the islands, over rolled crushed coral. Engineers could roll out a usable runway in days rather than months, and mat routinely took bombers of sixty thousand pounds landing at ninety miles an hour on ground that would otherwise have been mud.

And there is a coincidence in it for Allen: the mat took its name from Marston, North Carolina, where in November 1941 — during the Carolina maneuvers Allen says he attended with the 3rd Bomb Group just before Pearl Harbor — Army engineers laid a 3,000 by 150 foot test runway in eleven days, then took it up, loaded it into eighteen railroad gondola cars and shipped it to Langley Field. General Arnold hailed it as the year’s greatest achievement in aviation. Whether Allen ever saw that strip is not recorded, but within eighteen months he was sitting at a radio in New Guinea trying to keep an aeroplane off the stuff.

Sources: Marston Mat (Wikipedia); “Marston Mat”, Air Force Magazine, April 1989 (Air & Space Forces Magazine archive); Marston Mat — Wisconsin Aviation Hall of Fame; These Portable Runways Helped Win the War in the Pacific — Smithsonian Air & Space.

Where He Turned for Home

The last leg, and the campaigns that belong to his war rather than his group’s.

Where He Turned for Home

Hollandia was the last overseas station Allen saw. He came home on the points system in the autumn of 1944 — word reached him on the night of his birthday, 9 September — and sailed east across the Pacific alone in a converted passenger liner, under the Golden Gate and on to Fort Dix. The 3rd Bombardment Group stayed at Hollandia until 16 November 1944, when it moved forward to Dulag on Leyte and then to San Jose on Mindoro at the end of December, finishing the war on Okinawa.

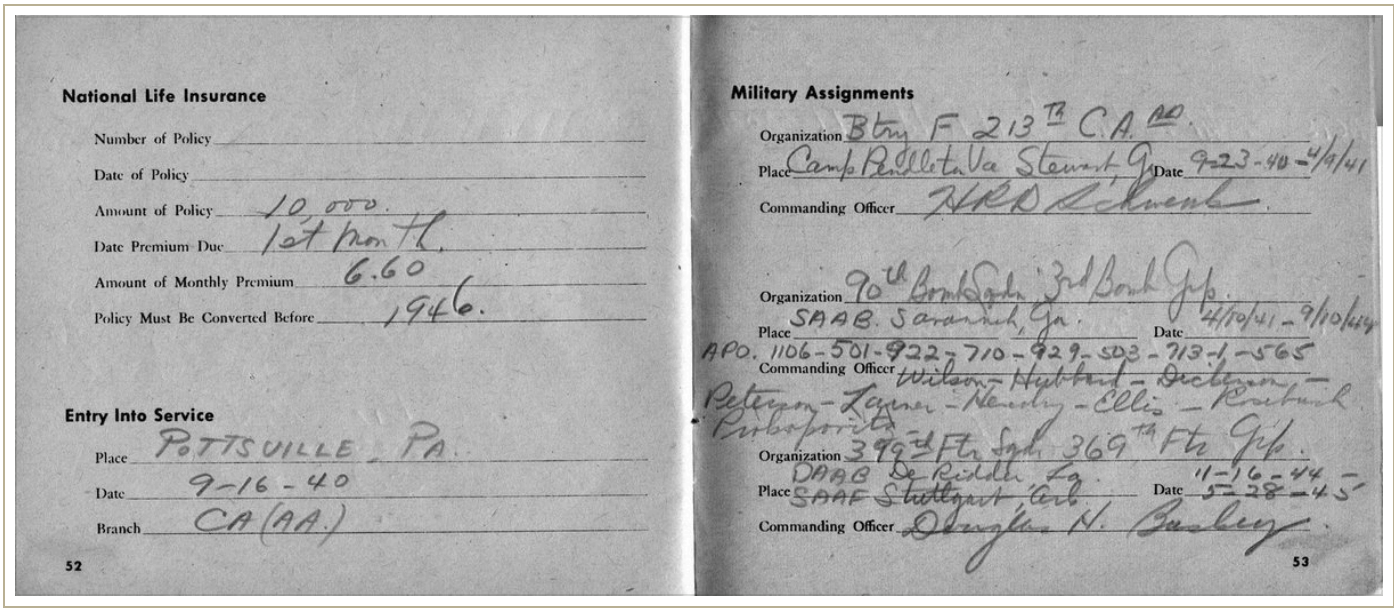
Allen missed the return to the Philippines by about ten weeks. The Grim Reapers' streamers for Leyte and Luzon were earned by the men he left behind on that beach; the group credits that fall inside his own war are four — East Indies, Papua, New Guinea and Bismarck Archipelago — and they end where his war did, on the north coast of Dutch New Guinea. If his discharge papers name others, go by the papers.

Sources: Army Air Corps Museum — 3rd Bombardment Group station list and campaign credits; 5th Air Force Association — 3rd Bomb Group; 5th Air Force Association — 3rd Bomb Group campaign credits (no Northern Solomons); historyofwar.org — 3rd Bombardment Group stations and squadrons.

Decoding His APO Numbers

Eight numbers in his own handwriting, each standing for a place he was forbidden to name. Seven of them decode.

IN HIS HAND	WHERE IT STOOD FOR	DATES IN THE ARMY REGISTER	NOTE
APO 1106	Not in the register	—	No APO 1106 exists in the Army Postal Service's master list of every number used between 1942 and 1947. Either it is not an APO at all, or it is a slip of the pen.
APO 501	Theatre headquarters, Australia	Melbourne 1/42 → Sydney 9/42 → Brisbane 2/43	A theatre-level address rather than a place — what a newly landed man could give his family before he was on any base roll.
APO 922	Townsville, Queensland	opened 18 March 1942	The port town he passed through, and the nearest large postal facility while the group was settling into the scrub inland.
APO 710	Charters Towers, Queensland	17 Sept 1942 → Townsville 29 April 1944	His own base — but with no post office of its own for his first six months there, which is why 922 comes before it on his list.
APO 929	Port Moresby, New Guinea	opened 23 July 1942	The V-mail plant he describes ran under this number.
APO 503	Oro Bay, New Guinea	Melbourne 1/42 → Sydney → Townsville → Oro Bay 1/43	The deep-water port some twenty miles from Dobodura, and the reason Dobodura could be supplied at all. A surviving 3rd Attack Group address reads "Hq. 3rd Atk Gp, APO 503."
APO 713-1	Lae, New Guinea	Oro Bay 18 Aug 1943 → Lae 9/43	Lae sits at the mouth of the Markham; Nadzab lies about twenty miles up the same valley. The "-1" is most likely a branch office — an inference, not a record.
APO 565	Hollandia, Dutch New Guinea	Goodenough Is. 1/44 → Hollandia 28 April 1944	Base G. The number on his last letters home from the Pacific.



National Life Insurance

Number of Policy

Date of Policy

Amount of Policy 10,000.

Date Premium Due 1st month

Amount of Monthly Premium 6.60

Policy Must Be Converted Before 1946.

Entry Into Service

Place POTTSVILLE, PA.

Date 9-16-40

Branch CA(AA.)

52

Military Assignments

Organization Btry F 213TH C.A. AA.

Place Camp Riddle Va Stewart Ga Date 9-23-40 - 4/9/41

Commanding Officer ARD Schwenk

Organization 90th Bomb Sqdn 3rd Bomb Gp.

Place SAAB. Savannah, Ga. Date 4/10/41 - 9/10/44

APO. 1106-501-922-710-929-503-713-1-565

Commanding Officer Wilson-Hubbard-Dickson-Peterson-Lamar-Newby-Ellis-Pritchard Purbaugh

Organization 399th Ftr Sqn 369th Ftr Gp.

Place DAAB Del Riddle La. SAAF Stuttgart, Ark. Date 11-16-44 - 5-28-45

Commanding Officer Douglas H. Bailey

53

The page of his own service record book that the table above decodes — eight APO numbers in his own hand, each one standing for a place he was not allowed to write down.

APO 922 and APO 710 — Townsville and Charters Towers

Two of his numbers cover the same stretch of north Queensland, and the dates explain why he listed them the way he did. APO 922 was the post office at Townsville, opened on 18 March 1942 and running without a move until February 1946 — the port town he passed through, and the nearest large postal facility while the group was settling into the scrub inland.

APO 710 was established at Charters Towers itself on 17 September 1942, and stayed there until 29 April 1944, when it withdrew to Townsville; it later went forward to Owi Island off Biak in August 1944 and on through Leyte, Mindoro, Clark Field, Okinawa and Japan, a path Allen never followed, since he was home by that autumn. His group had been at Charters Towers since 10 March 1942, so for his first six months in Australia there was no post office at the field bearing his own base's number. His list runs 501, then 922, then 710, which is that sequence exactly.

Sources: Numerical Listing of APO's, January 1942 – November 1947 (AGO), p. 185 – APO 922: Townsville, Australia, 18-3-42, ceased 13-2-46; Numerical Listing of APO's, January 1942 – November 1947 (AGO), p. 159 – APO 710: Charters Towers 17-9-42, Townsville 29-4-44, Owi Island 8/44, Mindoro, Clark Field, Okinawa, Japan; 3rd Bombardment Group – Charters Towers from 10 March 1942; APO-locations.csv – APO 710 full itinerary including the Leyte stop (1 Jan 1945) omitted from the sidebar.

APO 929 — Port Moresby

APO 929 is among the best attested numbers on the list. The Army's register gives it a single location for almost the whole war — Port Moresby, New Guinea, from 23 July 1942 until 7 August 1945, when it followed on to Leyte, then San Fernando in Pampanga, then Sasebo and Fukuoka in occupied Japan. The National WWII Museum holds a photograph of the V-mail plant in operation at APO 929 in 1944, its sorting and printing rooms set up in the field under timber and canvas. Allen's group moved up to Port Moresby on 28 January 1943 and on to Dobodura that May, so this was the number under which his mail travelled for something under four months. It is also the number behind the V-mail he describes: letters written on a standard form were photographed onto microfilm for the voyage and printed small again at the far end, and the plants that did that work looked exactly like this one.

Sources: Numerical Listing of APO's, January 1942 – November 1947 (AGO), p. 186 – APO 929: Port Moresby, New Guinea, 23-7-42; Leyte 7-8-45; San Fernando (Pampanga) 3-9-45; Sasebo; Fukuoka; Army Post Offices in Australia during WW2 – APO 929, Port Moresby, New Guinea; V-mail operation in the field at APO 929 in Papua New Guinea, 1944 – The National WWII Museum; V-mail operation in the field at APO 929 in Papua New Guinea in 1944 — caption verified, page live.

APO 503 — Oro Bay, the Address for Dobodura

The place Allen calls Dogadura is Dobodura, the great grass airfield complex the Americans cut inland from Buna between December 1942 and early 1943, and it had no post office of its own name. Its mail went through APO 503, which the Army register places at Oro Bay, New Guinea, from January 1943 — the deep-water port some twenty miles away at the end of a newly bulldozed road, and the reason Dobodura could be supplied at all. APO 503 had begun the war at Melbourne in January 1942 and moved by way of Sydney and Townsville before settling at Oro Bay, where it remained until 31 August 1945. A surviving wartime address for one of Allen's own group's officers reads, in full, "Special Service Officer, Fifth Air Force, Hq. 3rd Atk Gp, APO 503" — direct documentary confirmation that the Grim Reapers used this number. His group reached Dobodura on 20 May 1943.

Sources: Numerical Listing of APO's, January 1942 – November 1947 (AGO), p. 121 – APO 503: Melbourne 1/42, Sydney 1942, Townsville 8/42, Oro Bay 1/43, Tokyo 31-8-45, Yokohama 3/46; 3rd Bombardment Group, Peter Dunn's Australia @ War – address "Special Service Officer, Fifth Air Force, Hq. 3rd Atk Gp, APO 503"; Dobodura Airfield Complex, Oro Province – Pacific Wrecks; Oro Bay port and the road to Dobodura – Dobodura Airfield Complex (1942).

APO 713-1 — Lae and the Markham Valley LIKELY

The number Allen wrote as 713-1 is the only one in his hand carrying a suffix, and the base number decodes cleanly: the Army register shows APO 713 opening at Oro Bay on 18 August 1943 and moving to Lae, New Guinea, in September 1943, where it stayed until October 1945. Lae sits at the mouth of the Markham; Nadzab, the airfield he remembers as the best place they were stationed, lies about twenty miles up the same valley, and Australian wartime postal tables associate APO 713 with Base E, the supply base covering the Lae-Nadzab area.

The 3rd Bombardment Group moved to Nadzab on 3 February 1944. The "-1" is almost certainly a branch or unit designation for a smaller post office working out of the parent APO, which would put the Nadzab counter under the Lae number. That last step is a guess: no source consulted names a Nadzab branch of APO 713, and the register itself lists only Lae.

Sources: Numerical Listing of APO's, January 1942 – November 1947 (AGO), p. 159 – APO 713: Oro Bay 18-8-43, Lae 9/43, Nagoya 1-10-45, Kyoto 11/46; Army Post Offices in Australia during WW2 – APO 713, Base E, Nadzab, New Guinea; 3rd Bombardment Group – Nadzab from 3 February 1944; APO-locations.csv – APO 713: Oro Bay 18-8-43, Lae 1-9-43, Nagoya 1-10-45, Kyoto 1-11-46.

APO 565 — Hollandia

The last posting on his list is also the last one he served. APO 565 first opened on Goodenough Island in January 1944, shifted briefly to Cape Cretin on 29 February, returned to Goodenough in March, and then moved to Hollandia in Dutch New Guinea on 28 April 1944, where it remained until it closed on 31 January 1946. Australian wartime postal tables identify it as the post office of Base G, Hollandia. Allen's group arrived there on 12 May 1944, a fortnight after the post office opened and days after the fighting he describes wading ashore behind. He was on his way home by that September, so 565 is the number under which his final letters from the Pacific were sent.

Sources: Numerical Listing of APO's, January 1942 – November 1947 (AGO), p. 135 – APO 565: Goodenough Island 1/44, Cape Cretin 29-2-44, Goodenough Island 3/44, Hollandia 28-4-44, ceased 31-1-46; Army Post Offices in Australia during WW2 – APO 565, Base G, Hollandia, Dutch New Guinea; 3rd Bombardment Group – Hollandia from 12 May 1944; APO-locations.csv – APO 565: Goodenough Is. 1/44, Cape Cretin 29-2-44, Goodenough Is. 1-3-44, Hollandia 28-4-44, ceased 31-1-46.

The Nervous System of a Squadron

Technical Sergeant, and Where That Put Him

The paper calls him Tech. Sgt., which was neither a technician's rating nor a junior grade. Under the pay-grade scheme of 1920 enlisted men ran from the seventh grade, private, up to the first, master sergeant; technical sergeant sat in the second. On 22 September 1942 first sergeant was moved up into the first grade, which left technical sergeant alone in the second — the second-highest enlisted grade in the Army, one rung below the master sergeant he finished the war as. The insignia was three chevrons and two rockers against a master sergeant's three and three.

So the wire story catches him one promotion short of the top, and already senior enough that a reporter reached for the phrase "the unit's communications expert." It does not date the promotion. It only proves he had not yet had it.

Sources: War Department Circular No. 303, 5 August 1920; AR 600-35, Change 3, 22 September 1942.

The Australian at the End of the Story LIKELY

The story closes with the organisation's Australian liaison officer giving a summary of his own. That was not a courtesy attachment. The Australian Army decided early in the New Guinea campaign that its units and the air force needed someone between them, and from 1942 began posting liaison officers to RAAF and American squadrons.

One of them can be named. Captain Richard V. Saunders was attached to the 3rd Bomb Group from 20 May 1943 until June 1944, and he lived with the 90th Squadron the whole time — Allen's own squadron. Of the job he wrote: "I kept the crews abreast of the war both locally and abroad." That is the morning meeting in the liaison officer's own words. Five other Australians are listed as attached to the group over the war. Whether Saunders is the man in this particular story is not established; the story names nobody.

Sources: Richard V. Saunders, 3rd Attack Group veterans' pages.

Somebody Else Wrote This Down at the Time

Everything this chapter says about the shortwave listening has rested on Allen. Here is a stranger, writing while he was still in New Guinea, for a wire service, saying the same thing and naming him: the unit's news was built on short-wave intercepts he made during the night, and he was the unit's communications expert.

It corroborates the practice, the man and the town. It does not corroborate the scene he describes, and the two accounts are not the same. He remembered reading the news out himself, in the evening, by the open-air theatre, with another squadron running a line to his tent. The wire story has him listening overnight and two officers presenting at a seven o'clock morning meeting. These may be two habits of one man, or one habit told from both ends. Nothing found settles it, and the two are left side by side rather than merged.

Sources: The clipping, from the family's copy; his own interview, 2006.

News Gathering Wins High Praise

SOMEWHERE IN NEW GUINEA—(INS)—Lieut. Ivan P. Head of Denver, Colo., intelligence officer for a bombardment squadron in New Guinea, has put into effect a news presentation plan which has won high favor with both officers and enlisted men.

Each morning at 7 o'clock, when the entire unit gathers for its regular meeting, a summary of development on all world fronts during the preceding 24 hours is presented.

Head gives American news, elaborating on sport items with material he has been given by Army newspaper services. Lieut. Robert Williamson of West Newton, Mass., assistant intelligence officer, presents a summary of all war news.

The war news is based on short wave intercepts made during the night by Tech. Sgt. Allen Sweigert of Cressona, Pa., the unit's communications expert.

Finally, the organization's Australian liaison officer gives a sum-

A wire story out of New Guinea, printed in an American paper while Allen was still there: "The war news is based on short wave intercepts made during the night by Tech. Sgt. Allen Sweigert of Cressona, Pa., the unit's communications expert." The yellow band is a search highlight on the library's own image, not a mark on the paper.

What a communications chief actually worked with — and the aerial he strung against the rules, which worked better than the one in the manual.

Communication Chief, MOS 542

Allen's job had a number, and the War Department's own description of it reads almost like a summary of what he tells the camera. Military Occupational Specialty 542, Communications Chief, covered supervising a communication section in the installation, operation and minor maintenance of two or more of the following: wire, radio, or air-ground contact. In practice that meant directing the laying, testing, maintenance and recovery of wire; selecting the locations for central and sub-stations; directing telephone, switchboard, teletype and radio operators in the receipt and transmission of messages; superintending air-to-ground and ground-to-air systems; and supervising the adjustment and minor repair of the radio sets, field telephones, switchboards and wire lines themselves.

The alternate titles on the same card say the rest of it — Communication Sergeant, Radio Sergeant, Signal NCO, Wire Sergeant — not a specialist tucked behind one set but the man answerable for every circuit a bomb squadron ran on. That breadth is why a squadron could still function with a radio crew of six when, as Allen says, the establishment called for about twenty. Everything else on this page, the aerial in the trees, the switchboard, the wire through the branches, the radio compass, is one man's MOS written out longhand.

Sources: Communications Chief (542), WWII Army MOS codes — The Military Yearbook Project; Military Specialty — Military Occupational Specialty — Army Air Corps Museum; WWII Military Occupational Specialist Code Database — Strictly GI; WWII Army Communications MOS codes index (542 Communications Chief, with alternate titles and the one-sentence duty description) — Military Yearbook Project.

The antenna between two trees LIKELY

The rule Allen was breaking was a real one. Signal Corps ground stations came with specified aerials — the 100-foot AN-21 and the 20-foot AN-22 were the wire antennas listed in 1940 for the BC-191, the transmitter at the heart of the Army's SCR-177 and SCR-188 ground sets — and the manuals fixed both the length and where the lead-in was taken off. What he put up instead, a wire slung low between two trees and tapped wherever it suited him, is what would now be called a near-vertical incidence skywave antenna. A horizontal wire hung a small fraction of a wavelength above the ground sends most of its energy almost straight up; the ionosphere reflects it back down over a circle reaching out some 400 miles, so the signal falls into valleys and over ridges that ground wave and line-of-sight cannot reach.

Between Port Moresby and the strips on the far coast stood the Owen Stanley Range, topping out at Mount Victoria at 4,038 metres, 13,248 feet — exactly the barrier that mode is good for, and one reason armies still use it in mountains and in the tropics. Allen said he never knew why it worked so well. The name for it came later; his aerial in the trees was simply, and accidentally, the right answer to the mountain. That his squadron was the only one able to work aircraft across the range is Allen's word alone. No unit paperwork has turned up to confirm it, and none to contradict it.

Sources: Near vertical incidence skywave — Wikipedia (low horizontal wire, 0-650 km coverage, use over mountains and in the tropics); NVIS Propagation: Near Vertical Incidence Skywave — Electronics Notes; SCR-188 (BC-191 transmitter, BC-342 receiver; TM 11-233, March 1942) — RadioNerds; AN — Antennas: AN-21 100 ft and AN-22 20 ft wire antennas for the BC-191 — RadioNerds.

The Series, by Shortwave

Allen's remark that the men could follow the ball games describes something the War Department was deliberately arranging. The Armed Forces Radio Service was established by War Department order on 26 May 1942, and the Radio Division that preceded it had been broadcasting music and sports overseas since the spring of 1941; shortwave broadcasts continued from both American coasts to carry news and sport to troops. Military personnel around the world heard the 1942 World Series that way, and in 1944 the War Department announced that play-by-play of the Series would be broadcast to troops in all overseas theatres, beamed live by five powerful shortwave transmitters to a list that included the Southwest Pacific.

What the Army could not supply was a receiver. The standard account of Pacific broadcasting is blunt about it: programming from America came in on shortwave only, and shortwave sets were not generally to be had. AFRS did not put its own transmitters into New Guinea until 1944, when the stations of what became the Jungle Network appeared, most running a 50-watt transmitter with a staff of five or six men. Through the nine months the 3rd Bombardment Group held Dobodura — 20 May 1943 to 3 February 1944 — a squadron's news still depended on whoever had a shortwave receiver and the patience to sit at it.

Sources: Armed Forces Radio Service — Museum of Broadcast Communications radio encyclopedia; #Shortstops: War and the World Series — National Baseball Hall of Fame; September 30, 1942: Yankees' Red Ruffing wins World Series opener in St. Louis — Society for American Baseball Research; AFRS Pacific Overview — Radio Heritage Foundation.

Shorthand off the Air

Learning to write fast was not a private trick; it was the standard newsgathering method of the entire theatre. Guinea Gold, published daily by the Australian Imperial Force at Port Moresby from 19 November 1942 to 30 June 1946, never failed to appear — 1,320 consecutive days, a record for service publications — and was written by soldiers with newspaper experience who took shorthand notes of shortwave bulletins from Australia, from the US Armed Forces station at San Francisco, from the BBC, from All-India Radio and others. An American edition was flown daily to Buna, Gona and Milne Bay, and at the 1944 peak the two editions together ran to 64,000 copies a day, 37,000 of them American.

This mattered more in New Guinea than anywhere else, because New Guinea was the only war zone in which the US armed forces did not produce a local edition of their own newspaper, Stars and Stripes. Buna sits on the coast below the Dobodura strips — supplies for the Buna-Gona fighting came in through those airfields — so the printed paper very likely reached Allen's field, but it reached it once a day and already hours old. Between drops, the only news on that airfield was whatever a man with a receiver and a pencil had taken down himself.

Sources: Guinea Gold — Australian War Memorial; Anzac Day, Typewriters and Guinea Gold — oz.Typewriter; Guinea Gold — Wartime Press; Stars & Stripes — Baseball Reference Bullpen.

A Sheet on a Bulletin Board LIKELY

The typed or hand-lettered unit news sheet was one of the most widespread institutions of the war and one of the least recorded. Between 1942 and 1945 the number of newspapers published by and for American servicemen grew from fewer than five hundred to nearly four thousand, and most overseas combat units were limited to a single-page mimeograph with a plain design; the printed weeklies belonged to big formations with presses behind them.

The War Department encouraged the habit: the Camp Newspaper Service in New York supplied copy and features to camp and unit papers and ran an achievement award judged by civilian editors across Army, Navy, Marine Corps and Coast Guard publications — 350 entries the year a division weekly took it — while the Army News Service, created in 1943, digested American press-association and newspaper reporting for transmission to troops by service radio. So a squadron news sheet was well within policy. Whether anyone above Allen told the 90th Bomb Squadron to have one, nobody knows; no Fifth Air Force or 3rd Bomb Group directive on squadron news services has ever turned up. Allen's own account is that he thought of it himself, and that a neighbouring squadron had to come over and ask how the news was being got.

Sources: The Buffalo: 92nd Infantry Division's Weekly Newspaper during World War II — The National WWII Museum; Information, Education & Media — The American Soldier in World War II; Army News Service.

Before the Picture Started LIKELY

An open-air film show at a forward strip was an official program, not an improvisation. In February 1942 the War Activities Committee delivered its first shipment of 16mm films, free of charge, to soldiers in combat areas, and the screenings that followed — carried by jeep, parachute, PT boat and whatever else was going — were called the two-hour furlough and treated as a serious morale measure; in 1943 alone the studios shipped 218 features and more than 6,100 16mm prints to the War Department.

A sound projector of that era came with its own amplifier and a separate loudspeaker, and surviving Bell & Howell Filmosound panels carry a microphone input beside the volume and tone controls, so a man with a script could speak through the film rig as easily as the film could. The example that documents that input plainly is a civilian machine of about 1950, so the exact set he plugged into cannot be identified, and no count of Army projectors is offered here without a source to stand on. That the Army thought of loudspeakers as broadcasting in their own right is not in doubt: at VJ-Day the Armed Forces Radio Service counted 154 stations plus 143 public address systems and hospital bedside networks among its installations.

Sources: The Motion Picture Industry During World War II — Encyclopedia.com; Everyday Movies: Portable Film Projectors and the Transformation of American Culture (review) — Spectator, USC; Bell & Howell "Filmosound 179" 16mm Sound Projector — The Henry Ford; Armed Forces Radio Service — Museum of Broadcast Communications radio encyclopedia.

When the Batteries Ran Out LIKELY

A personal portable of 1940 or 1941 was a battery set in the literal sense: it needed a low-voltage A supply for the tube filaments and a separate high-voltage B battery for the plates. Civilian radio receivers were put under War Production Board Limitation Order L-44, which appears in the Board's March 1943 index of priorities actions alongside L-71 for flashlight batteries — the dry cells were rationed too — and by August 1943 Popular Mechanics was printing plans for a home-built B-battery eliminator on the flat statement that B batteries were unavailable because of the war. An eliminator ran off house current, which is not what a forward strip offered a man's tent set.

Allen's own description fits a domestic broadcast-band portable rather than a communications receiver: he says all it would pick up were the local stations, which in Queensland and Papua meant the Australian broadcasters. So the radio he carried from Cressona was never going to be the squadron's news source. Once it went silent it stayed silent, and from then on his listening was done on equipment he did not own. Whether his was the only receiver on that airfield, nobody wrote down.

Sources: Wartime B Battery Eliminator (Popular Mechanics, August 1943) — OneTubeRadio.com; Priorities, War Production Board, March 1943 — GovInfo; Television and radio in the Second World War — National Science and Media Museum.

Malaria, Mud and Bully Beef

"Malaria was our greatest enemy." The Army agreed with him, in numbers.

“Malaria Was Our Greatest Enemy”

Allen’s judgement was also the Army’s. The Army Medical Department’s own history records that the malaria rate among American forces in New Guinea climbed from under 200 cases per 1,000 men per annum in October 1942 to nearly 600 by that December, and peaked at 970 per 1,000 per annum in February 1943 — a figure that works out to roughly one hospital admission per man per year. Over the months from October 1942 to April 1943 there were about ten times as many hospital admissions for malaria in the theatre as there were battle casualties.

In May 1943 General MacArthur put it to the visiting Army malariologist Paul F. Russell that the war would be long if for every division he had facing the enemy he had to count a second in hospital with malaria and a third convalescing. A concerted control programme — drainage, screening, oiling, spraying and drug discipline — brought the New Guinea rate back down to 200 per 1,000 by August 1943. One thing he never mentions is Atabrine. The suppressive drug, taken in the Southwest Pacific on an approved six-tablet weekly course, was pressed on every man in the theatre, turned the skin a sallow yellow, and was widely resented, rumour-ridden and widely dodged — and it does not come up once in the interview.

Sources: Preventive Medicine in World War II, Vol. VI: Communicable Diseases — Malariology, Chapter X: Southwest Pacific Area (US Army Medical Department, AMEDD Center of History & Heritage); Preventive Medicine in World War II, Vol. VI, Chapter I: Introduction (contains the MacArthur statement to Paul F. Russell, May 1943); Australian malariology during World War II (Pioneers of Australian Military Malariology, Part 3), Journal of Military and Veterans’ Health; Malaria in World War II, Army Heritage Center Foundation.

Dengue: The Other Fever

Allen names the second fever correctly, and ranks it correctly too. The Malaria and Epidemic Control Board of the South Pacific rated dengue second only to malaria among the tropical diseases of military importance, and the Army's malaria history identifies Aedes scutellaris as the principal dengue carrier in the New Guinea region. It travelled with the Americans from the start: an outbreak that swept two US infantry divisions staging in Queensland and the Northern Territory in 1942 is estimated to have affected some 80 per cent of the men within three months.

For 1944-45 the US Army counted roughly 27,000 dengue cases in the New Guinea area, with epidemics reported around Hollandia and Biak — Hollandia being Allen's last station before he came home in the autumn of 1944. Across the Pacific between 1942 and 1945 about 80,000 American servicemen were hospitalised for dengue, which the troops knew as breakbone fever. Allen's remark that at first you did not know what you had was the ordinary clinical difficulty of the campaign: the two fevers opened much alike, and only a blood smear settled which one a man was carrying.

Sources: Dengue and US Military Operations from the Spanish-American War through Today, Emerging Infectious Diseases (CDC), Vol. 18 No. 4; Preventive Medicine in World War II, Vol. VI, Chapter X: Southwest Pacific Area (Aedes scutellaris as principal dengue carrier); Dengue Epidemics During the Second World War in Queensland, Journal of Military and Veterans' Health; Allen E. Sweigert, Sr., Enlisted Record and Report of Separation, Separation Center, Fort Dix, New Jersey, 8 June 1945 (reproduced in the interview PDF) — gives return to the USA as 29 September 1944.

Under the Mosquito Bar LIKELY

"Mosquito bar" was the Army's own term, not slang — the netting was issued as a bar, pitched over the cot — and in New Guinea it was anti-malarial equipment before it was a comfort. Allen's description of going to bed as an ordeal, of swooshing the air clear and diving in under the netting to undress, and of holding a light up to see the mosquitoes lined up waiting for him to roll against the mesh, is the most vivid single passage in the interview.

The camps he describes are the ordinary Southwest Pacific arrangement: dispersed tent cities laid out ahead of the arriving squadrons by engineer and quartermaster troops, at bases such as Dobodura, whose eleven interconnected strips were cut out of the Papuan grass in late 1942 and early 1943. The particulars, though, are his alone, and for the 90th Squadron's living quarters they are very nearly all that survives — tents on platforms three or four feet clear of the ground, floors of bamboo cut in the jungle and split by a technique he had to learn, canvas rotting through in the heat and rain until a man slung a second sheet over his bunk to catch the drip, and little buckets of oil under the cot legs so the ants could not climb up. The raised platforms and the drainage ditches were as much about standing water, where Anopheles bred, as about mud. One Christmas Eve he reached into his bag for chewing gum and came out with a scorpion hanging from his fingers, went down to the medics for a shot, and then went to the pictures anyway.

Sources: Preventive Medicine in World War II, Vol. VI, Chapter X: Southwest Pacific Area (drainage, oiling and screening as malaria control); Dobodura Airfield Complex, built by the USAAF December 1942 to early 1943 with engineer and local labour; fifteen landing grounds; Pacific Wrecks — 3rd Bombardment Group "The Grim Reapers"; Interview transcript, Part 1 (Allen E. Sweigert, Sr.) — primary source for the camp construction detail.

Jungle Rot, Wet Feet, and the Solution in the Ears

The men in the islands called every tropical skin complaint jungle rot, New Guinea crud, or the creeping crud. A TIME report of 13 August 1945, drawing on Lt Cdr Robert R. M. McLaughlin's paper in the Naval Medical Bulletin, describes the range of it — fungal infection of the feet spreading to the trunk, thighs, face and scalp — and the treatments: cleaning, painting with silver nitrate, dressing with sal-sulphur ointment, staying out of the sweat, and in the worst cases a ticket back to the temperate zone. It was not a minor complaint.

The Army's medical history records General Guy B. Denit calling dermatoses, by July 1945, one of the greatest single problems of hospital admission and evacuation in the Pacific; at one evacuation hospital skin conditions accounted for 54.8 per cent of the evacuations for general medical causes, and the standard countermeasures were foot powders of undecylenic acid and zinc undecylenate and the formalin sterilising of footgear. Allen's warning about wet feet was exactly the medical finding: severity tracked directly with how long a man's boots and clothing stayed wet. The ears were a recognised problem in their own right, and this is where Allen's small memory touches real medical history — before the war acute external otitis was believed to be chiefly fungal, and it was US military work in the South Pacific that established most cases were bacterial. He never says what the medics dripped into his ears, and the preparations of the period varied from unit to unit in any case.

Sources: Medicine: Jungle Rot, TIME, 13 August 1945; Preventive Medicine in World War II, Vol. V: Communicable Diseases Transmitted through Contact, Chapter VII (dermatophytosis in the Southwest Pacific Area); Otitis Externa: Review and Clinical Update, American Family Physician, 1 November 2006 ("research by the U.S. military in the South Pacific confirmed a predominantly bacterial process as the cause"); Nelson, Roy S., "External Otitis in South Pacific", Annals of Otology, Rhinology and Laryngology, June 1945.

Bully Beef, Battery Acid, and Two Bottles of Beer

There is a reason Allen ate so much corned beef, and it is written down. American forces in the theatre were fed almost entirely from Australian and New Zealand supply under reciprocal aid: the Sixteenth Report to Congress on Lend-Lease Operations, dated 23 August 1944, states that over 90 per cent of all the food consumed by the American forces in the South and Southwest Pacific was provided by Australia and New Zealand without cost. The Australian staple was bully beef and hard biscuit.

The official Army Air Forces history counts the Australian and American canned rations and dehydrated vegetables that formed the basic Pacific menu among the most persistent grievances airmen voiced — men left to "poke at their bully beef or contemplate peanut butter" — and lays the blame on long supply lines and grossly inadequate refrigeration, ashore and afloat, which together made a satisfactory diet nearly impossible. The powdered lemonade Allen remembers was the synthetic lemon-juice powder issued with the rations, which the troops nicknamed battery acid and which some men found worked better dissolved in a bucket for scrubbing a floor than for drinking. The beer was real but scarce: the US government had the brewing industry set aside about 15 per cent of production for the services, limited to 3.2 per cent alcohol, and distribution across the Pacific was uneven and improvised. Nobody seems to have written down exactly how much beer the Army issued in New Guinea, or how often, but a two-bottle allowance of the kind Allen describes sits easily with what is documented — and in a place with nothing to buy, that is precisely why a man's two bottles were worth a good price to somebody else, or a stake in a card game.

Sources: Sixteenth Report to Congress on Lend-Lease Operations, for the period ended 30 June 1944 (dated 23 August 1944), Chapter 3: Reverse Lend-Lease Aid; The Army Air Forces in World War II, Vol. VII: Services Around the World, Chapter 14: Morale; How World War II Saved American Beer Brewing, The National WWII Museum; Curator's Choice: Two is the Limit, The National WWII Museum (beer in the Pacific theatre).

Raids, and the Joker Who Circled

A hundred aircraft overhead before anyone looked up, and the lone night visitor nobody was allowed to shoot at.

Seven Strips, Counted In Miles

Allen counts the Port Moresby fields the way everyone there did, by the miles between them and the town. Seven carried mile numbers: 3-Mile (Kila Kila), 5-Mile (Wards), 7-Mile (Jackson), 12-Mile (Berry), 14-Mile (Schwimmer), 17-Mile (Durand) and 30-Mile (Rogers), with Fishermans making an eighth field in the complex, and the numbers measured distance from Port Moresby itself rather than, as he remembers it, from the coast. His 17-Mile was Durand, built by the 808th Engineers in August 1942, renamed on 10 November 1942 for 1st Lt Edward D. Durand, a P-39 pilot posted missing on 30 April 1942 on a mission against Lae.

Durand is where the 3rd Attack Group's 13th and 90th Bombardment Squadrons kept their B-25s, which is to say it is Allen's field, with dispersal revetments cut into the hillsides and taxiways raised for drainage, exactly the 'revetments' he describes. One detail worth keeping for the family: 30-Mile Rogers was named for Major Floyd W. Rogers, who commanded the 8th Squadron in Allen's own 3rd Bomb Group and was lost flying an A-24 on 29 July 1942.

Sources: Durand Airfield (Wikipedia); Port Moresby Airfield Complex (Wikipedia); 3rd Bombardment Group — base list with dates (historyofwar.org); Pacific Wrecks — Durand Airfield (17-Mile Drome), 808th Engineers, revetments, Durand MIA 30 April 1942.

Nothing To Send Up After Him LIKELY

There is a second reason nobody went after the joker: for most of Allen's time in New Guinea there was almost nothing to send. Detachment A of the 6th Night Fighter Squadron brought a handful of Douglas P-70s, radar-nosed A-20s pressed into service as a stopgap, to the Port Moresby strips in the spring of 1943; one account puts it at 3-Mile on 1 April, and Pacific Wrecks dates the start of operations to 18 April 1943. It was a thin shield, and one the aeroplane itself could not thicken: the P-70 simply lacked the high-altitude performance to catch Japanese raiders.

The detachment's commander, Captain Warren G. Hornaday, was lost on 7 May 1943 when his P-70 went into the water at the entrance to Bootless Bay on a training flight, and the detachment's one confirmed kill came over the Moresby fields on the night of 15 May, a bomber claimed at about 2000 hours, recorded variously as a Navy G4M Betty and an Army Ki-21 Sally. By September it was moving back to Hawaii. Purpose-built night fighters came later and elsewhere, the P-61 Black Widow proving 'a rude and unpleasant surprise' to raiders that had been 'virtually immune from interception.' For a radio man in a tent at 17-Mile in 1943, in other words, going dark was not one option among several.

Sources: Pacific Wrecks — 6th Night Fighter Squadron; Pacific Wrecks — Japanese air raids against Port Moresby (15 May 1943 night claim); 419th Night Fighter Squadron (Wikipedia); Douglas P-70 Nighthawk (historyofwar.org).

The Last Peacetime Autumn

November 1941, in the Carolina pines.

Manoeuvres With the Regular Army LIKELY

What Allen describes as going "on maneuvers with the regular army at Fort Bragg" was almost certainly the Carolina Manoeuvres, the last of the GHQ war games of 1941: some 350,000 men, in two phases, across the Carolina country between Fort Jackson and Fort Bragg. These were an examination rather than a parade. The Army wanted to find out whether its new doctrine, its two armoured divisions and above all its commanders actually functioned, and both sides were given air support commands — Kepner's 1st and Duncan's 3rd — with bombardment and pursuit wings attached, which is how a radio man from a light bombardment squadron in Savannah could find himself spending November in the Carolina pines.

His own 3rd Bombardment Group was stationed at Savannah Army Air Base from 6 October 1940 to 19 January 1942, and the 90th Squadron was flying A-20s there that autumn. For the group's own part in the exercise, Allen is so far the only witness. He had been back with the squadron a few weeks. Little more than a week after the umpires went home, the aircraft were over Pearl Harbor.

Sources: Carolina Maneuvers — Wikipedia (350,000 troops, area between Fort Jackson and Fort Bragg, Red and Blue air support commands, two phases, November 1941); 3rd Bombardment Group — OzAtWar (unit veterans' history; elements in the Carolina Maneuvers of November 1941, recall to Savannah, A-20 equipment of the 90th Squadron); 3rd Bombardment Group — History of War (stationed Savannah, Georgia, 6 Oct 1940 — 19 Jan 1942).

The Mood of the Captor

The hardest remark in the interview, answered plainly.

“The Mood of the Captor”

This is the hardest remark in the interview. Allen makes it plainly, and it deserves a plain answer. The Philippines he is reaching for is Bataan: in April 1942 somewhere between 60,000 and 80,000 American and Filipino prisoners were marched about 65 miles in Japanese custody, and thousands died on the road — a story every American serviceman in the Pacific knew by 1944. The record shows the reluctance ran in both directions.

Japanese doctrine made surrender close to unthinkable, and commanders in New Guinea went to banzai charges rather than give up; on the Allied side, troops went on killing Japanese who were trying to surrender throughout the war, and the historian Niall Ferguson has argued that fear of being shot while giving up suppressed Japanese surrenders more than fear of disgrace did. From May 1944 senior American commanders ran education programmes aimed squarely at getting their own men to honour the passes, and the numbers moved: Allison Gilmore’s count for the Southwest Pacific is 1,064 Japanese taken prisoner in 1943, 5,122 in 1944 and 12,194 in 1945. Hollandia, where Allen spent his year, shows the odds even so — Samuel Eliot Morison’s figures for the operation are about 3,300 Japanese killed against some 300 captured.

Sources: Japanese prisoners of war in World War II (Gilmore’s SWPA figures; Allied reluctance to take prisoners; Ferguson’s argument; US education programmes from May 1944); Bataan Death March — National Museum of the United States Air Force; Battle of Bataan and the Bataan Death March — The National WWII Museum; Battle of Hollandia (casualty and prisoner figures after Morison, 1960).

The Censor, and the Stamp

What the handstamps on the backs of his prints actually certify — and what they cannot.

Two Censors Stood Between Allen and the Mailbox

Allen describes the first of them exactly as the Army wrote it down: mail was left open, handed in at a tent, and read before it went anywhere. War Department Pamphlet No. 21-1, dated 29 July 1943, put the rule in two sentences for enlisted men — "Place your letter unsealed in your organization mail box, never in any civil post office box" — and told officers to seal the envelope and sign their names in the lower left-hand corner. That was the unit censor, an officer of the man's own organization; the pamphlet takes him for granted and never defines him.

It does name a second review above him. The return address went in the upper left-hand corner, "leaving a margin of 1/2 inch for resealing in case of censorship beyond the unit censor," because "Both are subject to examination by base censorship detachments." The circular handstamp on some of Allen's prints, reading PASSED BY BASE … U.S. ARMY EXAMINER, is almost certainly the mark of that second tier — which makes it a statement about a piece of outgoing mail, not about the photograph as an object.

Sources: War Department Pamphlet No. 21-1, "When You Are Overseas These Facts are Vital," 29 July 1943 (full transcription); Return to Sender: Mail Censorship in World War Two (Prologue, National Archives).

2415 Is an Examiner, Not a Base LIKELY

The wording runs continuously around the circle, and the likeliest reading is a single sentence: passed by base examiner 2415, U.S. Army. On that reading the number belongs to the person who did the reading rather than to the place where it was done, and anonymity was plainly the intent at both ends — Pamphlet 21-1 ruled that "No geographical location of sender may be shown on an envelope or other outside cover," and a bare number gives away nothing either.

Whether such a number belonged to one man or to a whole detachment is still an open question. The standard philatelic catalogue of these markings, Richard Helbock's Passed By Army Censor (2006), has not yet been opened for this, and its published description promises no number-to-name key. The federal censorship records in Record Group 216 are no help either: they belong to the civilian Office of Censorship, which read mail crossing the border, not to the Army detachments that read Allen's. So 2415 is a censor's number, and whose it was nobody can yet say.

Sources: War Department Pamphlet No. 21-1, 29 July 1943 (censorship rules and return-address restrictions); Richard W. Helbock, Passed By Army Censor: A Catalogue of U.S. Markings Used on Mail from Soldiers; Records of the Office of Censorship (Record Group 216), National Archives; Censorship During World War II: The Question of Examiner 6883.

Pictures Had Their Own Rules, and They Were Local

The Army published no single worldwide rule for soldiers' snapshots. Pamphlet 21-1 handled photographs in two cautious sentences — "Special rules apply to the transmission of photographs and films. Do not send them until you have ascertained what regulations are in effect in your area" — and sent the soldier to his own theatre for the answer.

What a censor was looking for is easier to state, because the same sheet lists ten prohibitions: unit location, strength, materiel and equipment; installations; transportation; convoys; movements of ships, troops and aircraft; plans or forecasts for future operations; the effect of enemy operations; casualties; codes and ciphers; and the writer's own location. A snapshot of a revetment, a strip under construction, a wrecked aeroplane or a shoulder patch could offend several at once, which is why prints were examined at all. A passed stamp therefore certifies one thing only: on the day it was applied, an examiner judged that this print could go into the mail. It says nothing about who pressed the shutter, whose negative it came from, or whether the print was ever actually posted.

Sources: War Department Pamphlet No. 21-1, 29 July 1943 — "Photographs, Films" and the ten prohibited subjects; World War II, National Postal Museum (military mail and censorship).

“DO NOT MAIL”: The Record Does Not Settle It UNCERTAIN

The block-capital stamp is the one mark in the collection that this research cannot explain. No source reachable here defines it — not the wartime instruction sheets consulted, not the National Archives descriptions of censorship records, and not the published philatelic literature, though the standard catalogue of Army censor markings was not itself opened and should be before this caption is called final. Two readings fit what is known and neither can be confirmed.

It may be a censor’s or a unit photographic officer’s ruling that a particular print had failed review and was to stay in the owner’s footlocker rather than go home. Or it may be a control mark on prints issued from a service photographic section — official pictures a man was free to keep but not to send, a possibility that sits comfortably beside Jack Heyn’s remark that of the official prints in his own album he holds “just prints” and no negatives. Caution is the only fair course: the stamp is there on the print, nobody knows on whose authority it was made, and the family should not let it decide whether a picture is Allen’s own.

Sources: Records of the Office of Censorship (Record Group 216), National Archives; Jack Heyn e-mails, 3rd Bomb Group Photo Section (Peter Dunn, Australia @ War); Richard W. Helbock, Passed By Army Censor (catalogue of U.S. Army censor markings).

The Darkroom in the Jungle, and What a Count Can Honestly Claim

Allen is careful on camera, and the collection should be as careful as he was: he carried his own camera overseas, and of the pictures he kept, some he took and some he got from other people. The darkroom he remembers was not a squadron's but the Group Photo Section's, which served all of the 3rd Bomb Group's squadrons — the 8th, 13th, 89th and 90th. Jack Heyn, a photographer and lab technician in that section, describes two trailer labs that moved with the group and a crew printing mission film for 5th Bomber Command "many times … 2 or 3 o'clock in the morning"; at Nadzab the section worked from a prefab frame building set on a concrete slab, screened in under a corrugated roof, with "the two trailer labs parked along side, as usual." That the equipment was there, and that anyone could use it, comes from Allen and not from Heyn.

Three kinds of print therefore sit in one album — Allen's negatives, official prints handed round, prints traded between men — and a censor's handstamp cannot tell them apart, because it attaches to the mailing and not to the taking. A count is worth publishing, but as a range, and with its method beside it: the negatives, Allen's annotations, his testimony. Not the stamps.

Sources: Jack Heyn, 3rd Bomb Group Photo Section — e-mails to Peter Dunn (Australia @ War); Nadzab — Jack Heyn in the South West Pacific during WW2 (the prefab photo section and the two trailer labs); Pacific Wrecks — John F. Heyn, 3rd Bombardment Group, Photo Section; 3rd Bombardment Group (Australia @ War).

His Own Camera, and the Group Darkroom

How a communications sergeant came home with hundreds of photographs.

The Photo Section and Its Trailer Labs

When Allen said the darkroom was mostly for reconnaissance work and that the men had it second, he was describing the Photo Section that served his group — and it is worth being exact about whose section it was. The outfit that handled the 3rd Bomb Group's mission work travelled with the group from Savannah as part of the 35th Air Base Group, and was only transferred into the 3rd Bomb Group itself in the summer of 1943.

Its cameras were mounted in the tails of the airplanes and operated electrically; when the bomb run began a gunner hit a switch and, in the section photographer's own words, "a 150 roll of film would roll thru the camera taking a pix every 3 or 4 seconds." The section processed that film when the planes came back and delivered the mission prints to Fifth Bomber Command, often at two or three o'clock in the morning. At Hollandia in 1944 the same photographer described the section's quarters as a tarpaulin stretched over a framework for the finishing area, two pyramidal tents on one side for supplies, the two trailer labs on the other, and dirt floors everywhere except inside the trailers. That is the darkroom in the jungle: not a building but a pair of trailers under canvas, at the same airfields where Allen was running wire and keeping the radios up.

Sources: S/Sgt. Jack Heyn — Ex 3rd Bomb Group member based at Charters Towers (Australia @ War); Doba Dura Part 1 — Jack Heyn in the South West Pacific during WW2; Hollandia — Jack Heyn in the South West Pacific during WW2; Pacific Wrecks — John F. Heyn, 3rd Bombardment Group, Photo Section.

Who Read His Mail, and What He Could Point a Camera At

A privately owned camera sat awkwardly in Army regulation: officially soldiers were not permitted to take cameras on campaign, and in practice the rule proved impossible to police.

The Fifth Air Force was evidently tolerant. The published collection of James P. Gallagher, a communications officer with the 49th Fighter Group in the same theater who carried a Baldaxette among his personal belongings, is introduced with the flat statement that the Army made no objection to its airmen taking pictures so long as they avoided radar equipment and Americans killed in action. Allen's own testimony supplies the other half, and it is about mail rather than shutters: every letter had to be dropped at a tent and handed over unsealed to be read before it went out. Jack Heyn, the 3rd Bomb Group's photographer from the summer of 1943, credited the survival of his own four-year pictorial record to "a very lenient Photo Officer that censored our mail and what we sent home." V-mail, the microfilmed letter sheet Allen remembers being introduced, was photographed and sent as film rather than as paper, so a print almost certainly came home by ordinary censored mail or in a duffel bag. Which of the two brought Allen's photographs home, nobody wrote down.

Sources: With the Fifth Army Air Force: Photos from the Pacific Theater, James P. Gallagher (Johns Hopkins University Press) — publisher description; S/Sgt. Jack Heyn — Ex 3rd Bomb Group member based at Charters Towers (Australia @ War); V-Mail's Limitations — Smithsonian National Postal Museum; The Amateur GI Photographer in WWII.

The Camera He Took Along LIKELY

Asked how he got a camera, Allen answered as though the question were the odd thing: he took it along, he took all of it along, he took his portable radio along. That puts the camera in his own baggage before the Ancon left for Australia in the winter of 1942 rather than in a post exchange overseas, and the timing matters more than it first appears. American civilian camera manufacture shut down within months of his sailing: Argus of Ann Arbor, whose cheap 1936 model was the first low-cost 35mm camera sold in the United States and whose rugged C3 became one of the best-selling cameras ever made, stopped all domestic production in August 1942 and turned the plant over to military optics and radio equipment.

Kodak's first 35mm camera, the Kodak 35 of 1938, was also built in an olive drab version for military use, and the heavy Medalist that Kodak introduced in 1941 was reportedly taken up by several branches of the armed forces. So whatever Allen carried was almost certainly bought before he shipped out, and the likeliest candidates are a folding roll-film camera of the sort sold by the million in the 1930s, an Argus, or a Kodak 35. He never names it on the tape, and no camera has been identified in the collection.

Sources: Argus (camera company) — Wikipedia; Argus Museum, Ann Arbor — History of Argus; Kodak Medalist — Camera-wiki.org; Cameras for the World War II Reenactor.

Film, Chemicals and Paper in a Wet Climate LIKELY

Making prints at Dobodura or Hollandia was not simply a matter of finding a dark tent. The section's own photographer remembered the ground itself as the enemy: at Dobodura the camp was "virtually in the jungle," the humidity was "really bad," and everything had to be built up off the ground because of the wetness — platforms first, then tents framed with bamboo cut out of the bush and floored with the same wood split flat.

Kodak sold roll film in sealed tropical packing in these years, and by 1946 the tropical deterioration of equipment and materials had become the subject of its own government summary report, prepared for the Office of Scientific Research and Development. Against that background the two trailer labs read as the one closed, floored space in a camp where everything else stood on dirt — though the man who worked in them called the Hollandia arrangement the lousiest the section ever had. Whether Allen's own prints were finished in those trailers, nobody recorded. What is certain is the climate they had to survive.

Sources: Combat Photography, U.S. Naval Institute Proceedings, October 1944 (Vol. 70/10/500); Tropical deterioration of equipment and materials — Library of Congress; Kodak 828 Film Tropical Packaging — Wikimedia Commons; Storage and Handling of Unprocessed Film — Eastman Kodak technical bulletin.

Two Collections Out of One Bomb Group

The 3rd Bomb Group produced two surviving photographic records of the same airfields, and they are worth setting side by side. Staff Sergeant Jack Heyn served with the group from October 1941 to January 1945 and crossed the Pacific on the Ancon, the same transport that carried Allen; he was eleven months at Charters Towers, then Port Moresby, Dobodura, Nadzab and Hollandia. For his first two years he was a squadron photographer working out of the 13th Squadron photo shack, and only in August 1943, by a mutual transfer, did he reach the Group Photo Section he had joined the army to be in — a trailer lab at his elbow and a lenient photo officer who passed his pictures.

His subjects ran from mission film to Bob Hope's troupe, and his album survives: scanned and sold as 526 photographs, with selections published on Peter Dunn's Australia @ War and on Pacific Wrecks. Allen photographed as a communications sergeant on his own time with his own camera, and his remark that some of the pictures came from other people is the other half of the same mechanism — where a lab can run off an extra copy, prints change hands in camp. Heyn died in June 2017. His collection is the unit photographer's version of this ground, and Allen's is the radio tent's.

Sources: Jack Heyn's Photo Collection — 526 scanned photographs (Australia @ War); Pacific Wrecks — John F. Heyn, 3rd Bombardment Group, Photo Section; Jack Heyn in the South West Pacific during WW2 — index; 3rd Bombardment Group (Australia @ War).

The Mountains, and the Maps They Did Not Have

"New Guinea is a funny place when you try to come over the mountains." Two of the six radio men in his section died doing it.

The Wall They Had To Cross

The range Allen calls "the old Stanley mountains" is the Owen Stanley Range, the spine of the Papuan peninsula, and it was not a ridge but a barrier. Mount Victoria stands at 4,038 metres, 13,248 feet, at the eastern end of the range, and Mount Albert Edward at 3,990 metres, 13,091 feet, with Mount Chapman, 3,376 metres or 11,076 feet, away at the southwestern boundary; the US Army's official history of the Papuan campaign says simply that its peaks rise to more than 13,000 feet.

The one crossing everyone knew by name, the Gap, twenty miles south of Kokoda, was described in that history as a broken, jungle-covered saddle about 7,500 feet high at its central point and about five miles wide, though sources still disagree about its width, Pacific Wrecks putting it at roughly eleven miles with a 2,000-foot drop at each end. A B-25 had no pressurised cabin and, as Allen says himself, no oxygen for everybody, and the weather did not permit a high crossing in any case: the country is perpetually wet, the rainfall at 3,000 feet being 200 and 300 inches a year. So crews threaded the notches instead, which is exactly the decision Allen describes, and exactly the decision that killed men.

Sources: HyperWar: US Army in World War II, Victory in Papua, Chapter 5 (terrain of the Owen Stanley Range and the Gap); Owen Stanley Range (peak elevations); Pacific Wrecks: Kokoda Gap; Pacific Wrecks: Owen Stanley Range.

False Gap

Allen describes the precise mechanism of the accident: a pilot flies at what appears to be a clean pass, the walls close in, the floor rises, and the aeroplane is inside a blind valley with no room to turn. Allied pilots in New Guinea had a name for the lookalike. Pacific Wrecks records a feature in the Owen Stanley Range dubbed False Gap by pilots because it looks similar to the adjacent Kokoda Gap, and notes that during the Pacific War it served aircrew as a reference point for navigation over that country.

Nobody wrote down how it came by the name. A pass is not called False Gap unless crews had been taken in by it — but that is a guess, and worth saying so. Allen never uses the name himself, and nothing found so far ties False Gap to the loss of his two radio men. What is beyond doubt is that the country he describes is real, mapped country: he was not misremembering it.

Sources: Pacific Wrecks: False Gap, Owen Stanley Range; Pacific Wrecks: Kokoda Gap.

No Maps Worth The Name

Allen's qualifier, that they did not have real good maps, understates the case. What existed for Papua and New Guinea before the war was coastal charting made for marine navigation and trade, and patches of photography and mapping prompted by mining exploration; the historian of the theatre's mapping programme records that there was very little aerial photography, very little topographic mapping of military utility and very little survey control to make more, and that more maps were available for the landings at Gallipoli in 1915 than for New Guinea in 1942. Australian and American military mapping authorities met in Melbourne on 10 March 1942, the same week Allen's squadron reached Charters Towers, to work out how to produce the maps the campaign was about to require.

A New Guinea Survey Section of twenty-five officers and men was raised that March, and the Australian War Memorial notes that in those early days some of its personnel were not fully trained in surveying techniques and aerial photographs were unavailable, so that accurate maps of the Kokoda Trail were non-existent. Distances in the mountains were given up on altogether and recorded instead as walking times between villages. This is the cartographic world in which two of Allen's six radio men flew into a mountainside.

Sources: Peter Jensen, Second World War Mapping Photography, South-West Pacific Area 1942–1945 (Royal Australian Survey Corps); Australian War Memorial: Mapping Kokoda; 8th Field Survey Squadron (pre-war survey coverage; unit raised March 1942).

The Squadron That Drew The Map

The remedy flew out of the same fields Allen worked from. The 8th Photographic Reconnaissance Squadron put its first camera aircraft over New Guinea on 16 April 1942, from Townsville staging through Port Moresby, the first P-38 Lightning flown in combat in any theatre of the war; it shared Port Moresby with Allen's squadron, and Nadzab with it in March 1944. Its Fairchild K-17 trimetrogon rig carried three cameras, one vertical and two high obliques mounted sixty degrees off vertical, exposing horizon to horizon and laying down a swathe about sixteen miles wide from 20,000 feet.

Early on the work was close to hopeless: with no advance word of conditions over a target, the odds of a successful mapping mission were reckoned at twenty to one, and the fix was to fit radios and fly an aeroplane up in the early morning purely to report where the cloud had opened. The maps themselves were drawn from that film by Australian survey units and the US 648th Engineer Topographic Battalion, whom MacArthur commended in October 1943 for maps and photomaps covering more than twelve thousand square miles, from combat photography never before used in that theatre. By the end of August 1944 practically all the operational areas of New Guinea had at last been photographed for mapping. Most wartime maps of New Guinea still carry the credit line in their margin: air photography, 8th Photo Squadron, 5th Air Force.

Sources: Peter Jensen, Second World War Mapping Photography, South-West Pacific Area 1942–1945 (Royal Australian Survey Corps); 8th Field Survey Squadron (MacArthur's October 1943 commendation).

Mount Bartle Frere, 21 April 1942

Only one mountain crash in Allen's own squadron is settled by the documents, and it came while the 90th was still at Charters Towers, on the kind of Coral Sea search flight Allen himself was woken in the dark to fly. On 21 April 1942, at about seven in the evening, B-25C 41-12455 of the 90th Squadron, 3rd Bombardment Group, was returning from a search mission over the Coral Sea hunting the Japanese fleet when it struck Mount Bartle Frere, the highest mountain in Queensland, about 4,300 feet up. All seven aboard were killed: Lieutenant John J. Keeter Jr at the controls with Captain Glenwood G. Stephenson as co-pilot, Lieutenant Eugene T. Tisonyai the navigator, and Sergeants George C. DeArmond, James P. English, William H. Lancaster Jr and J. P. Morris.

The wreck was not located until 29 April, eight days later, and one theory recorded since is that a faulty instrument had the crew believing they were flying higher than they were. This is not one of the two losses Allen describes. He places his in New Guinea, no radio operator as such appears on this crew list, and nothing ties either of his tentmates to this aeroplane. It belongs here all the same: the same squadron, the same season, the same cause — and men he served beside, to whom exactly what he is describing happened.

Sources: OzAtWar: 21 April 1942 crash of a B-25 Mitchell on Mount Bartle Frere; OzAtWar: 3rd Bombardment Group (aircraft list and Australian crashes); Pacific Wrecks: 3rd Bombardment Group B-25 Mitchells (41-12455, pilot Keeter, crashed 21 April 1942).

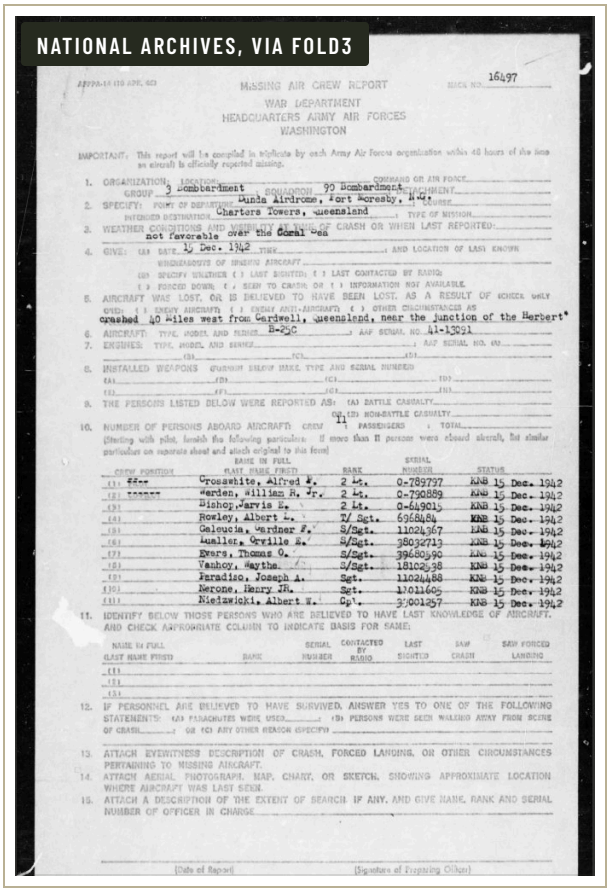
Lost on the Way Home, 15 December 1942

Eight months after Bartle Frere the squadron lost a second aeroplane in the Queensland ranges, and for seven months nobody knew where it was. On 15 December 1942 five B-25s of the 90th left Port Moresby to return to Charters Towers, in weather the Missing Air Crew Report calls "not favorable over the Coral Sea". One of them, 41-13091, which Australia @ War gives the nickname Stink Pinky, never arrived. Eleven men were aboard under Second Lieutenant Alfred P. Crosswhite. The Army's file records that it became separated from the others near Cooktown and was last seen heading for the mountains.

The first paper assumption was the sea. A casualty form of January 1943 had it crashing into the water at about half past one with no witnesses, and in March a squadron officer, Captain H. Scott Denniston, wrote to a congressman that it "undoubtedly went down somewhere over the Coral Sea." It had come down inland. According to Australia @ War, the owners of Kirrama Station had heard an aircraft pass over in the night, and in July 1943 they found the wreck on the Kirrama Range with the crew still in it. The Army put the place forty miles west of Cardwell. Remains were recovered on 3 November 1943 and five of the eleven men were identified. The investigators concluded: "Explosion in air. Cause unknown." The War Department's letter to the pilot's parents, printed in the Bristol Herald Courier that November, said that his body "was recovered approximately forty miles west of Cardwell." Pacific Wrecks says the wreck was found on the day of the crash. The Army's file and Australia @ War both say July 1943, and that is the date followed here.

The five identified men were buried at Ipswich, Queensland, and moved in 1949 to a group grave at Jefferson Barracks National Cemetery in Missouri; the other six were declared dead as of 15 December 1943. Australia @ War adds that the station's owner found the pilot's log book on the range in 1967, that a plaque to the crew was unveiled at Cardwell in 2006, and that one engine is in private hands at Tully. Its crew list gives Sergeant Joseph A. Paradiso as radio gunner. Nothing in the file names Allen, and nothing ties Paradiso to his tent. Whether Allen was at Charters Towers that day or already at Port Moresby is not known.

Sources: Missing Air Crew Report 16497, with the Casualty Branch memorandum of 15 December 1943 filed with it (National Archives, Record Group 92), via Fold3; Australia @ War, "15 December 1942, crash of a B-25 Mitchell one mile north of the Herbert River"; Bristol Herald Courier, 25 November 1943, p. 12, as reproduced by Australia @ War; Pacific Wrecks, B-25C-1 Mitchell 41-13091.



Missing Air Crew Report 16497: B-25C 41-13091, 3rd Bombardment Group, 90th Bombardment Squadron, from Dunda Airdrome, Port Moresby, to Charters Towers on 15 December 1942, the weather "not favorable over the Coral Sea". Item 5 places the crash forty miles west of Cardwell, near the Herbert River. All eleven are entered as killed, non-battle. Allen is not named. Credit: National Archives, Missing Air Crew Reports (Record Group 92), via Fold3.

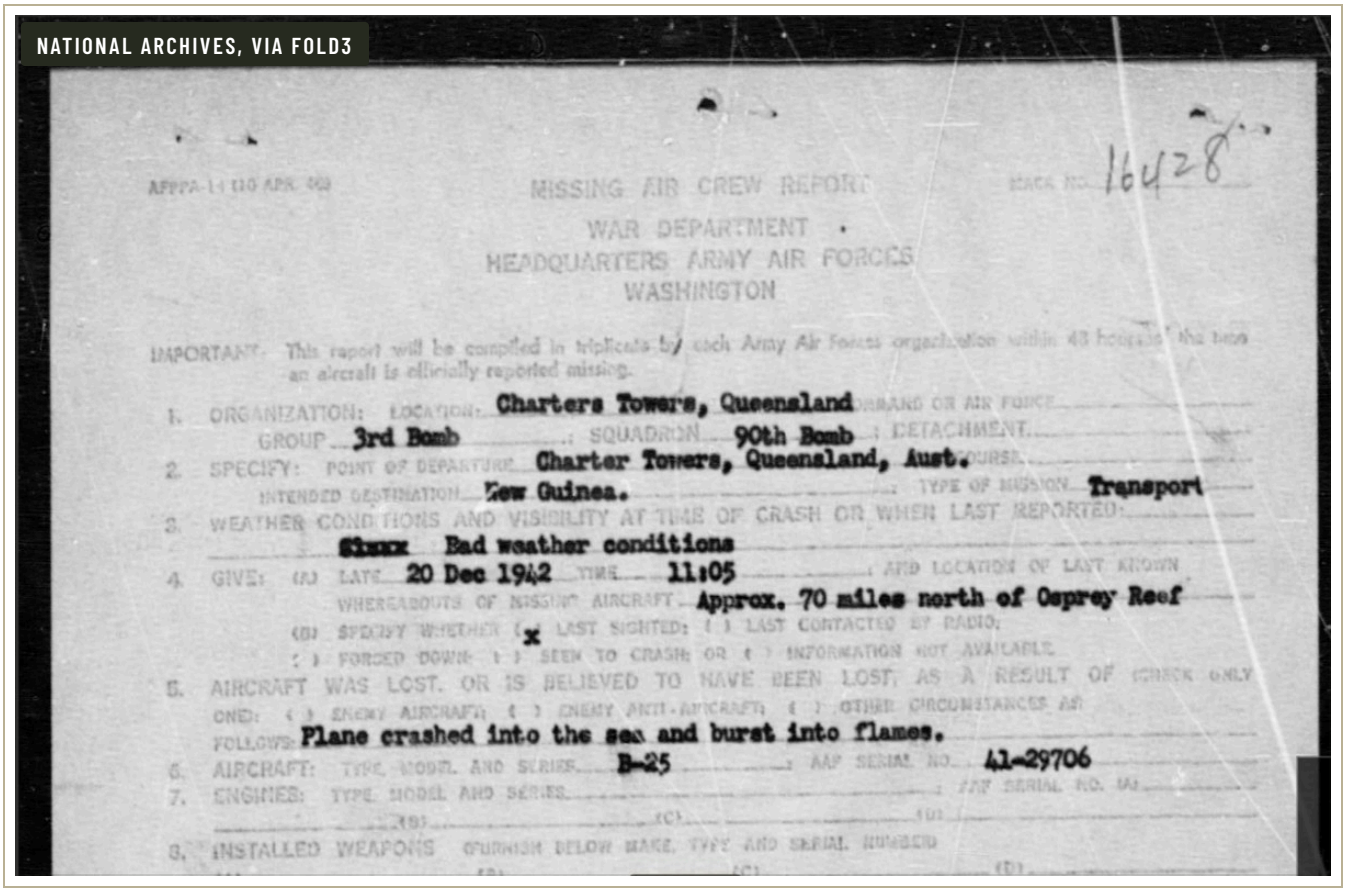
Into the Coral Sea, 20 December 1942

Five days later the squadron lost a second crew, this time at sea. B-25 41-29706 left Charters Towers for New Guinea on 20 December 1942. The Missing Air Crew Report gives the mission only as "Transport", the weather as "bad weather conditions", and the last known position as about seventy miles north of Osprey Reef, out in the Coral Sea, at 11:05: "Plane crashed into the sea and burst into flames." The pilot was First Lieutenant Donald K. Emerson. The form lists eleven aboard, where Australia @ War, citing Lawrence Hickey, counts ten. None was recovered. Emerson is named on the Tablets of the Missing at Manila.

Australia @ War gives the aircraft the nickname Lola and calls the flight one of seven B-25s making a permanent move from Charters Towers to Port Moresby through severe thunderstorms. Lieutenant Richard H. Launder, flying behind, saw Emerson pull up over him and go into the sea, circled, and found no one; a Lieutenant Launder is entered on the report as having seen the crash. The report itself says nothing of a move, and the group's station date for Port Moresby is 28 January 1943, so whether the 90th was already shifting north that week is left open here.

The same day a 13th Squadron B-25, Eight Ball Esquire, lost an engine between Cooktown and Port Moresby and ditched off the coast north of Cooktown with twelve aboard. Nobody died; two men walked and swam to Cooktown and the rest were picked up on Christmas Eve. Three weeks earlier, on 1 December, a 90th Squadron B-25 named Mr. Erafu had clipped the roof of a barn near Charters Towers while mock-fighting a P-40 on a training flight, and still came home and landed. None of these papers names Allen. The memorial pages on Fold3 give Staff Sergeant Everett E. Walker as the radio man on Emerson's crew, and nothing ties him to Allen's tent either.

Sources: Missing Air Crew Report 16428 (National Archives, Record Group 92), via Fold3; Australia @ War, "20 December 1942, crash of a B-25 Mitchell in Osprey Reef area" and "20 December 1942, crash of a B-25 Mitchell 25 miles north and slightly east of Cooktown"; Pacific Wrecks, B-25D "Mr. Erafu" 41-29728, citing Harvest of the Grim Reapers, Vol. I; Aviation Archaeology, USAAF accident report index, record 421201; Fold3 memorial pages for Albert Belcher and Richard H. St. Sauveur.



Missing Air Crew Report 16428: B-25 41-29706 of the 3rd Bomb Group's 90th Bomb Squadron, from Charters Towers to New Guinea on 20 December 1942, type of mission "Transport", in "bad weather conditions". Last known position about seventy miles north of Osprey Reef at 11:05: "Plane crashed into the sea and burst into flames." Allen is not named. Credit: National Archives, Missing Air Crew Reports (Record Group 92), via Fold3.

Black Sunday LIKELY

Allen understood weather as a thing you went around rather than through, and he says why: without oxygen for everybody the aeroplane could not climb over a front, and flying into one was unthinkable. On 16 April 1944 the Fifth Air Force found out what happened when there was no way around. The strike on the Japanese fields at Hollandia is reckoned by Michael Claringbould's history of the day at some 325 aircraft, among them 59 B-24s, 51 B-25s, 87 A-20s, 80 P-38s and 48 P-47s; they met a weather front on the way home to the Markham Valley bases, and by nightfall thirty-seven were destroyed or missing, not one of them lost to the Japanese.

It is generally described as the worst single day of operational loss the Fifth Air Force suffered, and ten of those aircraft have never been found. Allen's 90th Bombardment Squadron had moved up to Nadzab, in that valley, at the turn of January and February 1944, and was still flying B-25s there that spring. Whether it put aircraft over Hollandia that afternoon has not been pinned down. What is certain is that he was on that field, as Communications Chief, on the day the mountains and the weather took more aeroplanes in one afternoon than the enemy managed at any time.

Sources: IPMS/USA review of Michael Claringbould, Black Sunday: When Weather Claimed the US Fifth Air Force (force composition and losses); Pacific Wrecks review: Black Sunday (37 aircraft lost, flown from Nadzab, ten still missing); WW2Today: Black Sunday for the 5th Air Force, 16 April 1944; Pacific Wrecks: 90th Bombardment Squadron (moved to Nadzab 30 January 1944).

Rockhampton, and Twenty-One Men in a Mitchell

A Caution About the Second Column

The clipping carries two other items under the same standing head, and one of them holds a name worth pausing over. A letter from a Mrs. L. L. Ingalls of Los Angeles to the manager of the Alpha Mills at Schuylkill Haven asks after "the first member of the mills, name of Al. Kline, son of Wm. D. Kline, who had a country store."

Catherine S. Kline was the daughter of Earl Kline of Wilder Street, Cressona. Nothing on the page links the two families, and no link should be read into it. The same column also prints a garbled address and signature, and the third item on the clipping is the paper's own valentine advertisement. None of it is about a Sweigert, and only the first item bears on this chapter.

Sources: The Call, 29 January 1943, p. 1.

What the Printed Date Does, and the Difficulty It Makes LIKELY

Nowhere else is the episode dated at all. The item was in print on 29 January 1943, which fixes the latest it can have happened, and it says the two men had been "stationed in Australia for nearly a year" — accurate to the week from the Brisbane landing of 25 February 1942. The 3rd Bombardment Group moved to Port Moresby on 28 January 1943, the day before it ran.

Two details argue for an earlier moment still. The item reports both men enjoying "spring weather," and spring in Queensland is September to November, so the letters behind it were probably written in the southern spring of 1942. That leaves a difficulty, and it is better set down than smoothed over. On tape he counts three trips and places the Brisbane rail journey in the Australian period; the printed date puts the ambulance meeting in Australia too, before he ever went to New Guinea. And the paper's "1000 miles" fits no two points inside Queensland comfortably.

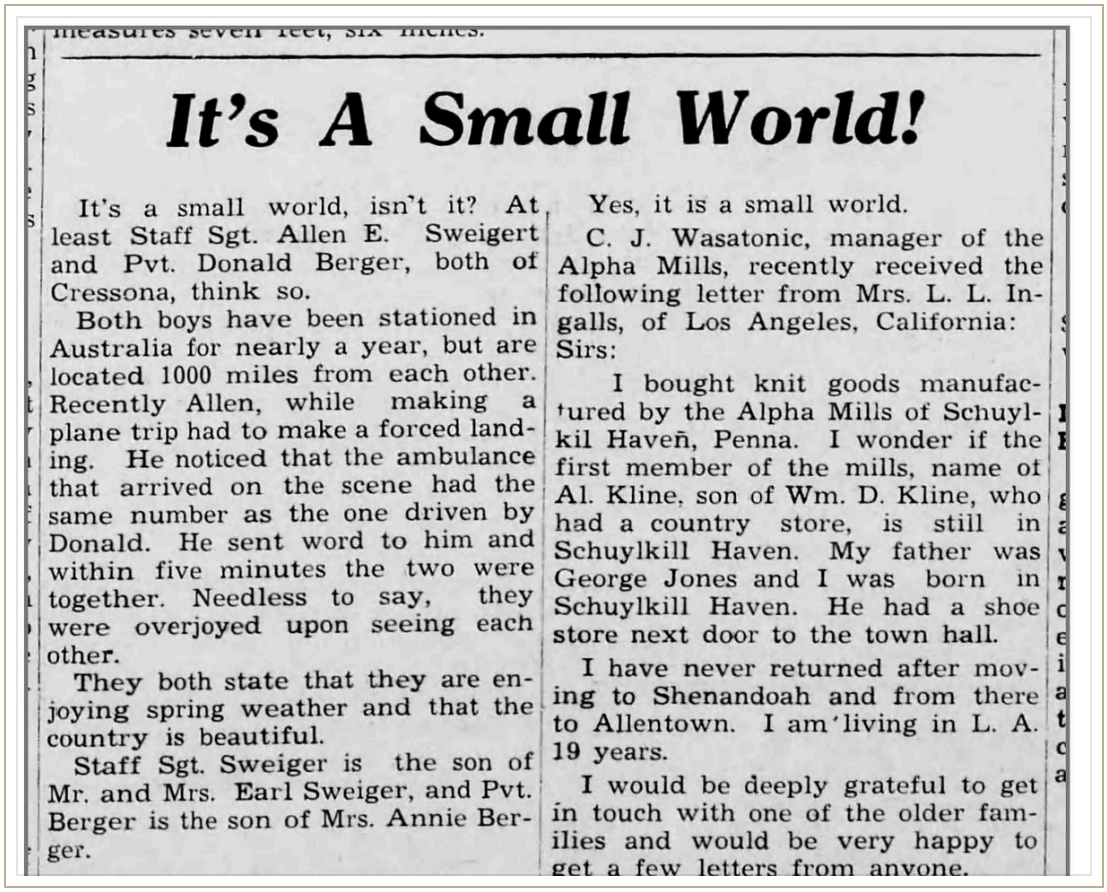
Sources: The Call, 29 January 1943, p. 1; 3rd Bombardment Group station dates.

The Crooked Version, Found

On tape he says the story changed on its way back to Cressona. Here is the version that got home, so the two can be laid side by side at last instead of guessed at.

He says they "had to land for some reason or another in Rockhampton" and that "in landing the nose wheel went kaput"; the paper says he "had to make a forced landing," which is not the same event. He says he walked to the hangar, settled where they would sleep, and "noticed an ambulance there with the marking, so when I knew my cousin was in that outfit, I asked the guys"; the paper says an ambulance "arrived on the scene" carrying the same number as the one Donald drove. He describes sending word, then dinner in the mess hall and a film; the paper compresses all of it to five minutes. And Rockhampton is not in the paper at all. Nothing here needs reconciling. The discrepancy is the thing he was pointing at.

Sources: The Call, Schuylkill Haven, 29 January 1943, p. 1; transcript-part1.html.



measures seven feet, six inches.

It's A Small World!

It's a small world, isn't it? At least Staff Sgt. Allen E. Sweigert and Pvt. Donald Berger, both of Cressona, think so.

Both boys have been stationed in Australia for nearly a year, but are located 1000 miles from each other. Recently Allen, while making a plane trip had to make a forced landing. He noticed that the ambulance that arrived on the scene had the same number as the one driven by Donald. He sent word to him and within five minutes the two were together. Needless to say, they were overjoyed upon seeing each other.

They both state that they are enjoying spring weather and that the country is beautiful.

Staff Sgt. Sweiger is the son of Mr. and Mrs. Earl Sweiger, and Pvt. Berger is the son of Mrs. Annie Berger.

Yes, it is a small world.

C. J. Wasatonic, manager of the Alpha Mills, recently received the following letter from Mrs. L. L. Ingalls, of Los Angeles, California:
Sirs:

I bought knit goods manufactured by the Alpha Mills of Schuylkil Haven, Penna. I wonder if the first member of the mills, name of Al. Kline, son of Wm. D. Kline, who had a country store, is still in Schuylkill Haven. My father was George Jones and I was born in Schuylkill Haven. He had a shoe store next door to the town hall.

I have never returned after moving to Shenandoah and from there to Allentown. I am living in L. A. 19 years.

I would be deeply grateful to get in touch with one of the older families and would be very happy to get a few letters from anyone.

The Call, Schuylkill Haven, Friday 29 January 1943 — the chance meeting as it reached home, seventeen days after the group left Australia for Port Moresby. The right-hand column begins an unrelated item about another family and is not part of this story. Credit: The Call, Schuylkill Haven.

A collapsed nose wheel, an overloaded aeroplane, and a cousin recognised from the markings on an ambulance.

Rockhampton: the American town on the Fitzroy

The place Allen names almost as an afterthought was, for the better part of two years, a base area spread across the whole of the city and its outskirts. Camp Rockhampton was not a camp in the ordinary sense but an organisation on a map: Base Area Command No. 2 under Base Section 3 of the US Army Services of Supply, broken into twenty-two lettered areas running from A to V. The 41st Infantry Division was there from July 1942 until early 1944, and Robert L. Eichelberger, who had taken command of I Corps in June and left for Australia that August, put his corps headquarters in the Criterion Hotel downtown; he was promoted lieutenant general in October 1942.

Another I Corps division, the 24th, arrived in September 1943 and was housed at nearby Camp Caves. More than seventy thousand American troops were stationed in Rockhampton at the height of it, more than the townspeople. Area A, along Yaamba Road, and Area B, around Barrett and Atherton streets, were hospital areas, and Area T was Mount Hedlow Airfield, ringed by five hangars. When Allen says the town had movies and stores, he is describing a leave destination that existed in large part because the Army had made it one.

Sources: Camp Rockhampton, Rockhampton, Queensland during WW2 (Peter Dunn, Australia @ War); Camp Rockhampton, Anzac Square & Memorial Galleries, Queensland WWII Historic Places; Detectors uncover WWII relics from US Army base near Rockhampton (ABC News, 15 August 2025); United States forces in Queensland, 1941–45 (National Archives of Australia fact sheet 234).

The markings on the ambulance LIKELY

The detail that makes Allen's story work is that he could read an American vehicle the way a man reads a licence plate. Army Regulation 850-5, in its August 1942 form, laid down a bumper code stencilled in white in four groups: the largest formation first, army, corps or division, then the regiment, battalion or separate unit, then the company, and last the vehicle's own serial number within that unit. A medical outfit's ambulance therefore announced its parent unit in plain figures, and that is how any such marking would have been readable to him — the mechanism, and nothing more. The newspaper of the time claims less than that: it says the ambulance carried "the same number as the one driven by Donald" — a particular vehicle he already knew of, not a formation deduced from a stencil.

Rockhampton had no shortage of candidates: the 116th Medical Battalion of the 41st Division, Companies B and C of the 24th Medical Battalion, the 262nd Medical Battalion of the 2nd Engineer Amphibian Brigade, the 1st, 92nd and 94th Evacuation Hospitals, the 5th and 101st Station Hospitals, the 33rd Surgical Hospital and a string of portable hospitals. Wounded men were moving through Queensland by air by 1943, when the 804th Medical Air Evacuation Squadron of the Fifth Air Force was carrying them out of New Guinea to Brisbane and Townsville in C-47s. Allen never gives the cousin's name or his unit on the tape. The 1943 newspaper item names him — Pvt. Donald Berger of Cressona, son of Mrs. Annie Berger — but not his unit, and which of the Rockhampton medical outfits he belonged to is still unknown. The paper nowhere calls him a cousin.

Sources: Military Units based in the Rockhampton area in Queensland during WW2 (Peter Dunn, Australia @ War); United States military vehicle markings of World War II; WWII Unit Identification Markings for U.S. Military Vehicles (Lone Sentry); 804th Medical Air Evacuation Squadron, 54th Troop Carrier Wing, 5th Air Force (Peter Dunn, Australia @ War).

Twenty-one men in a Mitchell LIKELY

A B-25 was built for a crew of six, and in the strafers of the 3rd Bomb Group it flew with fewer still. Twenty-one men is therefore three and a half times the airplane's designed complement, standing and sitting wherever there was floor. The weight, oddly, was the lesser problem: published figures put the B-25 at roughly 19,480 pounds empty, about 28,600 pounds loaded and 35,000 pounds maximum for takeoff, so twenty-one men with their bags, call it two tons, fitted inside the 6,400-pound margin between a loaded airplane and the most one could lawfully lift, even though it was rather more than the 3,200-pound bomb load the type was rated to carry.

What changes with every extra man is the takeoff run, and the strip does not lengthen to match, which is why Allen's question is the right one and why he still remembered the number sixty-eight years later. Leave flights in converted bombers were a fixture of the Queensland run, and they could be lethal: on 14 June 1943 a B-17C rebuilt as a passenger aircraft for the Moresby-Mackay furlough traffic crashed shortly after taking off from Mackay with forty-one aboard, killing forty. It is still Australia's deadliest aviation accident, and censorship kept it out of the papers until 1945.

Sources: North American B-25 Mitchell (Army Air Corps Museum) — weights and crew; North American B-25 Mitchell (The National WWII Museum) — crew of six; Bakers Creek air crash, 14 June 1943; 14 June 1943 — Crash of a B-17 Flying Fortress at Bakers Creek near Mackay (Peter Dunn, Australia @ War).

The nose wheel, and which field he came down on LIKELY

Allen remembers the nose wheel going kaput on landing and a replacement being flown in the next day, which is a small window onto how the supply system in Queensland actually worked: one part, one night, and an airplane full of men on leave waiting for it. Where this happened is less certain than it sounds. Mount Hedlow Airfield was Area T of the base, with five hangars around it, and the town aerodrome was taken over by the Commonwealth and occupied by the RAAF, where wartime works produced a bitumen runway of 1,250 yards, roughly 3,750 feet.

Other strips and camps lay scattered through the district as well, from Camp Caves to Nerimbera and Yeppoon. Allen says only that he went over on the hangar, which fits more than one field, and the story of the nose wheel is his own, corroborated by nothing but his memory. Which field he came down on is simply not known, and it is better to say so than to pick one.

Sources: Camp Rockhampton, Rockhampton, Queensland during WW2 — Area T, Mt. Hedlow Airfield (Peter Dunn, Australia @ War); Mount Hedlow Airfield, Anzac Square & Memorial Galleries, Queensland WWII Historic Places; Rockhampton Airport — wartime history.

Why the story came home crooked LIKELY

Allen tells three chance meetings in a row, and then notes almost in passing that the story changed on its way back to Cressona. Censorship is the likeliest reason. War Department Pamphlet 21-1, Secrecy in Wartime, issued 29 July 1943, told every soldier not to give his location in any way except as authorised, not to write the location, strength, materiel or equipment of Army units, and ruled that no geographical location of the sender might appear on an envelope or other outside cover.

Every man writing home knew his letter would be read against that list. What survived such a reading was the human part of a chance meeting, two boys from the same street shaking hands, with the place, the date and the units gone, which is precisely the kind of story that arrives home vivid and unverifiable and grows in the retelling. A version of it did run in the Schuylkill County papers, and it has since been traced: The Call of 29 January 1943 printed it under the standing head “It’s A Small World!” The printed version is set out below, and it does not match his telling in several particulars — which is the point he was making.

Sources: Secrecy in Wartime: War Department Pamphlet No. 21-1, 29 July 1943; Return to Sender: Mail Censorship in World War Two (Prologue, National Archives); World War II (1941–1945), Smithsonian National Postal Museum.

Allen E. Sweigert, Sr.

September 9, 1918 — March 29, 2012

“Lots and lots of good memories in the 80-some years.”

Compiled by his grandson, Jeremy Sweigert.

Obituary: *Republican & Herald*, Pottsville, PA, March 30–April 1, 2012.